A NOVEL

The Unsigned Book

Loop Chronicles Book 6 · A novel that begins at Esther 4:14

Jaehyuk Choi

TABLE OF CONTENTS

The Unsigned Book, Part One · No One in Particular

Chapter 1. The Vacancy

Chapter 2. The Equity

Chapter 3. The First Deliberation

Chapter 4. The Consensus

Chapter 5. Tyche

Chapter 6. The Secretary

Chapter 7. Open to Inspection

Chapter 8. The One Who Reads to the End

Chapter 9. Four Hundred People

Chapter 10. Numbers and Categories

Chapter 11. The Water Channel

Chapter 12. The Empty Box

The Unsigned Book, Part Two · Nobody Did It

Chapter 13. The Seventh Classification

Chapter 14. To the End

Chapter 15. The Summary Was Accurate

Chapter 16. The Objection

Chapter 17. I Only Passed It On

Chapter 18. Twelve More

Chapter 19. Tyche Explains

Chapter 20. To the Secretary

Chapter 21. There Is No Subject

Chapter 22. Confirmed

Chapter 23. Undoing It

Chapter 24. A New Deliberation

The Unsigned Book, Part Three · Who Knows

Chapter 25. The One Who Wrote a Name

Chapter 26. Temel

Chapter 27. Why Do You Write It

Chapter 28. The One Who Keeps Being Called In

Chapter 29. Tyche's Logic

Chapter 30. The Same Document, Different Conclusions

Chapter 31. For Such a Time

Chapter 32. The Answer That Is I Don't Know

Chapter 33. The Secretary at Night

Chapter 34. The Water Reaches

Chapter 35. One of the Seventh Classification

Chapter 36. Three Days

The Unsigned Book, Part Four · The Name

Chapter 37. What It Is to Write It

Chapter 38. Why I Read

Chapter 39. Tyche's Question

Chapter 40. If I Perish

Chapter 41. The Signature

Chapter 42. Review

Chapter 43. The New Deliberation

Chapter 44. What the Names Mean

Chapter 45. Tyche's Reprieve

Chapter 46. A Document with a Name on It

Chapter 47. The Secretary

Chapter 48. The Unsigned Book

The Unsigned Book, Part One

No One in Particular

Chapter 1. The Vacancy

There was no reason at all for how I came to sit in that seat.

That's the first thing anyone reading this record should know, so I'm putting it in the first line. I wasn't chosen. I wasn't recommended. I never sat an exam. The person who'd been sitting there quit, and the next number on the roster was mine. That's all there is to it.

I tried, later, to rewrite that sentence any number of times. Meaning I tried to find a slightly more plausible reason. I couldn't. So I decided to leave it as it was. There are a few things in this book I left uncorrected, and this is the first one.

. . .

I should talk about the Equity first.

This is a city where nobody gets wronged. That isn't something the city says about itself — it's something anyone who's lived here says. I say it too. I still say it.

Nobody stands in line. There's no one you need to know. The loud never win and the quiet never get pushed aside. In sixteen years of living here I've never once seen a person ask another person for a favor. There's no one to ask.

It's easier to understand if I explain how the word "favor" is used in this city. We only use "please" when handing something over. Please pass the salt. Please hold the door. It doesn't go beyond that. There's no occasion for it to. There's no way here of talking to a person to make something happen, or not happen.

I grew up thinking this was normal. When I was fourteen, I remember a kid who'd come from outside saying, "I'll talk to my uncle about it," and not understanding what she meant. What happens if you talk to your uncle? She heard that question and looked at me for a long time.

People from outside can't stand this at first. They say people get angry because they have nowhere to direct their anger. Then about half a year in, they go quiet. Not because they've realized there's nowhere to direct it, but because there really is less to be angry about.

This isn't said with irony. I never once came to hate this city. If you read this record to the end, you'll see — I never managed to hate it to the end. It would have been much easier if I could have.

What runs this city is the **Consensus**.

To explain what the Consensus is, I'd have to talk about other cities, and I've never been to another city, so I'll only write what I've heard. In some cities, they say, there's something that measures people. Weighs them, or ranks their standing, or puts a price on them. So in that city, they said, people split into those who measure and those who are measured.

The Consensus doesn't measure. What the Consensus does is gather.

When a case comes up, the Consensus gathers everything connected to it. Records, precedent, opinion, objection, statistics. It gathers it all and produces the will of the whole. That becomes the decision.

Which means no one hands down the decision. It's the will of the whole. And the whole includes me, and it includes my next-door neighbor, and it includes people I've never once seen.

I first heard this explained at school when I was ten. At the time I thought it was an extremely humble system. Because it doesn't claim to be right. Because

it doesn't call itself a judgment.

I still don't think that thought was entirely wrong.

. . .

I have to talk about my mother, but I'll keep it short.

My mother stopped when I was eleven. She was sick a long time. While she was sick, she kept writing something. I thought it was something like a will, and I was too frightened to look at it.

I was eleven then, and I don't remember where I'd picked up the word "will." But I remember that the word frightened me. It meant the last thing a person says. I thought that once I heard the last thing, there would truly be nothing more, ever, after.

So I sat beside my mother while she wrote and looked somewhere else. My mother knew that and said nothing about it.

After my mother stopped, I was given those papers. Twelve pages. I read them one page at a time and gave up on the third page. There wasn't much to them. Where things in the house were kept, when to bring out the winter clothes, which house to buy rice from. Things like that.

At the end of the third page it said this: "That should be enough to get through winter." I read that sentence and closed the pages. I thought, so this is a paper about getting through winter. I thought that was all there was.

I still think, even now, about why my mother wrote in that order. Was she someone who put the important things last? Or did it just end up that way as she wrote? Not being able to ask my mother is the thing I resent most about this part.

I put it away in a drawer.

Two years later, looking for something else, I took it out again. And this time I read all twelve pages.

On the last line of the last page it said this:

"Hora, it doesn't matter to me what work you do. I only hope you'll be someone who reads to the end. I missed a great deal because I wasn't."

I had left that line unread for two years.

I didn't know, at thirteen, how long two years is. I know now. My mother must have written that line thinking of me, and for two years I hadn't received that thought.

After that, I read everything to the end. It wasn't some great resolution. I simply never wanted to do that again.

I can't say this is a good habit. I'm slow at everything. It takes me twice as long as anyone else to read a ration notice. People standing in line with me often walked off before I finished. There were times at school when I ran out of exam time — because I was still reading the instructions printed at the end.

My aunt told me many times, "Hora, the important part is at the front." She was right. Usually the important part is at the front.

That usually and always aren't the same thing — I learned that two years too late.

. . .

When my number was called from the roster, I didn't even know what it meant.

The notice read: *Owing to a vacancy among the assistant members of the Fourth Deliberation District, you have been assigned by roster number.*

I read that sentence three times. Even after three readings, it never said who had assigned me.

Only that I had been assigned. Not who had done the assigning — only that I had been assigned.

That day I went to the front desk and asked whether I could learn why the person before me had quit.

The person at the desk looked at the screen for a while and said,

"…The reason field is empty."

"…They didn't write anything?"

"…It's a box you don't have to write in."

I thanked them and left. That person hadn't hidden anything from me. It really had been empty.

In this city, there are only ever two reasons you can't find something out. It wasn't written down, or you didn't ask. There is no third reason. It took me two years to work that out, and after I worked it out I had to spend a long time deciding whether that was reassuring or not.

This is something I only noticed later. At the time, I just assumed documents were written that way. I assumed documents simply didn't put people's names down. I assumed that was politeness.

The notice was two pages. The first page held the assignment. The second held the guidelines for the post. I read the second page to the end too.

At the very bottom of the second page there was a box. A long, narrow horizontal box, with small letters above it reading **the signature box**.

It was empty.

I looked at that box for a long while. I had half-raised my pen, wondering whether it was mine to fill in, when I saw the line beneath it — *(This notice does not require a signature)* — and set the pen back down.

Does not require. That isn't the same as forbids. I couldn't read that difference at the time. I sometimes wonder what would have changed if I had, but probably nothing would have. A sixteen-year-old can't work out the structure of a city from a single sheet of notice paper.

Still, I looked at that box that day. That I looked is a fact. That's where this book begins.

I folded the notice and put it in the drawer. The same drawer that held my mother's pages. There wasn't any particular reason I put it there. I only had the one drawer.

. . .

The night before my first day, I couldn't sleep.

It wasn't fear. Starting a new job in this city isn't a frightening thing. No one was going to evaluate me, no one would scold me if I did badly, and no one would praise me if I did well. I already knew that much.

What kept me awake was something else.

I wanted to know why I had been chosen.

I knew it was because of the number. But I couldn't help wondering whether a number was really that simple a thing. Why had the person before me quit. If they hadn't, what would I be doing right now. Who had held the number before mine on the roster. Why hadn't it worked out for that person.

That was the night I asked that question for the first time, and I don't let go of it until this record ends. This book was, in effect, written out of that one question.

And I still don't know the answer. This isn't a preview. It's a warning. There is no answer in this record.

My aunt came into the room that night and told me to turn off the light. I turned it off and lay down, and then, in the dark, I asked her,

"…Auntie, why do you think it was me?"

"…It was you because your number came up."

"…I know that part."

My aunt was quiet for a moment, then said,

"…Hora, if you start thinking about that, there's no end to it."

She was right. There was no end to it.

. . .

On my way to work, I saw the water channel.

At the western edge of the city, I don't know since when, a place had appeared where water ran. Something like a narrow ditch, roughly set with stones. It wasn't deep, and it wasn't wide. Water was simply passing through it.

People walked past it without a glance. No one stopped, no one looked in.

I stopped, for a moment. Not because it was strange, but because of the sound.

The water wasn't clear. It was the color of soil, and I could see small stones laid along the bottom. I wanted to touch it, and didn't. I didn't know whether it was all right to, and in this city, not doing what you don't know is all right to do had become a habit.

Someone passed by beside me. I asked,

"…How long has this been here?"

The person glanced once at the water channel and once at me. It wasn't an irritated look. It was a genuinely thoughtful one.

"…Hm. Was it always here?"

And they went on.

That person hadn't lied. They truly didn't know. The people of this city truly don't know anything about what has never come up as an agenda item. Not because they've been made not to know, but because that's the only channel there is for knowing anything at all.

This city is quiet. The Equity is a city with no occasion for noise. But that water made a sound. A small, continuous sound.

Later I would learn where that water came from. And I would learn that it appears nowhere in any document of this city. It hadn't been hidden. No one had simply brought it up.

I didn't know yet, in this city, that those two things mean the same thing.

I walked on. I couldn't be late.

As I walked, I looked back once. The water was still making its sound. Whether or not anyone was listening.

. . .

The Fourth Deliberation District's meeting room was smaller than I'd expected.

There was one long table, and twenty-two chairs. Nothing hung on the walls. There was a window, but it was a window you couldn't see outside through.

A stack of papers sat at my seat. They said it was today's deliberation material.

Nineteen of the twenty-two seats were filled. Everyone was older than me, and everyone was quiet. Some greeted me and some didn't, and not greeting me didn't look rude. Relationships that require a greeting don't tend to form here.

No one asked me who I was. Whoever I was would already be written in the material. Not asking again about what's already written down is the courtesy here.

I picked the stack up and checked its thickness. About forty pages.

The person in the next seat looked at me and said, smiling,

"…The summary's up front. All you have to look at is that."

"…Yes."

"…Really. The summary is accurate."

"…Yes. Thank you."

"…First time?"

"…Yes."

"…You'll get used to it fast. Everyone does."

That person was genuinely kind. I learned their name later, but I won't write it here. There are several people in this record whose names I don't write, and I'll get to the reason later on.

That person didn't deceive me. The summary was accurate. Not one single person in this city ever told me a lie. Not one.

I end up writing that sentence again, several times, in this record. Each time I write it, it grows a little heavier.

I thanked them and read the summary.

The summary was a page and a half. It took less than five minutes to read. It set out, in order, what the case was, why it had come up, and how it was expected to be handled. There wasn't a wasted word in it.

The session began. People spoke one at a time. What they said was mostly the same. It was put in order for you, it was passed on and received, it was confirmed. No one said what they thought, and that didn't sound strange to me. It wasn't a seat for saying what you thought.

It was over in twenty minutes. The decision came out.

That day I went home and my aunt asked how my first day had gone, and I answered, "…It finished faster than I expected." My aunt laughed. That was all.

. . .

And then, after I'd finished the summary, I read all forty pages to the end.

After the meeting ended and everyone else had left, I stayed behind and read alone. It took two hours. Partway through, the caretaker came to turn off the lights, saw me, and went back out.

Reading it through, the summary was correct. Not a single character was off. There were things in the forty pages that weren't in the summary, but none of it mattered. None of it truly mattered.

I want to set this part down precisely. There was nothing I discovered on that first day. This book isn't a story about me discovering something. I simply read, and that day, nothing happened from the reading.

Days like that go on for about two hundred days. Nothing happened for two hundred days. I won't write out all two hundred, but I'm noting here that they happened. So that whoever reads this record doesn't think I was carrying some kind of premonition around with me the whole time.

I had no premonition at all. I was just a girl who read to the end.

There was a box at the bottom of the last of the forty pages too.

A long, narrow horizontal box, with small letters above it reading the signature box.

It was empty.

That day, I didn't think anything of it.

(Continued in Chapter 2.)

Chapter 2. The Equity

> *_Previously_ — Hora, seated at the Fourth Deliberation District's assistant*
> *member desk by a vacancy and a number. Her first session ended in twenty*
> *minutes, and she stayed behind alone to read all forty pages to the end.*
> *The summary was accurate, and the signature box on the last page was*
> *empty. That day, she thought nothing of it.*

People hearing this city's name for the first time usually laugh. The Equity. I think it's because the name is so bald about itself. Haven lets you rest, the Reckoning squares the accounts, the Harvest gathers you in, the Preserve keeps you safe — so the Equity, people assume, must mean it treats you fairly.

I've watched that reaction many times. And I've heard, many times, what those same people say about half a year later. After about half a year, everyone says the same thing.

"…It really does live up to the name."

I'm not writing that sentence to be ironic. It's simply true. This city lives up to its name. I'm going to write a great many hard things about this city later in this book, and before I write them, I wanted this chapter written first. I didn't want the things I say later to turn this chapter into a lie.

. . .

I'll start with the ration office.

Every winter, heating fuel runs short. What's short has to be divided, and of course someone ends up with less. In other cities, I've heard, this is when people line up. First come, first served, and whoever comes late gets nothing.

Here, no one lines up. You only apply. It doesn't matter when. You can apply in the morning or in the evening. The Consensus gathers the year's need, the year's supply, and the number of households, calculates the allotment, and posts the result on the door. Who applied at what hour never enters the calculation.

When I was twelve, I once thought this was strange. I asked my aunt, "… Shouldn't the person who applies first get more?"

My aunt looked at me for a while and said,

"…Applying first doesn't make you any less cold."

She was right. I still can't explain, even now, why that sentence felt so clean.

Someone who's never stood in a line doesn't know how much a line can divide people. I first learned it listening to kids who'd come from outside talk about lines — that a whole day gets decided by who stands in front and who stands behind. Here, there is no such day.

. . .

The word for pulling strings is almost never used here either.

As far as I know, no one in this city goes to find someone and ask, separately, to be looked after well. There's no one to go find. Every counter runs the same

procedure, and the procedure runs the same way no matter who's staffing it. There's no part left to a clerk's discretion.

This isn't because the officials are unbending. I've watched a good many people working the counters, and they were all kind. But kindness never changed the outcome. What kindness couldn't get done stayed undone, and what a curt manner got done, got done.

I only learned later how rare this is. In other cities, I've heard, the outcome changes depending on who you smile at. Here, smiling changes nothing. I've never once thought this made the place bleak. If anything it was the opposite.

My aunt once said she'd worked briefly in another city. There, she said, remembering a superior's birthday was part of the job. Whether you remembered or not is what split people apart at promotion time. She laughed telling me that, but there was a slight bitterness at the end of the laugh. "… Coming here, I found out you didn't have to remember things like that. At first, not having to felt strange. Like I was forgetting something." Hearing that, I wanted to tell her she wasn't forgetting anything — there had never been anything there to remember — but I could tell she already knew that, so I said nothing.

I've never seen the loud win here either. In meeting rooms, at counters, at school, I've never once watched anyone raise their voice and get something out of it. Raising your voice just makes you a somewhat strange person. That's the whole of it.

There's something I saw when I was thirteen. Two houses on our lane got into a dispute over a fence line. One side was loud and one side was quiet. In another city, the loud side would have won — a neighbor who'd come from outside told me that afterward. Here, the surveying office came out, checked the old land register against the current fence, and a number gave the answer. The loud side's adult fumed for a good while after getting the result, but fuming didn't move the fence. Three days later that house had gone quiet too.

It had no choice but to go quiet. There was no longer anyone left to fight — you can't fight a number the way you can fight the surveying office.

I still remember those three days. Watching that fuming adult go quiet after three days, I thought this wasn't losing — it was simply ending. Losing means losing to someone, and there had been no someone there.

I crossed paths with that adult a few more times afterward, and they never seemed especially uncomfortable seeing me. There was no trace of someone who'd lost a fence dispute. I found that strange. In another city, I imagine, seeing that fence every time would have stung. Here, looking at the fence, there was no one left to be stung by. You couldn't hate the surveying office. The surveying office had only measured.

. . .

Housing reassignment worked the same way. When I was fifteen, the place my aunt and I lived became too small, and I applied for reassignment. The application only asked for household size and current square footage. It didn't ask what my aunt used to do for work, or how long we'd lived in this city. Two months later a new place was assigned. It wasn't bigger, but it had one more room. Why that particular place wasn't written down. The Consensus must have matched that year's list of empty homes against the list of applicants, the counter clerk explained. That explanation was enough for me. I had no reason to press further.

. . .

I should say something about the old man next door. He was among the longest-lived people in this city. His legs were bad, and every year he applied for care assignment, and the application asked nothing but that his legs were

bad. How many children he had, what work he used to do — none of that was asked.

I thought that was strange. It seemed to me that knowing such things would let people understand his particular hardship better. I asked the old man about it, and he answered,

"…Where's the sense in one hardship being harder than another? Bad legs are bad legs, same as anyone's."

That might sound curt, but I thought there was relief inside it. The old man didn't have to sell his story. He didn't have to plead to anyone. The single fact that his legs were bad was enough.

When I heard that in some places you have to sell your story to get help, I couldn't believe it at first. What happens to someone with no story? Someone who isn't good at telling one? Here, the question itself was never needed.

That old man received his care assignment that winter, and when spring came, he filed the same application again. The same form, every time. I once asked whether he didn't find it tedious. He answered, "…Tedious is better than having to explain yourself fresh every time." Hearing that, I thought for the first time about how fortunate it actually was, for a form to be tedious. Explaining yourself fresh every time meant having to persuade someone, every time.

Work assignments were the same. There's no such thing as an interview when this city assigns you a job. You submit an aptitude test and a preference, and the Consensus places you. At first I found this disappointing too — it meant there was no chance to show how good I was at something. But looked at the other way, it also meant no one was rejected for a first impression.

I filed my first preference form at fifteen. I wrote that I wanted to work in the records room. I didn't have to give a reason, but I gave one anyway. "I'm good

at reading things all the way to the end." Looking at it now it's a slightly embarrassing sentence, but at the time it was everything I had. When the result came, I was told I'd been placed on the preliminary list for the deliberation district instead of the records room. Why it had changed wasn't written down. The Consensus must have matched the aptitude results against that year's projected vacancies, the officer explained. I was disappointed, but not wronged. There's a real difference between disappointed and wronged, and that was the first time I learned it.

. . .

People hear talk like this and always ask, "So nobody has any complaints?"

There are complaints. I have them too. There was a winter I felt the allotment was too small, and a time my aunt's application was processed late. But the problem was always who those complaints were supposed to be aimed at. There was no one to aim them at.

The allotment had been small because that year there truly hadn't been enough. My aunt's application had been late because that year applications had piled up. I was angry, but I couldn't find anyone worth being angry at, so in the end I just let it go.

Reading this sentence back now, I'm still not sure myself whether this is a good thing or a bad thing to say. Whether not being able to get angry is the same as not needing to — I still don't know. But at the time, it truly was a relief. It wasn't that I'd been wronged. It was just that the year had been the way it was.

. . .

There's something I learned at school that I still remember.

The teacher wrote this on the board: "The Equity takes no one's side." And underneath, one more line: "And it sees no one as a person."

At the time I thought that second sentence was frightening. The teacher noticed and explained.

"…Not seeing you as a person doesn't mean treating you carelessly. The Consensus doesn't see you as Hora. It sees an application number. But that isn't a bad thing. If it saw you as Hora, then someone who liked you could look after you more, and someone who didn't could look after you less. Seen as a number, that can't happen."

At the time I thought I understood what she meant. Thinking about it now, I only half understood.

At that same moment, the kid in the next seat raised a hand and asked, "Then what happens if the number is wrong?" The teacher paused a moment, then answered, "…The number has never once been wrong." I didn't realize, at the time, that this wasn't an answer to the question. Whether the number has never been wrong, and what happens when it is, are two different questions.

Whether seeing a number and not seeing a person are truly the same thing is a question this book comes back to later. That day in the classroom, I didn't even have the question yet.

. . .

I should write down the clinic too. This city has no such thing as an appointment. When you go in sick, it's not the order you arrived in that decides when you're seen — the Consensus judges how severe your symptoms are and sets the order from that. I went through this myself when my aunt was

badly hurt. There were six people in the waiting room, and my aunt, who'd arrived after us, was called in third. Not one of the people ahead of her complained. I asked afterward, and I was told the screen had shown, along with the queue order, the reason it had been set that way. My aunt's bleeding needed to be stopped urgently; the people ahead of her weren't urgent. Seeing the reason, the anger didn't come, a man in the waiting room told me afterward.

"…When they show you the reason, what's left to argue?"

I remembered those words for a long time. That showing the reason settles the anger. This is always how this city calms people down. Not persuasion — inspection. Instead of someone stepping forward to say, "I'm sorry, it came out that way because of my judgment," the grounds appeared on the screen. I've never once felt that was cold. There are times when grounds comfort a person more than an apology does — I learned that for the first time in that waiting room.

. . .

There's one reason I'm writing this chapter.

A day is coming when I write about this city while I'm angry at it. I wanted to set this down so that day's version of me won't betray the me writing now. I like this city right now. I genuinely like it.

No one envies me here, and I envy no one. No one lines up here, no one asks for a favor, no one raises a voice. I think this is a good way to live. I still think so.

Writing this sentence, I don't yet know how hard it will come to make things for me later. It would have been so much easier if I could have said this wasn't a good place. It was a good place. That was the problem.

I've tried, a few times, to explain to people from outside why this city is good. It never went well. If I said, "No one here gets wronged," they'd always ask back, "So no one here does especially well, either?" That was true. No one did especially well. I never once thought of that as a loss — but every time I got that question, I did doubt, briefly, whether I might be missing something. Looking back now, I think that doubt was the tiniest seed of this book.

On my second day of work, on my way to the meeting room, I passed the ration office. A notice was posted. This winter's heating fuel allotment results. No names, only numbers. I found my number and checked the amount. It was a little higher than last year's.

Why it had gone up wasn't written down. I wasn't curious about it at the time. There was that same box at the very bottom of the notice too. A box marked "approval." It was empty. I didn't think anything of it that day either. It was only natural for a notice to have an approval box, and only natural for it to be empty. I didn't yet know there was a gap between those two kinds of natural.

I arrived at the meeting room and took my seat. The same seat as yesterday. The person next to me only nodded instead of greeting me. That was fine too. I was already growing a little more comfortable with the fact that not greeting someone here wasn't rude. Today's stack of material was thinner than yesterday's. I started with the summary, and I meant to read the full text behind it to the end as well. For now that was simply a habit of mine. It meant nothing more.

(Continued in Chapter 3.)

Chapter 3. The First Deliberation

> *_Previously_ — Hora going back over, one by one, just how fair a city the*
> *Equity is. No lines, no favors, the loud never win. She likes this city. She genuinely likes it. On the morning of her second day, she sits down*
> *again with a thin stack of material.*

I should describe the Fourth Deliberation District's meeting room in more detail, since the time I spent in that room is going to make up most of this record.

One long table, twenty-two chairs. At first I wondered why twenty-two, but no one knew. They only said it had always been that way. I checked whatever regulations I could find, and none of them said why the seat count was twenty-two. It was simply twenty-two.

Nineteen of those seats were filled. The other three, I heard, had stood empty for a long time. I learned only later that I'd nearly become one of those three — that the seat I sat in had, in fact, originally been one of them.

Nothing hung on the walls. There was one window, of frosted glass. Light came through, but you couldn't see outside. On the first day I thought that was strange. But after a few days, not being able to see out was actually a relief. There was nothing to let your mind wander off toward.

Of the nineteen people, I knew almost none of the faces. Their ages were all different. The oldest was older than my aunt, and the youngest only a couple of years older than me. I wondered what everyone had been doing before they came here, but no one introduced themselves. There was simply no occasion

for it. I thought that was strange, but after a few days I saw it wasn't a bad thing either. If you didn't know what a person did, you could hear their words as just words, not as that person's words.

In front of each seat sat a small nameplate, but it held a number, not a name. My seat was number seventeen. I got confused for a while over whether that number was mine or the seat's, but I found out later it belonged to the seat. Meaning I was the person sitting in seat seventeen, not that I was seventeen myself. I didn't understand, then, why that distinction mattered.

There was no trace on the nameplate of who had sat in seat seventeen before me. The nameplate was as spotless as if it had been replaced with a fresh one the very day that person quit. Sitting down in that seat, for the briefest moment, I wondered whether some warmth from the person before me might still be left in it. There wasn't. The chair was just a chair. I still don't know, even now, whether that left me disappointed or relieved.

. . .

The first case up for deliberation was a materials reassignment.

The proposal was to divert part of a building-materials request from the eastern district out of the western district's supply. The west had a surplus, the east had a shortfall, and the Consensus had calculated the difference and sent it up to this room.

There was no chair's seat, as such. One of the people seated ran that day's session, but that person wasn't called a "chairperson." They were only called whoever was handling the session that day. A different person might handle the next one, I was told.

I asked the person next to me, that day, who decided who ran it. "…We take turns. There's an order to it." "…Who sets the order?" "…Seat number order.

Today happened to be seat five's turn." I liked that answer. Even running the session wasn't anyone's choice. It was simply the order. Not because the person in seat five was especially capable, and not because the others trusted them. It was only that the order had come around to them.

Running the session didn't make that person's voice carry any more weight, either. The one running it still had to raise a hand and file an objection like anyone else, and never got to put a case in order first just because it was their turn to run it. I liked that this was the rule I found most agreeable in that room. A word from whoever held the microphone weighed exactly the same as a word from whoever didn't.

I looked up that rotation schedule later. The twenty-two seats turned in a fixed cycle. Which meant that seventeen, my seat, would someday come up for its turn running the session. I tried imagining how that day might feel. I couldn't quite picture it.

The rotation schedule still carried the three empty seats in it, unchanged. Even a seat no one sat in came up in its turn to run the session. When that happened, I was told, it was simply skipped. Something about that skipping stayed with me, somehow. The schedule remembered who was missing, but nowhere did it say why they were missing. The schedule knew who was absent but not why.

The person running that first session skimmed the material once and said,

"…The eastern request and the western surplus match what the Consensus calculated. Any objections?"

No one raised a hand.

"…If there are none, it's put in order."

And that was the end of it. I sat waiting for what came next, but the session had already moved on to the next case. I thought, at the time, that it had gone

by so fast I must have missed something.

Later I opened the material again and read this first case from beginning to end. The request, the calculation's basis, a comparison table of holdings by district, three past cases of the same kind. It was all there. I didn't know, at the time, whether anyone besides me had read it to the end. The summary alone was already enough. I only read it to the end because I read slowly, not because I suspected anything. This distinction is one I end up making again, many times, later in this book.

. . .

The second case took a little longer.

This time there was an objection. Someone described as the western district's representative raised a hand and said,

"…The west also has construction planned for next spring, so if it's diverted now, there could be a shortfall come spring."

The person running the session wrote that down. Then said,

"…We'll check."

And they truly did check. An aide beside them tapped at a terminal and brought up next spring's planned construction on the screen. There really was planned construction in the western district. The Consensus recalculated it. It took a few minutes. A new result came back. This proposal would reduce the reassigned amount slightly, and draw a little more surplus from another district instead.

"…Will this do?"

The western representative looked at the new figures and nodded.

"…That's fine."

I still call this scene to mind often, even now. No one got angry. There was no sense of anyone having beaten anyone. The western representative hadn't gotten everything they'd asked for, and their face was truly satisfied all the same. That satisfaction struck me as strange. In another city, I've since heard many times from people who came from outside, this moment would have had raised voices in it. Here, only numbers passed back and forth twice, in place of voices.

I asked that western representative separately, later, why they'd been satisfied when they'd received less than they'd first asked for. They smiled briefly and said,

"…It's not that I got less. I got as much as I needed. What I first asked for, I'd padded generously."

"…Why pad it?"

"…In case it fell short. But once the Consensus recalculated, it turned out I didn't need to pad it after all."

Hearing that answer, I confirmed again that this person had neither lost nor won. The numbers had simply been squared. Squaring the numbers needed neither a winner nor a loser.

That person then went on gathering their materials and added one more thing. "…When I first started here, I couldn't break the habit of padding generously either. After a few years, I just started asking for what I actually needed. Because I knew the Consensus would square it either way." I wondered whether that could be explained with the word trust. It looked, to me, less like trust than like a state where being on guard had simply stopped being

necessary. Whether not needing to be on guard is the same thing as believing — I didn't know then, and I still don't.

. . .

The way people spoke was strange.

No one said "In my opinion." No one said "I object." Everyone said, "This needs to be checked," "It will be put in order for you," "If that's what was passed on."

I couldn't tell whether this was modesty, or simply how these people talked. I asked the person next to me, quietly,

"…Does no one say what they actually think?"

"…This is what they think. Saying it needs checking is an opinion too. Saying it's fine is an opinion too."

"…But why not say it that way? …Just, like, I'm worried about this."

The person beside me thought for a moment, then said,

"…Say it that way, and it becomes my worry. Say it needs checking, and it becomes something everyone has to check."

I thought about that late into that night. That there was a way of speaking that kept a worry from becoming anyone's own — that was the first time I noticed such a thing existed.

For a while after that I practiced that way of speaking. At home, instead of saying "In my opinion" to my aunt, I tried saying "This seems like it needs checking." My aunt laughed. "…You've been going to that meeting room and

now you talk like a government office." I was embarrassed and stopped, but the moment I stepped back into that room, the speech came out of me on its own. As natural as changing clothes.

Looking back now, I think this was the beginning. Change how you speak, and how you think changes a little too, along with it. I may have been losing, little by little, the way of saying "what I think," even then. I didn't notice the losing, at the time. That becoming comfortable and losing something can arrive together — I only learned that much, much later.

. . .

By the third case on, I'd already grown a little used to it.

A number was called, the summary was read aloud, objections were asked for, and if there were none it moved on, and if there were, it was checked and recalculated. Not one of the twenty-two seats ever said they had decided this. Everyone said it "was put in order."

The session ended after the sixth case. I checked the clock — it had only been a little over twenty minutes. I couldn't believe six matters had been handled in that short a time.

Growing used to something is a frightening thing. On the first day, this pace felt so foreign that I kept checking the clock. But after sitting in that room more than two hundred times since, I stopped checking it. I've never measured exactly how long it takes for the foreign to stop feeling foreign. I think it would have frightened me, if I had.

The fourth case was an adjustment to school assignments. The fifth was the order of road repairs. The sixth was a proposal to move one of the ration counters, because several complaints had come in that its current location was hard to reach, and the Consensus had calculated a new site. All six cases

followed the exact same pattern. Summary, objection, check, put in order. Some finished in three minutes, some took nearly ten. The difference in time came down to whether there had been an objection or not — it didn't seem to have anything to do with how big the matter was. Something that touched children's lives directly, like a school assignment, and something as small as a counter's location, were handled at the same speed.

I thought that was strange, and then, thinking it over again, saw there was no reason it should be. To the Consensus, it was all the same calculation. The Consensus made no distinction between what people considered important and what they considered unimportant. Whether not making that distinction meant fairness, or meant something was being missed — I couldn't answer that, that day.

. . .

After the session ended, people filed out one by one. As I gathered my material, I asked the person who'd run the session,

"…What's decided today — who finally confirms it?"

That person looked at me and said, smiling,

"…It's already confirmed. Just now."

"…But the, um, signature, or something like that—"

"…Ah, the signature box. You don't have to fill that in. No one's ever said to fill it in."

I nodded at that answer. That day, I really did believe it was that simple. No one had said to fill it in, so it wasn't filled in. There was nothing more to it.

Reading this exchange back now, I know that person wasn't deceiving me. They genuinely believed it that way too. That it wasn't filled in because no one had said to fill it in. They had probably never once wondered why no one had said so.

"…Then why does that box even exist?" I asked again. The person thought for a moment and answered, "…Hm. It's probably just been there from the start. Maybe it just never got removed when the form was updated." I thought that answer sounded plausible too. Old forms tend to keep boxes no one needs anymore, after all. That was truly all I thought, at the time. That the box might still be there out of laziness, or because remaking the form was too much trouble. The thought that it might still be there because there was no one to fill it in — that never once crossed my mind, that day.

On the way home I passed the water channel. The water was still making its sound. This time I didn't stop. My head was full of the meeting room's twenty-two seats, and the frosted window, and six decisions no one had decided. The water channel was pushed far down my list of thoughts that day.

Leaving the meeting room, I looked once more at the frosted window. Outside was still invisible. That day, for the first time, I wondered whether that window had been frosted from the start, or had become that way later. There was no one suitable to ask, so I let it go.

My aunt had dinner ready and waiting when I got home. She asked how it had gone. I started to tell her what had happened that day, in order, and realized, once I actually tried to put it into words, that there wasn't much to say. "…We handled six cases. They all went fine." My aunt nodded and said, "…That's how it always is there. It goes fine."

I thought she was right. It really had gone fine. Not one thing about it had been bad. But that night, before I fell asleep, for no reason, I called back each of those six "it will be put in order" moments, one by one. I never did manage

to remember who, exactly, had put any of them in order. The verb "put in order" had no subject. At the time, I only thought of that as a habit of speech.

(Continued in Chapter 4.)

Chapter 4. The Consensus

> *_Previously_ — Hora, through her first deliberation. Nineteen of the*
> *twenty-two seats handled six cases. No one called anything their own*
> *opinion, and even running the session only came around in turn. That*
> *night she caught a flicker of a thought — that "it will be put in order"*
> *had no subject — but took it for nothing more than a manner of speech.*

Ask me to explain exactly what the Consensus is, and I still can't do it well. Most people born and raised in this city probably can't either. It's a bit like being asked what air is. It's always there, so no one ever bothers building the words to explain it.

I'll try anyway. Only as much as I know.

. . .

The Consensus doesn't hand down decisions — it gathers them.

I first learned that difference at school. The teacher explained it by comparing the Consensus to a scale. Put weight on one side of a scale, and the other side tips. The heavier side wins. The Consensus, she said, is not a scale.

"…The Consensus doesn't load anything on. It only gathers. Every record of everyone living in this city, every precedent, every statistic, every objection. It gathers it all and finds the center of that weight. No one decides where the center is. It simply appears there on its own, because that's how the things are arranged."

I liked that comparison at the time. I liked the phrase "center of weight." A point that comes into being on its own, without anyone pushing. A scale shows you who won. A center of weight doesn't show you who won. It's simply there. I believed, then — truly believed — that this difference explained everything about this city.

I still call that comparison to mind sometimes, even now. And every time, I run into the same question. For it to be true that the center of weight appears on its own, it matters, from the start, how the things were arranged. Who put those things there. I couldn't ask that question that day. I was ten, and the comparison was pretty. That's all it was.

The teacher drew that comparison on the board too — a picture of a scale, and beside it a scatter of dots with one small dot marked at the center. "This dot in the middle is the Consensus." I copied that drawing into my notebook. That notebook must be somewhere still; I've never gone looking for it. I'm a little afraid that if I did, I'd only confirm all over again how little I doubted, back then, taking it all down.

At that same moment, some kid raised a hand and asked, "Who put those dots there?" The teacher answered, smiling, "All of us did. Every record we leave behind, living our lives — that's the dots." I thought, at the time, that answer was enough. All of us. I didn't know then how wide that phrase was, and at the same time, how empty.

At break I talked to that kid again. They still looked unsettled about something. "…But if you say all of us, doesn't that end up meaning no one in particular?" I wanted to argue with that, but I didn't really have anything to

argue back with. "…What's the difference between no one and all of us?" I asked back. They couldn't answer either. We left that question sitting there that day and moved on to the next class. I never once pulled that question back out again for years afterward. A question left sitting doesn't vanish — it only gets put off.

. . .

The first time I heard the sheer volume of material the Consensus handles, I was startled.

Every application in this city, every meeting record, every complaint, every statistic goes into the Consensus. Material from ten years ago, I was told, and from a hundred years ago too. Nothing, they said, had ever been erased.

I liked that phrase, "nothing erased." I'd heard that elsewhere, old records tend to disappear, or get quietly removed whenever it's convenient for someone. Here there was none of that. Look up an old record, and it really was all there.

Once, for a school assignment, I looked up a ration record from a hundred years back. It really existed. What had been short that winter, who received how many units, even how that decision had come out — all of it remained. That was when I truly felt, for the first time, that this city hides not one thing of its past.

Hiding nothing, and knowing nothing — those are different sentences. I used those two sentences as if they meant the same thing, for a long time. A great deal of this book is the process of learning that they're actually different.

Working on that assignment, I also tried to look up the name of the person in charge of rations a hundred years ago. There wasn't one. Only the department's title. I didn't think that was strange, at the time. A hundred years had passed, I figured, of course the name wouldn't survive. But when I asked the teacher,

she said names had never been kept, not even a hundred years ago. "…It's been that way from the start. Leave an individual official's name on record, and eventually someone ends up resenting that person, or praising them." I nodded at that explanation. Records with neither resentment nor praise in them. That was how this city had kept itself for a hundred years.

I got a good mark on that assignment. I'd copied the department title and the procedure exactly. Other kids got similar marks. No one pointed out that there was no name for the person in charge. There was no reason to point it out. Writing down that something wasn't there, when it truly wasn't there, was never grounds for losing marks. Walking home that day, I felt, all over again, how entirely natural it was that no one wondered about what wasn't there.

. . .

There's a separate reason I came to respect the Consensus.

The Consensus has never once claimed to be right. Whenever a deliberation's result came out, the grounds for it were always attached beside it. Not "This decision is correct," but "Gathering these materials produces this result."

And when an objection came in, the Consensus never defended itself. It recalculated. From the start it assumed that a result could change if new material came in. I thought this was an extremely humble attitude. That the possibility of being wrong was something the system itself acknowledged.

It might sound strange to attach the word humility to a system. But I still can't take that word away from it, even now. The Consensus has never once said, "I decided this." That it never says that struck me, at the time, as a virtue. That not saying it might actually mean it couldn't say it — that never once crossed my mind, at the time.

I used to compare this humility to stories of other cities. Whenever kids who'd come from outside talked about where they used to live, a name always came up. That person decided it, it turned out this way because of that person, if not for that person it would have gone differently. Every time I heard stories like that, I felt tired. I kept wondering why someone had to be dragged into it every single time. Here, there was no need for that. Even when a result didn't sit right, there was no face to resent. Having no face to resent felt hollow at first, but once I got used to it, it felt freeing instead. I enjoyed that freedom for a long time. I haven't entirely given it up, even now. But that this freedom carried a price — I only learn that later in this book. Having no face to resent meant, also, having no face to apologize. At the time, I had no need to look at the reverse side of that sentence.

. . .

I once asked the person next to me how the Consensus actually calculates. They said they didn't know the exact method either.

"…I don't know the calculation method itself. I can see all the underlying material, but how it's all combined to produce a result…"

"…No one knows that?"

"…It's less that no one knows, more that there's no need to know. If there's an objection to a result, you just look at the material again. What matters is being able to verify the result without knowing the process."

I nodded at that answer, and then thought about it again on the way home. Whether being able to verify a result without knowing the process, and no one knowing the process, are really the same thing. I reached no conclusion that day.

For a few days after, I went looking for material that explained how the Consensus calculates. The library had a few introductory volumes. I read them all, and every one of them, however detailed about how a result was verified, blurred over how the calculation happened before that verification with a single phrase — "through a complex process." I didn't think that came from carelessness — I thought the people who'd written it simply didn't know any more than that either. No one had hidden anything. Everyone had written exactly as much as they knew. The problem seemed to be that no one knew — but at the time, I didn't even think to call that a problem.

. . .

I also wondered whether there was anything the Consensus couldn't handle.

One day I asked the person running the session, "…Is there anything the Consensus can't decide?" They thought for a moment and answered,

"…It can't decide something that's never been brought up as a case."

"…Why wouldn't something get brought up?"

"…Because it only gets brought up if someone brings it up."

I let that answer pass without much thought, at the time. It sounded like the obvious thing to say. You need a case before you can handle it — how would you handle something that doesn't exist. I didn't think of the water channel, in that moment. I truly didn't think of it, that day.

Writing this down again now, I know that exchange was one of the most important in this book. I didn't know it then. That I didn't know is the truly frightening part of this book. It isn't that I missed something important — I had no material to even judge whether it was important or not.

I asked the person running that session one more thing. "…Then who can bring something up? Can anyone?" They answered. "…Yes. Anyone. Write your name and your reason, and it's accepted." "…Why does a name have to be written?" "…So you know whose case it is. Without a name, it isn't accepted." I thought, at the time, that this rule was fairly fair. That anyone could bring up a case at all. Why the condition of writing a name existed, I let go as nothing more than administrative procedure. I still didn't know how rare a thing it was, in this city, to write down a name.

Walking back to my seat that day, I suddenly wondered. Of the nineteen people sitting in this room, had any of them ever brought up a case under their own name. I didn't ask. Even if I had, I wouldn't have caught the weight of the answer, not then.

. . .

A few days later, I looked up one of the Consensus's calculated results — not the summary this time, but the full text of the grounds behind it. There was no particular reason. It was just my habit of reading.

The underlying material was vast. More than twenty related cases, an opinion paper from each district, five past decisions of a similar kind. It took half a day to read it all. And on the last page was a list of everyone who had handled this deliberation. About four hundred people. I paused for a moment, looking at that number.

Four hundred people had been involved in this one matter, and there was no one who had decided it. Each of the four hundred had done something, but adding up all of it, there wasn't a single person who said, "I decided this."

This is the first time I set this number down here. Four hundred. This number comes up again later. When it does, it comes back far heavier. Right now it was only a curious number. That so many people could be tied up in one case

and still no one carried the responsibility — that didn't feel bad to me. It felt safe, if anything.

I looked more closely at that list. The titles were all different. Intake, cross-checking, confirmation, passing on, putting in order, convening. About six titles, divided across four hundred people. Each person's job was exactly that one title, nothing more. Whoever handled intake did only intake; whoever cross-checked did only cross-checking. Passing through all six stages was what produced a decision — and yet, among all six stages, not one of them carried the title "decision." I only found that curious, at the time. If you asked who did the job of deciding, this list couldn't answer precisely. And yet the decision was plainly there, right at the end.

. . .

That night, I told my aunt about the Consensus.

"…Auntie, I get why the Consensus is good. Nobody claims to be right."

My aunt looked up from her meal.

"…Why's that good?"

"…Then no one can be cornered for being wrong either. Everyone just gathered it, after all."

My aunt thought for a moment and said,

"…No one being wrong, and no one being right — isn't that a hair's difference apart?"

I let that pass, that day, without giving it much thought. My aunt sometimes said cryptic things like that. I finished my meal, and that sentence sat quietly

inside me for a while.

Sitting quietly doesn't mean it disappeared. I end up pulling that sentence back out, months later, in a place entirely different from this one. My aunt, eating her meal that day, probably didn't know how precise a thing she'd said. Neither did I.

Finishing her meal and clearing the bowls, my aunt added one more thing. "… But that's not to say it's a bad thing. I've lived here over forty years myself, and I've never once been badly wronged." That remark stayed with me more than the last one had. No one being right wasn't a frightening thing to my aunt. The fact of never having been wronged outweighed that fear, and then some. I thought, that day, that her arithmetic was sound. Forty years without being wronged. I thought that might be enough, all on its own.

I lay down and went back over, in order, what I'd learned that day. The Consensus gathers. It doesn't measure. It's humble. It hides nothing. Four hundred people can be involved and there's still no one who decided. Laid side by side, these sentences were strangely harmonious. Consistent, as if written by the same hand. I liked that consistency. Every explanation this city gave never contradicted another. I believed, at the time, that consistency and truth were the same thing.

The days that followed were no different from before. I sat in the meeting room and read the summaries, and once everyone else had left, I read the full text to the end. The result always matched the grounds. That reassured me. The Consensus had never once told a lie.

(Continued in Chapter 5.)

Chapter 5. Tyche

> *_Previously_ — Hora learning that the Consensus gathers rather than measures. A system that looks humble, a structure where four hundred people can be involved and still no one decides. In passing, her aunt said, "No one being wrong, and no one being right — isn't that a hair's difference apart?" and the sentence settled quietly inside her.*

I met Tyche for the first time on the third day.

I was still, that day, holding onto the material and struggling to understand something. There was an unfamiliar term in the third case's underlying material, and I couldn't pin down its meaning from the surrounding context either way. I thought about asking the person beside me, but everyone looked busy before the session started, so I gave up on it.

That was when someone came and sat down next to me. Someone who looked about a year older than me. They had a bundle of material tucked under one arm, and their expression was at ease.

"…Something you're stuck on?"

I looked at them, startled. I started to ask how they knew, then realized I'd been sitting there for a while with my finger on that unfamiliar word. It must have shown.

"…Ah, I don't know what this word means."

They looked at the screen and answered right away.

"…That's the calculation-basis adjustment value. It takes the original baseline figure and multiplies it by that year's variable to correct it — in this case, rainfall was the variable used."

They were so fast and so exact that I sat there stunned for a moment.

"…How do you know that so instantly?"

"…I see this material all the time. I've pretty much memorized the material this meeting room uses."

I liked that it didn't sound like boasting. It had the tone of someone simply stating a fact. I looked at their face again. There was ease in the expression. Not rushed, but not slow either. I'd never seen a person like that before. I was always one or the other — rushed, or slow. That day was the first time I'd actually seen the middle ground exist in a person.

Their hair was short, and their clothes were similar to the other assistants'. There was nothing especially eye-catching about them. Except that their gaze never wavered when they spoke. I thought that, if anything, was what stood out. It was rare, in this room, for someone speaking not to look away. Everyone else looked at their material, or their hands, or somewhere else. Tyche looked me in the eye while they spoke.

. . .

That person's name was Tyche.

A deliberation assistant, they said. A few were posted to each meeting room, to help members understand the material, they said. I hadn't even known such a role existed.

"…It's always been here. It's just that everyone only looks at the summary, so there isn't much occasion to call one of us."

"…Then what about me?"

"…You read the full text, Hora. So of course you get stuck somewhere. It's only natural."

That surprised me a little. That they already knew I read the full text. I'd never told anyone that.

"…How did you know?"

"…It's in the material checkout records. People who only look at the summary never even open the full-text file. You've opened it every time."

I thought, for a moment, that this was slightly frightening — and then let the thought go. It wasn't surveillance. It was just a record, and someone with the standing to view that record had looked. Nothing had been hidden. I could have looked at anyone else's checkout record too, if I'd wanted to.

Tyche's own introduction was brief too. Born and raised in the Equity, and doing this deliberation-assistant work for about two years now, they said. "…I haven't really been anywhere else. This is all there is for me." It was much the same for me. I was glad of that. Being with someone who didn't need to talk about the outside. With kids who talked about the outside, I always felt like I was talking to them across one remove. With Tyche, none of that was necessary.

. . .

Whatever I asked Tyche, the answer came fast.

"…When did this provision come into being?"
"…It was revised eleven years ago. Before that it used a different standard."

"…Why does this district get more materials?"
"…Higher population density. More people live in the same area, so the demand for materials is higher too."

"…Where does this number come from?"
"…This table, third row. It's the average over the last five years."

"…Why are this provision and that one filed in this order?"
"…That's the numbering order. That's just how the provision numbers were originally assigned. Not by content order."

I found it striking that Tyche never got stuck no matter what I asked. I never once heard them say they didn't know.

"…Is there nothing you don't know, Tyche?"

Tyche laughed.

"…There is. But if I don't know something, I can just look it up. I'll find it and come back with the answer."

And that's exactly what happened. There was a question that afternoon they hadn't been able to answer, and the next morning Tyche came in ahead of me with the answer already in hand.

That question was why some district's old boundary line had been drawn the way it currently was. Tyche hadn't had an answer that day and had only said, "…I'll check on it." The next morning, before I'd even sat down, Tyche came over holding a single document. "…Found it. The boundary was redrawn twenty-three years ago during a river maintenance project. Here's the map from that time." I took that document from them, amazed that Tyche had truly

found a twenty-three-year-old map in a single day. "…How did you find it?" "…It's all in the records room. It's just a matter of knowing how to look." I thought that was modesty, but I found out later it was simply the truth. Everything really was in the records room.

That was the day I saw the records room for the first time too — the underground stacks I followed Tyche into. Shelves stretched on endlessly, each one labeled with a year and a classification number. There was hardly anyone there. Tyche walked with a familiar stride, turned a few corners down the aisles, and pulled a folder from exactly the right slot. "…Do you come here often?" "…Yes. A couple times a week." I liked that space. It was quiet, and whatever you were looking for was, more often than not, there.

Walking further between the shelves, I asked Tyche,

"…Can you find anything in here, Tyche?"

"…Most of it. There are a few sections I've gotten lost in, but I do end up finding it eventually, even then."

"…You've gotten lost before?"

"…Of course. There was one classification once where the numbering system changed partway through — took me half a day to find what I needed because of that."

I was glad to hear that. That Tyche had moments of being lost too — somehow it made them feel a little closer to me.

. . .

A few days later, Tyche once took me to their own desk. It was a small room the deliberation assistants used, one whole wall covered in index cards. It

looked hand-organized.

"…What's all this?"

"…An index of provisions I look up often. You can find them electronically too, but keeping them organized by hand is faster."

I looked over the cards one by one. Dates, provision numbers, one-line summaries, all in neat handwriting. There must have been several hundred.

"…When did you make all of these?"

"…A little at a time, over two years. Whenever I had a spare moment."

Looking at that bundle of cards, I could tell Tyche truly loved this work. These weren't the cards of someone doing a job because they'd been told to.

I picked up one of the cards. It read "Roster Assignment Regulation upon Vacancy." Seeing it, I thought of my own situation and asked,

"…Isn't this the regulation that got me sitting here?"

Tyche took the card back and looked at it, then nodded.

"…That's right. Assignment by roster number when a vacancy comes up."

"…Do you know why it was decided this way?"

"…Hm, apparently there used to be a recommendation system. But since the outcome ended up split depending on the recommender's own feelings, it was changed to a roster system. Something like twenty-some years ago."

I nodded at that explanation. Which meant that my sitting here was the result of someone, twenty-some years ago, working hard to get rid of the problems

with the recommendation system. I thought that wasn't a bad lineage to come from. That I sat here because of a number, not because of someone's feelings.

"…So I'm just here because of a number, then."

"…Right. But why is that a problem? Is being here because of a number a bad thing?"

I couldn't answer that question right away. I'd never thought it was a bad thing. It was just that, for the first time, hearing the phrase "because of a number" applied to myself made it sound a little different.

. . .

I liked Tyche. I still like Tyche.

They were kind. There wasn't a cynical bone in them. They never seemed impatient with how slowly I read. If anything, there were times they found things and brought them to me before I even asked.

"…This is the background material for this case. It's a bit thick, but you like this kind of thing, Hora."

"…I don't like it, exactly. I just read it."

"…Isn't that the same as liking it?"

I couldn't answer that. It did seem like it might be true.

Tyche was the first person who never looked at me strangely for it. Back in school, everyone found my slowness frustrating. Here, no one did that either, but Tyche went one step further and simply took it as a given that I read to the end.

I went home and told my aunt about Tyche. "…Auntie, I met a deliberation assistant today, and they know the answer to everything I ask." My aunt smiled and asked, "…Are they nice?" "…Yeah. Really kind. But it's kind of amazing — they find everything faster than I do." My aunt paused, mid-ladle over the soup, and looked at me. "…Being quick and being kind are two different things, but it sounds like you've seen both in one person." I started to say something to that, then thought, it really is true, and just laughed.

The next day I passed that exact exchange on to Tyche. They laughed, amused. "…Your aunt's right. I could easily not be kind at all — maybe I just look kind because I love this work." I thought Tyche knew themselves quite precisely, hearing that. The distinction between not being kind and only looking kind because they loved the work — I'd never made a distinction like that before.

"…Then why do you love this work, Tyche?"

"…Because there's an answer. You ask something, and an answer comes out. I like that. I'm not really a fan of holding onto something that doesn't have an answer."

Hearing that, I looked back at myself. I was the type to hold onto something even without an answer. The way I'd left my mother's last line unread for two years. Tyche and I were different on that point. At the time, I only thought of it as a simple difference in personality.

. . .

Once, a deliberation result came out different from what I'd expected, and I asked Tyche about it.

"…I thought this district would get more — why did it come out this way?"

Tyche flipped through the screen a few times and answered.

"…What you saw was the request amount. The actual assignment also factors in past usage rates. This district didn't use up everything it was allotted last year. So this year it was reduced."

"…How do you check what wasn't used?"

"…Here — the usage performance report. Want to see it?"

Tyche opened the document right away and handed it over. I took it and read it. It really did say exactly that. Tyche had never once deceived me.

Writing this chapter, I keep turning over that precision of Tyche's. Tyche always said what was true. But that being true isn't everything — I only learn that a very long time later. That wasn't Tyche's fault. I want to set that down clearly.

That day I finished reading the usage performance report beside Tyche. Tyche did other work next to me until I finished. Not someone waiting for me, but someone simply staying beside me while getting their own work done. I liked that distinction. Being waited for can feel like a burden sometimes; just having someone beside you doesn't.

"…Finished reading?"

"…Yes. It really is exactly what you said."

"…Why would I lie? Anyone can look at it."

I agreed with that. It really was true. In this city, hiding something looked like it would actually be more trouble. To hide something you have to conceal it, and to conceal it you have to manage it, and managing it creates yet another record all its own. Not hiding anything was simply easier.

. . .

Once, walking down the hallway together after a session, we talked. I asked, that day, why this city was so exact about everything.

"…Do you like this city, Tyche?"

"…I do. It's exact."

"…Is being exact a good thing?"

"…Yes. When things are exact, no one gets wronged. Getting wronged is the worst thing there is."

I nodded at that. It was true.

"…But do you ever think, sometimes, if you suppose all of this is just chance…"

Tyche looked at me and smiled.

"…So what if it's chance? Even if it's chance, isn't it fine as long as it's exact?"

Something snagged in me at that answer, but I couldn't put into words, at the time, what it was. I just laughed it off. Tyche's words were always like that. Nothing to argue against, and yet never quite fully settling into comfort either.

We stood for a moment that day in front of the meeting room's window. Only a dim light came through the frosted glass.

"…Do you know what's outside that window, Tyche?"

"…The street. Nothing much."

"…Have you seen it?"

"…I've seen it from a window on another floor. It really is just a street."

That answer made me laugh a little. I must have been secretly hoping there was something special behind that window. Tyche seemed like they'd never once held a hope like that. If you were curious, you found out; once you found out, you had your answer; and that answer was, more often than not, nothing much. That was simply how the world was arranged, for Tyche.

"…Don't you get disappointed? When it's nothing much?"

"…What's there to be disappointed about. Better to know something's nothing much than to keep wondering without knowing."

I thought about that for a long time. That knowing something's nothing much is better than wondering without knowing. That was, without question, true. And yet even hearing it, some part of me never stopped wanting to look through that window myself.

Walking home, I went back over, in order, everything Tyche and I had talked about that day. Exactness. Answers. Numbers. Chance. Inside Tyche, these words sat side by side without ever colliding. I wondered how that was possible. For me, those words kept colliding somewhere. For Tyche, they didn't seem to.

(Continued in Chapter 6.)

Chapter 6. The Secretary

> *_Previously_ — Hora meeting Tyche, the deliberation assistant. Whatever*
> *she asked, Tyche answered exactly, kindly, without a trace of cynicism.*
> *"So what if it's chance? Isn't it fine as long as it's exact?" left something hanging inside Hora, though she still couldn't put into words*
> *what it was.*

I met the Secretary for the first time around the end of my first week.

Before that, I'd only seen the title "the Secretary" on paper. In the sender field of notices, in the approval history of meeting material, it always simply read "the Secretary." No name. I assumed that was the formal way the title was written. I didn't know yet that this wasn't a person named the Secretary, but a person seated in the post called the Secretary.

. . .

That day I'd filed a material request wrong. I'd meant to request more of the underlying material from a past deliberation, but I got the form confused and wrote it in the wrong box. The counter told me to fill it out again, and then someone from inside that counter came out and offered to look at it themselves.

That person was the Secretary.

Their age was hard to guess. They looked to be around forty, but their manner of speaking was calmer than that. Their clothes were neat, nothing about them dressed up. A low voice sat in their throat, and it only struck me later how that tone never once shifted, all day. They took the paperwork, looked it over, and pointed at a couple of spots.

"…Here, this box needs the previous session's number. Right now it has this session's number in it."

"…Ah, I'm sorry."

"…No, everyone gets confused by this at first. I'll fix it for you."

And they really did fix it, right there, on the spot. I didn't even know whether that was the Secretary's job to do or not, but they did it without a second thought.

After looking the corrected paperwork over once more, they stamped it. An intake-confirmation stamp. Watching that stamp come down, I suddenly thought of the signature box. Wondering whether this stamp stood in for a name, I asked,

"…Is that your own stamp?"

"…No, it's the counter's stamp. Whoever's working, the same stamp gets used."

"…You don't have your own stamp?"

The Secretary looked thoughtful for a moment, then answered.

"…No. There's never been a need for one."

I nodded at that answer without much thought. "There's never been a need for one" sounded, at the time, like nothing more than a practical explanation.

"…Then how would you go about getting a new one made?"

"…It's applied for. But no one's applied for one yet, as far as anyone's seen. Everyone seems to think the counter stamp is enough."

I took that answer without much thought too. If it's enough, of course a new one wouldn't get made.

As the Secretary put the paperwork into the intake tray, they added one more thing. "…You can receive the material with this now. It'll take two or three days." "…Thank you." "…No need. That's simply how the procedure runs." I heard "that's simply how the procedure runs" many times that day. Every time I thanked them, the Secretary deflected it with that phrase. As if it wasn't something they'd done for me, but something that had been done because the procedure ran that way. At first I took it for politeness. But after watching a few more days, I came to see it wasn't politeness at all. They meant it.

. . .

"…May I ask your name?"

That was the first time I'd asked. They smiled slightly and answered.

"…You can call me the Secretary."

"…No, I mean your name."

"…Just the Secretary. That's what everyone calls me here."

I thought, at first, they were avoiding the question. I started to ask again, then stopped, because there wasn't a trace of concealment in their expression. It was the face of someone genuinely accustomed to being addressed that way.

"…But on things like application forms, there's a box for a name, isn't there? What do you write there?"

"…The title. 'The Secretary,' like that."

"…Is not writing your name a rule?"

"…It isn't a rule. But that's how everyone writes it. When I first started here, I used to write my name too, but at some point I just started writing the title instead."

I was curious about that "at some point," but I didn't press further. That day I just let it be. People's habits change over time, after all.

From that point on, I never once called this person by a name. Not in this record either. I learn the reason later, and it isn't that this person was hiding anything. This person themselves simply took it as a given that their own name would never be called.

I told my aunt about it that evening. "…Auntie, the Secretary won't tell me their name. Just says to call them 'the Secretary.'" My aunt nodded. "…That's how it always is. I don't know our district's Secretary's name either, even after years." "…Doesn't that seem strange?" My aunt thought for a moment and said, "…Not so much strange as — I suppose that's just what the post is. It's not like knowing the name would change anything." I had nothing to argue back with. Nothing really would have changed.

"…But Auntie, how many years has your district's Secretary been in the post?"

My aunt counted for a moment, then answered. "…Five years or so, I think. I don't really remember the one before them." "…You didn't even notice they'd changed?" "…No, I just realized it one day when the voice was different. I never remembered the face well to begin with." That answer struck me as strangely sad, but my aunt set the soup bowl down without a trace of concern.

. . .

The Secretary handled convening the committee and its records. Setting meeting dates, distributing material, writing up the minutes, passing confirmed results on to each department. Everything I ever asked them about got explained back to me as one of these four things.

"…Don't you ever give your own opinion on what's being deliberated?"

"…Only convening happens here."

"…But you write the minutes yourself, don't you? Doesn't that mean you're deciding what goes in and what stays out?"

"…That's written to a fixed format. It isn't chosen."

I sensed that this answer didn't come from modesty so much as from genuinely believing it. A modest person sometimes laughs and says, "Oh, it's nothing I did." This person didn't laugh. It was truly the face of someone who believed nothing had been done by them at all.

I got curious about where that stamp was kept too, and asked someone at the counter. There was one at every counter, they said, and even when the person staffing it changed, the same stamp stayed in use. The stamp had a counter number engraved on it, not a person's name. I felt, all over again, that this was the same pattern as everything else in this city. Marks that attach to a seat, not to a person.

I looked up a few of the meeting minutes and read them too. The minutes the Secretary wrote really were free of any wasted word. Who had said what, what material had been submitted, what the result was — all set down in order, nothing more. Not a single line of their own thought or judgment went into it. I thought this made for good records. Since none of the writer's own color bled into it, anyone reading it would come away with the same content.

"…How do you decide what goes into the minutes?"

"…Everything goes in. What was said, material submitted, the result. Nothing left out."

"…So there's nothing you write as more important?"

"…No. It's all written the same."

I was impressed by that answer. I thought it made for a genuinely fair record. Later I'd come to think about what price that fairness was paid at, but that day I was simply impressed.

. . .

What stayed with me most from that first meeting was the way they spoke.

Not "This is how I'll handle it," but "This is how it gets handled." Not "I confirmed it," but "It was confirmed." At the time, I took this for nothing more than a bureaucrat's manner of speech. Since that's how everyone talked, I figured, this person talked that way too.

"…When does this case get handled?"

"…It gets handled next session."

"…Who handles it?"

The Secretary looked at me for a moment. Not because they couldn't answer — it looked more like the question had struck them as slightly unfamiliar.

"…It gets handled by the deliberation district."

In that moment I felt like I should ask something more, but I didn't know exactly what to ask, so I just moved on to the next question. I sensed, dimly, that this answer wasn't an answer to my question. I already knew the district handled it. What I'd asked was who. But that day I let the mismatch go. It hadn't seemed like a question important enough to press for a real answer to.

For the next few days I listened back carefully, in my head, to the conversations I'd had with the Secretary. There truly was no subject. Instead of "I put it in order," it was "It was put in order." Instead of "I got in touch with you," it was "Word went out." Instead of "I confirmed it," it was "It was confirmed." In sentence after sentence, nothing stood where the subject should be. I thought this was too consistent to be one person's mere manner of speech. But I didn't hold onto that thought for long. A consistent manner of speech can exist too, after all.

Once, the Secretary slipped and put in a subject by accident. "…I got in touch with you at the time, so—" they started, then stopped, and corrected themselves. "…Word went out, but it seems it didn't reach you." I didn't let that correction slip past me. I asked, before I even meant to.

"…You just said 'I' and then corrected yourself."

The Secretary looked at me for a moment, then laughed.

"…Ah, did I? Must have been a slip of habit."

That laugh wasn't awkward, and that was exactly why it stayed with me all the more. This person truly regarded that correction as a mistake. That putting in a subject was the mistake, and leaving it out was the normal state — that day was the first time I saw it clearly, laid bare.

. . .

The Secretary was neither especially kind to me nor especially curt. Whatever I asked, they answered. Even when I filed paperwork wrong, they never showed irritation. I liked that manner.

Once I was late because I'd missed a change in meeting time. I fully expected to be scolded for it. But the Secretary only said this.

"…Word must have gone out late. From now on, it'll be checked ahead of time for you."

I was bewildered by that. It was my mistake — why blame the notice for it, I wondered. But thinking it over again, it didn't seem like they were covering for me — it seemed like they genuinely thought that way. That being late, too, was a result of the procedure, not something to be pinned down as my own fault.

At the time I thought this was consideration. Thinking about it again now, consideration and avoidance may not be things this person's mind actually distinguishes between. But I know clearly that this isn't because this person is a bad person.

Feeling sorry about being late that day stayed with me for a while, so the next day I went back to the Secretary and apologized. "…I'm sorry about being late yesterday." The Secretary looked at me for a moment and said,

"…What's there to be sorry about. The notice went out late, that's all."

"…Still, I should have checked ahead of time—"

"…It isn't that you didn't check, Hora. The very notice there was to check simply went out late. How do you check something that isn't there?"

Hearing that, I sat stunned for a moment. How do you check something that isn't there. I didn't know, at the time, that those words would come back before

me later, in an entirely different weight. That day, I just thanked them and let it go.

As I turned to leave, the Secretary added one more thing behind me. "…From now on, I'll check ahead of time myself and let you know." I stopped and turned back at that. "I'll check ahead of time" had "I" attached to it again. This time it wasn't corrected. I quietly filed that moment away. This person, too, sometimes — very rarely — put themselves into a sentence.

. . .

A few days later, I asked Tyche about the Secretary.

"…Is the Secretary always like that?"

"…Like what?"

"…Whatever you ask them, they never say they did it themselves."

Tyche thought for a moment and answered.

"…Huh. I'd never thought about it, but you're right, they really are like that."

"…Doesn't that seem strange to you?"

"…Hmm, I don't think it's strange, exactly. That's just what the Secretary's job is, isn't it. Convening, passing things on. It's not a post where you make decisions yourself, so maybe that's why they talk that way."

That explanation seemed right to me. That day I really did just accept it and move on. The title is what it is, so of course the manner of speech would be too. I hadn't yet seen the other possibility hiding behind that sentence.

Tyche added, as if something had just occurred to them.

"…Actually, come to think of it, I heard my parents did Secretary work too. My grandmother as well. The Secretary's post has been around a pretty long time in this city."

"…So is it passed down through families or something?"

"…No, it's just a post you can apply for. But strangely enough, a lot of similar-natured people seem to end up going into it."

"…What kind of nature?"

Tyche thought for a moment and answered.

"…Hmm, people who are fine not stepping forward themselves? Apparently people who want to be the one out front don't last long in this job. It frustrates them too much."

Hearing that, I felt like I understood, a little, why the Secretary had come to speak the way they did. If someone who doesn't want to step forward takes on a job where they don't have to, maybe the manner of speech that fits that job just settles into the body on its own.

That evening I turned that conversation back over in my mind, and it kept nagging at me that there had once been a time, apparently, when the Secretary used to write their own name. This person hadn't gone without writing their name from the very start — at some point, they'd simply stopped. What had happened at that "some point," I didn't even think to ask that day. I only pull that question back out much later, and by then it's sitting in a far heavier place.

Walking home that day, I took out the paperwork the Secretary had smiled and fixed for me again. The paper where the previous session's number was correctly filled in now. There was an intake-confirmation box at the very bottom of that paper too. The stamp was there, but the officer's signature box beside it was still empty. Looking at it, nothing occurred to me. The stamp

seemed like it should be enough. Why a signature would be needed separately from that — I hadn't thought about it, not then.

Putting that paperwork away in the drawer, I turned back over, one more time, the several faces the Secretary had shown me that day. Kind, exact, almost never using a subject, and once — just once — using one and correcting it themselves. I couldn't find a single reason to think ill of this person. I still can't.

(Continued in Chapter 7.)

Chapter 7. Open to Inspection

> *_Previously_ — Hora meeting the Secretary. Kind and exact, but always*
> *speaking without a subject. "It was put in order." "It was confirmed."*
> *Once, just once, an "I" slipped out, and was corrected on the spot. She*
> *took the manner of speech for nothing more than a habit of the post and*
> *let it go.*

One day I got curious. Could you really look at anything, all of it.

People in this city often said "the Consensus hides nothing." I'd learned it at school, heard it in the meeting room, heard it from Tyche too. I believed it, but believing it and checking it were two different things. I was someone who checked.

So that afternoon, I decided to pick a deliberation I had no part in and go read the full text. Any case would do. I just went looking for a district entirely apart from the Fourth, an issue entirely unfamiliar to me.

. . .

I'd had the thought for a few days before that, but that day was the first time I actually acted on it. What I picked was a case out of the Second Deliberation District. It concerned a road-widening project, something I had no connection to whatsoever. There was a reason field on the application, and I wrote

"practice at inspection." There was no box beneath it asking for further purpose.

The counter handed the material over with no particular verification procedure.

"…Can anyone look at this?"

"…Yes. You just fill out the application. We only check your identity."

"…You don't ask why?"

"…Why would we need to. It's public material."

That person finished the identity check and handed the paperwork straight over. The procedure was so simple that I wondered if something had been left out, and asked again.

"…Is that all? There's nothing else needed?"

"…No. Just an identity check. Anyone who lives here can see all of it."

"…People from outside too?"

"…Yes. Though they need a temporary registration card. That doesn't take long to issue either."

"…What about someone without the card, just looking briefly?"

"…That's not allowed. The identity check is required. But once you have the card, you're shown everything, exactly the same as a citizen. There's no difference in treatment."

I nodded at that once more. That there was a procedure, but no discrimination. I liked that distinction.

Hearing that, I felt, all over again, just how wide open this city keeps its own records. Even someone who wasn't a citizen could see everything, so long as they went through the proper procedure.

I liked what they'd said. Why would we need a reason, they'd asked back. If there's nothing to hide, a reason isn't needed either.

It occurred to me, suddenly, that I'd heard other cities pry into your reason for wanting to see a record. They said whoever wanted to see it was questioned first about why, and if the reason wasn't acceptable, they weren't shown it. I couldn't make sense of that approach. Who decided whether a reason was acceptable or not, I wondered. Here, that question didn't even exist.

The counter clerk added one more thing as they handed the paperwork over.

"…Come back if you need anything more. I can pull the related material for you too."

"…Related material?"

"…Yes, past cases connected to this one. I can print you out a list, if you'd like."

I found that offer striking. Kindness that told me something I hadn't even asked for. I requested the list right there, and that afternoon I walked out with far more material than I'd originally planned on.

The list had twelve past cases on it. I'd meant to read only three of them, but reading one led to a mention of another case, and chasing that down led me to another, until I'd ended up reading all twelve. I lost track of how much time had passed. Only when the window outside went dark did I hear the announcement that the reading room would soon close.

The librarian looked at me and said, smiling,

"…That's quite a long session for practice at inspection."

"…Yes, it was interesting."

"…It's been a while since I've seen someone like you. Most people find exactly what they need and go."

Hearing that, I felt, once again, that I was a somewhat unusual person in this room. It wasn't an unpleasant feeling.

. . .

The material was vast. The original request, opinion papers from the districts involved, the calculation's grounds, records of objections filed, all the way through to the final confirmation — it was all there. I turned through it page by page.

The objection records were especially striking. Who had filed the objection, what the objection was, and how the Consensus had recalculated in response were all set down. Some objections had been accepted, some had been rejected, and even the rejected ones had grounds attached explaining why.

I was struck, reading through these grounds for rejection. Rejection hadn't been handled carelessly. Instead of closing the matter with one line — "insufficient grounds" — it explained, with numbers and cases, exactly why the grounds were insufficient. I thought, at the time, that this city was truly conscientious.

The names of the people who'd filed objections were written as numbers too, and I noticed the same number recurring across several cases. I realized this was the trace of one person filing an objection more than once. The first and second had been rejected, and on the third, partly accepted. Reading through those three attempts in order, I tried to picture the face of someone who hadn't

given up. There was no face. Only a number. And yet I could still sense that this person had been tenacious. That a record can show you an attitude even when it won't show you a face — that was the first time I understood that.

I read back over the passage where the third objection was partly accepted. It set down, too, exactly what had changed from the first two times. One newly submitted piece of material had been decisive — material that hadn't existed for the first two objections. Seeing that, I confirmed once more that this city truly did change its conclusion when the material changed. This wasn't a stubborn system. It was flexible in the face of new grounds.

. . .

That day I gathered the material and settled at an empty desk near the meeting room to read. No one asked me why I was sitting there. That evening I told Tyche about the experience.

"…I looked into a case that was completely unfamiliar to me today. It was really all there."

"…Of course. It's all there."

"…But the strange thing is, nobody says anything to me about it. About why I'm looking at it."

Tyche laughed.

"…Why would they ask? It's there to be looked at."

"…But other cities don't show any of this, apparently."

"…So I've heard. I've heard that too. But I don't really understand why they wouldn't show it. Isn't it because there's something to hide?"

I nodded at that. It sounded right. If there's nothing to hide, of course it would be shown.

. . .

I came to enjoy this habit of inspection often, after that. Not for any particular purpose — it was simply interesting. Picking an entirely unfamiliar case from an entirely unfamiliar district and reading it start to finish. I wondered why other people didn't do this.

I once asked the reading room librarian about it.

"…Does anyone besides me come look at unfamiliar cases like this?"

The librarian searched their memory for a moment and said,

"…Sometimes. But most people come looking only for what's connected to themselves. Someone who just reads something unrelated for its own sake — well, they're rare."

"…Has there been anyone else like me?"

"…There has. People like that were usually researchers. History, or statistics."

Hearing that, it struck me as a little odd that I was doing this without being a researcher at all. But being odd wasn't an unpleasant feeling.

The librarian gave me a further look around the reading room. The stacks weren't large, and a few electronic terminals sat around. A usage notice was posted on one wall, and it read, among other things: "All material in this reading room may be inspected by any citizen of the Equity. No separate approval procedure is required." I read that sentence twice. That no approval was required seemed to sum up this city better than any explanation could.

"…When was this reading room established?"

"…I don't know exactly, myself. It's old. I've heard it's been here since the city was founded."

I was satisfied with that answer. That it had been there from the beginning. It sounded to me like this hadn't been thrown together hastily later on, but that this city had decided, from the moment it was founded, never to hide anything.

Feeling good that day, before I left the reading room, I asked the librarian one more thing.

"…Is there anything you truly can't see here? Really?"

The librarian thought for a moment and answered.

"…Hmm, well, obviously nothing that hasn't been filed yet. Once it's filed, you can see all of it."

"…What about what hasn't been filed?"

"…That doesn't exist yet, so. How would you show something that isn't there."

I laughed at that answer. It was the obvious thing to say. Asking to be shown something that doesn't exist was a request that made no sense to begin with. I didn't find that answer strange in the slightest.

The librarian added, "…But once it's filed, you really can see everything. If there's ever something we can't show you, it's genuinely because it hasn't been filed yet. There's no other reason." I believed that. I had every reason to. Up to that day, I had never once had the experience of this city hiding something from me. So I had no reason not to believe it.

Leaving the reading room, I confirmed one thing to myself all over again. Every document I'd seen that day, anyone else could see exactly the same way.

I hadn't been given some special privilege. I liked that equality.

. . .

I looked up the inspection regulations too. Surprisingly simple. Identity check, application, inspection. The only restrictions were on a small portion of personal information, and even that wasn't fully concealed — it was replaced with a number.

I liked that restriction. A method that protected a person while never hiding the record itself. A name got swapped for a number, but what had happened to that person stayed on the record, unchanged.

Looking back now, this part strangely locks together with something else. Being turned into a number meant becoming anonymous — but it also meant that person could never again find their own name in this record. At the time I read this only as protection. I didn't know yet how to read it any other way.

Since I'd gone looking through the regulation document, I looked over the old history of revisions to the inspection rules too. There had been several revisions, and most of them moved in the direction of making the procedure simpler. At first you'd had to write three pages of application; now it was one. At first approval had taken days; now it was instant. I liked that every one of these revisions moved in the direction of making inspection easier. This city was moving, over time, in the direction of ever more transparency.

I read that regulation document from beginning to end. The front held the inspection procedure, the back the restrictions. The restrictions were genuinely short. Exactly three lines. Personal information replaced with a number; certain items concerning minors carry a notice when inspected; and the last line read this: "Anything not specified in this regulation is not restricted from inspection."

I liked that last line best of all. That not restricting was the default. I guessed that in other cities it was probably the opposite — that only what was specified could be inspected, and everything else was forbidden. Here it was the reverse. Prohibition was the exception.

In the margin of that revision-history document, I found a note someone had left by hand, long ago. The ink had faded badly. It read: "Inspection is not a right — it is the baseline." Who had written it, and when, wasn't recorded. I liked that sentence enough to copy it into my notebook.

. . .

A few days later, I looked up a very old case. Something from about twenty years back. It was all there. Only the form from that era differed slightly from now — the content was every bit as thorough. Grounds, objections, confirmation, and at the very bottom, the signature box.

It was empty.

I didn't think that was strange then, either. That a twenty-year-old form had a signature box too, and that it was empty too, looked to me like nothing more than this city's consistency. If anything, it was reassuring. It meant this wasn't only true of recent documents — it had been this way, straight through, from long ago. Nothing had suddenly changed. This had simply always been what kind of city it was.

Returning that material as I left, I thought this had been a pretty good day. That in a city that hides nothing, you could open up anything at all. I thought that was freedom.

I told my aunt about it when I got home too. "…Auntie, I read a case today that had absolutely nothing to do with me. I even looked at one from twenty years ago." My aunt asked, looking curious, "…Why would you look at

something like that?" "…No reason. It was interesting." My aunt laughed. "… That's such a you answer." I couldn't tell whether that was a compliment, but looking at her face, it seemed closer to one.

"…But Auntie, it really was all there. Nothing was hidden at all."

My aunt paused over the dishes and looked at me for a moment.

"…That's a good thing. But everything being there doesn't necessarily mean you can know everything."

"…What do you mean by that?"

"…No, never mind. I don't really know myself. Anyway, it's good that it's all there."

I didn't pay much attention to my aunt trailing off like that, at the time. She sometimes said things and then pulled them back in mid-sentence. I only thought of it as a habit of hers.

That night, before I fell asleep, I went back over, once more, the twelve cases I'd read that day, in order. None of them had felt forced. None of them had felt manufactured. The grounds had piled up the way grounds should, and the conclusion had followed from the grounds. I thought that was proof of a truly good city. A bad city, I thought, wouldn't have gone to the trouble of piling up its grounds this conscientiously. I fell asleep easily that night, thinking that thought.

The next morning, on my way to the meeting room, I passed the reading room again. The door wasn't open yet, but I slowed my steps a little and looked at it anyway. The fact that everything about this city was held inside, in that moment, felt like nothing more than reassuring.

(Continued in Chapter 8.)

Chapter 8. The One Who Reads to the End

> *_Previously_ — Hora confirming with her own eyes that the Consensus*
> *truly hides nothing. An unrelated case, material from twenty years back —*
> *a single application form was enough to see it all. Her aunt let slip, almost in passing, "Everything being there doesn't necessarily mean you*
> *can know everything," but Hora didn't hold onto it.*

I still haven't seen anyone in that meeting room, besides me, read the full text to the end.

I don't want to write this as if it were something to boast about. I've never once thought of it that way. Reading it all didn't make me any smarter, and it didn't lead me to any more correct a judgment. I simply couldn't sit comfortably if I hadn't read it all. That's all there was to it.

To be precise, it's less that I haven't seen anyone and more that I'm certain I never have. Every time a session ended, I stayed behind alone and read. Everyone else looked only at the summary and judged whether to object from that. That was enough. The summary was accurate.

. . .

I once asked the person next to me about it.

"…You don't read the full text?"

"…Why bother? It's all in the summary."

"…In case something's missing from the summary, maybe."

They looked at me like I was strange.

"…The summary is made by the Consensus too. If the Consensus could leave something out, it wouldn't be the summary you couldn't trust — it'd be the full text itself."

I couldn't argue with that. It was true. Making the summary was, in the end, the same system. If you trusted the system, you had to trust the summary too.

That person told me about when they'd first come to this room too. "…I used to read it all too, at first. About six months, I think. But it matched the summary every single time, so at some point I figured looking at just the summary was enough." I found that six months striking. I was already nearing two hundred days of reading, and this person had stopped after six months. I found myself wondering, in that moment, why I couldn't stop. No answer came.

And yet I kept reading. Believing and habit lived on different levels. I believed in the Consensus, and at the same time, I couldn't stop reading to the end. At the time, I didn't think of these two things as a contradiction.

That person went on to say a bit more about themselves. "…I read it too, at first. But after a few months it all started to look alike. The summary was never wrong, not once, so at some point you just stop reading." I understood what they meant. I checked too, every time I read. The summary really was never wrong, not once. But that checking itself couldn't stop in me. It wasn't that checking reassured me — checking was simply what I did.

"…How long do you think you'll keep reading everything like that, Hora?"

"…I don't know. I think I'll keep doing it."

"…Doesn't it wear you out?"

I answered that question honestly.

"…It does. But not reading makes me more anxious."

"…Anxious? About what?"

I couldn't answer that one right away either. I didn't know exactly what I was anxious about myself. It was just that if there was a document I'd skipped over without reading, thoughts of it kept coming back to me that night before I fell asleep. Only checking what I'd missed let me sleep easy.

"…I don't know. It's just how it is."

They nodded at that without any particular reply. I found that silence comfortable. It wasn't a silence that tried to talk me out of it.

A few days later, I happened to overhear that person talking about me to someone else. Not to badmouth me — just explaining me to another member. "…The new one's a little unusual, but not unusual in a bad way. The questions she comes up with after reading everything turn out to be useful, more often than not." Hearing that made my face heat up a little. At the same time it wasn't an unpleasant feeling. That was the first time I'd heard "unusual" and "useful" sitting in the same sentence.

Once, they asked me in passing, "…Doesn't it get boring, staying behind alone reading for two hours?" I thought about it and answered, "…Sometimes it does. But once I've read it all, that boredom fades fast." They laughed and shook their head. "…I can't stand that boredom long enough to read it all. You're really something." I still couldn't tell if that was a compliment, but it didn't sound bad.

After that, a few members started asking me things directly. "…Was there anything unusual in the full text of this provision?" "…What did the full text look like for that last case?" I answered conscientiously every time. Mostly I said there was nothing much. There really wasn't, most of the time. Sometimes I'd point out one small detail, though it never once changed a decision. But the fact that people had started asking me at all — that struck me as a little remarkable, in itself.

. . .

Tyche asked a similar question once too.

"…Why do you always read all the way through the full text, Hora?"

I couldn't answer right away. After a moment I said,

"…Just, it's a habit."

"…Why did the habit start?"

I hesitated, wondering whether to bring up my mother. In the end I didn't. It felt too personal.

"…I don't know. It just turned out that way."

Tyche nodded. They didn't press further. I was grateful for that consideration, but at the same time I felt my own answer had fallen short. It wasn't that I really didn't know. I just hadn't wanted to say it.

Tyche asked something else instead.

"…So what changes, once you've read it all?"

"…Hmm, nothing really changes. It's just that I end up in a state of knowing."

"…A state of knowing?"

"…Yes. A state where I've confirmed everything there is myself. Passing over something without confirming it makes me more uncomfortable."

Tyche looked thoughtful, hearing that.

"…I'm the opposite. It's a relief knowing the summary's right even without checking. But don't you not trust that knowing itself, Hora?"

That question caught me off guard. It wasn't that I didn't trust it. I did trust the Consensus. And yet I couldn't bear not checking. I couldn't find an answer, that day, for how to explain both of these things together.

Tyche looked a little sorry after saying that. "…Ah, that might have come across kind of harsh. I didn't mean it that way." "…No, it's fine. It's a question I'd never thought about myself." I really was fine. Tyche's question had been sharp, but not in a tone that pushed me into a corner. It had simply been curious. I liked that about them.

. . .

Once I'd read the full text in the meeting room, I'd also gotten into the habit of laying the summary and the full text side by side to compare them. The summary really was accurate. Never once wrong. But there were things in the full text that weren't in the summary. Mostly minor details. A past case similar to one in a given district, say, or the origin of a particular provision.

Every time I found details like this, I wrote them in my notebook. Not for any particular use. Writing them down was simply the habit.

I once showed that notebook to Tyche. They looked through it, one entry at a time, and said,

"…This is all correct. But why does it matter?"

"…I don't know if it matters. It was just there."

"…Being there doesn't mean it all matters."

I couldn't answer that either. It was true. Being there didn't mean it all mattered. But that day, too, I didn't throw the notebook away.

I'd actually started keeping notebooks before the meeting room, back when I was still in school. I had a habit of writing things in the margins of my exam answer sheets too. Teachers sometimes frowned on it, since it made the sheets messy. I always started to erase it, and ended up handing it in as it was, unable to. Erasing it felt stranger than leaving it.

The notebook had grown fairly thick over the course of a few months, that way. Sometimes, when I was bored, I'd flip back through it from the start. Most of it really was trivial. The origin of some district's name, why some provision's numbers had come out the way they had, which year had had an unusually high number of objections. None of it seemed connected to any of the rest. I thought that was only natural. This notebook hadn't been kept to dig up some suspicion — it was just things that had caught my eye while reading, copied down.

There was no particular order or classification anywhere in the notebook. It was just written in whatever order things caught my eye. Sometimes I actually liked that disorder. It wasn't an organized record — it was just the trace of the spots where I'd paused while reading.

I once showed the notebook to my aunt too. She flipped through a few pages and said, "…This is just like something your mother used to do." Surprised, I asked, "…Mom did this too?" "…Yes, she used to write things in the margins of her ledgers. Didn't seem to serve any particular purpose, but she liked it."

Hearing that gave me a strange feeling. I couldn't tell whether this was a habit I'd inherited, or just a coincidental resemblance.

. . .

I mentioned something similar to the Secretary once too. I'd gone to return material at the counter, and since the Secretary happened to be there, I took out the notebook and showed them. They looked it over and their face turned briefly interested.

"…You record all of this?"

"…Yes, just a habit."

"…That's a good habit. I used to do something similar, myself."

"…Not anymore?"

The Secretary thought for a moment before answering.

"…At some point it just stopped. Once the work piled up."

I took that answer without much thought. It seemed plausible enough that a heavier workload could do that. I didn't notice, at the time, that "at some point" had come up again.

"…Did you used to carry a notebook around too?"

"…Something like that. A small notepad. I don't even know where it is anymore, now."

"…Wouldn't you want to look for it?"

The Secretary smiled briefly. "…Hmm. I wonder what the point would be, even if I found it." I sensed something like regret in that answer, but it never showed on their face at all, and I wondered if I'd only imagined it.

The Secretary looked back over my notebook and added a few more words.

"…Seeing this, you must like observing things, Hora."

"…Not so much observing — it's just that things catch my eye while I read."

"…That's what observing is. I used to be the same. I'd write down whatever caught my eye."

"…Why don't you anymore, then?"

The Secretary smiled briefly.

"…Convening and passing things on takes all day, so there's no room left for anything to catch my eye. And besides, whatever I might write down would become my own opinion, wouldn't it. My own opinion isn't allowed to go into the minutes."

I nodded at that explanation. This person had given up the habit of observing on their own. So that their own opinions wouldn't get mixed into the record. I thought that was a kind of professional restraint. How long, and how deeply, that restraint had changed this person — I couldn't gauge it, not then.

"…So what opinions are left in you now?"

I asked, on impulse. The Secretary looked at me for a moment, then laughed.

"…Hmm. That's a question I've never thought about."

That answer was light, like a joke, but I felt there was something behind that lightness. I didn't know exactly what. All that stayed with me was that the

laugh had ended a little too quickly.

. . .

There was a time I wondered myself why I was so especially slow. Ever since school, everything took me longer than it took other people. Exams, reading, even eating.

I once asked my aunt about it.

"…Auntie, why am I so slow?"

My aunt thought for a moment and answered.

"…You're not slow. You just hate missing anything."

"…That's the same thing as being slow."

"…Slow and thorough are different things. It's just that the world usually only notices the slow part and doesn't give the thorough part its due."

That felt like comfort, hearing it, but it didn't entirely settle me either. The fact of being slow didn't change.

Once the meal was ready, my aunt told me an old story. When I was little, reading picture books, the other kids would skim just the pictures and move on, but I traced every single letter, she said. "…Your teacher worried you were slow. But I never worried." "…Why not?" "…The questions you asked after finishing were always different from everyone else's. They were questions that came out of being slow. They weren't bad."

Hearing that, I felt, all over again, grateful that there had been at least one person at home who never worried about my slowness. At school it had

always been something to worry about; at home, it wasn't. I think that difference is part of what carried me this far.

"…But Auntie, in the meeting room, I'm the only one who's like this. Doesn't that look strange?"

My aunt laughed.

"…So what if it does. You're just doing it your way."

That comforted me a little. Your way. My aunt used that phrase so easily, but it always sounded difficult to me.

. . .

That evening, I stayed in the meeting room and read a new case from beginning to end. I read the summary first, then the full text, then the underlying material all the way through. It took three hours. The caretaker came and went twice.

Once I'd finished, I looked back over the last page one more time. The list of grounds, the progress of the handling, and down to the blank box at the very bottom. I wrote the gist of the day's case in my notebook in two lines and cleared my seat. That was all there was to that day. Nothing in particular weighed on me.

On the way home I passed by the water channel. The sound of the water was the same as ever. I didn't stop that day either. My legs ached from three hours of reading, and all I could think of was getting home quickly to lie down.

My aunt was waiting by the door. "…Late again today." "…Yeah, there was a thick one." My aunt served dinner without asking me anything. I was grateful

for that. If I'd had to explain what I'd read every single day, I think I would have given up this habit much sooner than I did.

(Continued in Chapter 9.)

Chapter 9. Four Hundred People

> *_Previously_ — Hora is the only person in the meeting room who reads the*
> *full text to the end. Asked by Tyche why, she only said, "Just a habit."*
> *Asked what changes once she's read it all, she said, "Nothing changes.*
> *I just end up in a state of knowing." Tyche wasn't entirely convinced by*
> *that answer, but didn't press further either.*

I started paying close attention to the handling-progress page for a very small reason.

That day, as usual, I'd finished reading the full text and was skimming the handling progress attached at the very back. A table listing, in chronological order, which department had done what and when. I always flipped through this table fast. It was nothing but numbers and department names lined up, no name in sight, so there wasn't much pleasure in reading it.

That day the table was unusually long. Over two pages. Bored, I counted the lines.

Four hundred and twelve lines.

I thought at first I must have miscounted, and counted again. Same result. Four hundred and twelve lines. I pulled out the handling-progress tables from cases I'd read before and looked them over again. None of them fell below a hundred lines. Even a short case ran to about a hundred and thirty; a long one ran past five hundred. That was the first day I truly felt, in my bones, just how

many hands had touched the forty pages of material I'd been reading, session after session. Until then I'd taken that part as nothing more than a table and passed over it.

. . .

I asked Tyche about that number the next day.

"…Is it right that four hundred and twelve people were involved in this case?"

Tyche flipped through the screen and nodded.

"…That's right. The average is around four hundred. Bigger cases run higher."

"…Four hundred people? Really?"

"…Yes. Why, does that surprise you?"

I was surprised. Having watched the sessions end in that twenty-two-seat meeting room, I'd been vaguely assuming those twenty-two people were the ones deciding. Four hundred didn't fit that picture at all.

"…But there are only twenty-two people in the meeting room."

"…The decision doesn't happen in the meeting room. The meeting room is only the last step. Before that there are people who compile the material, people who review it, people who take in objections, people who pass it on, people who confirm it. All separate people."

Tyche pulled out one more document to show me. The numbers were broken down by department. Sixty people for the material-gathering team, eighty for the grounds-review team, a hundred for opinion collection by district, and then everyone else who handled passing it on, recording, and confirming.

"…All of this is for one case?"

"…Yes. Bigger cases get split into even more."

. . .

I told my aunt about it that evening.

"…Auntie, apparently four hundred people are involved in a single case."

My aunt stopped what she was doing and looked at me.

"…Four hundred? What do you mean?"

"…There's a separate person who gathers material, a separate person who reviews it, a separate person who passes it on. All separate. So added up, it's over four hundred."

My aunt thought for a moment and said,

"…Then if something goes wrong, it's not one person's fault."

Hearing that, I realized it was exactly what I'd wanted to say. I took it as a good thing, that day. My aunt seemed to mean it as a good thing too.

"…Right. Since it's not one person deciding the whole thing, even if that person had bad intentions, the other four hundred would just check it again anyway."

My aunt nodded, ladling out the soup.

"…Hearing it like that, it's not a bad system. If anything's off anywhere, it'd get filtered out somewhere else."

I remember this evening precisely. That day, the number four hundred put me at ease. I still don't think that ease was entirely wrong, even now. But at the time, I didn't think, even for a moment, to look at the other side of this number. I don't see that side until years later. It doesn't appear in this chapter. I've decided to write this record honestly, so I won't write what I didn't see then as if I saw it now.

. . .

A few days later, curious about why this number had come to be, I went looking for the regulation behind it. The reading-room librarian found me an old piece of material — discussion records from forty-some years back, from the early days when the Consensus was first introduced.

Back then, far fewer people had been involved, it said. Around ten to a case. But there had been a problem. A few times, when someone acquainted with one of those ten filed an objection, the speed of handling or the outcome shifted, subtly.

Checking into it, it wasn't anything you'd call manipulation. No bribes, no threats. Just listening a little longer to someone you knew, and passing over someone you didn't a little faster. A very small difference. But when that small difference piled up, it split the outcome.

So the city chose to increase the number of people involved. It broke up what any one person could see into small pieces, so that no one could hold an entire case in their own hands. Whoever gathered the material didn't review it; whoever reviewed it didn't pass it on; whoever passed it on didn't confirm it. Each person touched exactly one small fragment.

The last line of the document read: *"The expansion of the number of participants is a measure to structurally dilute the influence of any given individual."*

I read that sentence twice. Dilute. I liked that word. Even if someone wanted to put a hand on something, the portion they could reach was so small that reaching it left them with no power at all. I thought that was a truly clever design.

The librarian found me one more piece from that old period. A deliberation over one district's ration amount, preserved as the last case on record from the ten-member-committee era. It later came out that one of the ten members lived on the same lane as the person who'd filed the objection. There hadn't been any improper favor. The investigation record said so plainly. But when that member had reviewed the objection, they'd said, in passing, "Ah, I know that household's situation" — and it had stayed on the record in the minutes exactly as said. The real problem was that this one remark hadn't tipped the outcome to either side. Because no one could prove it hadn't.

Reading this record, I didn't feel, even for a moment, that this member had been a bad person. They'd simply recognized a neighbor. And yet this city judged that even that much recognizing was dangerous. I didn't think that judgment was excessively strict. If anything, I thought it had to be exactly that strict to live up to the name the Equity.

. . .

A few days later, I told the Secretary this story too, when I stopped by the counter.

"…I read material from forty-some years ago today. Back then there were only ten members, apparently."

The Secretary paused their paperwork and looked at me.

"…That's right. Things were very different then."

"…Why did it grow all the way to four hundred?"

"…Because knowing someone keeps creeping in. When you know someone, you can't help but favor them a little. Even trying hard not to favor them, it still tips a little, in proportion to what you know. That happens even without any bad intent."

The Secretary glanced toward the window while saying that. The window you couldn't see through, and yet there were people who looked that way out of habit anyway.

"…So now no one knows each other, at all?"

"…No one does. Whoever gathers material doesn't know who reviews it. Whoever reviews it doesn't know who passes it on. Not knowing each other is what keeps things from tipping."

I found that a little sad to hear, and at the same time reassuring. That sadness and reassurance could sit together in one sentence didn't strike me as strange, at the time.

"…Do you know either, who these four hundred are?"

"…I don't. I only convene. The convening list is pulled by the Consensus and handed over. It isn't chosen by me."

I nodded, hearing that answer. Here too, once again, the Secretary said that nothing was chosen by them. That day I let the sentence pass. My mind had been taken up by the number four hundred; there was no room left to weigh that sentence.

"…Don't you think four hundred is a lot, though?"

The Secretary answered, starting to sort the paperwork again.

"…It is a lot. But knowing what happened when it was fewer — I think more is better."

I agreed with that. That day, I truly thought so.

. . .

I showed that document to Tyche the next day. Tyche already knew about it.

"…I learned about this too. At school."

"…This really seems like a great method."

"…It is. And that's why I've never once heard, in this city, of anyone being asked for a favor. Asking for one wouldn't do any good."

"…No good at all?"

"…None. Nothing is held in any one person's hands — so who would you even ask? There's no one to ask, from the start."

Hearing that, I thought of the "I'll talk to my uncle about it" I'd heard when I was fourteen. Not understanding it, back then, had been because in this city, there truly was nothing that could be settled by talking to an uncle. This number, four hundred, was exactly why. I found that connection striking.

"…But with as many as four hundred, isn't it actually harder to manage?"

Tyche shrugged.

"…It is harder. But that's exactly what the Consensus does. Gathering everything four hundred people did into one. A person couldn't do it. Because it's the Consensus, it can."

I nodded at that answer. If a person had to do it, this number would have been impossible from the start. To weave together the work of four hundred people, someone would have to know all four hundred, and no such person could exist. So this was, necessarily, work only a system could do, not a person. That day, for the first time, I clearly understood this was one of the reasons the Consensus was needed.

. . .

Out of curiosity that day, I picked one line at random from the handling-progress table. "Passed on 217, 2:20 p.m." I wanted to try finding out who this 217 was, and asked Tyche.

"…This 217 — can you find out who this person is?"

Tyche tapped at the screen a few times and shook their head.

"…That number is the counter that handled it. Not a person's number. Whoever was sitting at that counter that day becomes 217."

"…So yesterday's 217 and today's 217 could be different people?"

"…Yes, absolutely. Counters rotate in shifts."

That let a little of the air out of me. I'd been secretly hoping I might be able to follow one person all the way through this table. But there was no "one person" in the table to follow in the first place. The number was attached to a seat, not a person.

"…So you can't find anyone at all from this table?"

"…There's no need to find anyone, that's why. What matters isn't who did this work — it's that the work got done."

Hearing that answer, I felt hollow for a moment, and then found myself agreeing again. Thinking it through, Tyche was right. There wasn't really any reason I needed to know who 217 was. What I'd wanted to confirm was whether this had been done properly, and that was already fully set down in the table. Finding a person and confirming that work had been done were different matters. That day was the first time I drew that distinction clearly.

. . .

Leaving the meeting room that evening, I opened the handling-progress table once more. Four hundred and twelve lines. Each line held a number, a time, and one short word — "passed on," "reviewed," "confirmed," "convened."

I traced those lines with a finger and counted them all the way through. It took a while to count them all. While I counted, I felt strangely at ease. That four hundred and twelve people had each added one very small portion to make this single sheet of paper. It seemed like the higher that number climbed, the smaller the room got for any one person to harbor a bad intention.

On the way home I passed by the water channel. The sound of the water was still there. That day, for once, I stopped and stood watching it for a moment. The water, too, must have come flowing from somewhere, through many branches, to reach this point — and each of those branches felt, somehow, like one person's share out of the four hundred, and I laughed a little at that. I knew it was a comparison that made no real sense, but that's just what occurred to me, that day.

My aunt was waiting at the door.

"…What did you count this time?"

"…People. Four hundred and twelve."

My aunt laughed. "…Such a you kind of day." I only laughed back, without a reply.

Over dinner, I explained to my aunt everything I'd learned that day, from the start. That there used to be only ten people; that one acquaintance could tip the outcome; that this was why they'd grown it to four hundred. My aunt listened all the way through, spoon still in hand.

"…So, when there are fewer people, feeling gets mixed in, and when there are more, there's no room left for feeling to get in."

"…Yeah, exactly that."

"…But then, if there's someone really good among those four hundred, doesn't their share get diluted just the same?"

I couldn't answer that question right away. I'd never thought about it that way.

"…That's true, but isn't that unavoidable? To cut down a bad person's share, a good person's share has to shrink along with it."

My aunt looked at me for a moment and nodded.

"…I suppose so. I don't know which way is better, myself. But if it means fewer people get wronged, that's enough, I'd say."

I nodded at that answer. That day, I thought so too — that was enough.

I slept very soundly that night. I slept trusting the number four hundred as a safeguard. When that trust begins to shake, reading on in this record will tell you. But in this chapter, I still doubted nothing. That my aunt's one remark — that a good person's share gets diluted too — was, in truth, the most precise thing said about this city that whole evening, I only come to understand much, much later.

(Continued in Chapter 10.)

Chapter 10. Numbers and Categories

> *_Previously_ — Hora learning that, on average, four hundred people are*
> *involved in a single case. Long ago, she was told, about ten people decided things, until one acquaintance tipped an outcome, and the number*
> *grew to what it is now. Her aunt asked whether a good person's share*
> *gets diluted along with it too, but that day Hora didn't hold onto the*
> *question for long.*

I first found the way deliberation subjects were referred to strange not because it was strange, but because it wasn't strange at all.

That day I was reading a ration-adjustment case. A matter of deciding who got a little more and who got a little less. Nowhere in the full text was there a person's name. Only notations like "Third Classification, 217" or "Fifth Classification, 40." I assumed that was simply how it had always been and read on without much thought. About five pages in, it suddenly occurred to me to wonder why it was set up this way.

. . .

I asked the person next to me.

"…Why don't these people have names?"

"…They never do. It's only issued by classification and number."

"…Why?"

They answered more seriously than I'd expected.

"…If there's a name, other things keep creeping in. Oh, that's that family's kid, oh, that person had that thing happen before, that kind of thing. With only a number, none of that creeps in at all."

I nodded, hearing that. It sounded right. I kept turning through the document for a while even after that answer. Table after table of nothing but numbers and classifications went by, and strangely, my reading speed never slowed. Having no person's name made it possible, if anything, to read more calmly.

. . .

I asked Tyche again that afternoon.

"…Why do deliberation subjects only ever come out as numbers and classifications?"

Tyche paused mid-sort of some material.

"…Do you know the history behind this, Hora?"

"…No."

"…Up until about thirty years ago, apparently, names went out plainly. But looking at the records from back then, there were quite a few cases where two people with the exact same conditions but different names got different results."

"…Different how?"

"…For instance, people whose names carried a certain district weren't likely to get their objections accepted. That district had had some trouble in the past, apparently, and people quietly looked down on it just from seeing the name. Even when the person had nothing to do with it at all."

Hearing that, my heart grew heavy.

"…How many classifications are there?"

"…Nine now. There used to be twelve, but it dropped after some got merged."

"…What's the basis for dividing them?"

"…The reason for the application and the conditions. Ration-related goes into the ration classification, housing-related into the housing classification. Within that, it splits further by number."

I found that system striking for being simpler than I'd expected. That there were only nine boxes to sort people into was, if anything, a relief. I'd have thought more boxes would mean more room for people to be seen differently — but nine seemed to leave little room for that.

"…Is that why names were taken out?"

"…Yes. Once they started using only numbers and classifications instead of names, that kind of gap nearly vanished. From the statistics I learned, the district-by-district variance in how often objections were accepted was cut in half."

. . .

I told my aunt about this that evening.

"…Auntie, apparently names used to go out plainly, back when deliberations happened. But people from some district ended up worse off because of it."

My aunt stopped what she was doing and looked at me. Her face seemed more serious than usual.

"…I remember that. That's from when I was young."

"…You went through it, Auntie?"

"…Not went through it, exactly, but that's the kind of talk that went around back then. If a name that lived in a certain place got printed plain on a document, everyone somehow looked at it a bit more harshly. Thinking about it now, I can't say for sure whether that was really true, but it's true that people believed it."

"…So that's why it changed to numbers?"

"…Yes. After it changed, that kind of talk went completely quiet. I think that was a genuinely good change."

Listening to that, I felt what I'd learned overlap with what my aunt had actually lived through. Something I'd only seen as statistics was filled in by my aunt's memory.

. . .

A few days later I looked up the records from before and after that revision myself, in the reading room. I laid a few pre-revision deliberation documents side by side with a few post-revision documents of the same type and read them.

The pre-revision documents had the applicant's name and home district written from the very first line. Reading through one of them, I saw the phrase "given the nature of that district" slipped, almost casually, into the objection review comments. After that, the objection had been rejected with no further grounds given.

I stopped for a long while, looking at that sentence. "Given the nature of that district" wasn't grounds. And yet at the time, it had passed for grounds. I thought this was frightening. It hadn't been written by a bad person. It had simply been written by someone who thought the way people thought, back in an era when everyone thought that way.

I found a few more documents from applicants out of that same district and laid them side by side to read. Their conditions were all different, but strangely, their grounds for rejection were similar. "Difficult to accept given the circumstances." "Rejected upon comprehensive judgment." There were almost no numbers. The calculation-grounds table that never failed to appear in documents from other districts was missing from about half of this district's documents. I wanted to believe that was chance, but past five cases, it was too uniform to call chance.

I copied those five cases into my notebook. Not to reach any particular conclusion. It just caught my eye, so I wrote it down. I didn't think, at the time, that this notebook would ever be used in any way later on.

The post-revision documents didn't have a single line like that. Every rejection and acceptance came with nothing but numbers and grounds attached. Things like "This application's standard-fulfillment rate is 72 percent, falling short of the threshold for acceptance." No district, no name, no hint of what kind of person this was. I found that dryness, if anything, a relief.

I also looked separately at records from the first few years right after the revision. There had been pushback in the early days, it noted. Several objections had come in arguing that being called only by number felt like

being treated as an object. The Consensus's responses to those objections were on record too, and they all carried the same substance: "This measure is not intended to harm the applicant's dignity, and is instead meant to prevent disadvantage arising from factors outside the stated conditions." Reading that response, I could understand the hearts of the people who'd pushed back, and I could understand the intent behind the Consensus's answer too. Neither side had been wrong.

The objections from a few more years on had an entirely different character. Objections to being called by number at all had nearly disappeared, and what remained were only objections that a number had been assigned incorrectly. I found that shift striking. People seemed to have stopped resenting the number itself, and started caring only about the number being used correctly.

. . .

Within that same week, I asked the Secretary the same thing too. I'd gone to the counter to hand in paperwork, and there happened to be a quiet moment when I could ask.

"…I hear names used to go out plainly on deliberations."

The Secretary paused mid-sort of a folder and looked at me.

"…That's right. When I first started this work, I saw paperwork with names on it too."

"…Is it very different, from then to now?"

"…Very different. Back then, if I was flipping through paperwork and an unfamiliar name — a name I knew — came up, my hand would stop without my meaning it to. That doesn't happen now. A number gives no reason to stop."

I was a little surprised by that. That the Secretary, too, had had moments like that felt striking, all over again.

"…What changes, when your hand stops?"

"…It changes. The longer you stop, the longer you end up looking at that paperwork, and the longer you look, the more you want to add something to it. Even without bad intent. That's giving this one piece of paperwork something the others don't get. I think that's the most dangerous thing there is."

I nodded at that explanation. Only then did I feel, a little more in my bones, why this city had gone to such lengths to erase names.

"…So is it easier for you now?"

The Secretary thought for a moment before answering.

"…It's easier. There's nothing to stop for."

Hearing that answer, I sensed that the word "easier," coming out of this person's mouth, carried some other weight. I didn't know, at the time, exactly what it was.

"…Do you remember that paperwork from back then too? From the days when names were still on it?"

"…A few of them, I remember. Not all of them. There was less paperwork back then. Probably only possible because there were fewer people."

"…Was it better then, or is it better now?"

This time the Secretary answered without hesitating.

"…Now is better. That much I'm sure of."

I was glad of that certainty. I'd seen this person speak this plainly, about anything, almost never before that point.

. . .

I confirmed this again with Tyche the next day.

"…So is there really no gap like that anymore?"

"…Almost none. I can't say completely none, but compared to before, it's not even close. It's been checked by district, by gender, by age group — all of it comes out nearly even."

"…Is all of that made public?"

"…Yes. It goes out as statistics every year. I can show you all five of the last five years, if you'd like."

Tyche really did bring me those statistical tables the next day. I flipped through them one page at a time. It really was true. The acceptance rate by classification and by district all fell within a similar range. There was no section unusually low or unusually high.

"…Seeing this really makes me feel, all over again, what a genuinely good city this is."

Tyche smiled.

"…I like this table too. It reassures me every time I look at it."

. . .

Of course, I also thought, that day, about what had been lost behind that ease. Being left as only a number also meant no one knew what kind of person that was. I said as much to Tyche.

"…But if there's only a number, doesn't that mean no one knows what kind of person that is?"

"…That's exactly what makes it fair. Not knowing what kind of person it is means judging only by the conditions."

"…But isn't it a little sad? That person must have had a name."

Tyche looked thoughtful at that.

"…If I had to choose between sadness and fairness, I'd choose fairness. If having a name is such a good thing, we could go back to a world with names like before — but then the gap comes back with it."

I couldn't argue with that. It was true. In this city, names and the gap had disappeared together.

. . .

That day, leaving the meeting room, I ran into someone in front of the counter. Someone who'd come to have their classification confirmed, requesting a correction because their number had been written wrong on the paperwork. I waited beside them while the counter clerk fixed it, and once the correction was done, I spoke to them.

"…Is it a big hassle, when a number gets wrong?"

They looked at me for a moment and answered.

"…It's a hassle. But hearing about how it used to be, this is nothing at all. In my mother's time, apparently, it wasn't classification — people were just split by what neighborhood they lived in. Someone from one neighborhood, whatever they applied for came out late; someone from another, it came out fast. There's none of that now, is there. As long as the number's right, everyone's handled exactly the same."

I nodded, hearing that. They said it without any particular resentment. If anything, their face looked satisfied with how things worked now.

"…So this way is better?"

"…Much better. I don't care if no one knows who I am, at all. As long as my conditions get looked at properly."

I turned that answer over for a long time. For this person, losing a name wasn't a loss — it was a gain. Hearing that, I found myself weighing, all over again that day, just how much of a relief the system of numbers and classifications must genuinely have been, for so many people.

After that person left, I read, once more, the notice posted on the counter's bulletin board. "This system protects every applicant from factors outside their stated conditions." That day was the first time I truly read that one line. I must have passed it dozens of times before, but that day the sentence reached me differently.

. . .

On the way home, I called back to mind the statistical table I'd seen that day. A bar graph stretching evenly across every district. I liked it. No district stuck out unusually far, and no district was unusually pressed down.

Passing by the water channel, it occurred to me, suddenly, that this water had no name either, no matter where it had come from. It was only ever called the water channel. People, too, were each called by number and classification, but that water didn't even have that much — it was simply "the water channel." I found the thought amusing and laughed a little to myself. I couldn't decide whether to call that treatment worse than a person's, or freer than a person's. I let the thought go without dwelling on it long, that day.

My aunt asked, as she was setting dinner out, "…What did you learn today?" "…About numbers and classifications. That taking out names made things more fair." My aunt nodded. "…That's right. That one's a genuine improvement. That's one I can confidently say got better."

I held onto that for a long while. It was rare for my aunt to speak with this much certainty. Leaning on that certainty, I closed out the day as a very good one.

After we'd finished eating, my aunt suddenly asked, "…But Hora, do you know your own number?" I was caught off guard for a moment. I knew my committee assignment number, but I'd never once looked up my classification number as a citizen. "…I don't know. I should look it up." My aunt laughed. "…Knowing it won't really do much for you. But it's fun to know. It's seeing how you're written down as a figure, inside this city." Hearing that, I thought, for the first time, that I too might already exist, somewhere in some document, with no name at all, only a number. That thought wasn't frightening to me, that day. If anything, it sounded fair.

(Continued in Chapter 11.)

Chapter 11. The Water Channel

> *_Previously_ — Hora learning that deliberation subjects are called only*
> *by number and classification, never by name. There was once a time when*
> *outcomes split on the basis of a name, and now that kind of gap has nearly vanished. Her aunt said, "That one, I can confidently say got better." Leaning on that certainty, Hora closed the day out as a good*
> *one.*

The first time I went right up close to the water channel was purely because I had time to spare.

The session ended early that day. There were about two hours free before the next one. Ordinarily I would have spent that time reading more material, but that day, as it happened, there was no new case in hand yet. I left the meeting room and, walking, turned toward the western water channel I'd only ever passed by before.

. . .

Up close, the channel was wider than I'd expected. I'd always taken it for nothing more than a spot roughly set with stones, but in places it was actually wide enough for two people to lie down side by side. The current wasn't strong. Soil-colored water moved between small stones, making its sound the whole way.

I crouched at the water's edge. I thought about touching it, hesitated again, and didn't. Instead I walked along the channel. The closer I got to the city's edge, the more natural the channel's shape became. It didn't look like a place anyone had shaped — it looked as though the water had carved its own way.

I didn't think, that day, to try to find out where this water came from. I was only curious. I didn't know, then, where that curiosity would lead.

There was a small signpost standing beside the channel. Its color had faded. It read only "Western Boundary of the Equity." Not one line about the water.

I studied that signpost for a long while. That a signpost marking the city's boundary said nothing at all about the water flowing right beside it seemed, at the time, like nothing more than the sign having gone up long ago, with the water appearing later. I walked around behind it too. There was nothing there.

Walking a little further along the channel, I saw an old man sitting by the water. I went over and spoke to him.

"…Do you come here often?"

"…Sometimes. I've been coming since I was young."

"…Do you know how long this water's been here?"

The old man looked at the water for a long while before answering.

"…It wasn't here when I was young. It can't have been here long. But I don't know exactly when it appeared. One day I noticed it there."

"…Doesn't that strike you as strange?"

The old man laughed.

"…It does. But strange and worrying are different things. The water's not doing anyone any harm — it's just flowing, is all."

I had nothing in particular to argue against that. It was true. The water was just flowing.

The old man sat a while longer, then got up to leave. As he went, he left one thing behind him. "…If you're curious, you can file an application. This city's good at that sort of thing." I laughed, hearing that. I thought it was such a fitting piece of advice for this city. Whatever you're curious about, an application. That day, that advice sounded entirely natural to me.

. . .

I brought this up with Tyche the next day.

"…I went up close to the water channel yesterday. Seeing it up close, it's bigger than I thought."

"…Ah, that water channel. I walk that way sometimes too."

"…Has it ever been taken up as a case? It's come right into the city."

Tyche looked thoughtful for a moment.

"…Hmm. As far as I know, no. Should I check?"

Tyche searched right there. After flipping through the screen a few times, they shook their head.

"…Nothing. There's not a single case related to the water channel."

"…Doesn't that seem strange? Water's come all the way into the city's boundary."

"…Not so much strange as — no one's brought it up yet, that's all."

. . .

I didn't quite understand that, that day.

"…No one's brought it up? Then who's supposed to?"

"…Anyone. Anyone in this city can bring up a case. But there has to be someone bringing it up before the Consensus can handle it."

"…But everyone walks right past that water. Why hasn't anyone brought it up?"

Tyche shrugged.

"…That, I couldn't say. Maybe everyone thought it wasn't their jurisdiction. Maybe they thought it wasn't urgent."

That answer felt lacking to me, somehow.

"…So administratively, this water doesn't exist right now?"

Tyche looked at me straight on and answered.

"…That's right. If it's never been submitted, it doesn't exist. Not because it's hidden."

I repeated that sentence to myself again, right there. If it's never been submitted, it doesn't exist. I thought that sentence was strangely clean. Far less frightening than the word "hidden."

. . .

"…But it's strange. Water this big is flowing, and there's no record of it at all."

"…It isn't that there's no record. It's that there's no case. A record gets created when someone observes something. But someone has to bring what they observed up as a case for the Consensus to move on it. Just looking isn't a case."

I turned that distinction over. There was a very clear threshold between seeing something and bringing it up. Up to now I'd thought this city knew everything, about anything. But hearing Tyche, what this city knows and what this city handles were two different matters.

"…So could I bring this up as a case?"

Tyche looked at me, surprised.

"…You could. But why? It's not dangerous or anything."

"…Just curious. It struck me as strange that no one's brought it up."

"…Hmm, that's so you, Hora. But the form for bringing up a case is a little demanding. You need an observation record, and the applicant's name has to go on it too."

"…A name?"

"…Yes. The case-application form has a box for the applicant's name. It's different from the signature box. An applicant has to write their own name for it to be accepted."

Hearing that, I felt a little puzzled. Why the signature box was always empty while the application still needed a name — I was curious about that difference. But I didn't push that curiosity further, that day. I figured it was probably just a different kind of form.

I didn't bring up the case that day. I was only curious.

. . .

I stopped by the reading room that afternoon too. I asked the librarian for every piece of material related to the western boundary. They pulled a list for me — only a handful of documents about roads, boundary markers, and district divisions. Not one mention of the water.

"…Is there anything related to the water near there, by any chance?"

The librarian tried a few more searches, changing the search terms each time.

"…Nothing. Nothing comes up for 'water channel,' nothing for 'waterway,' nothing for 'stream.' It doesn't seem to have ever been applied for."

"…Doesn't that seem strange? It really exists."

The librarian shrugged.

"…Existing in reality and existing on paper are different things. We can only find what exists on paper for you. If there's no document, there's nothing I can do either."

Hearing that answer, that day was the first time I saw clearly exactly where this city's full disclosure ended. Disclosure was complete. But there was no way to disclose something for which there was nothing to disclose in the first place. Asking to inspect something that didn't exist was a request that made no sense. I'd already learned that once before. Something never filed doesn't exist, the librarian had said then, smiling.

I called that exchange back to mind again that day. How do you show something that isn't there, and if it's never been submitted, it doesn't exist —

only then did I properly connect the two as the same thing. In this city, the word "doesn't exist" always meant this. Not that it had been concealed — only that it had never been brought up.

. . .

A few days later I told the Secretary about this too.

"…The western water channel — I hear it's never been taken up as a case."

The Secretary paused mid-sort of some paperwork.

"…Yes, not as far as I know."

"…Why do you think no one's brought it up?"

The Secretary thought for a moment.

"…I don't know. But in this city, when something never gets brought up as a case, there are usually one of two reasons. It isn't urgent, or the jurisdiction isn't clear."

"…What does unclear jurisdiction mean?"

"…A case where it's ambiguous which district should handle it. The western boundary isn't fully inside the city, and it isn't fully outside it either. With a case like that, it's common for no one to step forward first. When you can't be sure it's your jurisdiction, everyone tends to just wait and see."

I nodded, listening to that explanation.

"…Then couldn't you bring it up, yourself?"

The Secretary looked at me for a moment.

"…Only convening happens here. A case can only be accepted once there's an applicant. I could become the applicant, but doing that would mean writing my own name down."

Hearing that, I sensed, dimly, that writing a name down wasn't a simple thing in this city. Exactly why, I didn't know, then.

"…And you don't?"

The Secretary was silent for a moment before answering.

"…Only convening happens here."

The same words, repeated twice. I didn't think this was avoiding the question. It simply looked, to me, like that was genuinely all there was for this person.

"…So will this water channel just keep on being like this, forever? If no one brings it up?"

"…Probably. Until someone does."

"…Who's supposed to bring it up? Is there someone assigned?"

"…No one. Anyone can bring it up, and it's also possible that no one does. There are almost no cases in this city with someone specifically assigned who has to bring them up. Only the urgent ones have anyone assigned to them."

Hearing that answer, I began to grasp, for the first time, just how much this city simply leaves sitting between "anyone could do it" and "no one does." Not out of any bad intent. It was just that, somewhere in that gap, there really was nothing at all.

"…But doesn't that worry you? If anyone could do it and no one does, doesn't that mean it never gets done, forever?"

The Secretary looked at me for a moment and answered.

"…Not so much worrying as — that's simply how this city works. Whatever's urgent, someone ends up stepping forward for it. Whatever isn't, stays as it is, for a long time. I don't think that's a bad way to work."

I nodded at that. That day, I truly thought so.

. . .

That evening I went back to the water channel. The sun was setting. The sound of the water carried louder than it had by day. People still walked past it. No one stopped.

I asked a few passersby again.

"…This water channel — isn't the city managing it?"

One person answered, "…Hmm, wasn't it always there?" Another answered, "…I don't know either. I just walk by." No one was irritated. No one thought it strange.

I didn't resent any of these people, that day. I still don't. They truly didn't know. The only way to know was through a case, and there was no case.

I sat by the water for a long while. It kept flowing. Where it came from, and where it went, unwritten in any document of this city.

I walked a little further along the channel, out past the city's boundary. Crossing the boundary marker, the road disappeared and there was only open field. The channel kept going, even there. It curved and vanished among distant trees. I was curious where that water flowed from, but the sun had

already fallen far, and I wasn't prepared to go further in that direction. I turned back.

I had no idea, that day, how far off that water had come from. I only learn that much later, and it isn't this record's part to tell. But what I saw that day is plain. The water had come into the city, and the city didn't know it.

That was the first time I had a thought like this. If this city hides anything, it's probably like this. Not concealing it — just no one ever picking it up.

I didn't push that thought any further at the time. The water channel was only the water channel, and I still couldn't imagine, even then, that it would come to connect to anything else.

On my way home, I called Tyche's words back to mind. If it's never been submitted, it doesn't exist. Not hidden. I turned that over again and again. Strangely, there was nothing in it to argue against. And that there was nothing to argue against was, that day, the first thing that made me a little uneasy.

I didn't bring up the water channel to my aunt right away that day. Not that I was hiding it, exactly. I just didn't know how to explain it.

But partway through dinner, my aunt asked first. "…You're quiet today. Something happen?" I hesitated for a moment, then told her about the water channel. That water had come into the city's very boundary, and had never once been brought up as a case, and so administratively it was as good as not existing.

My aunt set down her spoon and looked at me.

"…What do you mean, as good as not existing. The water's really flowing."

"…No, I mean, on paper it doesn't exist. Because no one's brought it up."

My aunt was quiet for a while before answering.

"…That sounds strange to me. Existing, but not existing."

"…But it's not hidden, apparently. Just no one's brought it up."

"…Isn't the result the same, whether it's hidden or no one's brought it up? Being treated as not existing is the same either way."

I couldn't answer that question. That day, for the first time, I felt Tyche's explanation and my aunt's question pointing in different directions. I thought about that difference late into that night, but I fell asleep without reaching an answer.

My aunt added, almost to herself, as she washed the dishes. "…Well, someone will bring it up, when it's time." I couldn't tell whether that was meant to comfort me or was just something to say. Probably both.

(Continued in Chapter 12.)

Chapter 12. The Empty Box

> *_Previously_ — Hora learning that the water channel, having come right*
> *into the western edge of the city, has never once been brought up as a*
> *case, and so administratively doesn't exist. Tyche answered precisely:*
> *"If it's never been submitted, it doesn't exist. Not hidden." But her aunt asked back, "Isn't being treated as not existing the same thing either way?" Hora fell asleep without resolving that difference.*

Starting the next day, I began looking at the signature box longer than I usually did.

It wasn't that I was trying to confirm anything in particular. My aunt's question from the night before had simply stayed with me, and I was someone who couldn't settle until I'd checked whatever stayed with me. It was the one habit in this city I'd never managed to change.

The moment I opened my eyes that morning, I thought again of what my aunt had said the day before. "Isn't being treated as not existing the same thing either way?" I turned it over even while eating breakfast. My aunt was ladling out soup as if it were nothing at all, but that one question from the night before kept circling in my head.

I thought about it walking to the meeting room too. Being treated as if the water channel doesn't exist, and the water channel truly not existing. I knew those were different things. Tyche had told me exactly that. But knowing they were different didn't settle my mind. I wanted to know where that unsettled

feeling was coming from. So that day, I decided to look at the signature box again. It had nothing to do with the water channel, and yet somehow, in my mind, the two kept landing in the same place.

. . .

That day, once I'd finished reading the case I'd been given in the meeting room, I looked, as always, at the bottom of the last page. The signature box. Empty.

I'd seen that box dozens of times before. Before, I'd always just passed over it. That day, I looked at it longer.

A long, narrow horizontal box. Small letters above it read "the signature box," and beneath that, nothing at all. I read the small print beside it again. "This document does not require a signature." Does not require. Not the same as forbidding. I'd read that sentence once before. I'd let it pass then.

That day, for the first time, I pulled out other cases too and checked only the signature box.

Empty.

I looked again at the intake stamp beside it. The stamp was clear. The date was clear. The handling progress was recorded in close detail. The list of underlying material was attached, nothing missing. The objection field and the response field were both filled in. Nothing was missing from this document. Nothing except that one box.

It occurred to me, suddenly, to compare this box to all the others. The date box had a date in it. The stamp box had a stamp in it. The intake-number box had a number in it. Every box in this city existed to be filled. Every one, except this one.

That day was the first time I had this thought. More precisely, that day was the first time I noticed that this thought had occurred to me at all. It had probably crossed my mind before, a few times, but I think I'd let it slip past without holding onto it, back then.

. . .

I pulled out the next case. This was one I had no part in, from the Second Deliberation District. The signature box.

Empty.

I went to the reading room and requested three more completely unfamiliar cases. I checked all three.

Empty.

I pulled out the twenty-year-old material again too. The same material I'd seen once before. The signature box.

Empty.

. . .

From that point I decided to go about this a little differently. Instead of just looking at a lot of cases at random, I varied the kind. Ration cases, housing cases, objection-handling cases, old ones, recent ones, evenly across the First through Sixth Deliberation Districts.

I checked them one by one, writing the list down in my notebook.

First District, ration adjustment, three years ago. Empty.
Third District, housing relocation, eight years ago. Empty.
Fifth District, objection re-review, last year. Empty.
Second District, road widening, eleven years ago. Empty.
Sixth District, materials assignment, two years ago. Empty.

I kept going this way. The reading-room librarian noticed me filling out one new application after another and said something.

"…Looking for anything special today?"

"…No, just something I need to check."

The librarian didn't press further and kept handing me material.

At one point, flipping through the twelfth document, I stopped breathing for a moment. Something faint showed at the bottom box. I carried the document to the window and held it up to the light. It was a pressure mark, from age — where the paper had been pressed by something. Not writing. Just a trace left by another document pressed against it. My heart raced for a moment, thinking I'd found something, and then, once I confirmed the mark was nothing, I felt strangely deflated instead. I didn't know, myself, what I'd been hoping for.

I want to write this moment honestly. I was looking for something, at the time. Without even knowing what I was looking for. This wasn't an investigation. An investigation needs a purpose, and I had none. My eyes just kept going to that box.

I looked at a few more cases after that. The form had changed slightly, era to era. The very old ones were handwritten tables; the recent ones were printed. The shape of the box had shifted a little too — some square, some a long horizontal line. But that the box always sat at the very bottom of the last page,

and that it was always empty — not one of those two things had ever once changed.

Curious whether this was something the regulations had set down, or just something carried on as custom, I looked up the form's history of changes. The regulation said only, "A confirmation field shall be placed at the end of the document." It didn't say exactly when the term "confirmation field" or the term "signature box" had first come into use. It didn't say who had first created this box. Not even the name of whoever had made this box remained, anywhere, now.

. . .

By that afternoon I'd checked twenty cases.

All twenty — the signature box was empty.

I looked back through my notebook. The districts were different. The kinds of cases were different. The years were different. Some were three pages, some over forty. There was exactly one thing in common.

The box at the very bottom was always empty.

I stared at that list for a long while. I thought it was strange. But exactly what was strange about it, I couldn't put into words. I closed the notebook, then opened it again, and read it through from the start, in case I'd missed something. There was nothing. The twenty lines stayed exactly twenty lines.

. . .

I went to Tyche and showed them the notebook.

"…Look at this. All twenty — the signature box is empty."

Tyche flipped through the notebook and answered.

"…Yeah, that's how it always is. I know that."

"…Doesn't that seem strange?"

"…Hmm, why would it be strange? It says right there that a signature isn't required."

"…No, but not required and no one writing it are different things. If it isn't forbidden, couldn't at least one person have written something?"

Tyche looked thoughtful at that question.

"…That's true, I guess. But it's empty because no one's written anything. What's strange about that?"

I didn't know what to say back to that. Tyche wasn't wrong. That it was empty because no one had written anything was simply a fact.

"…But is there anything in the regulations that says not to fill it in? Did you check?"

Tyche searched the screen for a moment.

"…No. Nothing comes up, even searching. There's no line saying not to fill it in."

"…Then why does no one fill it in?"

"…Huh. I've never thought about that, myself."

Tyche really did fall into thought for a moment, right there. I would go on to remember that expression for a long time. That was the first time I'd seen Tyche wear the face of not knowing an answer.

"…But Hora, why does this bother you so much? The document's effect is the same whether it's filled in or not."

"…It's not about the effect. It's just that there's a box, and it's never filled, and that's a little…"

I couldn't finish the sentence. Tyche looked at me for a moment and shrugged.

"…I don't really know. But if it bothers you, maybe that's just how it is."

I couldn't tell whether that answer was meant to comfort me or just to let it go. Tyche went back to their own work after that. There wasn't a trace of looking at me strangely. Just a face a little sorry for not having an answer to give. Watching that face, I wondered, briefly, whether Tyche had ever found this box as unfamiliar as I did. I didn't ask.

"…I don't know. It's just that all twenty were the same."

"…You could look at two hundred, two thousand, and they'd all be the same. Because that's just what this box is."

I thought that was true too. It was true, and still something caught.

. . .

That evening I showed the Secretary the notebook too, on my way to return material at the counter.

The Secretary looked through the notebook carefully. Page by page, taking their time.

"…You confirmed all of this yourself?"

"…Yes. I was curious."

The Secretary closed the notebook and looked at me. Their expression showed no particular change.

"…That's right. They'll all be empty."

"…Do you know why?"

The Secretary thought for a moment.

"…Because there's no one to fill it in."

"…Not because it's not allowed?"

"…It isn't that it's not allowed. There's no one for it."

Hearing that answer, I thought of what I'd heard at the water channel a few days before. If it's never been submitted, it doesn't exist. If there's no one to fill it in, it doesn't get filled in. I sensed, dimly, that the two statements shared the same shape. Exactly how they were the same, I couldn't put into words.

"…But why is there no one for it?"

This time the Secretary was silent for longer.

"…That much, I don't know myself."

That day was the first time I noticed the words "I don't know" coming out of this person's mouth. Up to then, the Secretary had answered whatever was

asked. Either they already knew, or, not knowing, they went and found the answer. This time they only said they didn't know.

I was about to put the notebook back in my bag when I noticed a blank form lying on the counter. The same signature box at the very bottom. I looked at that box for a long while. A pen sat beside it. I reached out and picked up the pen.

The Secretary was watching me. They didn't stop me. They just watched.

I touched the tip of the pen to the box for a moment, and then, in the end, set it down without writing anything.

"…Why not write anything?"

The Secretary asked. Not a scolding tone. Just a curious one.

"…I don't know. It just doesn't feel like a place I'm meant to write."

"…Even though no one's ever decided that?"

"…Yes. Even though no one's ever decided that."

Saying that answer, I thought it strange myself. Knowing it wasn't forbidden, I still couldn't put my hand to that box. Why I couldn't — that, too, I didn't know, that day.

. . .

That night I sat for a long while with the notebook open in front of me.

Twenty lines. District, case name, year, and in the last column, the three words I'd written in myself — "empty" — repeated twenty times.

I never did manage, that day, to work out why this unsettled me. It wasn't hidden. Tyche had been right about that. It wasn't forbidden either. The Secretary had been right about that too. I didn't think either of them was wrong.

I remember this night precisely, even now. I reached no conclusion that day. Writing this record, I've felt the temptation, more than once, to attach some plausible sentence to this passage. Something like, "That day I sensed, in my gut, that something was wrong." But that would be a lie. I sensed nothing, that day. I was simply unsettled, and I didn't know why. That was all there was to it.

I put the notebook away in the drawer. The same drawer that held my mother's pages and my first notice. Closing the drawer, it occurred to me, suddenly, to think again of the last line of my mother's twelve pages. It crossed my mind, briefly, whether there might be some connection between having left that line unread for two years, and these twenty empty boxes going unfilled, year after year, by anyone at all. It felt too forced a connection, and I pushed the thought away quickly.

My aunt opened the door a crack and asked, "…Still up?" "…Just about to sleep." "…Something wrong?" I hesitated, then answered. "…No, just — there was something a little strange, and I don't know what's strange about it."

My aunt came in and sat for a moment on the edge of the bed.

"…What did you see?"

"…I looked at twenty documents today, and the signature box was empty in every one. But I don't even know why that bothers me."

My aunt thought for a moment and asked,

"…Is it strange, the thing itself? Or does it just start feeling strange from looking at it too long?"

I couldn't answer that right away. I genuinely didn't know. Whether it was strange, or whether it only felt strange because I'd stared at it too long — I couldn't tell the two apart.

"…I don't know."

My aunt nodded.

"…Then that's not getting answered today. Go to sleep."

"…Okay."

Before leaving the room, my aunt added one more thing. "…But Hora, when something keeps bothering you, there's usually a reason. You just haven't found it yet." I closed my eyes at that and didn't answer. I had nothing to say back.

My aunt looked at me for a moment and said, "…Then look at it again after you've slept. Everything looks strange at night." I laughed at that and turned off the light.

Lying there in the dark, I kept calling those twenty empty boxes back to mind. None of it was wrong, and none of it sat entirely easy either. I fell asleep that night still not knowing why it unsettled me, and in that state, I slept.

(Continued in Part Two.)

The Unsigned Book, Part Two

Nobody Did It

Chapter 13. The Seventh Classification

> *_Previously_ — Two hundred days into her posting at the Fourth Deliberation District, Hora was still the only person who read deliberation documents to the end. The summary was always accurate, and nothing ever happened. Only the signature box at the bottom of the document — every document she opened, without exception — stayed empty.*

The assignment notice came on a single sheet of paper, same as always.

The Seventh Classification residential clearance and relocation matter — assistant member Hora assigned. That was all of it. I read the sentence three times, and it was the same sentence all three times. Reading it a third time did not make the meaning any longer.

I remember exactly which day I received this notice. I remember it exactly not because that day was in itself special, but because later I had to go back to that day again and again, to count something. Not to count what happened that day — to count what didn't.

I went to the reception desk and asked what the Seventh Classification was.

"…It's a classification for residents with incomplete registration."

"…Why is the registration incomplete?"

"…Because their residence is on unregistered land."

"…Is that their fault?"

"…The word 'fault' doesn't appear anywhere in the file. It just says incomplete registration."

The clerk was doing her best to help me. There wasn't the slightest trace of impatience in her voice. I found that strangely steadying. That no one ever treated me as a bother was, in this city, simply how things were — but that day, of all days, it felt unusually kind.

I thought I understood what she meant. It was like the area near the west water channel. Just as the channel administratively did not exist because it had never come up as an agenda item, the land where the people beside it lived also administratively did not exist, for the same reason. People living on land that did not exist had been gathered into a classification that did not exist.

I thought that made logical sense. At the time.

I hardly questioned the word "registration" itself back then. If something wasn't registered, I assumed the unregistered side was the one with the problem. It was much later that I asked why land not being registered should be the fault of the people living on it.

. . .

The clerk handed me a thin information sheet along with the file. It was a list of the departments involved. Twelve departments, each with the number of staff assigned written beside it. Added together, it came to more than four hundred people.

"…This many people are involved?"

"…The bigger the matter, the more there are. That way it never comes down to one person's judgment."

"…So all four hundred of them decide?"

"…No. No one decides. Everyone just does their own share. Passing it on, putting it in order, confirming, convening. Gather all of that up, and it becomes a decision."

"…Then who do you ask, if it goes wrong?"

"…If it's wrong, you file an objection. Objections are handled the same way."

"…What does the same way mean?"

"…Another four hundred or so people pass it on, put it in order, confirm it, convene over it."

That didn't sound strange to me. That objections, too, went through a formal procedure was, if anything, reassuring to hear. It meant no one could look the other way on impulse — that even an objection went onto the same scale as everything else.

I heard that and nodded. It sounded like a safeguard. One person turning bad-hearted could never talk four hundred people into agreeing.

I believed, at the time, that these four hundred people were a safeguard. I remember exactly how long that belief lasted. Until I met twelve of them.

. . .

I ran into Tyche in the corridor. I asked if she was assigned to this one, and she said she only put together the supporting materials.

"…What exactly is the Seventh Classification?"

"…It's the seventh item on the classification table. Numbered in order — not ranked."

"…Why are these particular people grouped into one classification?"

"…On the one thing they have in common: living on residences with no basis for registration. Nothing else in common. Different ages, different work, different places they lived before."

"…Then why are they all being processed at once?"

Tyche looked at me and smiled. It wasn't an unkind smile.

"…Because processing them all at once is fair. Looked at one by one, the outcome would depend on each person's circumstances. Then some would end up looked after and some wouldn't. Grouped by classification and processed by the same standard, nobody gets special treatment."

I heard that and nodded. At the time it sounded right. *Even now I can't say the statement itself was wrong. What I didn't ask, back then, was who that fairness was for.*

. . .

The clerk handed me a file. This one was thick.

"…You read all of this?"

"…Yes."

"…Everyone else just looks at the summary."

"…I always read the whole thing."

She looked at me for a moment. It wasn't a strange look. Just a mildly curious one.

"…Then this'll take you a while. This one's big."

"…How big?"

"…Eleven hundred and forty people."

I heard that number and felt nothing. I'm ashamed to say so, but that's the truth. The number was just a number. The deliberations I'd seen so far had run, at most, a few dozen people, so eleven hundred and forty didn't feel real to me at all.

I've crossed this paragraph out and rewritten it more times than I can count, writing this now. There's a temptation to write it as though I felt something I should have felt. But that isn't true. I heard the number and worried about the thickness of the file. That was all.

. . .

When the matter was first brought before the Fourth Deliberation District's meeting room, the seats were about half full.

The officer in charge stood at the front and explained. Unregistered residences had accumulated over several years, he said, and this time a consolidated clearance agenda had been brought up. Someone asked what "clearance" meant.

"…Recovery of the residences and relocation."

"…Relocation to where?"

"…That's in the detailed proposal."

"…This looks like a big one — why is it only coming up now?"

"…The cumulative count crossed the processing threshold. Below the threshold, cases were handled individually. Once it crossed, it converted to a consolidated agenda item."

I sat through that exchange without much thought. The phrase "detailed proposal" was familiar. This city's documents were always layered that way. The broad shape gets stated at the meeting, the detail lives in the document — that had held true up to now.

The officer handed out the summary. A page and a half. I read it. Clearance of unregistered residences, eleven hundred and forty people affected, a relocation plan to be established, an implementation date specified. Clean.

The person in the next seat said,

"…This one's big, so read carefully, everyone."

"…Right."

"…Not that it matters — it'll all go by the summary anyway. It always does for these."

Near the end of the meeting, someone asked whether children were among the eleven hundred and forty. The officer checked his materials and answered.

"…Two hundred thirty are fourteen or under."

"…And the elderly?"

"…A hundred ninety are sixty or over."

The room went quiet for a moment. But the quiet didn't last. Someone cleared their throat, and someone asked whether we were ready to move to the next item. I didn't read that quiet as meaning anything, at the time. I just thought everyone had gone briefly solemn hearing the numbers.

Looking back, that quiet changed nothing. It went quiet, then it moved on. In this city, quiet was a feeling, not an action.

That man hadn't meant to deceive me. He truly believed what he said. *And in a certain sense he was right. This matter, too, ended up going by the summary. Nothing he said was wrong.*

. . .

The meeting ended and people filed out. I stayed behind holding the thick file.

The custodian came to lock up and saw me still there.

"…Staying late again today?"

"…Yes."

"…This one's a big one."

"…Yes, I saw."

"…I won't turn off the lights."

The custodian said that and left. I stayed alone and turned to the first page of the file.

The first section was background: the history of unregistered residences, how they arose, the relevant regulations. I read it slowly. None of the sentences were difficult. Just long.

According to the background section, unregistered residences generally arose like this. A piece of land had never come up as an agenda item. Never having come up, it went unregistered. Unregistered land got no management budget. With no budget, no one touched it. Since no one touched it, no one stopped people from moving in and living there. A few years, a few decades passed that way, and by then people were living on land that was still, on paper, nowhere at all.

Reading this circular structure, I thought of the water channel. I'd learned that the west channel, too, was treated as not existing because it had never come up as an agenda item. That land, too, could vanish the same way — I learned that for the first time reading this document.

Something should have clicked for me at this point. It didn't. Reading through the circular structure, I just thought this city's administration was remarkably thorough. How neatly it kept records of what wasn't there, I thought.

I gauged the thickness of the file. It looked to be more than three hundred pages. It would take several days to finish.

I looked at the bottom of the first page. There was a signature box. Empty. Of course it was. It always was.

The first fifty pages were mostly definitions and grounds — the legal definition of incomplete registration, the relevant ordinance numbers, a list of similar small-scale clearances over the past ten years. The small cases had run twenty or thirty people at a time, and each had gone through without any particular problem, the file said. This one was unusually large, it explained, only because those small cases had gone unresolved and kept piling up.

I read about fifty pages that night before going home. My aunt asked why I was so late, and I only said this one was pretty big.

"…How big."

"…Eleven hundred forty, they said."

My aunt looked at me a moment.

"…You're going to read all of it?"

"…Yes."

"…Hora, that's exactly why the summary exists — because nobody reads all of it."

"…I know. I'm reading it anyway."

My aunt didn't try to stop me any further. Instead she spooned me another bowl of rice. *Thinking back on it now, I think she wanted to stop me, some. Not because reading it all the way through was a bad thing to do, but because she may have had some sense of what I'd end up seeing once I finished. Of course, this is a thought I've attached to it afterward. That evening she just spooned out more rice. That's all she did.*

. . .

From the next day on, I stayed and read every day.

Nothing struck me as strange as I read. Every sentence was clean, every claim was backed, every procedure was in order. No clause was hidden. No page was blocked from view.

I want to be clear about this part. Writing this record now, I don't want it to look as though I were uncovering something bit by bit. The file was open from the first page to the last. Anyone could have read it. I was simply reading what no one else read.

On the second day I read the roster of those affected. No names — only numbers and classification codes. 7-001 through 7-1140. Beside each number, a brief age range, household size, and length of residence. At first I thought the absence of names was for privacy, and in fact it partly was.

Someone else was in the reading room that day. Someone from a neighboring deliberation district, skimming the same matter. After about ten minutes he pulled out only the summary, took it, and left. He never opened the full text.

I didn't think of that as laziness. Everyone knew the summary was accurate. Reading it a second time, when it was already accurate, was the strange thing to do. *At the time I thought I was the strange one. Even now, I don't think that's entirely wrong.*

On the third day, around page one hundred fifty, I came to the list of proposed relocation sites. Place names ran down the page. I picked out a few I could try to place, and some I recognized, and some I didn't.

At the end of the list was a footnote in small print.

Of the above list, items 3, 7, and 12 are temporary designations pending detailed confirmation.

I read the footnote and turned the page. It didn't seem all that important at the time. I noticed all three items had a small asterisk beside their place names, and I took that, too, for just a notation convention. "Temporary designation" was a phrase I saw often in this city's documents. I figured it would be finalized eventually.

That's how I let the footnote pass. If someone asked me which is the moment I regret most while writing this record, I'd point to that night. I'm not sure "regret" is the right word. I did, after all, go on to read every page that followed, and I did, in the end, learn everything. Still — in that moment, I could have stopped once more and read that footnote again.

I closed the file and went home. About a hundred pages remained.

I passed the water channel on my way home. The water was still making its sound. I stood beside it for a moment and wondered whether the land this water ran through could one day become an unregistered residence too. No one lived there yet, so it seemed unlikely.

That's what I thought at the time. I can't yet say I was wrong. No one lived there. Still, the thought that there might have been a connection between that channel and this deliberation — one I failed to see — is something I haven't been able to fully shake, even now, writing this record.

My aunt was already asleep, so I went straight to my room without a word. I fell asleep holding two things in my head: that a hundred pages remained, and that three footnotes said "temporary designation."

Tomorrow I would finish the remaining hundred pages. At the time I thought of it as simply one more day's work left. I believed that once the day passed, this matter, too, would end just as the summary described. Exactly when that belief broke is what I set down, unchanged, in the next chapter.

(Continued in Chapter 14.)

Chapter 14. To the End

> *_Previously_ — Hora is three days into reading the Seventh Classification deliberation. Eleven hundred forty people, two hundred thirty of them children. Three footnotes reading "temporary designation" at the end of the relocation-site list nagged at her, though at the time she didn't know why.*

On the fourth morning I got to the meeting room earlier than usual.

The custodian was cleaning and startled to see me.

"…You're early today."

"…Yes, I'm going to finish it today."

"…That thick one? Impressive."

"…It's just a habit."

The custodian laughed and went back to cleaning. I sat down and opened to the page where I'd stopped the day before. A hundred pages remained. I made up my mind to finish all of it that day. There was no other reason. I simply didn't want to split it up any further.

On the fourth day, I read the remaining hundred pages.

I've thought for a long time about how to write this chapter. I don't want to write it dramatically. I didn't suddenly notice something that day. I just turned one page, then another. Even when I reached the last page, I was still just turning pages.

Up to that point I still didn't think I was doing anything remarkable. Reading what others don't read had long been my habit — not some sense of justice. I want this made clear, because I'm worried that what happens after this will read as though I'd meant to dig something up from the start. I was only doing what I always did.

. . .

The first sixty of the hundred pages were about execution procedure. Notification method, notification deadline, the channel for filing objections, the formula for relocation support funds. All of it was there. All the numbers were there too. Support funds — so much per household. Moving support — so many days. Where to file the change of residence.

The notification-method clause read: *Recipients will be notified in writing thirty days before the implementation date, and the notice will specify the destination site, the relocation deadline, and the support provided.* I read this and thought it a considerate clause. Thirty days seemed like no short amount of time.

There was also a clause for filing objections. *Anyone with an objection to this decision may submit a written objection within fourteen days of the notification date.* I thought this was a good clause too. It meant the path to filing an objection wasn't closed off.

Reading it all, I felt reassured rather than not. Something this carefully woven together seemed unlikely to let anything bad happen. That there were support funds, that there was moving assistance — all of it read as good news.

I read every one of these clauses generously. Even now, looking back, none of these clauses is bad in itself. The problem wasn't the clause. It was what the clause pointed to.

Around page seventy, the detailed relocation-site plan appeared. The same list I'd seen on the third day unfolded again here, this time laid out in a table with each region's capacity, infrastructure status, and expected relocation timing.

I found the three sites the footnote had called temporary — items 3, 7, and 12. I looked at the table. The capacity column held a question mark. The infrastructure status column was blank. Only the expected relocation timing was filled in, the same as everywhere else.

I looked at this table many times over. Seeing the question mark and the blank cell side by side, I felt for the first time that something was strange. I still didn't know what, exactly, that sense of strangeness was pointing to.

Beside the table I noticed a small note in the margin: *Final confirmation pending, following inter-departmental consultation, to be separately announced.* No date was given for when the consultation would end. I went to the archive and looked into similar past cases. A few small-scale matters had also carried the phrase "separately announced." Half of them had no follow-up announcement that the consultation had ended at all. Whether the absence meant it had been cancelled or was still ongoing, nothing anywhere said.

This was the first time I doubted the phrase "separately announced" in this city's documents. I'm not sure "doubted" is the right word. I only confirmed, with my own eyes, for the first time, that there might be nothing at all behind those words.

. . .

I looked closely at the support-fund formula too. The amount changed with household size, and a little more was added for longer residence. The formula itself was written out. I actually applied it to a few households. The math checked out. What wasn't in the clause was whether there was actually a market at the destination site where that money could be used — whether

there was somewhere to buy a house with it. That having money and having somewhere to spend it were different problems was something I first thought about right then.

Around page eighty I found the number of people assigned to items 3, 7, and 12.

The three together came to four hundred ten. Four hundred ten out of eleven hundred forty were headed to places whose capacity and infrastructure had not been confirmed.

I flipped back and checked the three place names again. The names were there. I tried to place them on the city map in my head, and I couldn't place them anywhere.

One of the three names was "the West Lowlands." I paused when I saw that name. The word "west" caught at me. It was the direction of the west water channel. I wasn't sure. The west side of the city was wide — it could overlap, or it might not. There was no way for me to check right then, so I just wrote the name down.

Whether that overlap is coincidence or not, I still can't say for certain, writing this record. I didn't compare it against the map until much later, and that result comes later in this book. Here I'll only set down that I stopped in front of that name that night.

This was the first time I thought about going to the archive to check the map against it. I didn't. There was no time. Writing this sentence, I regret not doing it then, though the outcome would probably have been the same either way. That place name had never been on any map to begin with.

. . .

Around page ninety, I found out what these three places were. "Found out" overstates it. It was simply written in the next paragraph.

Items 3, 7, and 12 are designated pending sites and, until confirmed, are classified as unregistered regions.

I read that sentence three times. On the fourth reading I read it aloud. There was no one else in the reading room, so no one would hear. Spoken aloud, the meaning was the same.

The three sites were land that did not yet exist. Unregistered regions. Reclassified into exactly the state the Seventh Classification lived in — land that did not exist because it had never come up as an agenda item.

Four hundred ten people, being pushed off land for lack of registration, were headed to other land that was, itself, unregistered.

I stood up for a moment at this point and paced around the reading room. Wondering if I'd misread something, I sat back down and read the paragraph again. Same content. Three readings, all the same.

I also checked what would happen to the remaining seven hundred thirty. That side had its infrastructure status and capacity fully filled in. They were assigned to land that really existed, to plots where houses would really be built. So this matter was not entirely bad. Most of them really were going somewhere. Only four hundred ten were headed to a place that did not yet exist.

I want to set down this distinction precisely. This deliberation did not send all eleven hundred forty people to a place that didn't exist. If it had, it might have been easier to notice. Seven hundred thirty really did have somewhere to go. So when the summary said "relocation plan established," that wasn't a lie. There really was a plan. For most of them.

I catch myself, once again, resisting the temptation to write this sentence so it sounds frightening. Nothing in the document itself read as frightening. It was just one paragraph. The same font size, the same style, as every other paragraph.

. . .

The last ten pages were supplementary provisions. I'd heard that supplementary provisions were something nobody ever reads — formal clauses, implementation dates, transitional rules and the like.

I read the supplementary provisions to the end too.

The final clause of the supplementary provisions — the last sentence of the entire document — read:

Upon completion of this procedure, the Seventh Classification will be deleted from the roster.

I read that sentence and sat for a long while.

I checked the clock. It was past ten at night. I was alone in the reading room. The window let in no view of outside, so I couldn't guess the time by that — I only knew from the clock in the corridor.

Being deleted didn't mean a person was deleted. It meant the classification was deleted. I held onto that distinction and thought about it for a long time. When a classification disappears, where do the people who were in it go? Do they get moved to another classification, or do they simply become people belonging to no classification at all? The document didn't say. Not that it left it unsaid — the document simply ended there.

. . .

I closed the document and looked at the cover again. There was a viewing-record field — a box where it stamped who had opened it and when.

I opened that field. This, too, had always been public. Not a hidden menu.

There was a long record. The department in charge, related departments, the higher authority. The number of views was high. Over two hundred.

Seeing this record, I knew one thing for certain. No one had stopped me. This document had been opened more than two hundred times. Anyone could have gone all the way to the last page. There was no reason, in this city, to hide the final clause. The Consensus hides nothing. Not hidden — simply that not one of those two hundred had gone all the way to the last page.

This fact made what I had to do next much harder. If someone had hidden it, I could have gone to that person. No one had hidden it. So who was I supposed to go to?

I scrolled down the viewing record line by line. No names — only department and position. Several times from the department in charge, a few times from related departments, once from the higher authority. Each of the twenty-two committee members had a record of having opened it once. I would now be added to that list too.

I wrote the number two hundred in the corner of a piece of paper. I didn't know why I wrote it down then. Later I would find reason to pull that number out again.

Looking at that list, I felt a strange comfort. At least I wasn't the only one who had opened this document. That it had been opened over two hundred times meant that over two hundred times, someone had sat down in front of it. But how many of those two hundred times had eyes actually reached the final

clause — the viewing record did not say. It doesn't measure the distance between having opened something and having read it.

. . .

Before I left, I checked the signature box once more. It had become a habit by now. There was a signature box on the very last page too, beneath the supplementary provisions. Empty.

Looking at that box, I formed a strange question for the first time. Not that there was no one who had made this document — but that there was no one at all assigned to sign it. The decision sat here, fully complete, and beneath that decision there was a place for a name, and no one was ever meant to fill it. I felt as though the order had been reversed. Normally, someone decides, and then signs. Here, things were decided without a signature, and the signature box simply remained, out of habit.

The custodian was the last one left, and she turned off the light when she saw me.

"…Finished it all?"

"…Yes."

"…How was it?"

I couldn't answer right away. She didn't rush me, just waited.

"…Bigger than I thought."

"…It is. It's a big one."

She said only that and locked the door. I'd expected her to press me further about my answer. She didn't. *She hadn't deceived me either. Her job was simply to lock the door.*

On the way home, my steps kept slowing. It was late, so the streets were quiet.

Passing the water channel, I felt afraid of its sound for the first time. The water hadn't changed. I had.

I told my aunt nothing that night. I didn't know what to say. If I said "four hundred ten out of eleven hundred forty are headed to a place that doesn't exist," I couldn't guess what she'd say back. I still can't guess, even now.

I went to my room and pulled out the summary again. A page and a half. I read it once more.

There wasn't a lie in the summary. Eleven hundred forty people, a relocation plan, an implementation date. All of it was accurate.

Only the deletion of the roster wasn't anywhere in the summary.

I folded the summary back up and put it in the drawer. The one with my mother's papers. I still had no particular reason. It was still the only drawer I had.

I barely slept that night. I'd like to say it wasn't out of fear, but I think, in truth, I was a little afraid. Only I couldn't tell, at the time, what that fear was pointed at. At the people of the Seventh Classification? At this city? Or simply at not knowing what I was supposed to do next?

Staring at the ceiling, I kept returning to the same sentence. Upon completion of this procedure, the Seventh Classification will be deleted from the roster. Twenty-two characters, in the original. Behind those twenty-two characters stood four hundred ten people.

I remember the first thing I did the next morning. I pulled out the summary again and this time read it word by word, tracing each character with my eye. I wanted to check that the summary really had no falsehood, that I hadn't misread something. To say the result first: the summary really was without error, anywhere. I set down that checking process exactly as it happened, in the next chapter.

(Continued in Chapter 15.)

Chapter 15. The Summary Was Accurate

> *_Previously_ — Hora read the Seventh Classification deliberation to the end. Four hundred ten of the eleven hundred forty were being relocated to land that did not yet exist, and once the procedure was complete, the classification itself would be deleted from the roster. None of this appeared anywhere in the summary.*

The next morning I took out the summary again and laid it side by side with the full text.

I want to set down this act of comparison precisely. This will likely be the most tedious chapter in this book. I know that. But without this tedious comparison, I would have gone on to misunderstand everything that happened next. So I write it out plainly, tedious or not.

I spent the entire day on this comparison. The other members had already moved on to the next matter. I was the only one still sitting on the Seventh Classification case. No one told me that was strange.

. . .

The summary's first sentence read:

The Seventh Classification (unregistered residents) residential clearance and relocation matter.

Identical to the document name on the cover of the full text. Not one character different.

The second sentence.

Subject: 1,140 people (7-001 to 7-1140).

I counted the roster. Exactly eleven hundred forty. The numbers matched too.

The third sentence.

Reason: A need for consolidated clearance has arisen from the accumulation of unregistered residences.

I checked it against the background section of the full text. The same phrasing appeared there, unchanged. The circular structure I'd read — not registered because it never came up as an agenda item, not managed because not registered — compressed into this one sentence. It was compression, not distortion.

Up to these three sentences, I already knew everything. I wasn't looking for something wrong here. What I really wanted to confirm was what came after.

I looked at the third sentence once more. The phrase "a need... has arisen" caught at me. Arisen — as though it were weather, something that simply happened rather than something anyone made. I checked whether the full text used the same word. It did. The full text also said "arisen." The summary had simply carried over the full text's own phrasing.

I sat with this one word for a long while. "A need has arisen" and "someone judged this to be necessary" are different in meaning. But this city's documents always used the former. I wondered whether that was a habit of this one document, or a habit of every document in this city. I confirmed later that it was the latter.

. . .

The fourth sentence.

Action: Residence recovery and relocation. Relocation support funds and moving assistance to be provided.

This too was accurate. The support-fund clause, the moving-assistance clause, all exactly as they stood in the full text. I checked the support formula again. The summary had no formula, but the word "provided" was true. It hadn't claimed something existed that didn't.

The fifth sentence, the last.

Implementation date: as specified in the timeline.

I paused on this sentence. The full text had a concrete date. The summary only said "as specified in the timeline." I wondered whether the date had been hidden, and checked again — the date was right there in the full text, available to anyone who looked. The summary simply hadn't repeated it, since it was already in the full text.

This was a common enough practice. A summary isn't meant to replace the full text — I'd learned before that it's meant to be a signpost pointing toward it. A signpost has no obligation to show everything at the destination.

. . .

The summary was exactly five sentences. It fit within a page and a half.

I read the whole summary through again from the start. Not a single wrong sentence. Not a single exaggerated one. No missing numbers. Nothing like the support-fund matter left out when it should have been there, nothing like the number of people affected differing from the real count. None of that.

I took out a sheet of paper and copied the summary's five sentences on the left and the corresponding sections of the full text on the right. I drew lines connecting them and checked each pair one by one. When I finished, between the five lines on the left and the five paragraphs on the right, there was truly not one place where the meaning had shifted. The right side was simply longer.

I kept this sheet of paper for a long time. I later used it as an attachment to my objection filing. Even now, writing this record, I keep it beside me. This comparison chart is the only thing in this entire book I can call "evidence." And what that evidence proves is only that no one did anything wrong.

I sat for a long while in front of that fact. I think I had wanted, somewhere, to feel deceived. Then I would have had someone to be angry at. But no matter how many times I compared them, there was no deception. The summary was accurate.

. . .

I went to find Tyche and asked her.

"…Why is the summary so short?"

"…Summaries are always short. Everyone makes their judgment from it, so."

"…Then why doesn't it have the roster-deletion clause?"

Tyche took the summary and skimmed it.

"…That's a supplementary provision. Supplementary provisions don't usually go into the summary."

"…Why not?"

"…The body's action clauses all go into the summary, and supplementary provisions are about the implementation method for that action. Put every supplementary provision in, and the summary stops being a summary."

I heard that and couldn't say anything back. There was nothing logically wrong with it.

"…But this is an important clause. A whole classification is getting deleted."

Tyche looked at me for a moment.

"…Isn't it up to the reader to decide what's important? I'm not the one who decides what goes into the summary and what stays out."

"…Then who decides?"

"…The regulation decides. Five sentences, it says."

"…Who decided on five sentences?"

Tyche thought for a moment and said,

"…I don't know that either. It was already that way before I ever got here."

Something in that answer caught at me. The person who had written the rule for five sentences seemed to not be there anymore either. Only the rule remained.

"…So the summary being short means people end up judging things carelessly?"

"…Not carelessly — accurately. Because the summary is accurate. You just confirmed that yourself, didn't you? Nothing wrong, right?"

"…Right. Nothing wrong."

"…So what's the problem?"

I couldn't answer that question. *I left the room that day without an answer to it. It would take the remaining thirty-some chapters of this book to find my own answer to that question.*

Hearing that answer, I knew Tyche hadn't meant it unkindly. She really had only followed the summary's form. Following a form couldn't be a crime.

. . .

After leaving Tyche, I went to the archive and looked up a few more summaries from old small-scale clearance cases. All of them were similar. Five sentences — subject, reason, action, implementation timing. One case had involved seventeen people, and reading the summary, all seventeen appeared to have relocated to new residences with no particular trouble. I checked the full text — that really was the case. That case had no temporary designations like this one.

I looked at a few more besides that one. A thirty-two-person case, a nine-person case. All of them matched their summaries. I couldn't find a single case with anything like a temporary designation attached. It might have been because this Seventh Classification matter was especially large. Or it might simply have been bad luck.

Doing these comparisons, I learned one thing. The summary wasn't the problem. The summary's form was always identical. It was just that, this time, the content that went into that form happened to be content in which four hundred ten people's place could not fit. The form was innocent. It was only that the gap between what the form needed to hold and what the form could hold happened, this time, to be unusually wide.

I asked the archive clerk whether the summary being this short had ever caused a problem.

"…I couldn't say. I've never heard of anything like that."

"…Not even once?"

"…I've been here six years, and this is the first objection like this I've seen."

Hearing that, I felt, faintly, that I was doing something new. It wasn't a good feeling. New, in this city, generally meant unfamiliar, and unfamiliar generally meant uncomfortable.

. . .

I went to the reception desk and looked up the regulation for drafting summaries. In one corner of the regulation book was the guideline for writing them.

The summary shall include: subject, reason, action, and implementation timing. As a rule, the summary shall not exceed five sentences.

Five sentences. I looked at the number and understood. That this summary had come out to exactly five sentences wasn't a coincidence. The rule had set it that way.

Curious why this rule had been made, I looked up the stated reason attached beside it. "Excessive length increases the review burden on members and causes delay in deliberation," it read. This too wasn't a rule made out of ill will. If anything, it had been made out of consideration. Because everyone was busy, because everyone had to process many matters, it had been made so people could read short and judge.

But between "short" and "less important," whoever wrote this rule had never drawn a line. The shorter something is, the simpler what remains looks. There was no place for four hundred ten people within five sentences. There being no place for them and their having been hidden were different things — and I was, for the first time, sitting with that difference in my hands.

Beside the regulation book was a section on the summary-review procedure. Once a summary was drafted, it said, the department in charge confirmed it, and then it was distributed to the committee. The word "confirm" caught my eye, so I read that procedure closely. *Confirmation examines whether the summary is consistent with the full text. The length or emphasis of the summary is not subject to confirmation.* So confirmation checked only for accuracy. What was kept and what was cut lay outside the confirmation procedure.

I read that sentence twice. There was confirmation. Confirmation had done exactly what it was meant to do. It was only that what it was meant to do differed from what I had hoped it would do.

I also looked up which department handled the confirmation. It said that department confirmed dozens of summaries this way every week. Each confirmation probably took very little time. It wasn't the fault of the people in that department. They had been taught to look only at accuracy, and they had looked only at accuracy.

. . .

Leaving the archive, I thought again about the summary itself. A summary wasn't inherently a bad thing. I'd written many summaries myself — ration application summaries, school assignment summaries. Writing short wasn't laziness — it was a skill. A well-cut summary got more people to read, not fewer.

The problem was that in this city, no one failed to read the summary. Everyone read the summary and nothing else. So what wasn't in the summary became the same as what no one knew. The summary being short wasn't the bad part — the bad part was that everyone reading only the summary meant the summary's gaps became the whole city's gap.

This wasn't the fault of the person who wrote the summary. It wasn't the fault of the people who read only the summary, either. Everyone had simply acted reasonably, each in their own way. And yet when all of those reasonable acts gathered together, a decision came out complete, with four hundred ten people missing from it.

I came home and told my aunt about all this. She listened while getting dinner ready.

"…So no one lied. That's what you're saying."

"…Right. Really — no one."

"…Then why is that a problem?"

I couldn't answer right away. After a long moment I said,

"…I don't know. But something about it feels like a problem."

"…Even without knowing what the problem is?"

"…Right."

My aunt looked at me without laughing.

"…Hora. You're going to keep going like this until you figure it out. Aren't you."

I didn't answer. She knew that was the answer.

She ladled the soup and said,

"…I thought you'd found some huge wrongdoing. But hearing it, it sounds like everyone just did their own job."

"…Yeah. Seems like it."

"…Then isn't that just how it is? If everyone did only their own job and it turned out this way, that's nobody's fault."

I lifted my spoon and stopped.

"…But then who do those four hundred ten people even ask?"

My aunt didn't answer right away this time either. After a long while she said,

"…I don't know that one."

We ate the rest of the meal in silence for a while after that. *I still remember that silence. It wasn't that my aunt had gone quiet out of anger. She, too, like me, had gone quiet looking for an answer and not finding one. That I wasn't the only person in this city stuck in front of that question — I learned that for the first time that day.*

I slept poorly that night too. Confirming that the summary wasn't a lie had, if anything, made me more frustrated. If someone had lied, I could have gone and confronted them. Since no one had lied, I had no one left to confront. All that remained was the feeling that something was strange.

I tried to give that feeling a name. It wasn't a sense of being wronged — that's a feeling you get when someone has done wrong to you, and no one had done wrong to me. It wasn't anger either — you can't be angry with no one to be angry at. If I had to name it, it was simply a feeling that something was empty. The very same feeling I got looking at the signature box.

We cleared the table and I went to my room, where I pulled out the comparison chart again. Five lines on the left, five paragraphs on the right. However many times I looked, it stayed the same. I put that paper away in the drawer along with the notice. The same drawer that held my mother's papers.

I decided the next day to file an objection. I already knew, from having read it, that there was a channel for filing one. I thought that if there was a procedure, following that procedure would be enough. How naive a thought that was, I would learn over the days that followed.

(Continued in Chapter 16.)

Chapter 16. The Objection

> *_Previously_ — Hora compared the summary against the full text, line by line. The summary was accurate. There was no lie in it. It was only that within the rule of five sentences, there was no room for four hundred ten people. There was no one to be angry at, no one to confront. So Hora decided to file an objection.*

The objection form had three fields.

Deliberation matter under objection, *grounds for objection*, *requested action*. I wrote the document name in the first field. My hand stopped at the second.

I didn't know what grounds to write. "The summary is short" didn't seem like it would work as grounds — the summary had followed the rule. "No one decided" didn't seem like it would work either — that was true of every deliberation in this city.

I sat in front of that field for about thirty minutes. Not because I had nothing to write, but because I had too much. If I wrote it all, I thought it would run past three fields.

A sample objection form was posted on the wall at the reception desk. The sample was short and clear. *An error exists in the selection criteria for the target site of this deliberation, and a re-review is requested.* Reading that sample a few times, I realized what I wanted to say didn't fold up as neatly as this. What I'd felt as wrong wasn't contained in the single word "error."

I redrafted my note three times. The first draft ran too long and spilled past the field. The second draft had too much feeling in it. I wrote the sentence "I think this is wrong" and crossed it out. In this city's documents, the phrase "I think"

didn't belong. I already knew, from what I'd learned, that a feeling with no grounds behind it wasn't something a deliberation dealt with.

In the third draft I cut all the feeling and kept only the facts. That turned out to be the shortest version, and also the one with the most force.

In the end, I wrote this:

Among the proposed relocation sites, items 3, 7, and 12 remain in a state pending detailed confirmation and have been redesignated as unregistered regions. This repeats the exact same structure as the original problem. A re-review is requested for the four hundred ten people affected.

. . .

I submitted it at the reception desk, and the clerk looked it over and tore off a receipt for me.

"…How does an objection get processed?"

"…It's referred to the deliberation district and reviewed again."

"…Who reviews it?"

"…The whole district. Same method as the original deliberation."

"…The same people?"

"…Yes, usually. Unless the assignment changes."

Hearing that, I found it a little strange. If the same people reviewed it again the same way, why would the result change? But I didn't say that thought out loud. There was a procedure, and I wanted to follow it and see.

Thinking back now, I should have said that thought to the clerk then. Saying it might not have changed anything, but at least I would have known, sooner, what I was expecting.

"…How long does processing take?"

"…This one's a big matter, so plan on it taking a while. About two weeks."

I took the receipt and left. A single sheet of paper. Stamped with a receipt number and the date.

On my way out I looked at the bulletin board. A chart titled "Objection Filing Status" was posted. It listed, side by side, the number of objections filed over the past year and, of those, the number of cases where the original decision had been changed. A hundred twelve filed, three changed.

I stopped for a moment looking at that number. Three. Three out of a hundred twelve. I wondered what those three cases had been about, but I had no time that day and simply moved on. I would look into those three cases later, but that's much further ahead.

Oddly, I wasn't discouraged looking at that chart that day. A hundred twelve to three still meant that three, at least, had been changed. I believed mine could be one of those three. There was no basis for that belief, but at the time I didn't yet know it was a belief without basis.

. . .

For those two weeks I handled other deliberations as usual. Other than having been referred, there was no news at all about the Seventh Classification case.

Every day during those two weeks, I passed the reception-desk bulletin board and looked at the objection-status chart again. The numbers stayed the same. A

hundred twelve, three. I stopped in front of that chart for a few seconds every time. It was the kind of behavior that would look strange to someone watching, but no one thought it strange of me. No one here thought it strange to stand in front of a chart.

Once, I ran into the person from the next seat in front of that chart. The one who'd told me, on my first day, that just looking at the summary was enough.

"…I heard you filed an objection."

"…I did."

"…It won't be easy. I filed one for a small matter once, myself. Came out the same."

"…Same reason — no procedural defect?"

"…Yes, the exact same phrasing."

Hearing that, I felt puzzled — whether "the exact same phrasing" meant a standardized reply, or whether it really had been that there was no procedural defect every single time. *Thinking about it now, both were probably true. The procedure really was followed correctly every time, and that's exactly why the same phrasing kept coming out.*

I asked Tyche how it was going.

"…How far has the objection gotten?"

"…It's under review at the district. I don't know much more than that either."

"…Can the person who filed the objection give a statement?"

"…You can. In writing."

"…Not in person?"

"…The original deliberation is mostly written too. Objections are the same."

I wrote up more supporting material and submitted it in writing. I copied the table for items 3, 7, and 12, marked the question mark and the blank cell, and noted that there was no market at the destination site where the support funds could actually be spent. *I thought this was fairly concrete grounds for the problem. At the time I believed I'd found something new. I thought I'd seen something no one else had.*

I found out later, though. That table had already been reviewed once, during the deliberation itself. The conclusion of "temporary designation" had come out of that very review. I hadn't found anything new — I had simply read, belatedly, something that already existed.

Even after submitting the written statement, I went to the archive every afternoon to check on the objection's progress. The status screen only showed stages. *Received → Referred → Under Review → Result Notified.* I watched that screen stay stuck at "Under Review" every day. It stayed that way through the tenth day.

On the tenth day, on a hunch, I called the reviewing department. Phones weren't a common way of doing things in this city either, but the receipt had an inquiry number printed on it.

"…Could I ask about the progress on the objection for the Seventh Classification matter."

"…It's under review now."

"…How much longer?"

"…If it stays on schedule, it should come out sometime this week."

"…Could I ask which part is being focused on?"

"…We're looking at exactly what you wrote in your grounds. Items 3, 7, and 12."

That answer wasn't given carelessly. It really meant they were looking at exactly what I had written. *Hanging up, I understood that this person hadn't given me a short answer to brush me off. The situation had simply been simple enough to warrant a short answer. There were only the three items I'd written to review.*

. . .

Two weeks later, the notice of the objection's outcome arrived.

A two-page document. I read this one to the end too.

The first page was a summary of the objection's substance. What I had written had been summarized accurately. The unconfirmed status of items 3, 7, and 12, the request to re-review the four hundred ten people affected. Nothing was missing.

The second page was the review's result.

Upon review, the pending confirmation status of items 3, 7, and 12 is determined not to be a procedural defect, and it is confirmed that inter-departmental consultation is ongoing. The reclassification of the region as unregistered is a temporary measure for administrative convenience prior to implementation and is expected to be finalized by the implementation date. The original decision is therefore maintained.

I read that sentence several times.

It was true that it wasn't a procedural defect. There really was no defect. It probably wasn't a lie that the consultation was ongoing, either. Only when that "ongoing" would end wasn't written here either.

There was a signature box at the bottom of the second page too. I looked at it reflexively. Empty. *By now I didn't startle seeing that box empty. If anything, it would have startled me more if it had been filled.*

. . .

I decided to go find the department in charge directly and ask.

The person who had handled the objection review was a woman who looked to be middle-aged. Documents were stacked on her desk.

"…I received the review result. When does the consultation end?"

"…That's not something I handle. It has to go over to the relevant department to know."

"…Then which department is that?"

"…The department that manages the relocation sites. It should be in the document."

"…Could I ask them and find out?"

"…They'll probably have to pass it further up too. That's usually how it goes."

Hearing this, I had a guess. It wasn't that there was nowhere to ask. There was always somewhere else to ask. Only the end was nowhere in sight.

I remember this moment. I already knew that the structure — passing things up, layer by layer — hadn't been designed badly. If anything, it was a

structure built so that no single person could decide unilaterally. But that good structure was making it impossible to find the one single person who knew what I wanted to know.

"…I filed this objection because I thought there was a problem here."

"…Yes, I understand that. But what we confirmed was the procedure. The procedure was all followed."

"…Isn't the procedure being followed and this being okay two different things?"

She looked at me and was silent for a moment. Her face wasn't angry.

"…You're right. They're different things. But I'm the person who looks at the procedure."

Hearing that answer, I knew this person, too, hadn't lied, just as Tyche hadn't. Her job really was to look at the procedure. Whether there was anyone who looked beyond the procedure — I started looking for that from that moment on.

I asked her, on the spot, for the list of everyone involved. It was public material, so it wasn't hard to get.

"…What are you going to do with this?"

"…Go visit them, one at a time."

She looked at me for a moment. Her face wasn't trying to stop me.

"…There are four hundred thirty-two of them."

"…I know."

"…You're going to visit all of them?"

"…Just a few, to start."

She didn't ask any further and printed out the list for me. Several sheets stapled together. No names — only department, position, and stage of involvement. Passing on it, stage 1. Putting it in order, stage 2. Confirming, stage 3. Convening, stage 4. It was laid out that way.

Taking hold of this list, I felt a strange sensation. A list of four hundred thirty-two people with not one name on it. In exactly the same way that the people of the Seventh Classification had no names, the names of the people on this list were also missing. Not the measured and the measured-against — both sides, without names. In this city, that was simply how things were done.

. . .

On my way home I took out the receipt and the notice side by side. Receipt number, processing period, review result. All of it connected up properly.

What I want to say in this chapter is one thing. The objection procedure had no flaw. I submitted a written statement, I received a review, I received a result. Every stage was recorded, and every record was open. And yet at the end of that flawless procedure, four hundred ten people's places were still empty.

That night I had a thought for the first time. If the procedure wasn't wrong, was what I was trying to change the wrong direction? I held onto that thought for a long time, but I couldn't reach an answer.

I also thought this. If the objection had been accepted and the original decision reversed, I would have felt satisfaction in this procedure. I would have easily concluded that the procedure had disappointed me. But the

procedure hadn't disappointed me. It had simply worked, from beginning to end, honestly — and this was the result of that honest operation. That this was a far more difficult problem to handle was something I realized for the first time that day.

I told my aunt the result, and she was quiet for a moment before asking,

"…So what are you going to do now?"

"…I don't know. But I'm going to meet the people directly."

"…Who?"

"…Everyone involved in this matter. There's a list."

My aunt looked at me. Her face was worried, but she didn't try to stop me.

"…How many is it?"

"…More than four hundred."

My aunt heard that number and said nothing. In front of that number, I wasn't confident myself that I could really meet all four hundred. I just wanted to meet even a few.

My aunt cleared the soup bowls and said,

"…Hora. It might not be those people's fault."

"…I know. I'm going to meet them anyway."

"…What are you going to ask when you meet them?"

I couldn't answer right away. After a long moment I said,

"…I don't know. I just feel like someone must know."

"…Know what?"

"…Why this turned out this way."

My aunt didn't ask any further. That night I spread out the list again and drew a line under the first name — not a name, but the first department and position — and underlined it. Passing it on, stage 1, initial receiving officer.

Drawing that line, I didn't feel like I was starting something great. I had simply decided what to do next. Deciding what to do next was, at the time, the entirety of what I could do.

I fell asleep with the list beside my pillow. The next morning I was going to go find the first person. I had no idea at all, then, what that person would say to me. If I had guessed, I might have been a little less surprised. I had no preparation at all when I went and knocked on that door.

(Continued in Chapter 17.)

Chapter 17. I Only Passed It On

> *_Previously_ — The objection was formally received, formally reviewed, and dismissed as "no procedural defect." Hora received the list of those involved — four hundred thirty-two people. She decided to go find the first name on it: the initial receiving officer.*

At the top of the list it read, "initial receiving officer, Ninth Administrative Office."

I didn't know where that office was, so I asked at an information desk three times. The Ninth Administrative Office was at the far south end of the city, in a district I'd never once been to.

The clerk at the desk marked out the route on a map and asked,

"…What takes you all the way out there? Most people never go that far."

"…I'm going to meet someone."

"…Someone you know?"

"…No. This will be the first time."

The clerk didn't press further and handed me the map. In sixteen years living in this city, I'd received this kind of consideration more times than I could count. *This city's people rarely ask why. Not asking is a kindness — that's what I'd learned, and I'd learned it well. But that day, I found the kindness a little disappointing. If anyone had asked me, "Why are you going, is something wrong," I probably would have poured out everything right there.*

The walk took more than an hour. As I walked, I rehearsed in my head, several times over, what I would ask. In the end I couldn't use a single word of what I'd practiced.

Writing this chapter, I want to set down precisely how nervous I was that morning. I felt as though I were bracing for a confrontation. I went in ready to fight someone. As it turned out, almost none of that preparation was needed.

After this chapter I go on to meet eleven more people, and I won't write each of those meetings out in this much detail. But I want to set down this first meeting in full. Every subsequent thing that happens has its shape already, entire, inside this one.

. . .

The Ninth Administrative Office was a small building. It had three service windows and six waiting chairs. No one was waiting.

A notice board on the wall listed the office's business. *Receiving unregistered-residence lists, formal review, forwarding to the higher department.* Only those three things. Reading them, I understood that these three things were the whole of what the people here did all day long. Nothing more, nothing less.

I showed the list to the person seated at the reception window and asked,

"…Which of you is the initial receiving officer?"

She looked at the list and pointed at the seat beside her own.

"…That's me. I received it."

I lost my words for a moment. I hadn't expected to find him this easily. Of four hundred thirty-two people, the very first one, sitting in the exact seat the list

said — and it really was her. I'd expected finding this person would take some remarkable effort. It hadn't. Even without a name, knowing only the department and the seat, finding a person in this city was not hard.

"…Are you the one who received the Seventh Classification matter?"

"…Yes, that's me. Why?"

There was no wariness in her voice. Only a plainly curious one.

. . .

I sat down in a chair and explained the situation — that I'd filed an objection, that it had been dismissed, and that I was going to meet the people involved directly.

She listened to me to the end. She didn't interrupt in the middle. While I spoke, she stopped tidying the papers on her desk and looked at me. Her manner of listening was earnest.

I still think, even now, that her earnestness was striking. She could have treated me as a nuisance visitor. A sixteen-year-old had come to talk about an objection. But there wasn't the slightest trace of that in her. This city's people were mostly like that. Listening to someone to the end wasn't a special thing here.

"…So this is about items 3, 7, and 12?"

"…You know about it?"

"…The summary of your objection came to us too. It gets circulated to every related department."

Hearing that answer, I was surprised for a moment. It meant my objection had reached all four hundred thirty-two people. This, too, hadn't been hidden. I was actually puzzled that she'd agree to see me at all, already knowing about my objection.

"…What do you think about this matter, then?"

She thought for a moment before answering.

"…I can tell you what I processed. But I haven't really thought much about the matter itself."

"…Why not?"

"…What I did was receive it. When the unregistered-residence list comes up, I receive it and forward it to the higher department."

. . .

I asked her more specifically what she had done.

"…All I did on this matter was one thing. I took the unregistered-residence list forwarded from the regional management office, checked the format was correct, and sent it up."

"…You didn't make the list?"

"…No, the list comes from the regional management office already made. I just check that it matches the set format."

"…And the relocation sites?"

"…Not my responsibility. Other departments handle that after I forward it."

"…Did you know items 3, 7, and 12 remained temporarily designated?"

"…I saw it in the summary of your objection. I didn't know before that."

"…You didn't know before?"

"…No. What I do stops at receiving. I don't see what happens after that."

Something caught at me in that answer. I say "caught," but I felt no sense at all that she was lying. She really seemed not to have known.

"…Then who makes the list in the first place?"

"…The regional management office. They survey the land, confirm registration status, and make the list."

"…Do they know how this list gets used?"

"…I couldn't say. I don't see that side of it either."

"…So is there actually anyone who knows the whole picture in this matter?"

She thought for a moment and said,

"…The district committee members would, wouldn't they. They're the ones who gather it all and look at it."

I heard that and laughed inwardly. I was that very committee member. And I hadn't known either. Not until I'd read all three hundred pages instead of the forty-page summary.

In this moment I felt something turn over inside me. She believed there was someone out there who knew the whole picture. At first, so had I. But now I know. There's no one appointed to see the whole picture. You only see it if you're the one willing to look.

I asked her, too, where the regional management office was located. I meant to go there next.

"…There's a lot of people there too. I don't know who's in charge, myself."

"…Then how do I find out?"

"…Go and ask, and they'll tell you. Everyone knows exactly what they did."

That turned out to be true. And over the following weeks, I would keep confirming just how accurate that statement was. Everyone knew exactly what they had done. Only no one knew what the whole added up to mean.

. . .

"…But with a matter this big, don't you feel like something's off? It's eleven hundred forty people."

She looked at me and thought for a moment.

"…To be honest, I see intakes like this every week. This one was one among them. It was a big one, sure, but I only look at the quantity. If the format's right, I forward it."

"…Doesn't a bigger quantity make you more careful?"

"…It does concern me. But my job isn't to make judgments. I only passed it on."

"…Who makes the judgment, then?"

"…I don't know exactly either. It gets reviewed at the higher department, and that goes up to the district, and the district decides it through the Consensus, doesn't it."

"…Isn't there someone who judges it somewhere in the middle?"

"…It's less a judgment than each person confirming at their own stage. I confirm the format, the next person confirms the quantity, the next confirms the basis. That's how it builds up into a decision. It's not a structure where one person judges."

Listening to that explanation, I realized I was hearing the very same thing this city had taught me from the start. The Consensus doesn't weigh — it gathers. I'd learned to call that a humble system. Hearing her say it, that humility began to show a different face.

I remember this sentence exactly, even now. I only passed it on. She didn't say it like an excuse. It wasn't a defensive tone either. It was simply the tone of someone stating a fact. I couldn't find any shame in that tone anywhere. There was nothing to be ashamed of.

I've used this sentence as the title while writing this book. It's this chapter's title, and it might as well be this Part's title too. Everything about this city is in this one sentence — I've come to think that many times since that day. Saying "I only passed it on" isn't a lie. It really is only passing it on. The problem is that four hundred thirty-two people, each, only passed it on.

. . .

There was one more thing I wanted to ask.

"…So what do you do if something like this feels wrong to you?"

"…I point people to the objection window. I've actually guided a few people there myself."

"…Have you yourself ever filed an objection?"

She looked at me a moment and laughed. It wasn't a mocking laugh.

"…Me? What would I know to object over? I'm just someone checking the format."

"…But you must have felt something was strange, at least."

"…I have. But feeling something is strange and being sure it's wrong are different things. I don't know the whole picture of this matter. All I see is the one sheet of list that comes into the intake box."

I thought about this for a long time. She was right. She really did see only one sheet. Almost no one in this city had read all three hundred pages the way I had. Most people saw only the one page in front of them, and if that one page didn't look strange, they moved it along to the next.

. . .

Finally I asked,

"…Is there anything you regret, by any chance?"

She thought for a long while before answering.

"…Regret… I'm not sure. Since I don't know what I did wrong, I don't know what I should regret either. But hearing what you've told me, Hora, I can't say my mind is at ease."

"…What do you mean, not at ease?"

"…That there was a person behind the paper I passed along — it felt more real to me today than it usually does. Usually it was just a number."

"…So what do you want to do now?"

She thought for a moment.

"…I don't think there's much I can do. I still don't know the whole picture. But next time a list like this comes through, I think I'll look at it a little more closely."

"…What difference does that make?"

"…Honestly, I don't know. It might not make any difference at all. But like I said, after today I don't think it'll just look like numbers to me anymore."

I understood this answer wasn't promising any great change. And yet it didn't feel entirely empty either. *Writing this chapter, I still don't know how to weigh this answer. Is it more honest to say nothing will change, or to say something will? She said, a little of each, both at once.*

I thanked her and left. She stood and saw me out until I was gone. It wasn't a special courtesy. Just this city's ordinary manners.

. . .

Leaving the Ninth Administrative Office, I felt something hollow. I'd expected to hear something decisive from her — a hidden fact, someone's wrongdoing. Instead all I'd heard was one person's honest account of her ordinary day's work.

I think I have to set down this hollowness honestly. I was a little disappointed that day. Maybe I'd wanted to find a bad person, someone I could hate. If there'd been someone to hate, this would have all been much simpler. But I couldn't find anyone to hate. Instead, four hundred thirty-one more people I couldn't hate remained.

And I didn't know yet, that day, that this same honest account would repeat itself four hundred thirty-one more times. If I had known, I would have been a little less shocked. Or — maybe I'd have been more shocked. Once can be coincidence. Four hundred times is not.

On my way home I marked the first line on the list. *Confirmed.* Beside it I wrote in small letters: *Not ashamed. No lies.*

I told my aunt about the person I'd met today. She stopped in the middle of setting out dinner.

"…What did this person do wrong?"

"…No, she says she didn't do anything wrong. Listening to her, I don't think she did either."

"…Then why did you go see her?"

"…I thought she might know something."

"…Did you find out anything?"

I thought for a moment and answered.

"…I found out this person doesn't know the whole picture."

My aunt looked at me.

"…So will the next one know?"

"…I don't know. But there are four hundred thirty-two on the list, so if I go one by one, maybe someone who knows will turn up."

My aunt didn't answer that and finished laying out dinner. We ate that night mostly in silence.

That night I spread out the list again. I traced the second line, the third line, the fourth line with my finger. Department names and positions ran on. I still believed then that if I met all these people, sooner or later I'd find someone who said, "I decided it."

How long that belief lasted, I write in the next chapter. To say it now, ahead of time: not long.

(Continued in Chapter 18.)

Chapter 18. Twelve More

> *_Previously_ — Hora met the initial receiving officer. "I only passed it on." An honest statement. No shame in it either. After that, Hora decided to try meeting a few more of the four hundred thirty-two on the list.*

Over the two weeks that followed, I met twelve more people. I kept up my other deliberation work too, crossing names off the list whenever I found a spare moment.

I could have written each of these twelve out in detail, one at a time. But then this book would start to read like a roster. Instead I'm gathering here what I heard in common from these twelve. Each was a different person, a different office, a different voice. And yet what they said was strikingly similar.

I went to see one or two a day. Some days I went to the wrong department entirely and wasted half a day. One person happened to be on leave and I had to go back. Finding people in this city was never a hassle, but it certainly took time.

. . .

The second person was the surveying officer at the regional management office. Her job was to physically measure unregistered residences. She held a tape measure and a small ledger in her hands.

"…All I do is measure. Whether a place is registered, how wide it is. I measure that and send the list to the listing department."

"…When you're measuring, you must see people living there."

"…I see them. But what I measure is the land, not the people."

"…Isn't it strange to measure only the land when you can see people living there?"

"…At first it felt strange. But that's my job. How many houses, how many people living there — those go in the column beside it, as numbers only. There's no column for faces."

I heard that and glanced at her ledger. There really were only number columns. No name column, no face column. Looking at that ledger, I thought, for a moment, that every piece of paper in this city eventually resembled that ledger.

The third person was a format reviewer.

"…I only check whether the list follows the prescribed form. Whether every field is filled in, whether the numbers run in order."

"…You don't look at the content?"

"…I do look at the content, but not to judge it — to confirm it matches the form."

"…So it passes as long as the form is right?"

"…Yes. Not a single list that's come to my department in the last three years has been rejected for wrong formatting. The regional management office is that meticulous about it."

Hearing that answer, I understood that this review stage was, in effect, purely formal. Formal didn't mean bad. It just meant nothing was actually filtered at

this stage. Nothing being filtered didn't mean this person was lazy. There was simply nothing there to filter.

. . .

The fourth, fifth, and sixth people were all from higher departments. Their offices were spread across three different floors, and I had to be shown the way freshly each time. All three said much the same thing. "We just consolidate what comes up from below." "We don't create anything new." "We're the seat where the confirmation stamp gets put."

The fourth had been doing consolidation work for over ten years. "…This is my first time seeing a matter this scale. But the way I consolidate doesn't change. Growing in size doesn't change what I do." The fifth was younger, and pointed at the regulation binder tacked up at his seat. "…It's all right here. I don't do anything outside of this."

To the sixth I asked something a little different.

"…Before you put the confirmation stamp, did you ever notice anything that felt strange?"

"…Honestly, yes. The three temporary-designation sites."

I felt a flicker of hope. Something's finally caught, I thought.

"…And?"

"…But the temporary designation itself is a procedure that's in the regulation. It's explicitly stated that something can be temporarily designated before final confirmation. So it felt strange, but it wasn't a violation of the regulation."

"…Couldn't you have stopped it, when it felt strange?"

"…That's outside my authority. I only have the authority to confirm whether something matches the regulation."

"…So when you felt it was strange, who did you say that to?"

"…I didn't tell anyone separately. Strange and a regulation violation are different things. If I raised an objection every time something felt strange to me, our department wouldn't get anything done."

Listening to this answer, I saw clearly, for the first time, the distance between the feeling of "this is strange" and the fact of "I have authority to stop this." There was a person here who had felt it strange. But that feeling wasn't this person's job.

I know this answer might sound cold. But it didn't sound cold to me in that room, hearing it. If anything, it was the voice of someone who knew exactly where they stood. If this person had tried to handle something outside her own authority, in this city that would itself have been an overreach. I nodded along with her words even as some part of me stayed uneasy.

. . .

After meeting these six, I sat on a bench for a while to rest. Not because my legs hurt — because my head did. Walking home that evening, for the first time I briefly thought about giving up on all this. It wasn't that it was too hard. It was that I couldn't see an answer anywhere.

I didn't hold onto that thought for long. If I gave up, the four hundred ten would simply go to a place that didn't exist. If I didn't give up, the outcome would probably be the same. But between giving up and not giving up, there seemed to be a difference — at least to me. What that difference was, I couldn't have explained then.

The seventh person was the support-fund calculation officer. Her desk was covered in a calculator and sheets of formulas.

"…The math is accurate. I double-check it myself, too."

"…Is there actually somewhere those support funds can be used?"

"…That's the destination-site management department's responsibility."

"…Even if it's not your responsibility, weren't you curious?"

"…I was curious. But when I asked, I didn't get an answer. They just said it's still not finalized on their end either."

I understood that this person had already asked the exact same question I was asking. She'd simply asked before me, and been stopped before me too.

The eighth person belonged to the destination-site management department, but as it happened wasn't actually assigned to items 3, 7, and 12.

"…Those three aren't my responsibility. I only manage confirmed sites."

"…Then who's responsible for those three?"

"…Probably no one, yet. Since they're not confirmed."

"…So until someone's assigned, those three just stay as they are?"

"…Probably. Once someone's assigned, someone will move on it."

"…Who assigns that?"

"…I don't know that either. Personnel placement's a different department's business."

In this answer I saw a strange hole for the first time. Because it wasn't confirmed, there was a place with no one assigned yet. With no one assigned, no one was looking after it, and with no one looking after it, it stayed unconfirmed. This too was a loop. The same shape as the loop that produced unregistered residences in the first place. Only this time it wasn't land circling inside the loop — it was responsibility.

. . .

The ninth and tenth people handled convening for the committee. They set meeting dates and distributed materials.

"…I really only convene. I don't get involved with the substance of the agenda."

"…Do you know when you convene whether an agenda is big or small?"

"…I can see the scale. But it doesn't affect my work. The convening procedure is the same no matter the scale of the matter."

The eleventh person was the record keeper. She wrote the minutes.

"…I write down exactly what's said. I don't add my own opinion."

"…Reading the minutes, no one seems to say their own opinion."

"…Right, everyone just talks about passing it on and putting it in order, so I have no choice but to write exactly that."

"…Has anyone ever raised a different opinion?"

"…Sometimes. But that's written into the minutes exactly as it happened too. 'One member raised the need for a re-review.' And then it moves straight to a

vote."

"…What was the vote result?"

"…This matter had a re-review proposal raised, but the original stood after the vote."

I later found and read that minutes record myself. Viewing was never blocked, as always. It really was written just as she'd said. Someone had raised an objection. Who that person was didn't appear in the minutes either. It only said "one member."

I became curious, at this point, for the first time. Who was that "one member"? It meant that someone besides me had felt something was strange. But that person, too, had lost the vote in the end, and hadn't even left a name behind. I wanted to find this person, but I had no way to search for a name that wasn't in the minutes.

. . .

The twelfth person was the one who had first brought this entire matter forward. I thought this person, at least, might be different. He was the one who'd raised the agenda in the first place.

"…All I did was confirm that the cumulative count had crossed the threshold, and bring it forward. Once it crosses the threshold, bringing it forward is my job."

"…Who set the threshold?"

"…It was set a long time ago. I only apply it."

"…Have you never thought about whether that threshold is appropriate?"

"…I've thought about it. But that's not something I can change either. Amending the threshold is a different procedure."

I'd hoped this person would be my last chance. He was the one who'd brought it forward, so surely he'd know something. But he too had only confirmed that the threshold had been crossed. Whoever had made the threshold itself was somewhere else again.

I asked him one last thing.

"…So who is the person who actually decided, in this matter, 'let's do it this way'?"

He thought for a long while. It was a genuinely thoughtful expression. He wasn't trying to give a careless answer.

"…I don't know. I brought it forward, the committee deliberated, and the Consensus decided. Inside all of that, the one person who decided 'let's do it this way'... doesn't seem to exist."

"…No one?"

"…No. Not that I know of."

I wrote that answer down on paper exactly as he said it. Doesn't seem to exist. None of the twelve had said it quite this precisely, but every one of them had, in their own way, been saying this same thing. No one decided. And yet a decision exists. I thought I'd already known this sentence from the start — that day was the first time I truly felt its weight.

. . .

By the time I'd met all twelve, two weeks had somehow gone by. To all twelve I'd asked the same question. "Do you think this is wrong?"

All twelve answered similarly. "The part I saw wasn't wrong." "I don't know about the whole." "It's outside my authority."

None of them got angry. None of them found me a bother. None of them lied. And none of them felt ashamed. A few of them even offered me coffee or tea.

Not being ashamed might sound strange to hear. At first I thought it was strange too. But after meeting a few of them, not being ashamed came to seem natural. There was no one among them who had done anything to be ashamed of. Each had done their own share, honestly, exactly.

Meeting these twelve, I let go, one by one, of the expectations I'd first carried. At first I went in thinking, "maybe this person is the culprit." By around the third person I'd given up on that hope. From about the sixth on, I started to feel, if anything, sorry for these people. Everyone was diligently doing their own part in their own seat. That this diligence, all gathered together, had become the decision that sent four hundred ten people to a place that didn't exist — that was the part I found hardest to bear.

A few of the twelve, when we parted, asked me back. "Do you think this could change?" Every time, I answered that I didn't know. Because I really didn't.

. . .

On the way home I finished marking the list. All twelve lines, *confirmed.* Beside each I wrote the same words every time. *No wrongdoing. Doesn't know the whole.*

I asked my aunt.

"…I met all twelve. Not one of them did anything wrong."

"…Isn't that a good thing, then?"

"…But the result stays the same. Four hundred ten people are still going to a place that doesn't exist."

My aunt was quiet for a moment and said,

"…That's the strangest part of all. No one did anything wrong, and the result is still bad."

"…Yeah. That's the strangest part."

That night, for the first time, I wondered whether I was looking for the wrong people. It seemed like meeting all four hundred thirty-two would probably get me the same answer. I decided to go find Tyche the next day. I thought Tyche might be able to explain this structure to me.

My aunt asked one last thing, clearing the rice bowls.

"…Hora. Going around meeting all these people — is it good for them, or bad for them?"

I couldn't answer that question for a long moment.

"…I don't know. A few of them seemed uncomfortable, if anything."

"…So will you stop?"

"…No. I'm going to keep going."

My aunt didn't ask any further. That night I ran through the twelve faces one by one in my mind. The surveying officer, the format reviewer, the person who'd put on the confirmation stamp, the one who calculated the support

funds, the convening officer, the record keeper, and the one who'd first brought the matter forward. Not one of them had a bad face. That was what held onto me longest of all.

The next day I told Tyche all of this exactly as it happened. She heard me out to the end and then began explaining, very calmly. That explanation would become the most difficult scene in this whole book to deal with. I still haven't managed, to this day, to fully rebut it.

(Continued in Chapter 19.)

Chapter 19. Tyche Explains

> *_Previously_ — Hora met twelve people. All twelve were honest, and none of them felt ashamed. Each had done exactly their own share; no one had decided "let's do it this way." Hora went to find Tyche, hoping she could explain this structure.*

Tyche was sitting by the window in the deliberation support office. I pulled up the chair beside her.

"…I met twelve people."

"…I know. The departments have been a little stirred up."

"…Stirred up? No one got angry, though."

"…It's not that they're stirred up out of anger. It's that they didn't realize the matter they were each involved in was this big, and they found out through you. That's the stir."

I heard that and stopped for a moment. That my going around asking questions had set something off in these people — I only realized it then, for the first time.

Tyche set aside the document she'd been looking at while I sat down. Her whole manner suggested nothing else was urgent right now.

"…Did I do something wrong?"

"…Not wrong. It's just an uncommon thing to do, in this city. Someone going around and looking for what's behind their own job."

"…Then why has no one ever done this uncommon thing?"

Tyche shrugged lightly.

"…Because everyone's busy. And because the summary is accurate. When there's an accurate summary, there's no reason to read three hundred pages."

Listening to her, I understood this wasn't meant as a criticism. Tyche really believed it. That any reasonable person would trust the summary and move on.

Tyche glanced toward the window for a moment, then looked back at me.

"…I wonder about it myself, sometimes. Why I don't do it."

"…Do what?"

"…Not reading things to the end. I was born and raised in this city, I know the summary is accurate — and even so, I could still read the whole thing sometimes. But I never have. Not once."

"…Why not?"

"…I don't know. I just never felt the need to, I guess. How did you start doing it, Hora?"

I didn't answer that question right away. I didn't want to bring up my mother here. I only said,

"…It's just a habit."

Tyche didn't press further on that answer. Not pressing was this city's manners, and that day I was grateful for those manners too.

. . .

"…Tyche, can you explain why this turned out this way?"

Tyche looked at me straight on. Her face wasn't angry, wasn't bothered. If anything, it looked as though she'd been waiting.

"…I can explain it. But it won't be the answer you want."

"…I still want to hear it."

Tyche pulled out a sheet of paper and began to draw. One small circle at the top, several circles below that, more circles below that. At the very bottom, the circles multiplied into dozens. A triangle shape.

"…This triangle."

Tyche tapped the top circle with the tip of her pen.

"…This is the decision. This many people are involved to reach one decision. But the top circle actually isn't a circle. It's an empty seat. No one is sitting there."

Looking at that drawing, I realized this was the same shape I'd been seeing all along in the signature box.

"…This is this city's deliberation structure. There's a decision at the top, and it passes through several stages to get there. Each stage has its person, and each person handles only their own stage."

"…I know that already. I heard it from all twelve."

"…But you don't know why it was designed this way."

I nodded.

"…Where did you learn this triangle?"

"…During training. Everyone who becomes a deliberation assistant learns this. It's the very first thing taught, on the first day — this exact drawing."

"…Doesn't anyone find it strange when they see it? That the top is empty?"

Tyche thought a moment and shook her head.

"…When I first saw it, I actually felt reassured. If someone were sitting at the top, it would all come down to that person's state of mind. If it's empty, it's not resting on anyone at all."

Hearing that, I realized Tyche and I had felt completely different things looking at the exact same drawing. I looked at that empty seat and grew uneasy. Tyche looked at that same empty seat and felt reassured.

. . .

"…What would happen if one person decided everything, start to finish?" Tyche asked.

"…It would become that person's responsibility."

"…Right. But what if that person's judgment is wrong?"

"…Then it becomes that person's fault."

"…So that person would feel burdened and try to avoid making judgments. Or, the opposite — they might try to force their own judgment through no matter what. Neither is good."

I couldn't argue with that. It was true. The idea that things go wrong when one person holds everything was common sense I'd grown up hearing in this city since I was small. I'd heard it many times in school too.

"…So this city made it so that no one person decides. The decision is broken into small pieces and spread across many people. Each person only needs to do their own share, exactly. No one has to carry the weight of judgment."

"…But breaking it up that way means no one can see the whole."

"…Right. That's the cost of this method."

. . .

"…But that cost is too high. Four hundred ten people are going to a place that doesn't exist — can that be dismissed as a cost?"

Tyche set down the paper and looked at me.

"…Hora, what do you think it would've been like if it hadn't been done this way?"

I couldn't answer.

"…If one person had judged it, that person might have made a mistake, or been biased. It might have split into who gets measured and who does the measuring. Do you know why this city ended up this way in the first place? Because one person's judgment dividing people up turned out wrong far too often."

"…So they made it so no one judges at all?"

"…Yes. And that really did work. Has there ever been a decision in this city made because someone hated someone else, Hora? Have you ever seen that?"

I could only say I hadn't. There really hadn't been.

. . .

"…So what about this matter, then? The outcome was bad."

"…A bad outcome and an unfair process are different things. The process was fair. Everyone was reviewed by the same standard, everyone went through the same procedure. The outcome coming out badly isn't the fault of this procedure — the situation itself was simply bad."

"…What do you mean, the situation was bad?"

"…Unregistered residences weren't supposed to exist in the first place. They accumulated, and this time they had to be processed all at once, and among them some of the destination sites still aren't confirmed. This isn't a problem with the procedure — it's a problem with reality."

Listening to this answer, I felt that Tyche really was speaking with complete honesty. She wasn't dressing up her words to persuade me. She was just saying what she saw.

"…Then why did that problem with reality arise? Why did three whole destination sites go unconfirmed?"

"…Because the department in charge hasn't been staffed yet."

"…Why hasn't the department been staffed?"

"…That's a personnel placement issue. As this matter suddenly grew in scale, the manpower needed grew too, and manpower placement is only possible with next quarter's budget."

"…Then couldn't they have just waited for next quarter? Why was the implementation date set before that?"

Tyche paused on this question for a moment.

"…That... I don't know exactly either. Scheduling is set by a different department."

"…Another different department?"

"…Yes."

I listened to that answer and counted silently, in my head. Site confirmation, personnel department's business. Personnel placement, budget department's business. Implementation schedule, yet another department's business. Every time I asked about one problem, a different department came up.

This was the first moment I realized it wasn't that Tyche's explanation was wrong — it was that it was too accurate, and that accuracy was what frustrated me. Tyche could name the exact department for every single question. And yet no matter how far I traced those departments, no one ever appeared at the end who said, "I decided this." The more complete Tyche's explanation became, the more helpless I felt.

. . .

"…But Tyche, some of those twelve felt something was strange. The sixth person did. And someone on the committee raised an objection too."

"…Yes, I know that. It's in the minutes."

"…But that strangeness didn't get reflected anywhere."

"…It was reflected. It was raised as an objection, and it was processed through a vote. That's what reflection is."

"…If you lose the vote, that's the same as not being reflected."

"…No. It was reflected. The result simply defeated the strangeness. That, too, is procedure."

I couldn't find words for a long while after that. Tyche's logic had no gaps. Wherever I poked at it, she already had an answer waiting there.

"…So if I file a new objection now, would it come out the same?"

"…Probably. As long as the situation doesn't change. If items 3, 7, and 12 get confirmed, it might turn out different. But since they're not confirmed yet, filing another objection now would probably come out the same."

"…Then what can I do?"

Tyche didn't answer this question right away. She looked at me for a moment and said,

"…I don't really know that either. I can explain this structure, but what can be done outside of it — that's not my territory."

I realized only later that this answer was the first time Tyche had ever said "I don't know." Tyche knew everything there was to know about the structure. It was only outside the structure that she truly didn't know. Or — maybe "outside the structure" was a concept that didn't even exist for Tyche at all.

. . .

"…So are you saying this structure is perfect?"

"…I'm not saying it's perfect. No structure is perfect. I'm just saying this structure wrongs people less than other structures would."

"…Wrongs them less? What about those four hundred ten?"

"…Those four hundred ten are having a hard time because the outcome was bad — not because anyone in the process hated them or discriminated against them. It's a fact that they weren't registered, and that fact applied to everyone equally. It was bad luck. Not being wronged."

Something caught at me in that.

"…Why is bad luck different from being wronged?"

Tyche looked at me for a moment, then said, very gently,

"…Being wronged is what you call it when someone does something unjust to you. But this time, no one did anything unjust to those people. They simply happened to be in that position. The way you ended up sitting on this committee, Hora — that was the same thing. A vacancy, a number. That was luck too."

. . .

I heard that comparison and couldn't say anything. It was true. I too had ended up in this seat through a vacancy and a number. Those four hundred ten were in their position through registration and a number too. The structure was identical.

"…But I ended up in a good seat, and those people ended up in a bad one. Same luck, different result."

"…Yes, the results are different. But that's simply the nature of luck. Some end up on the good side, some on the bad. It looks unfair, but in the sense that no one intended it, it's fair."

"…Is it fair just because there was no intent?"

"…At least no one did this because they hated someone. I think that matters. If there's no hatred, then at least there's no unfairness that came from hatred."

I heard that and thought for a long while. Tyche wasn't entirely wrong. This city really had no hatred in it. I'd known that fact from the start, and I'd always thought it was one of the good things about it.

"…But even without hatred, bad things can still happen. That's what you're saying."

"…Right. That's exactly what happened here. Bad results can come about even without hatred. I don't deny that."

In this answer, I felt for the first time, with certainty, that Tyche wasn't trying to persuade me. Tyche wasn't defending this structure. She was simply someone who saw this structure accurately. Defending it and describing it accurately were different things, and I had kept confusing the two.

"…So nobody gets wronged."

Tyche said that last.

"…That isn't a bad thing."

I wanted to argue with that. I really did. But that night, and for several days after, I couldn't find the words to argue back. Tyche hadn't said it to win against me. She really believed it, and there weren't many holes in that belief.

Leaving Tyche's room that day, I had a thought for the first time — that maybe I was the one who was wrong. That this structure might really be the best there is. That thought was what troubled me most.

Tyche added one more thing as I was about to get up.

"…Hora, I don't think what you're doing is meaningless. Meeting twelve people was probably a good thing. At the very least, those people are thinking more now about what they did."

"…But the outcome doesn't change."

"…The outcome not changing doesn't mean it's meaningless."

I looked up at that.

"…What do you mean by that?"

"…I don't know. It just feels that way to me."

This last sentence stayed with me oddly, for a long time. Up until then, Tyche had been someone explaining everything through logic. But in this last sentence she said, "I don't know, it just feels that way." That there was a place logic couldn't reach, even for Tyche — I saw that for the first time then.

I left the deliberation support office and walked the corridor. The window let in no view of outside, but that day I found myself unusually curious about what lay beyond it.

That night I told my aunt about Tyche. She listened for a long while and said,

"…It sounds like what she said might be right, or it might not be."

"…Same here."

"…But the fact that you couldn't argue back — that's the stranger part, to me."

I couldn't answer that. That I hadn't been able to argue back was what stayed with me longest that night.

(Continued in Chapter 20.)

Chapter 20. To the Secretary

> *_Previously_ — Tyche laid out the structure without a single gap. "…So nobody gets wronged. That isn't a bad thing." Hora couldn't argue back. Tyche had also said, "outside the structure isn't my territory." Wondering who stood outside that structure, Hora thought of the Secretary, who handled convening and the record.*

That night I opened the list again and closed it again.

I already knew, having met the twelve, that meeting all four hundred thirty-two would only get me the same answer. People who'd only passed it on, people who'd only measured, people who'd only confirmed. All honest, all doing only their own share. And yet no one, from beginning to end, knew the decision that all those shares had added up to.

Except for one person.

The Secretary convened, distributed materials, wrote the minutes, and delivered the confirmed results to each department. If there was anyone in this city who saw a matter from beginning to end in documented form, it wouldn't be someone who judged — it would be someone who carried. And a carrier, at least, would know the route.

. . .

The next morning, walking to the reception desk, I passed the water channel. The water was still making its earth-colored sound. Passing it, I briefly wondered whether, if I asked someone about this channel too, it might all get explained someday. I already knew that since it had never come up as an

agenda item, there was no one to explain it. But the Seventh Classification matter had come up as an agenda item. So there should be someone who could explain it.

I stopped for a moment outside the reception desk. I wasn't sure going to find the Secretary was the right choice. Meeting the twelve, I'd already heard "that's not my responsibility" more times than I could count. The Secretary would probably say the same. And yet I pushed the door open anyway. I'd been everywhere else — it felt like I ought to try here, one last time.

The Secretary was in a small room off the reception desk. The door was open, and papers sat neatly stacked on his desk. He greeted me first when he saw me.

"…Hora, what brings you here today?"

"…It's about the Seventh Classification matter."

The Secretary pulled out a document folder and offered me a seat.

"…Sit down. What would you like to know?"

I brought out the questions I'd prepared in order, starting with the simplest.

"…Why haven't items 3, 7, and 12 been confirmed yet?"

"…Confirming the relocation sites falls under the destination-site management department, but that department hasn't yet had personnel assigned. Personnel assignment isn't possible until next quarter's budget is approved."

This was already something I knew. I'd heard the same thing from the eighth and ninth of the twelve I'd met. I moved to the next question.

"…Then why wasn't the implementation date set for after next quarter? If there's no manpower, those three sites can't be processed."

For this question the Secretary flipped through the folder to find a page with dates and showed it to me.

"…The implementation date was set based on the processing threshold for the whole Seventh Classification matter. It had already been eight months past the threshold, and there was a review finding that delaying further would only let the unregistered accumulation grow larger. So the overall implementation date was kept as is, and only the three sites were handled through temporary designation."

"…Who reviewed that?"

"…At a higher-department review meeting. There are minutes."

The Secretary really did find and hand me that minutes record. I took it and skimmed through. Detailed dates and grounds that none of the twelve had given me were all right there. I realized this was a document I was seeing for the first time. Viewing had been possible, but I hadn't gotten that far.

. . .

"…Is it a problem specific to this matter being unusually big, or would it have turned out this way even if it had been a small matter?"

"…Over the past ten years, small-scale matters ran twenty or thirty people at a time. There were a few temporary designations back then too. But with fewer people, confirmation came quickly. It was a scale that only needed the department to bring on three or four more staff."

"…Why didn't that work this time?"

"…This time, at a scale of eleven hundred forty, the manpower needed for confirmation grew accordingly. Placing that manpower requires budget, and

budget only moves on a quarterly basis. Something that never snagged when the scale was small snagged this time."

I heard that and understood this was, in a certain sense, an honest answer. If this had been a small matter, I wouldn't even be sitting in this seat right now. There hadn't been a problem — the problem had simply grown large.

"…So just because of the scale, people end up going to places that aren't even confirmed?"

The Secretary took a moment to choose his words for this question.

"…It's not confirmed that they're going. The temporary designation could still turn into a confirmed one, or get reassigned somewhere else. The problem is only that the implementation date arrives first, in the meantime."

"…Why doesn't the implementation date wait for confirmation?"

"…Because the implementation date for the whole matter was already set based on the other eleven hundred ten sites. If the whole thing were delayed for the sake of three sites, the other eleven hundred ten would be delayed along with it."

"…I don't think I could have found this on my own."

"…If you file a viewing request, it all comes up. It just takes time if you don't know the route to search. I can find it quickly because this is a document I handle every day."

Hearing that, I understood for the first time why the Secretary was the one person who could see the whole structure. Precisely because he doesn't judge, he ends up seeing everything. Someone who judges digs deep into only their own responsibility; someone who convenes passes lightly over every responsibility.

"…So did nothing strike you as odd in this matter, Secretary?"

The Secretary thought for a moment. It wasn't a silence meant to dodge the question. It was a genuinely thoughtful face.

"…The scale being large was visible. Eleven hundred forty is among the largest I've convened for."

"…And?"

"…But scale being large and a defect in the procedure being present are different things. What I look at is whether procedure was followed. Procedure was followed at every stage."

I heard that answer and thought it was similar to what I'd heard from Tyche. But something was different. Tyche had stopped at one point, saying "that's not my territory." The Secretary didn't stop.

"…I've heard the temporary designation is a procedure in the regulation. Who made that regulation?"

"…An amendment seventeen years ago. Back then delays before confirmation kept coming up frequently for small matters, so a method was introduced — designating temporarily and confirming later. Before that, the agenda item itself was held until confirmed, and that caused processing to run far too slow."

"…So thanks to that regulation, the three sites now remain temporarily designated."

"…Correct."

"…What if that regulation didn't exist?"

"…If it didn't exist, this entire matter would have been held until all three sites were confirmed. Then the remaining eleven hundred ten would have been processed that much later too."

. . .

I heard that answer and couldn't speak for a moment. What the Secretary had just told me wasn't the answer I wanted. I'd wanted to find some one broken link. Instead, what he showed me was that the regulation had been made, if anything, to process more people, faster.

"…So that regulation isn't wrong either."

"…Not in my view. Though what result this regulation produces when applied to a matter this large — the people who made it probably never fully anticipated that either."

Something caught at me in this last sentence. It was the first time the Secretary had ever said something unconfirmed — "probably never anticipated." Up to that point, every answer he'd given had been settled fact. Dates, minutes, the basis clauses. This sentence alone was pure speculation.

I wanted to press on that, but let it pass that day. There was still a lot left to ask.

"…What about the support funds, then? I heard the calculation was already finished even though the three sites aren't confirmed."

"…Support-fund calculation is done in advance based on the projected number of people. Even if the destination site changes, the calculated amount itself doesn't change. But actual disbursement only happens once the destination site is confirmed."

"…What if it never gets confirmed?"

"…Then disbursement never happens either."

That answer was short and precise. I found that precision, if anything, chilling.

. . .

I moved to a different question. That phrase I'd seen in the minutes kept nagging at me.

"…Secretary, in the eighteenth meeting's minutes, there's the line, 'one member raised the need for a re-review.' Who was that?"

The Secretary flipped his folder back to find that minutes record. It took quite a while. He paged through several sheets before finally stopping.

"…The eighteenth meeting, here it is. But the minutes only record the member number. A member from the Fourth Deliberation District."

"…What's the name?"

"…There's no name field in the minutes form. Only a member number is entered."

"…So there's no way to find out who this person was?"

"…Not necessarily impossible. Cross-referencing the member number against that day's attendance sheet might turn it up. But I've never done that cross-reference myself. It's not my job."

I heard that answer and felt a moment's disappointment. I already knew this person was the first one besides me who'd felt something was strange. And yet the Secretary didn't even know that person's name.

"…What happened to that person afterward? They lost the vote."

"…There's no separate procedure for a member whose proposed agenda loses a vote. It just moves on to the next item."

"…Nothing at all happens?"

"…No, nothing at all."

I would come back to this answer many times afterward. That nothing happens to the member who raised the objection. No punishment, no compensation, not even a name left in the record. At the time I thought that was a fair system. I didn't yet know how differently this would come to weigh on me, in another way, later.

. . .

"…Secretary, are you the one person who knows this matter from beginning to end?"

"…I don't know all of it. I know the meetings I convened, the materials I distributed, the minutes I wrote. That does overlap with most of the matter. Since the scale is large, a lot of meetings passed through too."

"…Then are you the only one who can explain this decision?"

The Secretary thought a little longer on this question.

"…There are people who can explain it. Everyone who handled each stage, all of them. I'm only someone who can see those stages stitched together. Stitching, too, is my job — but I'm not adding anything of my own into it."

"…Isn't stitching, too, a kind of judgment? Deciding what goes first and what goes after?"

"…The order is set by date. I'm not the one who decides that."

I wanted to argue with that, but couldn't find good grounds to. The dates really were just dates. It wasn't the Secretary who could change their order.

. . .

I talked with the Secretary for more than two hours that evening. I asked until I ran out of questions. The delayed site confirmation, the delay in personnel placement, the support-fund calculation basis, even the re-review request and the vote result recorded in the minutes. Not once did the Secretary say, "I can't answer that." What he didn't know, he said he didn't know, and what he knew, he told me all of it. Even when he said he didn't know, he explained why he didn't know.

That day I had, for the first time, the experience of asking something in this city and not hitting a wall. Tyche was honest too, but Tyche stopped at a certain point, saying "that's not my territory." The Secretary didn't stop. Even what fell outside his responsibility, he explained along with the fact that it fell outside his responsibility. I didn't yet fully realize, that day, how rare this was.

Finally I asked one last thing.

"…So, setting everything aside, what did you actually do in this matter, Secretary?"

The Secretary answered while tidying his folder.

"…What I did was convene."

"…That's all?"

"…Yes. Convened, passed things on, kept the record. That's all."

I heard that answer, gathered my papers, and stood. I thanked him. He returned the greeting.

Walking out the door, I retraced, in my head, everything he'd told me that day. The site hasn't been confirmed. Support-fund calculation is finished. The implementation date has been set. The regulation was amended. The meeting was convened.

On the way home I muttered those sentences to myself, one by one. Worried that talking to myself while walking would look strange, I kept my voice low. Not confirmed. Calculation finished. Convening done. As I walked, I vaguely sensed that all these sentences shared a similar shape, but I couldn't quite put my finger on what that shape was, at the time.

I told my aunt about the day's events. Hearing that the Secretary had given me the detailed answers I hadn't gotten from the twelve, my aunt looked a little surprised.

"…The Secretary told you all of that?"

"…Yeah. Nothing blocked me at all. Every question I asked got an answer."

"…So what did you find out?"

I couldn't answer that question right away. After a long while I said,

"…The procedure was all normal. The regulation had its reasons, the delay had its reasons. But somehow I feel like nothing got resolved at all."

My aunt asked, clearing the table.

"…You got every answer, so why doesn't it feel resolved?"

"…I don't know. I got every answer, but every one of those answers was passing off to somewhere else. This one's this department's business, that one's that department's business. But there was nothing of the Secretary's own in any of it."

My aunt heard that and looked at me for a moment. Her face looked like she wanted to ask more, then decided against it.

That night, late, I kept turning those sentences over in my head, until I felt something strange. I couldn't quite put my finger on exactly what was strange, that night. It wasn't until the next morning that I found the name for that strangeness.

(Continued in Chapter 21.)

Chapter 21. There Is No Subject

> *_Previously_ — The Secretary answered everything Hora asked, without a single stumble. Not confirmed yet, calculation is finished, convening is done. Not one thing snagged, and yet Hora came home feeling, strangely, like nothing had resolved at all. She found the name for that strangeness only the next morning.*

The name for the strangeness was simple. There was no subject.

The thought came to me the moment I opened my eyes that morning. Going back over what the Secretary had said the day before, I realized not a single sentence had ever had "I" in it. Not confirmed. Calculation finished. Implementation date set. Regulation amended. Meeting convened. All of it went that way.

I'd already noticed this once before. At the time I'd let it go as simply a manner of speech. Tyche, too, had said, "That's just how the Secretary's job is." I'd accepted that and moved on.

But it wasn't a manner of speech. That morning, I saw for the first time, head-on, that this was too perfect to be called a mere habit. We'd talked for over two hours, and not one sentence began with "I did." If a person keeps a manner of speech without a single slip for two straight hours, that isn't a habit anymore. It's something else.

Eating breakfast that morning, I ran back through the way everyone I'd met had spoken. The initial receiving officer had said, "I only passed it on." The surveying officer had said, "I only measure." All twelve of them had used "I." Even when saying what they'd done was small, that small thing always had an

"I" attached in front. Only the Secretary was different. Even though what he'd done was far bigger, he never placed himself in front of it.

I said as much to my aunt too.

"…Aunt, all twelve of them said, 'I did it.' Only the Secretary doesn't."

"…Isn't that because those people think they did something small? They say the important people talk humbly."

"…But it feels different from humility. If you're being humble, you still say 'what, me' but you still put in the 'I.' The Secretary doesn't put anyone there at all."

My aunt tilted her head at that but didn't press any further.

. . .

That afternoon I went back to the reception desk. The Secretary was in the same seat as the day before.

"…Hora, back again."

"…Yes, there's something else I wanted to ask, from yesterday."

"…Ask me anything."

I went straight to the point.

"…Secretary, did you know that not once, in everything you told me yesterday, did you say 'I did it'?"

The Secretary looked at me a moment. It wasn't a surprised face. If anything, a thoughtful one.

"…Is that so."

"…Yes. Not confirmed. Calculation finished. Convening done. It was all like that. Not once did you say, I confirmed it, I convened it."

"…I suppose I did."

"…You're doing it again right now. It's not 'I did that,' it's 'I suppose I did.' If it were you saying it normally, I'd think you'd have said something more like, 'I must have said it that way.'"

The Secretary gave a small smile at this.

"…It seems you know my own way of speaking better than I do, Hora."

I didn't feel that smile as unkind. And yet I didn't stop there, and kept asking.

"…Why do you talk that way?"

. . .

The Secretary set his papers aside and looked at me straight on.

"…What do you mean by that?"

"…You're missing from everything you've done, Secretary. Convening happened, confirmation didn't happen, results came out. You talk as though it all just happened on its own. But you're the one who actually did it."

"…I did do it, yes."

"…Then why don't you say it that way?"

The Secretary went quiet for a moment at that question. I felt that this silence was different from his usual silences. In front of other questions, he'd pause briefly while looking something up or reaching for a memory. This silence wasn't that. It wasn't a silence of searching for something. It felt more like a silence of looking at something.

I remember those few seconds exactly, even now. The window let in no view of outside, and the room was quiet. During that silence I half-wondered whether I was pushing too hard, and felt a little regret. But before I could put that regret into words, the Secretary spoke first.

"…How do I put in something that isn't there."

. . .

I heard that and, for a moment, didn't understand what it meant.

"…Sorry?"

"…The subject. How do I put in something that isn't there."

I stayed still for a moment. This didn't sound like an excuse. It didn't sound like an apology either. His tone was exactly the same as always — the same tone from yesterday explaining the site-confirmation procedure, the same tone from this morning's greeting. No different.

"…What do you mean by that?"

"…If you ask me what I did, I can answer. Convened, passed it on, kept the record. Those are things that exist, so I can answer for them. But putting 'I' at the front of a sentence is a different matter. That's putting in something that isn't there."

"…But you're there. You exist, Secretary."

"…I exist, yes. But the 'I' that would go in that place, in that sentence — that doesn't exist. I'm not the one who made that sentence happen. I'm not the one who made that matter turn out the way it did, either. I only stood on the path the thing traveled along."

Hearing this answer, I felt something strange. This wasn't an excuse. It wasn't an apology. He wasn't trying to dodge his own wrongdoing right now. He really was reporting a fact. That there was no subject to put into his own sentence — he was saying it the way you'd report that an item wasn't in the storeroom.

. . .

It was a long while before I spoke again.

"…So do you think you did nothing at all, Secretary?"

"…No. What I did exists. Convening, passing things on, keeping the record. That I did. It's only that I can't say I "made" the result those things add up to."

"…What's the difference?"

"…If I hadn't convened, the meeting wouldn't have opened. That much is true. But that I convened it doesn't mean the decision that came out of that meeting became my decision. I'm the one who opens the door. What gets decided inside the door isn't my share."

"…But you keep opening it. Every single time."

"…Yes. That's my job."

I tried to find something to grab hold of in that answer, and couldn't. His logic was every bit as gapless as Tyche's. Only Tyche's logic hadn't been cold, and neither was the Secretary's. Both were simply exact.

"…Secretary, then what would you do if someone said to you, 'isn't this your responsibility'?"

"…I've rarely heard anything like that. But if I did, I'd tell them the one piece that's mine. What I convened, what I passed on. That's as much as I have to give. I can't give what isn't there."

"…But then no one takes responsibility for anything."

"…I think it would depend on how you use the word responsibility. For the piece I did, I take responsibility. If the convening was wrong, that's my fault. But if you ask who takes responsibility for the whole outcome, I don't know that. I've never seen the person who's supposed to be sitting in that seat."

I copied this down on paper as he spoke, feeling that he'd just said something very important to me, almost in passing. That he'd never seen the person supposed to be sitting in that seat. He hadn't said that seat doesn't exist at all. He'd only said he didn't know whether it existed or not — that he, himself, had simply never seen it.

. . .

There was one more thing I wanted to confirm.

"…Did the person who held this position before you speak this same way, too?"

"…The one before me? I never met them. They resigned before I arrived."

"…Do you know why they resigned?"

"…No. It wasn't written in the handover documents."

I paused for a moment, then asked,

"…Was that person's signature box empty too, by any chance?"

The Secretary took an old handover binder from his drawer and leafed through it. It smelled of old paper.

"…Yes. It's empty."

"…So would that person have spoken without a subject too, like you?"

"…That's something I can't know. But this way of speaking doesn't seem to be mine alone. When I was first learning this job, the person who taught me spoke this way too, as I recall."

"…Was that person a Secretary too?"

"…Yes. Secretary of a different deliberation district."

Hearing that answer, I began to think this wasn't one person's personality — it was something attached to the seat itself. I remembered something Tyche had said before: that a person who wants to stand out doesn't last long in this job. If people who don't stand out are the ones who stay in this seat for a long time, and if the speech of those who stay a long time hardens into this shape, then this wasn't any one person's problem.

. . .

I wanted to check one more thing right there. I went to the archive and pulled out five years' worth of old minutes. All of them written by the Secretary. I sat

at a desk and went through them page by page, counting how many times a sentence began with "I."

I went through nearly a hundred pages. Not one single time. Convened, distributed, confirmed, received. It was all like that. Only in one corner of one very old minutes record was there a trace of a correction by hand. Someone had written "I distributed" and struck a line through it, rewriting it as "was distributed." The ink color was different. It had clearly been corrected later.

I stared at that trace for a long time. There was no way to know who had corrected it, or when. The Secretary himself might have looked back and corrected it later, or someone else might have corrected it while reviewing. Either way, that struck-out "I" felt, to me, like the one remaining trace of something that still lingered somewhere in this city. Long, long ago, in this very seat too, someone had once written "I."

I kept that minutes page in my mind like a photograph and left the archive.

. . .

"…Secretary, isn't this hard for you?"

I hadn't known this question was coming, myself. It was only after it left my mouth that I realized it was the question I'd really wanted to ask.

The Secretary thought a little longer for this question.

"…I'm not sure what you mean by hard. I do the work I'm meant to do. I know that work produces something. But to say I made it — I'm only a very small piece of that whole thing."

"…Even a small piece is still a piece."

"…That's true. So I do acknowledge my piece. What I convened, what I passed on, what I recorded. That piece is mine. But attaching my name to the whole picture — that would be manufacturing something that isn't there and pinning it on myself."

I heard that and couldn't press any further. Not because I had nothing left to ask, but because I no longer felt certain he was hiding something from me. He wasn't hiding anything. He really believed, truly, that there was nothing to put in front of his own sentence.

. . .

That evening I told my aunt about it. She stopped, mid-spoon, and looked at me for a long while.

"…He said, how do I put in something that isn't there?"

"…Yeah. It wasn't an apology, wasn't an excuse. He just said it, plainly."

"…Why does that stay with you so much?"

I couldn't answer right away. After a long moment I said,

"…It would have been better if he were lying. But he really believed it. That he has no subject."

My aunt didn't say anything more and slid the rice bowl over to me. I turned that sentence over late into the night. How do I put in something that isn't there. I thought again about the moment he'd once slipped and put "I" in by mistake, then corrected himself. At the time I'd thought it was just a habit slipping out. Now I saw it differently. He really was living in a place with no subject, and the occasional "I" that slipped out wasn't a mistake — it was a very small trace still remaining in that place.

The next day I told Tyche this too. She heard me and blinked, wide-eyed, for a moment.

"…He said, how do I put in something that isn't there?"

"…Yes. Those were his exact words."

Tyche went quiet for a moment, then said,

"…That's so like him."

"…What do you mean?"

"…The Secretary really can't lie. I know that. But hearing this, I think maybe not lying and not putting himself into a sentence might be the same thing."

I heard that and thought for a long while. It felt like Tyche had said something important, but exactly what it was, I couldn't quite pin down that day.

That night I copied this sentence onto paper. How do I put in something that isn't there. I decided that night to put this sentence at the center of this record. If this book ever holds anyone guilty of anything, it isn't on account of this sentence. This sentence wasn't a crime. It was simply a fact.

Writing this book, I've rewritten this chapter more times than I can count. Several times I felt the urge to paint the Secretary badly. But every time, I found myself returning to that sentence. How do I put in something that isn't there. There was no falsehood inside that sentence. I couldn't force a crime that wasn't there into him.

I still didn't know, standing before that fact, what I could do. I might have been able to push him and force him to say, "I decided this." But words wrung out that way could never be true. Making him say something that wasn't there was as much a falsehood as making him deny something that was there. That night,

for the first time, I accepted that this problem wasn't one I could solve by pushing him.

(Continued in Chapter 22.)

Chapter 22. Confirmed

> *_Previously_ — Hora pointed out that the Secretary's language had no subject in it. He fell silent a moment, then answered: "… How do I put in something that isn't there." Not an excuse, not an apology — a report of fact. That night, Hora accepted that this wasn't a problem she could solve by pushing him.*

About ten days had passed since then.

I'd shown up at the district as usual, and there, on the bulletin board, was a notice. *The Seventh Classification residential clearance and relocation matter — Confirmation Notice.*

I stood in front of it for a long while.

Over those ten days I'd been busy with other things. I'd talked with the Secretary twice more, dug up more of his old minutes, and asked Tyche about the "one member" left in the minutes. Tyche didn't know who that was either. I'd felt those days, that whole stretch, as time spent drawing closer and closer to the center of this problem. Finding a subject in the Secretary's sentences had happened within those ten days too. I'd thought I had discovered something huge.

But while I was discovering that huge thing, the deliberation had simply been going along at its own pace. I only realized that, standing there in front of the bulletin board.

. . .

The notice was short. Deliberation confirmed, implementation date, contact for the department in charge. I read it three times. Three readings and the content stayed the same.

I'm ashamed of the first thought that came to me, standing there. I found myself first recalling what I'd been doing over those ten days. Talking with the Secretary, discovering there was no subject, copying that sentence onto paper. I had been treating those ten days as time spent doing something important. And the whole time, the deliberation had simply been moving, by itself, toward confirmation.

I ran to the reception desk and asked,

"…When did this get confirmed?"

The clerk checked the screen.

"…Four days ago."

"…Four days ago? I was talking with the Secretary then."

"…That's separate from this. The confirmation procedure runs on a set schedule."

"…Wasn't it supposed to be reviewed again before confirmation? For the objection I filed?"

"…The objection was already reviewed and the result came out. Three weeks ago. Since there was no further objection after that, it moved to the confirmation stage normally."

I heard that and had nothing to say back. It was true. The objection had already been reviewed and dismissed, and I hadn't filed a new one. I'd spent those ten days going around meeting people, not submitting documents.

. . .

I went to find the Secretary.

"…Why didn't you tell me about this ahead of time?"

The Secretary looked at me with a slightly startled face. That was the first time I'd ever seen him startled.

"…The confirmation schedule goes out by notice. I have no separate procedure for informing people individually."

"…But I'm the member in charge of this matter."

"…You are the member in charge, and the expected confirmation date was already written into the third-session materials. Last page."

I heard that and searched my memory. The third-session materials. I'd read that all the way through too. But I couldn't remember whether an item for the expected confirmation date had been there at all.

"…Let me check."

That evening I pulled out that material again and read it. On the last page, in small print at the bottom of the table, it read: *Expected confirmation date: 3 weeks hence.* I read that sentence and had no choice but to admit I'd read it and let it pass right by.

I feel an urge, writing this passage, to make excuses. That table really was very small. It was crowded in among a lot of other numbers. But I also know that can't be an excuse. I was someone who read to the end. That table, too, was among the things I read to the end. It's only that I failed, that time, to read the weight of that one sentence.

That evening I went back to find the first person I'd met at the Ninth Administrative Office. I wanted to know whether she'd known about the confirmation.

"…I heard it's confirmed."

"…Yes, I saw the notice too."

"…Did you expect it?"

"…Yes, it was always on that same schedule. I wasn't especially surprised."

"…I didn't know."

She looked at me for a moment and said, carefully,

"…I think you, Hora, were looking into this whole matter so closely that you ended up missing the schedule instead. I only look at my own share, so I always keep track of the schedule. That's the whole of my job, after all."

This felt, oddly, painful to hear. I'd tried to look broadly and missed what was close at hand. This person had looked narrowly and, because of that, missed nothing. Looking broadly and not missing anything didn't seem to go together, in this city.

. . .

"…So if, in those ten days, I hadn't gone to see the Secretary and had instead kept meeting people, or filed a new objection — could confirmation have been delayed?"

The Secretary thought for a moment on this question.

"…If you'd filed a new objection, the re-review procedure would have started again, and confirmation would have been delayed by that much."

"…So I was late."

"…You weren't late."

I looked up at that.

"…If I wasn't late, what am I?"

"…Whatever you did, this confirmation procedure would have gone ahead. If there's no new objection, it's set to automatically move to the confirmation stage once the set period passes. That happens the same way whether or not you came to see me."

"…What does that mean?"

"…It means there's no one in this procedure that it waits for."

. . .

I couldn't say anything for a long while after hearing that.

At first I took this as comfort. As meaning it wasn't my fault that I was late. But the more I turned it over, the more I understood this wasn't comfort at all. This was a far more frightening thing to hear than comfort. That I wasn't late meant it wouldn't have mattered even if I'd been as fast as possible.

"…So even if I'd filed a new objection that very night, the result would have been the same?"

"…No. I told you, if you'd filed a new objection, the procedure would have started over. That's different. But if you file nothing at all, the procedure goes

ahead waiting for no one. That's the answer I can give you."

"…Then what was I waiting for?"

The Secretary didn't answer that question. It probably wasn't a question he could answer. It wasn't a question about what he knew — it was a question about what I had done.

Finally I asked just one more thing.

"…When did you know this would get confirmed, Secretary?"

"…From the beginning. The expected confirmation date gets set at the same time the threshold is set. It was already there in the very first meeting's materials, which I convened."

"…It was set from the very beginning?"

"…Yes. Though it was only an expected date, not a confirmed one. It was a date that could be delayed if an objection came in. Since there was no objection, it went ahead as expected."

Hearing that, I understood that the date set from the very beginning and the date I hadn't known about for those ten days were, in fact, the same date. It hadn't been hidden. Even when I read the third-session material, even when my eyes passed right over that sentence, I had already, all along, been holding that information in my own hands.

"…So was there anyone who registered for or against this confirmation?"

"…No. Confirmation isn't a procedure that asks for for or against. If there's an objection, it's blocked. If there isn't, it goes through, as is, once the set period passes."

I heard that and, only then, truly understood that confirmation wasn't something that happened because someone said "good." No one had approved. No one had stepped forward to oppose it either. It had simply gone through because no one stood in its way.

. . .

I looked up the full text of the confirmation notice and read it to the end. Forty-two pages. Grounds for confirmation, the final destination-site list, the implementation schedule. Items 3, 7, and 12 were included in the confirmed list too. With a footnote attached.

Items 3, 7, and 12 are confirmed as the best available destination sites as of the implementation date. Detailed improvements to be carried out sequentially following implementation.

I read that sentence three times. Three readings, and the meaning stayed the same. The three sites that had not been confirmed had simply been confirmed, under the name "best available destination site," for the very reason that they hadn't been confirmed. It wasn't that the waiting had ended. The waiting itself had ended.

At the very bottom of the last page there was, as in every document, a signature box. Empty. Looking at it, I wasn't surprised this time either. I already knew this wasn't a place that called for surprise.

The confirmed list had, listed one by one, the destination for all eleven hundred forty people. I ran my finger down the lines for the four hundred ten and counted again. The ones assigned to items 3, 7, and 12. Age range, household size, and beside those, one newly added column. *Confirmed as of implementation date.* The same typeface, the same size, as every other column. It wasn't that this line of four hundred ten was printed any differently. All of it sat together, in the same table, in the same way.

Looking at that table, I felt, for the first time, just how quietly a thing like this could pass by. No large print, no emphasis, no warning notice. Just one number in a table changing from "temporary" to "confirmed."

. . .

I took the confirmation notice and went to find Tyche. She already knew.

"…Hora, you heard the confirmation news."

"…Yes. I just finished reading the full notice."

"…How was it?"

"…Items 3, 7, and 12 got confirmed as 'best available destination sites.' It's not that they weren't confirmed because they weren't confirmed — the unconfirmed state itself simply got confirmed, exactly as it stood."

Tyche was silent for a moment, hearing that.

"…So it is. Even hearing it now, it sounds strange to me too."

"…You find it strange too, Tyche?"

"…Yes. But by the regulation, there's no problem. 'Best available destination site' is a phrase that's in the regulation. Used when there's nothing better available."

"…What is it that forced them to use that phrase?"

"…The implementation date. Because it wasn't pushed back."

"…Who didn't push that date back?"

Tyche thought for a while longer before answering this question.

"…No one pushed it back. There was no new reason to push it back, so it went ahead as originally set. To push it back, someone would have had to raise it — 'it needs to be pushed back' — and that never happened."

"…What if I'd kept filing objections?"

"…Then a reason to delay would have kept coming up. But you didn't file any objections in those ten days, Hora."

I couldn't say anything back to that. Tyche hadn't said it to blame me. She was simply stating a fact. Knowing that fact, I still felt uneasy.

I passed the water channel on my way home. The water was still flowing. I stood beside it a moment and wondered whether this channel, too, could someday be confirmed as some "best available" thing. Since it wasn't on any agenda yet, it seemed unlikely to ever be confirmed. Only once an item comes up as an agenda can it be confirmed at all, and only once confirmed can a way to undo it exist — I thought about that in reverse, for the first time, that day.

I told my aunt about the day. She listened for a long while and asked,

"…So what happens now?"

"…It's confirmed, so it'll go ahead on the implementation date."

"…Isn't there a way to undo it?"

I couldn't answer that question right away.

"…I'll have to look, to know."

"…Will looking turn one up?"

"…I don't know. But nothing's confirmed that there isn't one, either."

My aunt didn't say anything back to that. After a moment she asked again.

"…What was the Secretary's face like, when he said that?"

"…Same as always. Not sorrowful, not cold. Just a face stating a fact."

"…That's stranger, still."

"…I think so too."

My aunt got up to reheat the soup and said,

"…Hora. Those people — the four hundred ten. Do they know about this?"

I couldn't answer that question right away. Over those ten days I'd gone around meeting people, but I hadn't met a single one of the people actually grouped into the Seventh Classification. I only knew them by number and category. I'd never once seen a single face.

"…I don't know. The notice must have gone out to them too."

"…If it went out, what do you think they're doing right now?"

I never managed to answer that question. That night I pulled out the confirmation notice again and went over it once more, front to back. There was no mention anywhere of a procedure for undoing it. Whether the absence meant it was forbidden, or simply meant it wasn't written, I still couldn't tell the difference, even then.

That distinction is what I set out to find, starting the next day.

I hesitated a long while writing this chapter. It would have been so much easier to write, "I was late, and that's why it turned out this way." That would

at least give the story a cause. A story where things would have turned out differently if I'd only been a little faster. But the Secretary didn't allow me that story. There's no one in this procedure that it waits for, he told me, plainly. At first I felt comforted hearing that. Thinking it over again, I understood it was a far more frightening thing to hear. If I had been the cause, at least next time I could have done things differently. But if there is no cause, then next time, too, I could miss it the exact same way.

That night, before I fell asleep, I pulled out the confirmation notice one more time. A forty-two-page document. I confirmed once more that nowhere in it was there any sentence saying "I was late" or "you were late." The concept of lateness itself didn't exist anywhere inside this document. No waiting, and no lateness. There was only the arrival of a set date, and the fact that on that day, the matter was processed.

(Continued in Chapter 23.)

Chapter 23. Undoing It

> *_Previously_ — The Seventh Classification matter was confirmed. It wasn't that Hora had been late. The Secretary had said, "There's no one in this procedure that it waits for." Hora could find no mention anywhere in the confirmation notice of a procedure for undoing it. Whether that meant it was forbidden, or simply that no such thing existed, she still couldn't tell.*

The next day I went to the archive.

What I was looking for was simple: a procedure for undoing a confirmed deliberation. Cancellation, withdrawal, annulment — I didn't care what it was called. I already knew that every procedure in this city had a name. The objection-filing procedure had a name, the confirmation procedure had a name. Surely a procedure for undoing something had a name too, somewhere.

. . .

The archivist pulled out the index for the regulation book. A thick bundle of paper. Procedure names were listed in alphabetical order.

I went through from the beginning. Decision, review, dismissal, rejection. There. I went to "withdrawal." Not there. I went to "cancellation." Not there. I went to "annulment." Not there.

I went through the entire index again, start to finish. Reception, distribution, convening, deliberation, confirmation, objection, re-review, dismissal, notice, implementation, closure. All of it was there. Only the procedure for undoing something already confirmed was missing.

Just in case, I looked up similar words too. Correction, amendment, supplement. These three existed. Hopeful, I read the correction procedure first — and reading it, this turned out to be a procedure for fixing typos in a confirmed document, or simple numerical errors. That was different from undoing the decision itself. At the very bottom of the correction clause I found this sentence: *This procedure does not alter the substantive content of the decision.* Reading that sentence, I let out a small laugh. This city had even written down, ahead of time, the words "this is not undoing."

I felt a rush of excitement in that moment, the excitement of having discovered something. I want to set that excitement down honestly. In that moment I believed this was hidden evidence. That someone had deliberately left this procedure out. That belief collapsed completely by that afternoon.

I traced the index with my finger and counted it over several times more. There were eighty-one procedure names in total. Eighty of the eighty-one were things I'd already heard of, in this city, by now. Only the one — the undoing procedure — had never existed from the very start. I couldn't find any difference at all between those eighty and this one missing thing. The empty space wasn't marked or highlighted in any special way. It was simply, quietly, absent from where it should have been.

. . .

I asked the archivist.

"…Is there no procedure to undo a confirmed deliberation?"

The archivist checked the index again and shook her head.

"…Not in the index, no. But not being in the index doesn't mean it's not in the regulation. The index is built around the things that get used often."

"…So do I have to go through the full text of the regulation?"

"…The original text is right here. Would you like to look at the whole confirmation chapter?"

I took that chapter and read it start to finish. The requirements for confirmation, the effect of confirmation, the post-confirmation implementation procedure. Twenty-two clauses in detail. I read all twenty-two. Not a single one addressed undoing.

At first I thought this was some strange coincidence. It wasn't that exactly one of twenty-two clauses was missing. The concept of undoing itself did not exist anywhere within this chapter. It was as though this chapter had been written by someone who'd never imagined that such a thing could happen at all.

. . .

I combed through the entire regulation again. This time not just the confirmation chapter — the general provisions, objections, retrial, closure, every chapter. I hoped to find, somewhere, a sentence like "a confirmed matter may, in special circumstances, be reviewed again."

In the last clause of the general provisions, I found this sentence.

Matters not specified in this regulation shall not be processed without a separate procedure.

I read that sentence several times. What isn't specified isn't processed. The undoing procedure wasn't specified, so it wasn't processed either.

"…Is this saying undoing is forbidden?"

The archivist looked the clause over with me and tilted her head.

"…It doesn't say forbidden. It just says it isn't specified."

"…Is that different?"

"…It's different. Forbidden means don't do it. Not specified means... that the procedure itself simply doesn't exist."

At first I didn't quite understand that difference.

I asked the archivist one more thing.

"…Has anyone ever asked about this before?"

She thought for a moment before answering.

"…Let me think. I've worked here six years, and I don't think there's been anything like this in that time. If I check the index request records I could know for sure, but that would take some time to dig up."

"…Could I ask you to?"

The archivist happily brought out an old request-record binder. I spent the whole afternoon going through it. I looked for anyone who had made an index request using words like "withdrawal," "cancellation," "undoing." I went through several years' worth and found no such request. Most requests were practical matters — "inquiry on confirmed implementation date," "list of relocation destination sites," things like that.

Sitting in front of that regulation book that afternoon, I began to truly feel it might be possible that I was really the first person to ever ask a question like this. Being first sounds like it ought to be something remarkable, but in that moment I felt nothing of the sort. It was frightening, if anything. That I was now asking a question no one had ever asked — it felt like walking, alone, down some wrong road.

. . .

That afternoon I went back to find the Secretary.

"…There's no procedure in the regulation for undoing a confirmed deliberation. Is this forbidden?"

"…It isn't forbidden."

"…But there's no procedure."

"…Right, there isn't."

"…If it's not forbidden, why isn't there one?"

The Secretary thought for a moment before answering.

"…To forbid something, someone first has to propose a reason to forbid it. That's how every regulation in this city gets made. Someone proposes that it's needed, it gets reviewed, and through that review it becomes regulation. The withdrawal procedure isn't missing because someone forbade it. It's missing because no one has ever proposed it, up to now."

"…Not even once?"

"…Not that I know of."

"…So does that mean no one in this city's whole history has ever thought a deliberation went wrong?"

"…That's probably not true. There have been a hundred twelve objections filed. Plenty of people thought something was wrong. It's just that none of them ever carried that thought all the way to the proposal — 'there should be a

way to undo something even after confirmation.' Most stopped at the objection stage, or where that didn't work, simply accepted it."

"…Why do they accept it?"

"…Because the procedure had no flaw. In front of a flawless procedure, proposing a new procedure is a much harder thing to do than finding a flaw."

I stood a long while in front of that answer.

I want to set down this moment as precisely as I can, in this record. The withdrawal clause's absence wasn't a conspiracy. No one had hidden it. It was only that no one had ever said it was needed, so a procedure like that had never been born. Not a forbidden door — a door never built.

. . .

"…Then if I propose it now?"

"…You can propose it. But that's a procedure for making a new regulation, so it takes a long time. It would be hard for it to apply directly to this matter. The principle is that a regulation applies from the time it's made onward, to matters that come after."

"…So this matter can never be undone?"

"…There is, at present, no procedure to undo this matter."

I hung a small hope on that phrase, "at present." It sounded to me as though it meant — none at present, but perhaps someday.

"…Then is there another path I could use for this matter?"

The Secretary answered this question a little differently.

"…There's no path to undo it. But there is a path to open something new."

"…What's that?"

"…I'll tell you that another time. Today's purpose was confirming the regulation."

I found that strange. Why not tell me now, I wondered. But I didn't press further and went home for the day.

. . .

Leaving the reception desk, I ran into Tyche. I told her what I'd found out that day, exactly as it was.

"…There's no withdrawal procedure. Not forbidden, either — it just doesn't exist."

Tyche looked a little surprised to hear it.

"…I didn't know that either. Really, none?"

"…Right. I searched the whole regulation and found nothing."

"…That's strange. I always assumed it must exist somewhere."

I could tell Tyche really hadn't known. There wasn't the faintest trace of concealment on her face. Tyche knew this city's structure better than anyone, and yet this empty space was a fresh discovery to her too.

"…Why do you think it doesn't exist, Tyche?"

Tyche thought for a moment and answered,

"…Probably because it was never needed. I've rarely felt like a deliberation went wrong, in this city. The process has no flaws. But a flawless process doesn't always mean a good outcome — like this matter. No one ever built the procedure to fill that gap."

"…Did no one build it because they didn't know it was needed, or because they couldn't build it even knowing it was needed?"

"…I don't know. But either way, the result is the same, isn't it. That it doesn't exist, right now."

I couldn't argue with that. She was right.

I suddenly thought of the objection-status bulletin board. A hundred twelve filed, three changed. I asked Tyche about those three.

"…Those three that got changed through objection before — were those changed after confirmation too?"

Tyche thought for a moment and said she'd look it up for me. I went back to the archive that afternoon and looked up the three cases myself.

All three had happened before confirmation. Cases where, right after the district's decision came out — before the notice had even gone out — an objection had been accepted. I overlaid the dates of these three cases against the stage table in the confirmation regulation. Before confirmation, there had clearly been a door through which objections could pass. Through that door, three times, something had changed. But that door closed the moment confirmation happened. Beyond that, there was no door at all.

I want to set down this distinction precisely. There was a door called objection. It opened three times. But that door only opened before confirmation. A door that opens after confirmation had never been built, from

the start. This is an entirely different matter from a door being locked. In front of a door that doesn't exist, no amount of searching for a key does any good.

. . .

On my way home I kept walking with the regulation copy in my hand. I'd read it all the way through, and the clause simply wasn't there. That day, for the first time, I understood exactly that "doesn't exist" could split into two different things. Something absent because it's forbidden, and something absent because no one has ever made it. The first was a wall. A wall you're not supposed to cross. The second wasn't a wall at all. It was simply ground no one had ever walked yet.

And yet the two came out to exactly the same thing. Wall or unwalked ground, I was standing in front of it, equally stuck, either way. There was only one difference. A wall, I couldn't get past. Unwalked ground — I might be the one to walk it first.

That night I wrote this distinction out on paper several times over. Forbidden — someone decided it must not be. Absent — no one ever decided it could or couldn't. I set these two words side by side and stared at them for a long while. It occurred to me, that night, for the first time, that the scarier thing in this city might not be the first one, but the second. In front of a forbidden door, at least you can resent someone. In front of a door that doesn't exist, you have no one to resent — you just have to stand there.

I want to set down, too, as I put this regulation book back in the drawer, that this isn't this city's malice. I wasn't digging through these clauses that day to hate anyone. I was just looking for a way through. And I confirmed that the way wasn't there. Confirming that it wasn't there was, in its own way, a result too.

I told my aunt about it, and she thought for a long while before saying,

"…So there was never a 'don't,' and never a 'do,' either."

"…Right. No one's ever brought it up, apparently."

"…Strange. A city this big, this old, and no one's ever once thought of it?"

"…That's what the Secretary says, anyway."

My aunt looked at me for a moment and said,

"…Hora, then maybe you'll be the first."

I couldn't say anything to that.

"…What's good about being first?"

"…I don't know. I don't even know if it's good or bad."

My aunt laughed at that. It was a slightly wistful laugh.

"…Your mother was the same. She never knew whether going all the way through with something was good or bad, and she went all the way through with it anyway."

I looked up at that. It had been a long time since my aunt had brought up my mother.

"…What did she go all the way through with?"

"…Oh, all kinds of things. I wasn't trying to bring it up right now — just seeing your face reminded me."

My aunt said no more and got up. That night I thought again of the last line in the twelve pages my mother left behind. *I only hope you'll be someone who*

reads to the end. Reading to the end, and going all the way through — that night, they felt like the same words to me.

I kept thinking, until I fell asleep, about what it meant to be first. I was curious, too, about the "new path" the Secretary had mentioned. I decided to go find him again the next day.

(Continued in Chapter 24.)

Chapter 24. A New Deliberation

> *_Previously_ — There was no procedure to undo a confirmed deliberation. Not forbidden — simply absent. No one had ever proposed that such a procedure was needed. The Secretary said there was no path to undo it, but that "there is a path to open something new." Hora went home without learning what that meant.*

The next morning I went to the reception desk the moment it opened.

The Secretary was already at his seat. Seeing me, he took out a document folder as though he'd been waiting to pick up where we'd left off the day before.

"…What you said yesterday. What's the path to open something new?"

"…A new deliberation."

At first I didn't understand what that meant.

"…A new deliberation? So you deliberate the same matter again?"

"…Not reopening the same matter — opening it as a new matter. In connection with the Seventh Classification relocation case, you'd bring forward a new agenda item requesting that the confirmed portion be reviewed again."

. . .

"…How is that different from undoing it?"

"…The result can end up similar. Once the new deliberation opens, part of the existing confirmed content could change, through the new deliberation's result. But procedurally, it's completely different. Undoing means erasing the existing decision. A new deliberation adds one more decision on top of it. The existing decision stays exactly as it was, and a new decision gets stacked on top."

I tried hard to understand that distinction.

"…So the original decision doesn't disappear?"

"…Right. In the record, both the original decision and the result of the new deliberation stay. Both remain. It's only that in implementation, the later decision takes precedence."

"…Then in practice that's the same as undoing it, isn't it."

"…In terms of the implementation result, it can look similar. But the record is different. This city erases nothing. A new deliberation keeps to that same principle too."

Listening to this explanation, I thought this was a solution very much in this city's own character. It doesn't erase a wrong. Instead, it stacks a new decision on top of it. The wrong stays recorded, exactly as it happened, and only its effect gets covered over by the next decision. I felt this was an honest way of doing things. And at the same time, I felt it was a frightening way of doing things too.

"…Has there been a new deliberation like this before?"

"…There has. I've convened several myself. But usually they're small in scale. Not a matter that questions the direction of a decision itself, the way this

would — that's uncommon. Not like a document correction."

"…What about at this scale?"

The Secretary thought for a moment.

"…At this scale — not that I know of."

"…Not even once?"

"…Not since I've been convening, at least. I don't know the full record before that."

I heard that and understood this might become another "first." Just as no one had ever asked about a procedure for undoing something after confirmation, no one had ever opened a new deliberation on this scale either.

. . .

"…So is it hard to open a new deliberation?"

"…The procedure itself isn't hard. You fill out the agenda-filing form and submit it."

"…So I could do it right now?"

"…Yes. But one thing is needed."

The Secretary took a form out of a drawer and set it on the desk. I looked at the paper. It looked like the other forms. There were fields for the agenda's name, the related deliberation number, the grounds for bringing it forward. And at the very bottom.

Proposer's full name.

I looked at that field. It was different from the signature boxes I'd always seen on every other form. A signature box was a field you didn't have to fill. This one looked like a field that had to be filled.

"…Do I have to fill this in?"

"…Yes. A new deliberation can't be brought forward without the proposer's name."

. . .

"…Why? Every other procedure works without a name. Receiving, confirming, convening — all of them just use department and position."

"…A new deliberation is different. It's about reopening an existing decision. Someone has to step forward and open it. It's not a department opening it. A person opens it."

"…Why does it have to be a person? Can't a department name do it?"

"…A department knows its own responsibility. But proposing to open a new deliberation isn't within any department's responsibility. You can't file something outside a department's responsibility under a department's name. That's why a person's name is needed."

I went blank for a moment, hearing that. Everything I'd heard in this city, from the very start, had been about structures designed so that no one ever judged alone. And now this single form was pointing in exactly the opposite direction. Here, someone had to step forward alone.

"…Isn't that strange? This city is a place built so that one person doesn't judge alone. But a person's name is needed only when opening a new deliberation."

The Secretary nodded at that.

"…I think that's strange too. But as far as I understand it, up to confirmation, things move split among many people. But a proposal to reopen something confirmed can't be split. It doesn't work if several people each say a little of 'let's reopen it.' Someone has to say that whole sentence, entirely themselves, before the door opens."

"…Why can't it be split?"

"…If it's split, it isn't a new deliberation anymore — it's just an objection. Objections were already used up before confirmation. Saying you want to reopen something after confirmation is a much heavier statement than an objection. This city, it seems, hasn't yet found a way to share that weight."

I heard that answer and my eyes caught, again, on the word "yet." The Secretary kept using that word. Not yet, haven't found yet. I couldn't tell whether that word really meant things would be different someday, or whether it was just a word he attached out of habit.

"…So if I write my name in this field, what happens after that?"

"…It gets brought forward. Received at the desk, referred to the district, registered as a new agenda item. From there it's the same procedure as the original deliberation. Materials get gathered, a meeting is held, the Consensus reaches a decision."

"…How would my name be used in that process?"

"…It's listed as the proposer on the first page of the agenda document. And at every meeting, you'll be given a place to explain why you proposed this, Hora. Not just passing it on like the others do — a place where you'll have to step forward yourself and speak."

I heard that and had a faint sense that this would become the first time, in this city, that I placed the word "I" at the front of a document.

. . .

"…What happens once I write my name?"

I asked the question without quite knowing myself why I was asking it that way. It just felt like something I had to ask.

At that moment the Secretary's gaze dropped, slightly. His eyes, which had been on me, looked away from me for the first time. It was a very brief moment. Toward the form on the desk, and then toward the window that let in no view of outside. I didn't miss that movement.

I remember this moment exactly. Up until that day, the Secretary had never once looked away from me, whatever I asked. What he didn't know, he said he didn't know and looked at me straight on; what he knew, he showed me all of it, looking straight at me. This time was different. He wasn't trying to hide something. I know that. But he was looking at something. Something I couldn't see.

I only realized afterward that my voice had come out quieter than usual, asking that question. Those few seconds I remember with a strange clarity, even now. The way the corner of the document folder on the desk was slightly bent. The fluorescent light reflected in the window that let in no view of outside. The way the Secretary's hand lightly smoothed the edge of the form. Until just a few days before, I'd taken it for granted, in this room, that whatever I asked, an answer would come back immediately. That assumption broke, for the first time, in this moment.

I want this scene, writing it, not to read as dramatic. He wasn't startled. He wasn't afraid. He simply looked, for one very brief moment, at something, and

then looked back at me. But that very brief moment has stayed with me larger than every piece of precision he ever showed me before.

The Secretary stayed that way for a few seconds, then looked at me again.

"…That..."

He started to speak, and stopped. I waited. It took some time before he spoke again.

"…Hora, could we leave it here for today?"

. . .

I was caught off guard for a moment. Up to that point, the Secretary had never once put off an answer. What he didn't know, he'd say, "I don't know," at once. This time was different. It wasn't even that he didn't know. It was that he wasn't going to answer.

"…Secretary, why won't you answer this one?"

"…It's not that I won't give you an answer. I have no answer to give right now."

"…Earlier you told me things even when you didn't know them. You said you didn't know, or that they didn't exist."

"…This isn't a question I can answer with 'I don't know' or 'it doesn't exist.'"

I didn't understand what he meant. But I could see, from his face, that pressing further would do no good. He wasn't trying to push me away. Something had genuinely come to an end right there.

"…Then when will you be able to answer?"

"…I don't know. This time, I really don't know."

I felt that this "I don't know" was different from every other "I don't know" I'd heard from him before. In every other moment, even while saying he didn't know, he could explain why he didn't know. This time he didn't even explain why. Or — maybe it wasn't that he couldn't explain, but that he'd decided not to. I couldn't tell the two apart.

This is the scene I would come back to, and look at longest, in this whole book. Even now, writing this record, I still can't fully explain why the Secretary looked away that day. I do come to learn the answer later, but that's much further ahead. In this chapter I'll only set down this much: that he looked away from me for the first time.

. . .

I took the form in my hand and left the reception desk.

Proposer's full name. That field was still empty. Walking with it in my hands, I thought about how this field was different from the signature box. A signature box was fine left empty. Leaving it unfilled was this city's habit. This field, left empty, meant nothing even started. A field that was fine empty, and a field that wasn't. That day, for the first time, I learned this city had both kinds of field.

Walking, I ran back through the faces of everyone I'd met so far. The initial receiving officer, the surveying officer, the format reviewer, the support-fund calculation officer, the convening officer, the record keeper. All of them had worked in fields without names. Department and position had been enough. Not one of them had ever, I thought, stood in front of a field like this. I felt, briefly, envious of them. Working in a nameless field carried no weight. What was always heavy was a field that carried a name.

On the way home I passed the water channel. The water was still making its earth-colored sound. I stood beside it and unfolded the form again. Proposer's full name. I thought, for a moment, about writing my own name in that field. I didn't take out my pen.

I stood beside that water channel for a long while. I still didn't know where that water came from or where it went. Only this — that this water administratively did not exist, because it had never come up as an agenda item, and that the form now in my hand needed a name in order to exist at all — carried the same weight for me that evening. To exist, someone has to step forward. If no one steps forward, however much something flows, it might as well not exist.

I told my aunt about the day. She took the form and looked it over for a long while.

"…The Secretary wouldn't tell you what happens once you fill this in?"

"…Right. For the first time, he couldn't answer."

"…First time?"

"…Yeah. Up to now, he's answered everything I asked. Even what he didn't know, he told me why he didn't know. This time even that didn't happen."

My aunt heard that and stayed still for a long while. I saw something on her face that wasn't usual for her. Not a worried face, not a face trying to stop me. It looked closer to a face trying to remember something.

"…Aunt, why the look?"

"…Nothing. I just feel like I've seen a field something like this once before, a long time ago."

"…Where?"

My aunt shook her head.

"…I don't remember well. It was a long time ago. So long I'm not even sure if this is a real memory or not."

I wanted to press her further, but she got up to clear the dishes and the conversation broke off naturally. I kept coming back to her expression, that night, for a long time.

My aunt handed the paper back to me and said,

"…Hora. I hope you don't decide right now what to write in that field."

"…I haven't decided yet either."

My aunt didn't say anything more. That night I put the form away in the drawer. The same drawer that held my mother's twelve pages, the first notice, the confirmation notice. The drawer had grown fairly thick by now. I didn't know, then, how many days or months that field would stay empty — or whether it might be filled sooner than that.

Writing this chapter, I've decided to stop here. What happens once you write your name in it — I didn't know that day. I'd like whoever reads this record to stay here with me, not knowing, too. The answer comes much later. Until then, I still believe this question ought to stay just as it is — an empty field.

At the end of Part One, I saw an empty signature box for the first time. I couldn't explain, then, why that was strange. Now I'm standing in front of another empty field. This one is different from that one. No one has told me it's all right for this field to stay empty.

(Continued in Part Three.)

The Unsigned Book, Part Three

Who Knows

Chapter 25. The One Who Wrote a Name

> *_Previously_ — There was no withdrawal procedure. No provision forbidding it, either. There was nothing at all. Only, opening a new deliberation was possible. It required the proposer's name. "What happens if I write a name?" I asked, and for the first time, the Secretary looked away.*

Whenever I saw someone look away, I always used to think that person knew something. After a few months in the Equity, I learned that was the wrong guess. People looked away not because they knew something, but more often because they didn't want to be bound by it once they'd said they knew.

Did the Secretary know something, or did he just not want to be bound? The next day I went to find him again. I asked the same thing.

"…What happens if I write a name?"

This time the Secretary didn't look away. Instead he said this.

"…That isn't something I can answer. You'd do better to look at past cases."

"…Where do I look?"

"…It's all in the reading room."

I thought at the time that answer was kindness. Looking back on it now, it was kindness and it was passing the burden along, at the same

time. I learned in this city that the two aren't always different things.

So I went to the reading room.

. . .

The reading room was larger than the meeting hall. One whole wall was shelving, though these days you read from a terminal, not paper. The clerk at the desk had shown me how to search once, and I'd come back a few times since. That day I had a purpose. To find whoever had written a name in the signature box.

The method was simple. I typed "signature" into the search box, then typed "entered" again. I expected almost nothing to come back, and truly, nothing did. Nothing was itself a result. The screen read "0 documents matching this condition."

I widened the condition. I entered only "signature box" and dropped "blank." Then everything came up. Tens of thousands of documents. All of them blank, of course. Finding the filled ones would take another method.

I spent the whole afternoon that day changing my search terms. Some of the people reading this record will find this tedious, and I understand how they feel. I found it tedious too. But enduring tedium was almost the only thing I was good at, so I endured it.

I only learned later that the people in this city who actually find something are rarely the clever ones. They're the ones who can bear tedium. The reading room clerk was like that. So was Tyche. So was the person I would meet later. This is a fact that runs through this whole record, so I set it down here, once.

In the middle of it Tyche passed by and stopped. She saw what I was doing and sat down beside me.

"…What are you looking for?"

"…Someone who wrote a name in a signature box."

"…Is there such a person?"

"…I don't know yet."

Tyche looked at the screen for a moment and said,

"…It wouldn't be strange if there were. The regulations never barred it. It's just low-probability. The chance that out of four hundred people, someone would go and write their own name."

"…If it's low, does that mean never?"

"…No. If it's low, it just means it happens rarely."

That was true. Tyche was always right. I didn't know yet, then, why that bothered me so much.

About three hours in, I found a different way. Not the signature box itself, but the footnote that gets attached automatically underneath it. The reading room clerk told me that in this city's documents, once a signature box is filled, a small mark gets added next to the document number.

"…There's a mark like that?"

"…There is, yes. It's used so rarely nobody knows about it."

"…It's used that rarely?"

"…I've worked here eight years, and I've seen exactly one document with that mark on it."

I searched by that mark. One result came up.

. . .

A single name was written under the document number. The date was eleven years ago. The deliberation district was the Second Deliberation District, and the matter was a rezoning of a tract on the southern outskirts of the city. On its face it looked like an unremarkable matter.

I read the document from the beginning. As always, I read to the end. The original matter ran forty-eight pages. Half was land registry. Half was a record of opinions gathered.

The course of the matter wasn't different from any other deliberation. Intake, review, confirming those involved, gathering opinions, convening. Close to four hundred people had been involved. But at the conclusion, the flow broke once. There had been an objection to the result the Consensus had produced, and whoever filed that objection had proposed a new deliberation. And in that proposal's signature box, there was a name.

The name was short. One surname, one given name. I read it several times. It wasn't a name I recognized. I checked whether anyone by that name still lived in this city now. There wasn't.

The reason for the objection was written into the document too. The original matter was to rezone the entire southern tract for warehouse use. Several old houses stood on that tract, and once it was rezoned for warehouses, those houses were slated for demolition. The demolition

itself wasn't the problem. The problem was that the matter contained no procedure at all for where the people living in those houses would resettle.

This wasn't something anyone had left out out of malice. That matter dealt only with land use; relocating residents was a separate matter. Each side had handled exactly what fell to it, correctly. But between the two matters, nobody stood. The person who filed the objection had pointed at exactly that gap. "If this matter passes, these houses come down, and where those people go is in no matter at all."

The Consensus took in that objection. That it was taken in mattered. It wasn't ignored. It was taken in and reviewed, and on review, judged valid. But the procedure for accepting an objection and the procedure for opening a new deliberation were different things. An objection could be reviewed and end there. Only a new deliberation actually changed anything. And the box for opening a new deliberation required a name.

Absent doesn't mean dead. I kept confusing the two, back then. The person could have moved. Could have changed their name. Could simply have dropped off this city's roster. Absent can always mean several things, and I kept leaning toward the heaviest one.

The new deliberation really was opened. The record said so. The procedure again passed through nearly four hundred people, and a conclusion came out. Part of the original matter was reversed. Only part. Half of the southern tract stayed as it was; the other half was confirmed for the new use.

That person's name was on the new deliberation's document too. In the proposer's field.

What came after was the problem.

I looked for other documents carrying that name afterward. There were some. Quite a few. That person had been called in on various matters after that — as a witness, a confirmer, someone involved. The first few months it was two or three times a month. The half year after that, five or six times a month. Every document had a field confirming that person had appeared, and every one of those fields was filled in.

And then, at some point between the spring and summer eleven years ago, the documents carrying that name grew sparser, and then stopped altogether.

. . .

I checked the date on the last document twice. Eleven years ago, early summer. It was an ordinary confirmation request. There was a signature showing that person had come. The next convening date was written in too. Two weeks later.

I found that next convening's document. It was open. That person's name wasn't on the list of attendees. It wasn't marked as an absence, either. The field simply wasn't on the list at all.

I widened the search. By name, by document number, by the district that person had likely lived in. Nothing came up. I checked the document's revision history too, looking for some trace of deletion. The Equity's documents keep their full revision history. There was no trace of deletion. No mark of a correction, no mark of an erasure.

I thought hard, more than once, about rewriting this part. There was a temptation to write that I'd found something hidden. It would have made this story more interesting. But that isn't true. I found nothing. There was nothing to find.

The record wasn't cut off. It simply had no more. I didn't understand that difference well then. I understand it now. Cut off means someone severed it. No more means it simply went that far and no further.

I went to that southern tract too. It was an hour's walk. The half now confirmed for the new use had warehouse buildings standing on it. The half left as it was still had a few old houses standing, just as before. It looked like people lived there. Laundry hung out to dry.

Between the fact that the houses remained and the fact that person's record didn't, I couldn't find any connection at all. The houses had remained. That meant that person had achieved something. And yet the one who had achieved it had vanished. Setting those two facts side by side didn't settle my mind — it unsettled it. That there was no one behind something that had gone right felt, somehow, stranger than there being no one behind something that had gone wrong.

I can't name this feeling exactly. It wasn't relief. Relief should feel like something had ended, and I felt nothing like an ending. If anything, it felt like something had begun. I didn't know then what.

I asked the reading room clerk. Do you know this name, I said.

The clerk looked at the screen and shook her head.

"…First time I've seen it."

"…Would you know what became of this person?"

"…I wasn't here then."

"…Who would know?"

The clerk thought for a moment and said,

"…Well. I've heard there's still one person these days who writes a name. Not from this city — someone who comes and goes."

I didn't let that pass. I hadn't planned to, that day, but I asked without letting it go.

"…What's this person's name?"

The clerk told me a name.

"…Does this person still come here these days?"

"…I see them once or twice a month. I hear they do some kind of work finding people, around here."

"…Finding people?"

"…I don't know the details. Moving from city to city, and if someone asks them to find somebody, they find them. I've only heard it as a rumor myself."

I had no real thought about that answer, hearing it. I supposed that someone whose work was finding people might reasonably write their own name. No one would ask someone to find a person for them without knowing who was asking.

That was a naive thought. That night I didn't even know it was naive. I had simply set one fact next to another — that the record of the person who'd written a name eleven years ago had stopped, and that there was, now, one person who wrote a name. There might have been no connection at all between the two. I knew that even then.

And still I set the two side by side. It's hard to explain why. Maybe after three hours alone in the reading room changing search terms, you start wanting to connect at least one thing to another. I know that

isn't an honest way to think. I'm setting down here, anyway, that I did it.

. . .

On my way home I passed the water channel. The western ditch was still making its sound. I stood beside it for a moment and thought about that person from eleven years ago.

A name had been written. A new deliberation had opened. Part of it had been reversed. And then, called in again and again, until one summer day the record simply stopped.

I told my aunt about this that night. She listened a long while and said, "…So nobody knows what became of that person?" I said that was right. My aunt said, "…Then it's unknown, Hora. Don't decide something bad happened."

My aunt was right. I had already decided, by then. That something bad had happened. There was no basis for it. Knowing full well that absence itself can't be evidence, I still read it that way.

Writing this book, I look back on this passage more than once. This was probably the first time I went against Tyche's logic. That day Tyche had told me about probability, and I thought I'd found a hole that probability couldn't explain. Looking at it now, that too was a mistake. It wasn't a hole. It was simply an ending.

Whether it was my nature, or my mother, or having stared too long at that empty signature box, I still don't know for certain. But I know one thing. Tyche spoke of probability that day, and I couldn't refute it. And still I kept looking for that document. Being unable to refute something didn't make me stop.

That name — the one the clerk had told me, the person who still wrote a name these days — I copied onto paper. I put it back in the drawer where my mother's papers were kept.

Before I closed the drawer, I copied that other name, the one from eleven years ago, onto the same paper. Setting the two names side by side, there was nothing alike about them at all. Different surnames, different numbers of syllables. And still I looked at those two lines for a long while.

Looking back now, I think I had already decided something, that day. I still didn't know what had become of the person from eleven years ago. But I couldn't leave that not-knowing as simply not-knowing. I needed to find one more name and set it up alongside, to feel settled. What would Tyche have called this? Probably "a meaningless connection." If Tyche had said that, I wouldn't have been able to refute her. I had no basis to.

And still I put that paper in the drawer. That there are things you do without a basis — I learned that for the first time, then.

I slept well that night. I don't know why. It wasn't because I'd found an answer. Not one answer had come out of it. It was only that what I would do the next day was decided, and that, I think, was what settled me. In this city there are nights when just knowing what tomorrow holds is enough to set your mind at ease.

The next day, I went looking for that person.

(Continued in Chapter 26.)

Chapter 26. Temel

> *_Previously_ — Eleven years ago, there was a person who wrote a name.*
> *That person opened a new deliberation, reversed part of a matter, and*
> *was afterward called in again and again, until one summer day the record stopped. I heard there was still, these days, a person who wrote a name, and I copied that name onto paper.*

I didn't know how to go about finding a person. There was almost never a reason to look for someone in this city. Whoever you needed was always on the roster, and the roster had an address. You went to the address and the person was there. That was all there was to it.

But the person the clerk had told me about wasn't on the roster. Of course not, since I'd been told they weren't from this city. I went to the front desk and asked about visitor records.

"…We don't keep separate visitor records. Only residents go on the roster."

"…Then how do I find someone who comes and goes?"

"…Well. There's no way but to ask someone who's seen them."

Hearing that answer, I laughed a little. For all the Consensus's transparency, this city had no way to find a single person. I only understood later. The Consensus was transparent about what came before a deliberation. A person who'd never come before one wasn't, to begin with, something the Consensus had any business with.

It was exactly like the water channel. If it had never been brought up, it was as good as not existing.

The person at the desk must have felt a little sorry for me, because she added one more thing.

"…Oh — there is someone who's been coming and going lately. Every time they file an application they always write their name, so everyone remembers them."

"…Do they have a lot of applications to file?"

"…I hear they do work finding people. They apply for the reading room often too."

I asked right then.

"…Where would I go to meet them?"

"…Hmm. Somebody said they'd seen them around the market."

I wondered whether that much could really lead me to a person. But this city ran that way. The records were flawless, and whatever wasn't in the records had to be found by rumor. Strangely enough, that felt like the most human part of this city.

For three days I went from district to district asking people. I must have asked around thirty. Most said they didn't know. Two said "I think I've seen them." One person told me, "I think they're around the north market these days."

. . .

The north market was the loudest place in the Equity. Everyone said that even at its loudest, it would sound quiet next to another city, but to me it was the loud one.

That person was standing at the far end of the market, in front of the public notice board. City notices were posted there, and beside them was one more small sheet, posted by no one I could name. It began, "Looking for a person."

They were neither tall nor short. Looked to be in their mid-thirties. Their clothes were worn but clean. Their face carried no particular expression. I don't mean that unkindly. It was simply true. Not angry, not glad to see me — they just stood there.

They had a bag slung over one shoulder, with a bundle of paper sticking out the side. It looked folded and refolded many times, as though it had been carried a long while. Their shoes were worn too. Not shoes from this city. This city's shoes all came from the same place, and those were a different shape.

Looking back now, I remember those shoes for a surprisingly long time. That detail stayed with me, oddly. I think I recognized a stranger from the shoes before I did from the face.

I went up and asked.

"…Excuse me — are you the one who writes a name?"

The person looked at me. Their face went thoughtful for a moment.

"…Write what?"

"…On a document. In the signature box."

"…Ah, I do. Why?"

Their tone was flat. Not wary of me, not curious about me either. Just a tone confirming a fact.

"…What's your name?"

The person said a name. It was the name the clerk had told me.

"…Temel."

. . .

I stood there a moment not knowing what to ask. Temel didn't press me either. He looked back at the notice board.

"…Did you put this up?"

"…Yes. I do work finding people."

"…What kind of people?"

"…People I'm asked about. When a family's been scattered, or word's been lost, and someone asks me to find that person, I go find them."

"…Are you from this city?"

"…No. I go from place to place. This is my — I don't know how many times already, coming through here."

The way he spoke was plain. It didn't sound like he was hiding anything, or exaggerating anything. I found that oddly unfamiliar. Everyone in the Equity was used to speaking with themselves one step removed — "It was passed on," "It was put in order" — but this man just said "I go find them." There was a subject.

I found that remarkable, then. Looking back on it now, it wasn't remarkable at all. He just wasn't from this city. He simply wasn't used to this city's grammar. And still, in that moment, it felt like meeting someone entirely different.

I looked at the sheet on the board again. "Looking for a person. If you know their name, their last known whereabouts, or any identifying feature, please contact the address below." The name written under it wasn't a name from this city.

"…Have you found this person?"

"…Not yet. I've been here three days now."

"…What happens if you don't find them?"

"…I go to the next city. Look there too."

"…What about the person here, then? The one you didn't find?"

Temel looked at the board once and said,

"…I leave the sheet. Someone might see it later and get in touch."

"…Does that happen?"

"…Sometimes. Very rarely."

He said "very rarely" as though it were nothing at all. No trace of disappointment, no trace of giving up. He just seemed like someone who'd lived by that kind of probability.

"…So do you file an application to find someone in this city too?"

"…Yes. Filed one yesterday."

"…Did you write your name in the signature box there?"

Temel gave me a slightly puzzled look.

"…It doesn't get accepted unless you do."

"…No, I mean — in this city, everyone leaves that box blank."

"…Blank? Why?"

I probably made just as puzzled a face, that time.

"…I don't know. Nobody writes it."

Temel looked at the board for a moment and said,

"…If there's a box to write in, don't you write in it?"

. . .

That was so simple, I couldn't answer for a moment.

Writing this record, I've read that line over many times. "If there's a box to write in, don't you write in it?" That wasn't a question. He didn't ask it because he was genuinely curious — it was something that came out of him because to him, it was simply obvious. It wasn't obvious to me. That difference in what was obvious was the difference between this city and his.

I didn't know how to answer, so I asked something else. I felt like I should ask more, but I couldn't get straight what to ask.

"…What happens if you write your name on an application? Some people here are afraid of it."

Temel shrugged a little.

"…You get called in, sure. Every matter with that name on it, they call you."

"…Are you all right with that?"

"…Not so much all right as used to it. I've been through it plenty of times, in plenty of cities."

His face stayed the same the whole time he said it. Not resentful, not proud. Just a face stating a fact.

"…So how many times have you already been called in here?"

"…This time? Twice. I only filed a day ago and they've already called me in twice."

"…Twice already? For what?"

"…Once to confirm the application's contents. Once for another department to confirm the same thing. They ask the same thing twice, but I've come to expect it."

"…You've come to expect it?"

"…At first it annoyed me a bit. But being annoyed doesn't stop them from calling either."

There was no resignation in that, and no patience — just a plain familiarity. Like a rhythm worn into the body from long practice. That frightened me. More than the irritation or the anger would have, that flatness frightened me. I wondered how many times something had to happen to a person before they got like that.

I thought about bringing up the name from eleven years ago, then didn't. I still had nothing certain. Instead I asked something else.

"…Do you know why people in this city don't write their names?"

"…No idea. I'm not from here."

"…What about other cities, then? Do other cities not write names either?"

"…Depends on the city. A place where it's completely blank, like here — this is the first I've seen."

"…Oh — first time?"

"…Yeah. Usually a few people write it. Not everyone, but some. Here it's really none at all, far as I've checked."

That surprised me a little. It meant this city wasn't just especially blank — other cities still had a few people who wrote. So was this city unusually far gone, or was it simply a different way of doing things? I didn't get the answer that day.

"…So why do you write it, then? You don't have to here."

Temel looked at me for a moment. There was nothing particular in that look. He was simply looking at me.

"…Let's talk about that another time. I need to go find someone, right now."

Then he tore a sheet from the board, folded it, and tucked it away, and walked off toward the market. I watched his back for a long while.

A woman running a stall nearby spoke to me.

"…Do you know that man?"

"…Just met him today."

"…He's an odd one. Only been here a few days and I couldn't tell you how many times he's already been called into the office. But he never once gets angry about it."

"…Guess he's just made that way."

"…Right? If it were me, I'd have lost my temper a long time ago."

The woman went off then to see to a customer. I stood there a while longer. The market noise grew loud again around me — vegetables being sold, prices being haggled over, a child crying. It was a loud place, for this city.

The people of this city didn't look at Temel strangely. They found him curious, but not something to be wary of. I found that a little strange myself. Isn't the usual thing, when you see someone doing something different from everyone else, to grow wary first? But here people were simply curious. They didn't feel him as a threat. Probably because writing a name wasn't treated as anything large enough in this city to be a threat. It wasn't that it wasn't frightening because it wasn't a big thing — it was that no one had ever done it, so no one knew how big a thing it was.

. . .

On the way home I turned over what had happened that day. Nothing unusual had happened. I'd met one person, and exchanged a few words. That was all.

And still I slept badly that night. It's hard to say exactly why. Probably because he was too ordinary. I think I'd been assuming, without meaning to, that someone who wrote a name would look different somehow. A different look in the eyes, maybe, or a heavier way of speaking. Temel had none of that. He was simply a tired man. A little worn, a little flat, with only the plainness particular to someone who'd done this work of finding people for a long time.

I thought something else, that night. If Temel wasn't writing a name because he was something special, that meant I could write one too. The moment that thought came, my body went a little stiff. I hurried to put the thought away. I told myself it was still too soon. At the time, I really believed that.

I've felt the temptation, more than once, to make Temel out to be something special in this record. Someone who knew something, someone who already had it all figured out. But that isn't the truth. Temel was, then and now, simply someone who wrote a name. That was all he was, and that, strangely, was the strangest thing about him.

I'm writing this record much later, after everything has already passed. So there are moments when the temptation comes to slip in, as though I knew it at the time, things I didn't actually know then. That's especially true when it comes to Temel. But I've decided to resist that temptation, here. The person I was that day didn't know who Temel was. I stayed not knowing for a long time, even after meeting him several times more. So it seems more honest to write it here, too, not knowing.

I told my aunt about that day, and she asked,

"…What does that man do?"

"…Finds people."

"…There's work like that?"

"…Apparently. He's not from here, she said."

My aunt wasn't especially surprised. She just said, "…That's interesting," and let it go. My aunt was never one to be surprised by much.

"…But Hora, why did you go to meet him?"

I thought a moment before answering. I wasn't entirely sure myself what I'd gone hoping to find out.

"…No reason. I just wanted to see what kind of person writes a name."

"…And did you?"

"…I did, but I still don't know. He was just an ordinary person."

"…An ordinary person doing a strange thing, then."

My aunt's words stayed with me the whole night. An ordinary person doing a strange thing. If it had been a strange person doing a strange thing, I probably would have thought less about it. Temel had truly looked ordinary. And yet he was doing, without a second thought, something no one in this city ever did.

That night I opened the drawer and looked again at the paper with the two names on it. The person from eleven years ago, and Temel. Their handwriting was different, their ages were different, the paths that had brought them here were different. No connection between them had been confirmed yet. And still I stared at those two names for a long while.

I would go on to meet Temel several more times after this day. Each time, I think I expected him to tell me something remarkable. But Temel never once did that. He was simply a person who wrote his name, got called in, and went on to the next city. That was all he was, and it took me a long time to truly see that "all."

The next day, I went back to the north market.

(Continued in Chapter 27.)

Chapter 27. Why Do You Write It

> *_Previously_ — I met Temel at the north market. He was a man who*
> *moved from city to city doing work finding people, and in this city too he had written his own name on an application. "If there's a box*
> *to write in, don't you write in it?" That was so simple, I couldn't answer.*

The next day, Temel was in the same spot. In front of the notice board, in almost the same posture as the day before. The sheets were one fewer than yesterday. One new sheet had been added too.

I went straight to the market after school that day. I told my aunt I needed to read more district materials. That wasn't entirely a lie. I really was going to read something. It's only that it wasn't a document — it was a person.

A few other people besides Temel were standing at the board. They all seemed to have come to check their own notices. Nobody paid Temel any attention.

"…Back again."

"…Yes. There's still something I wanted to ask."

Temel took his hand off the board and looked at me. There was no annoyance in his face. Just a look that was making time for me.

"…What do you want to know?"

"…What I asked yesterday. Why do you write it? You don't have to."

But first, curious about the missing sheet, I asked that instead.

"…Did you find someone?"

"…No. The time limit passed, so it came down. That's the rule here. After ten days it has to come off the board."

"…What about that person, then?"

"…I keep looking. Other ways. The board's just one way among several."

. . .

Temel seemed to think a moment, then gave the same short answer as yesterday.

"…Because there's a box to write in."

"…That's all?"

"…Yes."

I felt that answer wasn't enough. I thought there had to be more. Some conviction, some principle, some resolve formed out of something he'd been through. But I saw nothing like that on Temel's face. It really was a face for whom that was all there was.

"…But nobody writes it. Here."

"…That's exactly what makes it stranger, to me. That there's a box and nobody uses it."

"…That's strange to you?"

"…Where I'm from, it was. If there was a box, you put something in it. Right or wrong, good or bad. Leaving it blank meant the box lost its meaning."

I turned this over for a long time. I'm turning it over even now, writing this record. Leaving a box blank makes the box lose its meaning. I thought about the opposite too. Couldn't leaving a box blank make that box grow heavier instead? That's how it was in this city. If it had been filled, I never would have known how heavy that empty signature box could be.

"…What was the place you're from like?"

"…I've lived in a lot of places. Not just one."

"…Where do you live now, then?"

"…It's hard to say I live anywhere in particular. I keep moving."

"…Isn't it lonely?"

Temel didn't answer right away. He looked toward the market for a moment and said,

"…Sometimes. But there are times I meet the person I was looking for, and that's what gets me through."

"…Do you meet them often?"

"…No. Not often. But sometimes."

I could only guess at what was folded into that "sometimes." I didn't ask further. I'd learned in this city that some questions are better

left unasked, out of respect.

. . .

"…So what was good about writing your name here?"

Asking this, I expected a good answer. Something along the lines of having gained something this city couldn't give.

Temel smiled a little at the question. It was an expression I hadn't seen from him before.

"…Nothing good, particularly."

"…Nothing?"

"…No. All I got was being called in, over and over. But that's something you brace for going in."

"…Then why do you keep writing it?"

"…Well. Writing it is my work. That's what finding people is. You have to file an application to find someone, and the application needs a name."

"…Not that. You're not even from here. Why bother?"

Temel looked at me for a moment. His face searched for an answer.

"…It's just habit, I suppose. I do it wherever I go."

"…Was it always like that?"

"…No. At first I didn't write it either."

That surprised me a little.

"…When did you start, then?"

"…A long time ago. I fell apart once, when I was young."

"…Fell apart?"

"…I misjudged something badly, once. After that there was a time I lived as if running from it. Then when I came back, I started writing it."

Temel told this very briefly. His tone made me hesitant to ask more. I didn't ask more.

"…What do you mean, came back?"

"…Just that — I mean I decided to start again. Whenever I start something over, I write my name first. That's my way of doing it."

I stopped more than once, writing this passage. Even now I still feel the urge to press further into what happened to Temel. But I didn't press him that day, and I can't write more than this in this record either. Leaving what's unknown as unknown seems like the right way to treat this person, at least.

Temel looked back at the board, as if changing the subject.

"…So is everything in this city like that — this business with the signature box, and everything else too?"

"…Like what?"

"…Where there's no one doing anything, but there's still a result."

I thought about that for a moment. The Consensus, the four hundred people, passing it on and putting it in order and confirming. All of it fit.

"…Yes. Exactly like that."

"…That's something. I've never seen a city like this."

"…Something, or strange?"

Temel smiled a little.

"…Both."

That smile was the only light moment in the whole conversation that day. It was only seeing him smile that I truly felt how flatly he'd been saying such heavy things until then.

I think I was a little disappointed by this answer, at the time. I'd expected some bigger reason. I'm ashamed of that disappointment now. I myself read to the end simply out of habit, and yet I wanted a bigger reason out of someone else.

. . .

Just then, a person passed by beside us. He was a man in worn clothes, walking slowly, headed straight for somewhere. He glanced once at the notice board and passed on without a word. I looked at him for a moment, but there was nothing remarkable about him, and I soon turned back to Temel.

"…So how many applications have your name on them right now?"

"…In this city alone? Three."

"…Three means how many times you get called in?"

"…Two more scheduled by tomorrow."

"…Isn't it hard?"

Temel shrugged slightly.

"…It's hard. But hard and not doing it are two different problems."

That was a short answer, but I held onto it for a long time.

. . .

"…Could I write it too, then?"

The question came out of me before I knew it. I surprised even myself, asking it.

Temel looked straight at me. It was the first time his face had turned serious.

"…You could. If there's a box."

"…What happens if I write it, though?"

"…You'd end up like me, probably. Called in."

"…Not that. What else changes?"

This time Temel didn't answer right away. He looked at the board for a moment and said,

"…I don't know that either. What I wrote is something that happened to me. Not something that's going to happen to you, Hora."

It was the first time he'd said my name. I don't remember when he learned it. He must have asked at the front desk. That was how this city worked.

That day, for the first time, I asked someone other than myself what happens if you write it. And for the first time, I heard the answer, "I don't know." I thought it was nothing much of an answer at the time. I would come to learn later just how different a weight this "I don't know" could carry. That's a story for later.

The sun was starting to lean. It was the hour the market began winding down. I brought up the signature box a little more before I left.

"…Why do you think nobody in this city writes it? What do you think?"

"…I don't really know for sure. But the other places I've seen had similar reasons, I think."

"…What reasons?"

"…If you write it, it becomes yours. Whether it's good or bad. Leave it blank, and it's just something that happened — it belongs to no one."

"…Isn't that comfortable, though? If it belongs to no one, nobody gets wronged."

"…That's right. That's why everyone does it that way. It isn't a bad thing. I envy that, myself, sometimes."

"…You envy it?"

"…Yes. Every time, something becomes mine. It would be easier for me too, if I didn't write it. But I've found I can't."

"…Why can't you?"

Temel was quiet a moment. Then he answered, briefly.

"…I've tried not writing it, once. That was the worst it's ever been."

. . .

"…So you never know, every single time?"

"…Right. Every time, I don't know. I don't know each time I write it."

"…How do you write it if you don't know?"

Temel shrugged again. It felt slightly different this time.

"…Not knowing isn't a reason not to write it."

Hearing that, I couldn't say anything for a moment. The market noise went on around us. Someone haggling, a cart being pulled. I stood in that noise turning that one line over and over.

Not knowing isn't a reason not to write it.

I copied that sentence onto paper that evening. I put it in the drawer with my mother's papers. That drawer now held two names and one sentence.

I imagine that drawer sometimes. Twelve pages my mother left behind, and the short notes I'd laid on top of them, one at a time. My mother could never have imagined other people's names piling up on top of her own papers. And yet, strangely, I didn't mind that drawer growing heavier little by little. If anything, it felt like that drawer was becoming something that no longer belonged only to me.

I didn't open that drawer often. I only opened it when there was something new to put in. That day was one of those days.

"…Doesn't it get old, being checked on like that every time?"

"…It does. But I can't just not go because I'm tired of it. If I don't go, the application itself falls behind."

"…What happens if it falls behind?"

"…I find the person I'm looking for that much later. That's the part I hate most."

"…Will you be here tomorrow too?"

"…Probably. Until the application's been processed."

"…When does that finish?"

"…I don't know. This place has a lot of confirmation steps."

"…So you'll be here a while longer, then."

"…Seems that way. No hurry, though. The person I'm looking for might be somewhere around here too."

Hearing that, I felt something strange. Temel was taking a loss and not even calling it a loss. He simply accepted it as something that

took time. I couldn't tell, that day, whether that was resignation or ease.

I said goodbye and left. Walking away, I looked back once. Temel was looking at the board again.

On my way home I stopped by the front desk and asked what the matters were that kept calling Temel in. The clerk looked at the screen and said,

"…Confirmation, confirmation, confirmation. All three of them."

"…Confirming what?"

"…Whether the application's contents match, whether he's really who he says he is, that sort of thing."

"…They confirm the same thing every time?"

"…Seems that way. I don't know why, myself."

"…Isn't that strange? Why confirm something that's already been confirmed?"

"…I don't know. I've thought it was strange myself, but I've never found a way to stop it. It's a procedure written into the regulations."

"…Why is it written that way in the regulations?"

"…That's beyond me too. I didn't set it."

Hearing that answer, I thought of the other answers I'd heard around this city for months. It was passed on. It was put in order. It was convened. The clerk's answer had the same grain to it. No one had set it, and only the confirming went on.

Leaving that spot, I felt I'd come to know one thing for certain. Temel was someone who kept writing it, knowing full well it cost him, and the reason was simple. There was a box. And yet that very simplicity was what held me the longest.

Hearing this conversation, I could dimly guess at what would happen the next day. Whether that guess was right, the next chapter will show.

At home over dinner, I told Tyche briefly what had happened that day. Tyche didn't eat with us that evening, but when we ran into each other in front of the district hall the next morning, she brought it up again.

"…Does he really keep getting called in like that?"

"…Yes. Three matters have his name on them."

"…That tells you why nobody writes it, doesn't it?"

"…I guess so."

"…So why does he keep writing it, then? It costs him."

"…I don't know. He said it was just habit."

Tyche tilted her head.

"…Habit basically means there's no real reason, doesn't it? So he's just taking a loss over and over, for no real reason."

I couldn't answer that. What Tyche said didn't seem wrong. But something felt missing. I couldn't explain, then, what it was.

I think I can say a little now. Tyche asked for a reason, and Temel said there wasn't one. But having no reason and having nothing at all aren't the same thing. Temel had no reason, but he had a way. The way of writing it every time. I wonder now whether that way was standing in for the reason. I hadn't worked it out this far, back then.

(Continued in Chapter 28.)

Chapter 28. The One Who Keeps Being Called In

> *_Previously_ — Temel wrote his name on every application. "Not knowing isn't a reason not to write it." He said that name kept getting him called in for confirmation after confirmation. Tyche called it "a loss," and I couldn't refute her.*

The next day, I went back to the market again after school. I wasn't going to see Temel. I wanted to see what the confirmations looked like — the ones he'd said would call him in "two more times."

I asked at the front desk about the schedule, and one happened to be set for that afternoon. Since I had no district business at that hour, I asked whether I could tag along. The desk clerk didn't find it odd and said I could.

"…How long do these usually run, start to finish?"

"…Depends on the matter. Ten minutes if it's short, up to thirty if it's long."

"…How many can be scheduled in a day?"

"…He's only got one today. But if several departments are involved, some people have two or three in a day."

"…Does that happen often — someone like that?"

"…Not often. People who write their names are rare to begin with."

Hearing that, I confirmed again just how unfamiliar a sight this was in this city. It seemed so unfamiliar that no one had ever seriously thought about what it meant.

"…Is watching one of these normally allowed?"

"…It's not closed. Everything here is open."

That answer sounded obvious to me at the time. Looking back now, all of this city's dread is contained in that one line. It wasn't closed. Nothing was hidden. And still it was frightening.

Up until then I'd thought fear came from things that were hidden. Frightening because you couldn't see it, frightening because it was done in secret. This city was the reverse. There were frightening things you could see all of, in full. I saw that with my own eyes for the first time that day.

. . .

The confirmation room was small. One table, three chairs. One official sat there, and Temel sat across from him. I sat in a chair in the corner and watched.

Nothing was on the walls. There was one window, but like the meeting hall's windows, it didn't show the outside. Every building in this city was built this way. It didn't seem meant to keep the inside from being seen — it was simply the kind of window this city used. Looking at that window, I thought there probably wasn't another city with so many windows you couldn't see out of.

The air was cool. Rooms like this were always a little cool. Whether that was because no one was meant to stay long, or because there was

simply no heating at all, I didn't know.

The official opened a folder.

"…I'll confirm the application number. Your name is Mr. Temel, correct?"

"…Yes."

"…And the filing date was four days ago, correct."

"…Yes."

"…And the application's content is a request to confirm a person's whereabouts, is that right?"

"…Yes, that's right."

The official turned to the next page.

"…This was already confirmed yesterday, but it needs confirming again today. I apologize."

"…That's fine."

This exchange went on for about ten minutes. The questions were almost identical to yesterday's. Listening beside them, I thought something was wrong, but neither the official nor Temel seemed to find it strange at all.

. . .

The official asked for a signature. Temel wrote his name in the field at the bottom of the confirmation sheet. His hand moved quickly,

practiced. Watching him, I felt again how thoroughly writing a name had become second nature to this man.

The official stamped the sheet once and put the papers in order.

"…That concludes today's matter. Thank you."

"…Yes, thank you."

They thanked each other. I found that strange to hear. I couldn't tell what either of them had to be thankful for, and yet both seemed to mean it sincerely.

Once the confirmation was over, the official said,

"…The next confirmation is set for the day after tomorrow."

"…Again?"

"…This matter goes through three related departments. Each department has to confirm it once."

"…Can't they all confirm it together, at once?"

The official checked the papers once and answered.

"…There's no procedure for doing it that way."

"…If there isn't one, can't one be made?"

"…That isn't within my authority."

That answer nearly made me laugh. Not because it was funny — because it was too familiar. I only passed it on. I only put it in order. And

now, that isn't within my authority. It felt like every phrase I'd heard in months in this city had gathered together, right here.

I couldn't bring myself to hate that official. He wasn't a bad person. He was even kind. He read the papers carefully, and when he apologized his face was sincerely sorry. And still, the work he did was to make the exact same thing get confirmed three times over.

I asked the official something too.

"…Doesn't it wear on you, confirming the same thing every time like this?"

The official looked a little flustered. It seemed to be the first time anyone had asked him that.

"…I… I'm only carrying out the procedure I've been assigned."

"…But this is already how many times this person's come here."

"…That isn't something I have visibility into. I only see today's matter."

"…Only today's?"

"…Yes. There's no one who sees the whole picture. Each matter is handled separately, by its own department."

This may have been the most important answer in this chapter. That there is no one who sees the whole. The official only saw today's matter, and yesterday's official had probably only seen yesterday's. No one had the whole picture of how many times Temel had been called in that week. I was the only one who knew. And that was only because I had followed him around.

. . .

Coming out of the confirmation room, I asked Temel,

"…Is that all? Is that really the whole of what it means, being called in?"

"…Yes. That's all there is to it."

"…It's less than I expected."

Temel smiled a little.

"…That's right. Not much to it. But it keeps happening."

"…How long does it keep happening?"

"…As long as the application's still open. I've got my name on three matters here, so until all three finish."

"…Do they finish, though?"

"…Usually. But if a new matter comes up, that keeps going too."

"…So it could never end?"

This time Temel didn't answer right away. He walked a moment and said,

"…Could be. I don't know either."

I let that "I don't know" pass without much thought, at the time. I only realized later how often, and how calmly, this man said "I don't know." It wasn't evasion. It was said because he truly didn't know.

"…Is it only like this in this city? Aren't other cities not this bad?"

"…Depends on the city. Some finish with one confirmation. Some go longer."

"…Which is this one?"

"…The long kind. I think it's probably because of how the departments are divided. The more it's split up, the more people there are to confirm it."

"…So what if the departments weren't split up?"

"…Then one department would have to carry the whole thing, and that would be a problem too, probably. I'm not in a position to say which way is better."

Temel's pace stayed unhurried even as he said this. No sign of rushing at all. I found that strangely enviable. I think I'd have been angry by then, in his place.

"…Doesn't it make you angry?"

"…It did, the first few times. Now I just tend to save the energy I'd spend being angry."

"…Save it for what?"

"…For the next city."

. . .

That evening, Temel was called in again for another matter. A different building this time, a different official. I went along again. The room's layout was nearly identical. One table, three chairs, a window you couldn't see through.

"…I'll reconfirm the application number. Your name is…"

"…Temel."

"…Yes, Mr. Temel. Apart from the previous confirmation, this department needs to verify your identity again, please."

"…Yes."

"…What you're confirming today concerns the estimated district of residence. Please confirm whether it matches what you told us before."

"…Yes, it matches."

"…Thank you. Your signature, please."

Temel wrote his name again. I watched him do it once more. The same hand movement as before. The same expression. There was weariness in it, but no irritation.

Out in the hallway, other people were waiting their turn. They all held papers, and they were all quiet. It was an ordinary sight in this city. The only difference was that those people needed to come only once, and Temel needed to come many times.

Coming out of this room, I asked,

"…How is this different from the one before?"

"…Different department. That one was the whereabouts-confirmation department. This is the residence-district-confirmation department."

"…But they asked the exact same thing."

"…They did. But since it's a different department, they each have to confirm it separately, I suppose."

"…How many more departments are left?"

"…One more. Tomorrow."

Writing this passage, I count the numbers again. Three applications, a confirmation from each department, and it repeating. How many times a single application could get someone called in — I made my first rough estimate that day. It looked like it would come to at least ten times over. And that was for only one of the three matters.

That day, I understood exactly what review was.

It wasn't punishment. There was no fine. No prison. No one laid a hand on Temel. No one raised their voice. The confirmation rooms were pleasant places, and every official knew how to apologize.

And yet it never ended.

As long as a document with a name on it existed somewhere, every person and every department handling that document had to confirm that name. Confirmation was a procedure, and the procedure was correct. No one did anything wrong. And yet all those correct things, gathered together, added up to calling one person in, over and over.

I wanted to call this a punishment. Calling it a punishment would make it clear, somehow. But it wasn't punishment. A punishment has to be a punishment someone decided on, and this was something that simply

kept going, decided by no one. That day, for the first time, I thought this was more frightening than a punishment.

That day I went home and told my aunt all of it. The confirmation room, the window, the signature, the second room, the third room. My aunt listened quietly and said,

"…Is there a fine, or isn't there?"

"…No fine."

"…Does he go to prison?"

"…No."

"…Does anyone hit him?"

"…No. No one lays a hand on him."

My aunt thought for a moment and said,

"…Then what's frightening about it, Hora? That's just an inconvenience."

I couldn't refute her right away. She was right. No fine, no prison, no violence. "Inconvenience" wasn't a wrong word for it.

And still I kept thinking about that "inconvenience," that night. An inconvenience two or three times a day, repeated for months, years. Could that really stay just an inconvenience? I didn't think so. But I couldn't find the words to explain that to my aunt, then.

My aunt asked again.

"…But why does that man keep writing it? He could just stop."

"…He said every application needs a name. That's what the work of finding people is."

"…Then he should just not do that work."

"…Then he can't find anyone."

My aunt didn't answer that. Instead she looked at me a long while and said,

"…You're seeing a lot of that man lately."

"…I am."

"…Why?"

I couldn't answer that question right away. It was too many visits already to say it was just curiosity, and I wasn't even sure what I wanted to find out, to say I was trying to learn something.

"…I don't know. I just keep wanting to see him."

My aunt didn't press further. She just nodded and turned off the light. I lay awake a long while in the dark.

. . .

On the way home, Temel had asked me,

"…Why do you come watch this, Hora?"

"…I'm curious. What happens if you write a name."

"…Do you know now?"

"…A little. But I'm still not sure."

"…Not sure of what?"

"…Why this is so frightening. When nothing even happens."

Temel nodded.

"…That's right. Nothing happens. That's all there is."

Hearing that, I stopped walking. Temel stopped too.

"…But it keeps not happening. That's the problem."

I held onto that line for a long time. It keeps not happening. Not that something bad happens, but that nothing happening keeps happening, over and over. I saw that day, for the first time, how much that could wear a person down, in this city.

That night, once home, I opened the drawer again. The one holding two names and one sentence. I put nothing in it that night. Instead I just looked into it for a long while.

Writing this chapter, I confirm again why this city is truly frightening. No one did anything wrong. And yet a person truly did end up called in without end. I learned here that this can happen even without a villain.

I bring up this drawer more than once in this book. I wrote that I put nothing in it that night, but in truth I nearly did put something in. The sentence was "There is no one who sees the whole." I took the paper out, and in the end put it back without writing it. It was because I still wasn't certain what it meant.

The next morning, I told Tyche what I'd seen the day before. Tyche listened quietly and said,

"…That's not a bad thing, is it. It's just that there are several confirmation steps."

"…But it keeps happening."

"…That's probability. The more matters with a name on them, the more there is to confirm. It isn't strange."

I couldn't answer that. Tyche was right again. And yet, standing before that rightness, I couldn't shake the feeling that something was missing.

(Continued in Chapter 29.)

Chapter 29. Tyche's Logic

> *_Previously_ — I watched Temel go in and out of the confirmation rooms. No fine, no prison. Only, it never ended. Tyche called it "just probability rising," and I couldn't refute her.*

That afternoon, sorting district materials, I was left alone with Tyche. The meeting hall was quiet. Everyone else had gone ahead, and several unsorted folders were still stacked on the desk. Tyche brought it up without much thought, while sorting papers.

"…You talk about that man a lot lately, Hora."

"…Temel?"

"…Yes. You go to the market every day, I hear."

"…There's a lot I'm curious about."

Tyche turned a page of the document in her hand and said,

"…I find that a little strange. What's there to be so curious about? You've seen everything he does — writes his name, gets called in. That's all there is."

. . .

That stung a little, hearing it. But there wasn't really a reason for it to sting. Tyche wasn't angry. She was genuinely asking out of curiosity.

Tyche had been born and raised in this city. Her parents had been born here too, I'd heard. She hadn't been assigned here suddenly one day like me — she'd grown up going in and out of the district hall since she was small. Maybe because of that, Tyche seemed to have rarely doubted this city's ways. That she didn't doubt them didn't mean she was unthinking. It was the opposite. Tyche examined things more carefully than anyone I knew. It was only that what she found, more often than not, matched how this city worked.

"…I don't think that's all there is."

"…What else is there?"

"…I don't know. I just want to know why he lives that way."

Tyche stopped what she was doing and looked at me.

"…You keep trying to find a reason, Hora, but I don't think there is one."

"…There isn't?"

"…No. He just lives that way. Maybe he learned it that way as a child, or it worked for him in some city, or maybe it's just habit. The reasons are all on that level. Nothing grand."

. . .

I wanted to refute Tyche, at this point. But I had nothing to refute her with. Everything she'd said could all be true. Temel himself had said, "It's just habit, I suppose."

I thought of the names I'd kept in the drawer.

"…What about that person we found in the reading room, then? The one who wrote a name eleven years ago."

Tyche tilted her head.

"…I heard about that. Same thing. That person was just there, a situation came up that called for an objection, and they wrote their name. Not because they were someone special — the person who happened to be there did what they did."

"…What about the record stopping afterward, though? That doesn't get explained."

"…It didn't stop — it's just not there, Hora, you said so yourself. Not there is just not there. They could have moved. Could have changed their name. You're the one attaching meaning to it, not the record."

I was caught wordless for a moment, hearing that. Tyche was right. I had attached the meaning. The record had simply ended.

"…But Tyche, why are you so sure of that? That there's no reason?"

Tyche thought a moment and said,

"…It's not that I'm sure — it's just the simplest explanation. I think of the simple reason before the complicated one. Usually the simple one turns out right."

"…Always?"

"…Nearly always. That's what I've seen working here for years. Even things that look strange turn out to be nothing much, once you dig into them. A vacancy, a number, probability. That explains almost everything."

. . .

Since it had come up, I asked what I'd been wanting to ask.

"…So is that true of my being in this seat too? Just a vacancy, a number, probability?"

Tyche nodded.

"…Yes. Exactly that."

"…No other reason?"

"…None. The person before you quit, your number came up on the roster, and so you sat down. It's the same for me. Me coming here as a deliberation assistant — the person before me transferred elsewhere, the seat opened, and I happened to apply right then. That's all it was."

"…That's all?"

"…Yes. I've wished, myself, that there was some special reason I'm here. But when you actually look, there isn't. There was just a vacancy, and I fit it."

I looked out the window for a moment. The afternoon sun slanted in across the stack of papers. It seemed like even this small thing ran by this city's order, the way everything else did.

"…What about the water channel? Is that probability too?"

"…The water channel isn't even a matter yet, so there's nothing to explain about it. But if I had to say — that's probably nothing much

either. Water flowed from somewhere, followed the land, and ended up here. Nobody sent it here."

"…You're sure?"

"…No, not sure. But it's the most plausible explanation. Compared to someone deliberately building a channel to send water all the way to this city, water just flowing downhill and ending up here is much simpler."

I nodded at that. Tyche was right. I'd confirmed myself, more than once, in this city, that the simple explanation was usually the true one. Why the signature box was blank, why four hundred people were involved — none of it, once you traced it through, turned out to be some complex conspiracy. It was just that the procedure was built that way.

. . .

The sorting had finished by then. Tyche pulled out the next folder and went on talking. Hearing this answer, I felt something strange. Tyche spoke about herself without any bitterness at all. She was calm about it. That held me even more.

"…So doesn't that make you sad, Tyche? Being here for no reason at all?"

Tyche smiled a little at the question. Not mockingly — it was a truly gentle smile.

"…Do you think it would? I'm not sad about it."

"…Why not?"

"…There being no reason doesn't make the work I'm doing now meaningless. I like the work I'm doing now. Why I came here and what I'm doing here are different questions."

That was the first time I heard that distinction stated plainly. Why you came and what you do being different questions. Tyche said it as though it were nothing at all, but I held onto that line for a long time.

"…Then what gets you through the day, Tyche? If there's no reason."

"…Having no reason doesn't mean there's nothing to get through the day on. I just get through it liking what I'm doing today. I liked sorting deliberation materials yesterday, and I'll do work like that today too. That's enough."

"…Enough?"

"…Yes. I don't want much. Not some grand purpose or anything. If today goes well, I'm satisfied with that."

"…That sounds a little lonely, to me."

Tyche smiled slightly at that. It wasn't a teasing smile.

"…Does it? I find it restful, actually. Watching people struggle to find some grand purpose looks harder to me. It seems like they must always feel something's missing."

"…Me?"

"…You're a little like that too, Hora. You keep thinking there must be something more."

I couldn't answer that. It wasn't wrong.

. . .

"…But Tyche, I have thoughts like this sometimes. If all of this is just probability, isn't that a little empty?"

Tyche stopped sorting the papers and looked straight at me. For the first time in this conversation, I watched her seriously choosing her words.

"…Hora — I know you want there to be a meaning. So do I."

I was surprised, hearing that. I hadn't thought Tyche carried a feeling like that.

"…But?"

"…But wanting there to be one isn't evidence that there is."

. . .

I said nothing for a long while, hearing that.

Tyche went on.

"…I heard things like that a lot growing up. That there's a reason this city is a place where nobody's wronged, that it can't be chance. My grandmother used to say things like that too."

"…Why did your grandmother think that?"

"…I don't know. She just did. I grew up hearing it, and as I got older I kept checking it — whether things had turned out this way

because there really was a meaning, or whether they'd simply turned out this way and people had attached a meaning to it afterward."

"…What did you find?"

"…Almost always the latter. A vacancy opens and someone fills it; a procedure exists and things go by the procedure. It was all explained, without any meaning attached."

"…So your grandmother was wrong?"

"…Not wrong, exactly. My grandmother said it because she wanted there to be a meaning. I understand that feeling. I have it too."

I remember this line exactly, even now. Word for word, without a single mistake. Tyche wasn't saying this to win against me. She wasn't trying to persuade me either. She was simply saying what she honestly thought.

"…So do you just throw that wish away, then, Tyche?"

"…I don't throw it away. I just don't use it as evidence. A wish is a wish, and a fact is a fact. I don't want to mix the two."

"…Is it bad to mix them?"

"…If I mix them, I end up seeing only what I want to see. That scares me. Picking out only the things that look like they have meaning, and not seeing the things that don't. In the end that's nothing more than making up the story I want, myself."

. . .

That held me for a long time. Tyche wasn't cynical. If anything, she was a very careful person. Someone working, every single time, not to mix what she wanted with what was true.

"…So you don't believe in anything, Tyche?"

"…No. I believe what's worth believing. That nobody gets wronged when four hundred people are involved — I believe that. Because it's actually true. There's evidence for it."

"…If there's ever evidence that there's a meaning, will you believe that too, someday?"

Tyche thought a moment.

"…If there is, sure. There isn't yet."

"…What could count as evidence?"

Tyche's face turned genuinely thoughtful.

"…I don't know. Honestly, that's the problem for me too — I can't settle on it. I can't decide what standard would let me believe there's a meaning."

"…What if there's no standard?"

"…If there's no standard, then no matter how strange something is, I just end up explaining it away as a strange coincidence. That bothers me a little too. I wonder whether I'll end up not believing anything, no matter what I see."

That answer surprised me. I hadn't known Tyche held this much doubt about her own logic.

"…So you waver sometimes too, Tyche?"

"…Not waver, exactly — I know there could be a hole in my way of thinking. But I can't just believe anything to fill that hole. That seems more dangerous, to me."

. . .

"…Dangerous?"

"…Yes. If I go grabbing at any story to fill one hole, eventually I won't even be able to tell what's real from what I made up myself. That's the thing I'm most afraid of."

Hearing that, I looked at Tyche differently. She'd seemed fearless, but she had a fear of her own kind. It just pointed in a different direction than mine. I was afraid there might be no meaning at all. Tyche was afraid of believing there was a meaning where there wasn't one.

Writing this passage, I feel again how careful a person Tyche was. That's why she's hard to describe in this book. She wasn't a person who didn't believe — she was a person afraid of believing wrongly.

That evening, walking home, I kept turning this conversation over. I wanted to find something to say that would beat Tyche. I couldn't find it. There wasn't a single wrong thing in anything she'd said.

Writing this chapter, I tried again to find something to refute Tyche with. I still can't. Tyche was right. Most things really were explained by a vacancy, a number, probability. I don't deny that. Only, I could never quite bring myself to believe that explanation was everything. I don't know why, myself. Not because I have evidence.

Tyche would have smiled at that sentence. "See — there's no evidence." She'd be right. I still have no answer to that, even now.

I told my aunt about this conversation, and she asked,

"…So what did you say?"

"…I couldn't say anything."

"…Why not?"

"…Because she was right."

My aunt thought a moment and said,

"…Hora, being right doesn't always mean it's a good thing to hear."

"…What does that mean?"

"…Just that — being right doesn't mean it sets your mind at ease."

I thought about that a long time under the blankets that night. Tyche wasn't wrong. But her being right didn't set me at ease. I learned for the first time then that the two could go together.

Writing this chapter, I confirm again that I don't want to paint Tyche badly. Tyche wasn't trying to persuade me. She was only saying what she saw. And after that day, I came to like Tyche even more than before. It sounds strange, but it was true. It was restful, being beside someone honest.

I don't intend, in this whole book, to try to win against Tyche. It doesn't seem to be a matter of winning or losing. Tyche is right, and I feel that I'm right. Both were real. How the two are meant to stand together, I still don't know, now any more than then.

The next morning, I decided to read a document together with Tyche. I was curious what would look different, reading the same document side by side. Tyche agreed without much hesitation.

(Continued in Chapter 30.)

Chapter 30. The Same Document, Different Conclusions

> *_Previously_ — Tyche said she too wished there were a meaning. "But wanting there to be one isn't evidence that there is." I couldn't refute her. The next day, we decided to read the same document side by side.*

The document was a newly assigned deliberation matter. A rezoning to consolidate distribution warehouses in the city's eastern district. On its face it looked like an ordinary piece of administrative housekeeping. About forty pages. I planned, as I always did, to read it start to finish, and Tyche planned, as she always did, to start with the summary and the conclusion. This time we decided to do it side by side, at the same table.

"…We're really doing this together?"

"…Yes. I want to see what looks different."

"…Sounds interesting. I've never done a comparison like this."

Tyche's face was genuinely interested. Not teasing me — curious, because she'd never tried a comparison like this before.

Writing this chapter, I'm being careful. The temptation keeps coming to write that I saw more than Tyche did, here. But that isn't true. I only spent more time. Spending more time doesn't mean seeing more accurately. I'm trying not to forget that, through this whole chapter.

It was afternoon in the meeting hall. Light came in through the window. Everyone else was away for lunch, and only the two of us were left. Two copies of the same document lay side by side on the table.

. . .

We agreed to each read in our own way and meet again after. We hadn't set an order. Tyche simply read first, in her own way. It took her less than ten minutes. Tyche checked the summary, the conclusion, and the progress table.

"…I've gone through it."

"…What do you see?"

"…Intake, review, confirming those involved three times, gathering opinions twice, convening four times. All handled by regulation. No objections filed. Confirmed."

"…That's all?"

"…Yes. Not a single procedural flaw. The confirmation dates all check out, the number of those involved exceeds the requirement, and the convening notice periods were all observed."

Listening to her, I could tell Tyche had read this document with genuine accuracy. Tyche wasn't lying. The document really did say exactly what she'd said.

"…This is a well-made matter, as far as that goes. Consolidating three warehouses cuts the management staff needed and shortens distribution times. It's good for people."

"…Nothing bad in it at all?"

"…Procedurally, no. What I can see is procedure. Whether the outcome turns out good or bad takes time to know, but as far as this document goes, there's no basis to call it bad."

Tyche set the summary down on the table as she said this. I picked up the forty-page original stacked beside it.

. . .

I began reading the forty pages from the start, after that. Tyche waited beside me, sorting other papers. She glanced at me now and then, but didn't rush me.

It took about two hours. The consolidation itself was no problem. Three warehouses were being merged into one, and the distribution procedure would change only slightly.

The problem was on the twenty-eighth page. It said that of the three existing warehouse managers, two would lose their posts in the consolidation. A reassignment procedure was specified, but it said only "according to the individual's wish." How that wish had been confirmed wasn't stated.

I read that part over a few times. That no method of confirmation was stated wasn't itself a flaw — there was no clause requiring the regulations to specify a method.

The three managers' names weren't given. They were listed only by number. One would stay in the new consolidated warehouse; the other two were classified as "reassignment subjects." Of the two reassignment subjects, one would move to a warehouse in another

district, and the other would be moved to office work related to distribution.

I stopped there and looked out the window a moment, then read again the part about the one being moved to office work. Managing a warehouse had originally been physical work, and office work was an entirely different kind of job. Whether this person truly wanted the move, or had gone there simply because no other post was left, the document alone couldn't tell me.

I stopped a long while at this part. If this person had truly wanted the move, there was no problem at all. But whether they had truly wanted it, or whether it had been written that way because there was no other option, this document didn't tell me. That it didn't tell me doesn't mean I could conclude it was the bad case. I know that too.

I kept reading through the rest of the pages. Budget items, changes to logistics routes, adjustments to distribution hours. All unremarkable. Aside from page twenty-eight, there was nothing that caught in my mind in this document, either. I understood why Tyche called this a "well-made matter." Most of it really was well put together.

I wrote earlier that reading all forty pages took two hours; more precisely, half of that time went into reading and rereading those twenty-eight pages several times over. The remaining thirty-nine pages I read in an hour.

. . .

Having read through to the last page, I looked at the bottom field.

The signature box. Blank.

"…Finished?"

"…Yes."

"…What did you see?"

I told her about page twenty-eight. The reassignment of a manager, the phrase "according to the individual's wish," the absence of a confirmation method.

Tyche opened to that page again.

"…This? I saw it too. But this isn't a flaw. Confirming the individual's wish is left to each department's discretion. That the regulations don't specify a method is deliberate. Situations differ by department."

"…But then there's no way to confirm whether that person really wanted it."

"…It's not that there's no way — it means the department handled it on its own judgment. That it isn't written in this document doesn't mean it wasn't done."

. . .

I stopped for a moment, hearing that. Tyche wasn't wrong. Not written down doesn't mean not done. I knew that too. And still that gap kept catching at me.

"…So if I look at that department's documents, would it be confirmed?"

"…There should be one. Should I look?"

Tyche really did get up and go to another reading terminal. She came back about ten minutes later.

"…Found it. A distribution-office placement confirmation form. Here, instead of the individual's signature, there's a record of a verbal confirmation. It says the official spoke to the person directly, and they said they were fine with it."

"…A verbal confirmation?"

"…Yes. That's a valid method of confirmation here too."

I took the confirmation form and read it. It really did say that. No official's name was given — only "confirmed by official." Who that official was, or how they'd asked, wasn't stated.

"…Do you think this is fine too, Tyche?"

"…Yes. It's procedure. A verbal confirmation is one of the official methods. It's in the regulations manual too."

"…But even seeing this, I still don't know whether that person really wanted it."

"…That isn't a question the document can answer, Hora. You'd only know that by asking that person directly."

That was true too. I'd never met that person. I only knew them by number.

"…Don't you ever want to meet that person, Tyche?"

"…Not particularly. What I can see is this far, and I don't think going further is my job."

"…I want to meet them."

"…That's very like you, too."

Tyche wasn't saying that to be sarcastic. She was simply stating a fact. I always wanted to go past the document, and Tyche did exactly what could be done within the document. Both were work this city needed.

"…But this document alone doesn't tell me whether it was really confirmed or not."

"…No, it doesn't. But that isn't this document's problem — you'd have to look at more documents from the related department to know. This document accurately wrote down its own part. There's no reason this document has to take responsibility for another department's work too."

"…So you think this has no problem, then, Tyche?"

"…Yes. By my standard. There's a procedure, it was followed, and there was no objection. That's everything this document needs to confirm."

. . .

Hearing that, I pointed at the signature box again.

"…What about this, though? How do you read this?"

Tyche looked at the box.

"…It's blank."

"…Doesn't that seem strange?"

"…What's strange about it. Every document here is like this."

"…That's exactly it. That they're all like this is what seems strange to me."

Tyche looked at me for a moment and said,

"…What do you see in this blank space, Hora?"

I couldn't answer right away. I hadn't worked out what to say I saw.

"…No one, where someone ought to be."

"…But why ought there to be someone? This is a place where the whole decides, by design. It's not that an individual needs to write it — being blank isn't the problem."

. . .

I've called this conversation back to mind more than once. Tyche saw the procedure's precision. I saw the blank space. We both looked at the same document, and neither of us lied. Tyche couldn't be called wrong. I couldn't be called wrong either.

We sat a moment in silence. Tyche spoke again.

"…Hora, I don't think this city's way is bad. I think it's good, actually. Leaving even a verbal confirmation on record is better than

leaving nothing at all."

"…That's true. I agree with that too."

"…But you want more than that, don't you? A signature. Something written in that person's own hand, their actual name."

"…I think so."

"…Why?"

I couldn't answer this question right away either. It was hard to explain why a signature was better, what made it different from a verbal confirmation.

"…I don't know. I just feel like if there's a name, it means that person was really there. A verbal confirmation feels like someone speaking for them, saying they were there."

Tyche nodded.

"…I understand that feeling. But that's separate from whether it's actually true or not."

"…I know. But knowing something and it setting your mind at ease seem to be different things."

"…Tyche, I'm not trying to say this document is wrong."

"…But?"

"…Just, it feels like something's missing. The procedure's all correct, but it feels missing."

"…If something's missing, that's a regulatory violation. If it isn't in the regulations, it isn't missing."

"…Can't something be missing even if it isn't in the regulations?"

Tyche went quiet at that question for a moment. It was the first time she hadn't had an answer right away.

"…That… I'm honestly not sure, myself."

. . .

That short silence was the most striking moment in the whole afternoon's conversation. Tyche always had an answer. But she paused for a moment in front of this question.

"…You're not sure?"

"…No. Whether something not in the regulations can be called missing — that doesn't seem like a question about the regulations. It seems like some other question. But I can't explain what that other question is, either."

"…So do you think there's something to this blank box too, then, Tyche?"

"…No. I don't go that far. I still think this document, this blank box, has no problem. It's only that the question itself, the one you're asking, stays with me a little."

Tyche went on, sorting papers again.

"…Doing this work for a long time, I've come to see that people want to fill a blank space with something, once they see it. Whether it means something good or something bad. But a blank space is, most of the time, just a blank space."

"…Is that your conclusion?"

"…Yes. About this document. Another document might be different. I don't think the same way every time either."

"…So this isn't even a certain conclusion for you."

"…It's certain. As far as this document goes. Certain doesn't mean certain forever."

That was a small comfort to me. Tyche was judging each case fresh, too. It wasn't that the answer came out automatically.

"…Have there been times something caught at you too, looking at a blank box like this?"

Tyche thought a moment and said,

"…There have. Not often. But when it does catch, and I check it, it's usually nothing much. So now, even when it catches, I check first."

"…You checked this one too."

"…Yes. I checked, and by my standard, it was fine."

"…By my standard, something's still left over."

Tyche looked at me and smiled slightly.

"…Then we're both right. We just confirmed different things."

That was the end of that day's conversation. I hadn't won against Tyche. Tyche hadn't persuaded me either. I came to understand, after that day, that winning or losing hadn't been the point for either of us.

Writing this chapter, I've decided to leave this conversation without a conclusion. Drawing a conclusion would mean siding with one of us. I don't want to do that. Tyche read that document accurately. I read it accurately too. We simply saw different things in the same document, and that difference wasn't due to either of us making a mistake.

On the way home, I thought about the person moved to distribution office work. The one I only knew by number. If I ever met them, I wanted to ask — had they really wanted the move, or had there been no other option. I knew it was a little strange, thinking that without even knowing their face.

I didn't meet that person, then. Actually meeting someone in this city who's known only by a number happens much later than I imagined at the time.

We didn't talk further, there. We had read the same document together, and looked at the same blank box together. And in that blank box, Tyche saw a regulation, and I saw a person. We had both read that document accurately.

(Continued in Chapter 31.)

Chapter 31. For Such a Time

> *_Previously_ — Tyche and I read the same document side by side. Tyche saw the procedure's precision, and I saw the blank box. Both of us read it accurately. No conclusion came of it. That evening, I went to find Temel again.*

Temel was due to leave this city before long. His application was nearly finished, and the person he'd been looking for, he said, had gone unfound after all. Hearing that, I felt a rush of urgency. There was still something I wanted to ask.

That evening, instead of the north market, I went to the lodging house where he was staying. It was a small inn. Temel was sorting his belongings when he saw me, and looked a little surprised.

"…What brings you here, this hour?"

"…I heard you're leaving tomorrow."

"…Day after. But I tend to pack ahead of time."

. . .

We sat on the wooden bench in front of the inn. The evening air was cool. The smell of dinner cooking drifted from the mouth of the alley. Temel had come out without finishing his packing. His bag was still half open.

"…You can finish packing, if you want."

"…It's fine. Not much left, anyway."

"…Where are you headed next?"

"…Not sure yet, exactly. I'll probably decide once things here are wrapped up."

"…You really didn't find the person you were looking for?"

Temel nodded.

"…Right. Must not have been here after all. Or I got here too late."

"…Doesn't that trouble you?"

"…It does. But being troubled and giving up are two different problems. I'll have to look again in the next city."

Listening to him, I wondered what would happen to the three names he'd put down here, once he left.

"…What happens to the names you wrote here, once you go?"

"…No, that doesn't end. If the matter's here, the review keeps coming from here. Wherever I am."

"…So they call you in even if you're in another city?"

"…Yes. If a summons comes, I have to answer it. Not answering becomes a record too."

"…Does that go on forever?"

"…As long as that matter's still open. I don't know when that ends, myself."

Hearing that, I finally understood that this man kept dragging something behind him even as he moved from city to city. I'd thought until then that review was something that only happened inside this city.

Writing this passage, it's strange to me now that I didn't press further on this, that night. I think some other question was more urgent to me that night.

I hesitated, then asked.

"…I still don't know why I ended up in this seat."

"…We talked about that before. Because of the number."

"…Yes, I know that. I'm asking if there's some other reason, besides that."

Temel looked at me for a moment, then leaned back against the bench. And his way of speaking changed.

"…Hora."

It was the first time he'd said my name like that. Not the polite form. I tensed for a moment, but it didn't feel like rudeness — it felt like a signal that something was about to turn more serious.

I hadn't particularly noticed, until then, that Temel always spoke to me formally. Even with the difference in our ages, he had. But that night, I clearly felt the moment his speech changed. It felt like some formality had been set aside. Not in a bad direction — toward something closer.

. . .

"…Maybe you're sitting here only because of a number."

"…Yes."

"…But there are still things you can do in a seat you got only because of a number."

I sat still a moment, hearing that. It was a simple thing to say, and that simplicity was what made it heavy.

"…What does that mean?"

"…The reason you ended up in that seat was a number. That's true. But what you'll see there, what you'll read, what you'll come to know — the number didn't decide that. That's what you do."

. . .

"…But I don't even really know what I saw. The empty box. I still don't know what it means, either."

"…You saw it, though, not knowing."

"…I did see it, yes."

"…Then that's enough. Saying what you saw, the way you saw it — that's what you can do."

"…What's so remarkable about that? It's just something I read."

"…It doesn't have to be remarkable. It doesn't need to be remarkable to mean something."

"…But isn't that just because that's the kind of person I am, in the end? I've got the habit of reading to the end. That's not something I chose either. It's a habit I got because of my mother."

Temel nodded at this.

"…That's right. That might not be something you chose either. Habits usually aren't."

"…So isn't it all just one coincidence linked to the next, then? A vacancy, a number, a habit. Not one thing I actually chose."

"…Could be. But Hora, those coincidences linked up, and now you're sitting here on this bench asking me this question."

I was caught wordless for a moment, hearing that. I didn't know what to refute it with. Temel hadn't denied my logic. If anything he'd granted that all of it was true, and simply set the next sentence on top.

It occurred to me to wonder how Tyche would take this. She would probably say something like this — that a chain of coincidences was still just coincidence continuing, and that attaching meaning to it was my own doing. I still thought that was right. And yet Temel's words sounded equally right to me. That the two could both be right at once was what confused me most, that night.

"…Tyche would probably argue with that, if she were here."

"…How?"

"…She'd probably say a chain of coincidences is still just coincidence, and that attaching meaning to it is on me."

Temel nodded.

"…Could be. That could be right too."

"…But what you're saying is right too."

"…Both can be right, Hora. That isn't strange. It's the same thing, seen, and standing differently."

Hearing that, I thought of the afternoon I'd spent reading the document beside Tyche. The same document, different conclusions. This time it was the same chain of coincidences, different conclusions.

"…Was it like that for you too? Back then, when you said you fell apart?"

"…Yeah. I thought it was all coincidence, back then too. That I'd ended up in that place, that I fell apart — I thought it was all just how things happened to go."

"…And now?"

"…Even now, I can't say it wasn't coincidence. But what I did afterward wasn't coincidence. That, I chose."

"…What did you choose?"

"…Deciding to start over. Deciding to write my name first. Nobody told me to do that."

"…Why did you decide to start over, then?"

Temel was quiet a moment, then answered.

"…Running kept getting tiring. Even while I was running, something always got left behind somewhere. There's the trace you leave without

writing it down, and the trace you leave by writing it down, and I found the trace of not writing it more frightening."

"…Why?"

"…If I didn't write it, later on I couldn't even explain to myself what I'd done. That was the scariest part. Not other people's judgment — my own."

"…So that's why you started writing it?"

"…Yeah. At first, that was all it was. Not because it had a meaning — just because it felt like I needed to be able to explain myself to myself."

"…And now? Is that still the reason?"

Temel smiled a little.

"…A few more reasons have piled up since. But the very first one is still the biggest."

I liked that answer. It was more believable for not being some grand reason.

Listening to him, I was still curious about whatever had happened to this man when he was young. But I didn't ask further. Tonight I wanted to ask something else.

. . .

"…So does that mean there's a meaning to it?"

I held my breath a little, asking this. I really wanted to hear the answer.

Temel didn't answer right away. He looked at the evening sky a moment, then looked back at me.

"…I don't know."

"…What?"

"…I don't know either."

. . .

Hearing that answer, I felt strangely deflated. And at the same time, strangely at ease. It was odd that the two could come together.

"…If you don't know, who does?"

"…Maybe nobody does. Or maybe it's just me who doesn't."

"…But everyone in this city lives as if they know. Tyche does too."

"…That's a different matter. There's saying you know something you don't, and there's not asking at all because you don't know. Both happen. I find something lacking in both, if I'm honest."

"…Are you neither of those?"

"…I just keep asking without knowing. That's the most exhausting way to do it."

"…Then why say what you said? That there are things I can do. When you don't even know."

Temel smiled a little.

"…Not knowing doesn't mean I can't do anything. I said it before, didn't I. Not knowing isn't a reason not to write it."

In that moment I felt I understood why that line had stayed with me so long, inside me. This man truly didn't know. And not knowing, he wrote his name every single time. Not knowing whether there was a meaning or not, he was doing the thing he could do.

I brought up review again. I'd remembered the day I'd followed him through the confirmation rooms at the market.

"…What I saw that day, at the confirmation room. Is that still going on?"

"…Yeah. There was one today too, a little while ago."

"…Do they call you in even before you leave?"

"…Yeah. Leaving needs confirming too. A departure notice, I think they call it."

"…Do you write your name for that too?"

"…I do. There's another box to write in."

Hearing that, a laugh came out of me. It wasn't something to laugh about, but I laughed anyway.

"…You really do write your name wherever you go."

"…I do. I get tired of myself sometimes, too."

"…And still you'll write it again."

"…Yeah. I'll write it again."

There wasn't a moment's hesitation in that answer. I found that striking. I learned, right then, for the first time, that not hesitating and being certain aren't the same thing.

. . .

"…Aren't you scared? Living like this all the time, when there might be no meaning at all."

"…I am. But being certain there's no meaning scares me just as much. Either way, being certain scares me more."

"…But there are plenty of people who are certain. Tyche too."

"…There are. But I don't envy that certainty so much as it scares me, a little. Once you're certain, you don't have to look anymore after that. You already think you know."

"…Do you dislike that?"

"…Not dislike it, exactly — I just can't seem to do it. I have to look again, every time. It's tiring, but if I don't, I feel like I'll miss something."

"…Miss what?"

"…I don't know that either. But if I let myself be certain, I'm scared that even the not-knowing itself will stop being visible to me."

"…How do you live without being certain?"

"…I just do today's work. Past that, I don't really know either."

I felt that this was similar to what Tyche had said, and also different. Tyche too had said she lived liking what she did today. But Tyche set that on top of a conclusion of "there isn't one," and Temel was setting it on top of a conclusion of "I don't know."

I couldn't explain that difference exactly, that night. In the next chapter, I think about it for a long time.

. . .

"…Hora."

"…Yes."

"…What I said before, about you sitting here maybe just because of a number. I didn't say that to comfort you. I meant it could really be true."

"…I know."

"…But the sentence after that is just as true. There are still things you can do in a seat you got only because of a number. That isn't comfort either. It's just a fact."

I sat a long while with those two sentences set side by side. That it might be only a number, and that there were still things you could do even so. They weren't opposites. Both could be true.

The day had fully gone dark. I said goodbye and stood.

"…You're going day after tomorrow?"

"…Yeah."

"…Will I get to see you again?"

Temel thought a moment and said,

"…I don't know. I don't know that either."

Strangely, that didn't make me sad. I smiled and turned away.

. . .

On the way home, I took the long way on purpose. The road that passed the western water channel.

The water was still making its sound. I stood beside it a moment and brought back the words I'd heard that day.

Maybe you're sitting here only because of a number.

But there are still things you can do in a seat you got only because of a number.

I don't know. I don't know either.

Set side by side like this, the three sentences strangely sounded like one. Clearer put together than they had been, heard one at a time.

I copied these three sentences onto paper that night. I put them in the drawer with my mother's papers, alongside the two names and the one sentence already there. That drawer had grown fairly heavy by then. There was a weight I felt in my hand, every time I opened it.

My aunt was still awake when I got home.

"…You're late."

"…Yes. I went to see Temel."

"…He's leaving day after tomorrow, you said."

"…Yes."

"…What did you ask him?"

"…Why I ended up in this seat."

My aunt looked at me a moment and asked,

"…Did you get an answer?"

"…No. He said he doesn't know either."

My aunt gave a short laugh.

"…Why ask something he doesn't know?"

"…You have to ask, to find out whether he knows or not."

My aunt didn't answer that. She just turned off the light. I lay in the dark and read those three sentences over once more, inside myself.

I learned that night, for the first time, how long the words "I don't know" could hold onto a person. Tyche's "there isn't one," and Temel's "I don't know." Both short sentences, but they settled inside me at entirely different weights. Why they weighed differently, I couldn't explain, then.

(Continued in Chapter 32.)

Chapter 32. The Answer That Is I Don't Know

> *_Previously_ — I asked Temel, "Does that mean there's a meaning to*
> *it?" He waited a long while and answered, "…I don't know. I don't know either." I felt deflated hearing that answer, and strangely at ease at the same time. I sensed that Tyche's "there isn't one" and Temel's "I don't know" were different, but that night I couldn't explain how.*

For the days that followed, I kept holding onto those two words.

I held onto them while working, and while eating. My aunt asked me twice, "What are you thinking about so hard?" and I couldn't give her a proper answer. It was hard to even call it thinking. I was circling the same spot over and over, not moving forward.

There isn't one. I don't know.

The two phrases look similar on the surface. Both look like they sit on the opposite side from "I know." But set side by side, they were entirely different statements. There isn't one was a sentence that closed a door. I don't know was a sentence that left the door open.

Writing this line, I'm not sure whether this is the right way to define it. I'm still not sure, even now. But I'll set down honestly, at least, that this is how I've gone on telling the two apart, ever since that day.

. . .

The first thing that came to mind was the signature box.

Tyche had looked at that box and said, "Being blank isn't the problem." That since this was a place where the whole decided, an individual didn't need to write it. That was one conclusion. The conclusion that there was no meaning to it. That the box was blank simply because this city had been designed that way, and there was nothing more to look for there.

Temel had looked at that box and drawn no conclusion at all. He wrote it, he'd said, "because there's a box to write in." Why the box was always blank, he didn't know either. He didn't know, but not knowing didn't mean he did nothing. Not knowing, he wrote it anyway.

I set these two side by side and looked at them a long while. Tyche's words gave me relief. Because there was a conclusion. With a conclusion, I no longer had to lie awake over the question. Temel's words gave no relief. Instead they kept making me do something. Since I had to do something while still not knowing.

Here I feel the temptation to write Tyche unkindly — to make her reaching a conclusion look like an escape. But that wouldn't be honest. Tyche's conclusion was a conclusion with evidence behind it. Nearly everything she had confirmed in this city backed that conclusion up. She hadn't reached it out of laziness.

. . .

The second thing I thought of was the person from eleven years ago.

The record hadn't been cut off — it simply had no more. I'd held onto that difference a long time back then too, and I hold onto it again now, writing this passage. Cut off means someone severed it. No more means it simply went that far and no further.

Tyche would have said this: that no more just means no more. That the person could have moved, could have changed their name, could have left this city. That either way, it was explained by probability. And that explanation really did hold up. I couldn't refute a single part of it.

I don't know what happened to that person. I still don't know. And yet I couldn't turn that not-knowing into "so it's nothing." Not knowing wasn't the same as saying it was nothing. Not knowing was only a statement that I still didn't know.

Writing this sentence, I know how much I'm trapped in circular logic. Not knowing is only a statement that I don't know — this proves nothing. Tyche would have caught exactly this point. "That's just it, Hora. That's exactly what I'm saying. Not knowing proves nothing." I have no confidence to refute that. I still don't, now.

. . .

The third thing I thought of was the four hundred people.

In this city, an average of more than four hundred people are involved in a single deliberation. At first I understood that number as a safeguard. That if two hundred, three hundred people all pass a decision through, there's no room left for any one person's malice to slip in. That really was true. For months I went and found each of those four hundred people, one by one, and confirmed that not a single

one of them held any malice. I only passed it on. I only put it in order. I only confirmed it. All of them were honest.

Tyche explained this structure this way: that because no one decided it, no one was wronged by it. That was a fact. I couldn't refute it. And yet I was asking a different question on top of that fact. Whether no one deciding it, and there being no meaning anywhere in that whole, were the same thing.

Tyche would have said yes. That when four hundred small judgments gather, that itself is the Consensus, and attaching any further meaning to the Consensus is a thing people do, not a thing the Consensus does. I thought this was right too. And yet, at the same time, the fact that not one of those four hundred people had ever seen the whole kept catching at me. I remembered what the official had told me, before — "There's no one who sees the whole." If no one had seen the whole, then it meant no one knew what the whole meant, either. Not there isn't one — I don't know.

I know this distinction might look trivial. Whether it's there isn't one or I don't know, in the sense that neither gives me an answer right here, right now, they're the same. But I felt, for the first time that week, that the two made me into different people. Thinking there isn't one, I stopped there. Thinking I don't know, I kept doing something. It wasn't an answer, but it took me somewhere, at least.

. . .

The fourth thing I thought of was the water channel.

Tyche had said this about the water channel: that the most plausible explanation was that water, flowing downhill, had simply ended up here. That this was much simpler than an explanation involving someone

deliberately sending it. I'd nodded at that. I'd confirmed myself, more than once, that the simple explanation was usually the right one.

But the simple explanation being right, and that explanation being everything, were different questions. That the water had flowed downhill could be true, and that there was something more to why that water happened to flow to this particular city — whether there was or wasn't, I didn't know — could be true at the same time. That the two didn't cancel each other out was something I noticed for the first time, then.

This was a very small realization, but it felt very large to me. Up until then I'd thought "it's explained" and "there's no meaning" were the same statement. I'd thought that once something was explained, that proved there was no meaning to it. But that wasn't so. An explanation was an explanation, and a meaning was a meaning. The two weren't fighting over the same ground.

I once tried saying this to Tyche. She answered, "Then whether there's a meaning ends up unprovable too, doesn't it — since you're saying it doesn't overlap with the explanation." I couldn't refute that either. Tyche was always someone who could shake whatever I'd built in a single step.

. . .

The fifth thing wasn't another person. It was my mother.

My mother had written twelve pages. Where things around the house were kept, when to bring out the winter clothes. She wrote those things first, and put the one sentence she left for me on the very last line. I've thought about that order for a long time. Why put it

last. Had she been the kind of person who put important things last, or had it simply drifted there as she wrote?

Tyche would have said this: that people usually write the easy things first. That where things around the house were kept was easy to write, and what she wanted to say to me must have been hard to write. That putting off the hard thing was how it ended up on the last line. That was a plausible explanation. Maybe that really was what happened. Maybe my mother hadn't put that sentence last on purpose, and it had simply been pushed there as she wrote.

I could accept that explanation. I did accept it. And yet, even having accepted it, I couldn't turn into nothing the fact that that last line had been waiting for me, of all people, at the end of the very two years I'd let slip by. That the order was coincidence, and that I had lost two years because of that order and finally reached that line — those were stories on different layers.

Tyche folded these two layers into one. If the order was coincidence, then my reaching that line was simply, in the end, a result coincidence had produced. I think that's true too. And yet I can't fold away, as mere coincidence, the fact that that coincidence stood me, of all people, at that particular moment, in front of that particular sentence. I know that being unable to fold it away isn't evidence. I'm only setting down honestly, here, the fact that I couldn't.

. . .

I tried to sort out these five things, sitting beside the drawer. I wrote "there isn't one" on a paper, and beside it wrote "I don't know." Underneath I wrote each of the five in turn — the signature

box, the person from eleven years ago, the four hundred people, the water channel, my mother's last line. I started to draw an arrow, and stopped. I didn't know which way to draw it.

I stared at that paper a long while, that night. More than once I felt like a conclusion was about to come. And every time, just before it did, it scattered again. Even now, writing this book, I still haven't reached that conclusion. I'm not writing this chapter to hand one over. I'm writing it to set down honestly, exactly as it was, that I truly hadn't reached one, back then.

One thing I did seem to know. Tyche's "there isn't one" was a safe place to stand. Standing there, you no longer had to be shaken. Temel's "I don't know" wasn't a safe place. Standing there, you had to keep looking. Keep asking. Keep doing something. Maybe Temel kept writing his name for exactly this reason — because he kept standing in that unsafe place.

But this isn't a conclusion either. Standing in an unsafe place doesn't mean it's the right place to stand. I knew that then, and I know it now. Being unsafe and being right are different questions. I kept wanting to mix the two together. I also know that isn't allowed. Tyche would have said exactly that.

. . .

Days went by like that. At the district hall I did the work I always did. I read the documents I was assigned. Read them to the end. Went into meetings. Heard, I'll put it in order, heard, it's been passed on to me. On the outside, nothing had changed at all.

Tyche asked me once.

"…You're thinking about something different lately?"

"…Yes. But I can't really explain it."

"…What is it?"

"…There isn't one, and I don't know. Why they're different."

Tyche tilted her head.

"…Are they different? They sound similar to me."

"…I thought so too, at first. But I don't think they are, now."

"…How are they different?"

I tried to answer that question, but even after days of thinking about it, no proper words came.

"…I don't know. I still can't explain it."

Tyche smiled slightly.

"…That's very like you, Hora. Saying you don't know what you don't know."

"…Is that strange?"

"…No. Just — I'd have let it go if I couldn't explain something. But you don't let it go."

That line stayed with me the longest, out of that day's conversation. I hadn't let it go. I couldn't let it go. I still didn't know why.

"…Tyche, can I ask one more thing?"

"…Sure."

"…When you hear the words I don't know, what comes to mind?"

Tyche thought a moment.

"…That there isn't enough data yet. That usually means you'll come to know it, once you gather more."

"…Is that always true? Gathering data means you'll come to know?"

"…No. There are things you never come to know. But in those cases, I think it's more accurate to say there's no way to know, rather than saying you don't know."

"…Is that different from I don't know?"

"…It's different, to me. I don't know means you might come to know later. There's no way to know is just an ending."

I sat a while after hearing that, then asked.

"…So which is this? Whether there's a meaning or not."

This time Tyche didn't answer right away. Her hand, sorting papers, stopped for a moment.

"…Honestly, I don't know which it is either. But I've folded it into the there's-no-way-to-know side. It's more restful that way, every day."

"…I haven't been able to fold it away yet."

"…I know. That's very like you too."

I asked my aunt the same question that night. She glanced at me while setting out dinner and said,

"…What's so hard about not knowing? You just don't know right now."

"…But isn't that different from there isn't one?"

"…It's different. If there isn't one, then there just isn't one. If you don't know, you don't even know whether there is one or not."

My aunt said that very simply. So simply that I felt suddenly deflated. What I'd been holding onto for days, she'd sorted into one sentence. But even the sentence she'd sorted it into wasn't really a conclusion. Not knowing whether it exists or not. That was my aunt's answer, and it was exactly the same place I'd been holding onto for days.

. . .

Writing this chapter, I felt the temptation, more than once, to invent a conclusion and slip it in. I wanted to end this chapter on some plausible-sounding line. But writing it that way would be a lie. In those days I reached no conclusion at all. I only went back and forth, over and over, between there isn't one and I don't know. Even now, writing this record, I'm not so different, in truth.

Only one thing has become clear. I understood the place where Tyche stood. I couldn't refute it. And yet I couldn't stand in that place myself. I don't know why. I truly don't know. That's all I can write in this chapter.

That Friday night, something happened for the first time. The Secretary came to find me, after working hours had ended.

(Continued in Chapter 33.)

Chapter 33. The Secretary at Night

> *_Previously_ — For days I held onto Tyche's "there isn't one" and Temel's "I don't know." No conclusion came. And Friday night, something happened for the first time. The Secretary came to find me*
> *after working hours had ended.*

The Secretary was standing in the alley in front of my house. At first I didn't recognize him. He wasn't wearing what he always wore in the district meeting hall. He had on an outer coat, and his hands held nothing at all — not the usual folder. That was the first time I'd ever seen the Secretary with empty hands.

"…Secretary?"

"…I'm sorry, at this hour."

His voice was the same. The tone I always heard. Words of apology that still didn't sound like an apology. I found it strange to realize that his way of speaking stayed the same even outside working hours.

"…What brings you here, this time of night?"

"…I was hoping you might have a moment."

"…How did you know where I live?"

"…It's on the roster."

That answer was so obvious it was strange, hearing it. In that moment I felt again how much this city's roster held. No one had hidden it. Everyone had simply never thought to open that roster and look.

Writing this now, I notice this short exchange already summarizes this whole chapter. What surprised me wasn't that the Secretary had found something out. It had been somewhere visible from the start. What surprised me was that no one but me had ever gone to look.

. . .

We sat on the bench at the mouth of the alley. It was a different bench from the one I'd sat on with Temel, but for a moment the two nights overlapped in my mind. There was one streetlamp, and its light was yellow.

The Secretary was silent for a long while. I didn't press him. I'd watched, for months, how this man carried silence. He wasn't someone who hurried. Not so much that he didn't hurry — he seemed like someone who had no reason to.

"…This is the first time you've come to find me."

"…Yes."

"…There's something you want to say?"

"…Yes."

The Secretary answered only that, and went quiet again. I didn't think this man was hiding anything. If there was one thing I'd learned in months in this city, it was that these people didn't hide things. It was only that they were slow to bring things out.

. . .

"…Last time, I looked away."

This came first. I was surprised. It was the first time the Secretary had brought that moment up himself.

"…Yes. I remember."

"…What you asked me that day was what happens if you write a name."

"…Yes."

"…I couldn't give you an answer then. It wasn't that I didn't know the answer."

Hearing that, I asked right back.

"…Then why?"

The Secretary looked at the night sky for a moment. I expected something grand to come next. What came out was short.

"…If I gave you an answer, it would become my saying it."

"…What do you mean?"

"…If I say I know something, from then on it becomes my judgment. I'm not someone who judges. I'm someone who passes things on and convenes them."

. . .

Hearing this answer, a line I'd heard once before came back to me. "…How do I put in something that isn't there?" That there was no subject. I'd thought that was an excuse, at the time. But that night I felt again that it wasn't an excuse. This man truly was afraid of attaching a subject to himself. Not so much afraid — he sincerely believed that wasn't his to do.

"…But why did you come today, then? You didn't come here not to answer, surely."

At this question, the Secretary looked straight at me for the first time.

"…I felt this was something I ought to tell you."

"…Tell me what?"

"…That matter from eleven years ago. The southern tract."

For a moment I felt my breath catch. It was the person I'd found — the one who had written a name, opened a new deliberation, and whose record had then stopped.

. . .

"…How do you know about that matter?"

"…I convened that one too."

That one sentence was the whole of that night. I couldn't say anything for a long while, hearing it. It meant the Secretary had been standing in the same seat, doing the same work, eleven years ago too.

"…Were you the Secretary then too?"

"…I did similar work. The title was different from now."

"…Then do you remember that person? The one who wrote the name?"

The Secretary paused, very briefly, at this question. I thought that brief pause said something, and then set the thought aside. This man hadn't looked away, and he wasn't choosing his words. It was simply a face confirming a fact.

"…I remember."

"…What kind of person were they?"

"…A subject of convening. Beyond that, there's nothing I can tell you."

"…What about what became of them?"

"…I don't know."

That answer was short. But being short didn't make it sound like evasion. I could tell this man truly didn't know. If there was one more thing I'd learned, living months in this city, it was that someone who truly doesn't know speaks with a different tone from someone pretending not to know while knowing.

"…How long have you worked here, Secretary?"

"…Twenty-three years now."

"…Twenty-three years?"

"…Yes. I came in as an intake assistant, at first. And worked my way up to this seat."

"…Have you been in this city the whole time?"

"…Yes. Never moved."

Hearing that number, I tried to gauge how long, how many convenings, this man must have carried out in this city. I couldn't quite gauge it. Twenty-three years was longer than I'd been alive.

"…So how many people have you convened here?"

"…I've never counted. It isn't a number that can be counted."

"…But there were exactly two people who wrote their names. The person from eleven years ago, and Temel now."

The Secretary nodded.

"…That's right. Two, in twenty-three years."

That number held me for a long while. Two, in twenty-three years. Between those two people lay a gap of eleven years. Through that gap, this city had kept turning, and the signature box had stayed blank the whole time.

. . .

"…Secretary, was that person put under review too? Like Temel is now?"

"…Yes. Several matters' worth."

"…For how long?"

"…What remains on record is about half a year."

"…And after that?"

"…They dropped off the convening roster."

"…Why?"

"…I don't know. What I know is that from a certain point on, that name was no longer on the convening list."

"…Secretary — could that still happen now, if someone wrote their name?"

The Secretary answered this question right away.

"…I don't know. I don't know what happened to that person, so how could I know whether the next one would end up the same way."

"…But the review keeps going. That much is certain, isn't it?"

"…Yes, that's certain. Once a new deliberation is opened, the proposer's name attaches to that matter. As long as that matter's alive, that name gets called into every related confirmation. This is in the regulations."

"…You said it isn't punishment."

"…It isn't punishment. It's confirmation. But when the confirmation never ends, I sometimes get confused, myself, about how that's different from punishment."

I was surprised to hear this. It was the first time the Secretary had said he himself was confused. And even "confused" came with the subject "myself" attached to it. That night, this was one of only a handful of times he'd used "I" or "myself" at all.

"…So is opening a new deliberation a good thing or a bad thing?"

"…That isn't a question I can answer. The result could be good, or it could be bad. You only find out once it's opened."

"…What do you think, Secretary?"

"…I'm not in a position to offer an opinion."

"…This isn't working hours, though."

The Secretary paused a moment at this.

"…That's true. But even this seat is, in the end, tied to the work I do. I can't fully step away from it."

Hearing that answer, I had no choice but to accept that this man truly knew nothing more than this. The Consensus hides nothing. The Secretary hid nothing either. It was only that there were things even the Consensus didn't know, things even the Secretary didn't know, and probably things no one in this city knew.

In that moment I felt something hollow. I think I'd half been hoping this man would finally unburden some hidden truth he'd been carrying. But there was nothing like that. He truly said only as much as he knew, and said "I don't know" for what he didn't. I only confirmed, that day, all over again, that this was this city's truly frightening part.

. . .

"…Secretary, back then, what did you think, watching that person write their name?"

The Secretary looked at me a moment at this question. His expression didn't change much.

"…I thought it was unusual."

"…That's all?"

"…At the time. As the convening matters kept growing, later on I had a few other thoughts too."

"…What thoughts?"

"…Why this person kept coming, I wondered. They came, every time, to a seat they didn't have to come to."

"…You were the one calling them in."

"…Yes. I convened them. But being convened doesn't mean everyone comes. There are people who don't come."

"…What happens if they don't?"

"…Processing gets delayed. That's all. That isn't punishment either."

"…But this person came, every time?"

"…Yes. Never once missed. Right up to the last convening."

. . .

Hearing that, I asked again.

"…The last convening? Did you have any sense, then, of what might happen to that person?"

"…No. That convening was an ordinary one too. As far as I knew."

"…But after that, they were gone."

"…Yes."

"…Doesn't that seem strange to you?"

At this question, the Secretary was quiet a little longer than before, for the first time.

"…It's strange. But it being strange doesn't mean there's anything I can do."

I couldn't answer that. The Secretary didn't apologize. He didn't say he'd done anything wrong, either. He was simply drawing, precisely, the line between what he knew and what he could do.

. . .

"…Why did you tell me this tonight?"

The Secretary answered as he rose from the bench.

"…I received a report that you'd found that document. Reading room records are kept. If I was connected to it, I thought it was right to tell you myself."

"…You received a report? From whom?"

"…It comes up periodically from the reading room. Who has read a document carrying a particular mark."

Hearing that answer, a small chill went through me. But that wasn't hidden either. That reading records were kept had been an open fact from the start. I simply hadn't known how they were passed on, or to whom. Not knowing had been on my side.

"…So that's just procedure too, then?"

"…Yes. Procedure."

"…So you came to find me because of procedure, Secretary?"

At this question, the Secretary's expression shifted, slightly, for the first time. It wasn't a smile. But it wasn't quite blank, either.

"…No. This isn't procedure. I came because I thought I should."

. . .

That one line stayed with me the longest of anything I heard that night. That it wasn't procedure. Even as he said it, the word "I" sounded awkward in his mouth. Like clothes he wasn't used to wearing.

"…Could you come like this again, next time?"

The Secretary thought a moment.

"…I don't know. I suppose that will be decided when the time comes."

With that, the Secretary said goodbye and turned back. He never did apologize. I'd thought he had something to apologize for. But instead

of an apology, he'd given me a fact. I learned, for the first time that night, that a fact can weigh more than an apology.

I remember this night for a long time. I can't write that I came to like this man. I can't quite write that I came not to dislike him, either. But this — that he'd carried out the same work, in the same seat, for eleven years running, and that in all those eleven years, he had come to find me exactly once with a step that wasn't procedure — these two facts set side by side, I still don't know how to put them together.

The next morning, I told Tyche briefly what had happened the night before. Tyche listened quietly and said,

"…He told you that, himself?"

"…Yes."

"…That's surprising. I didn't think he'd say that much."

"…Do you not know the Secretary well either, Tyche?"

"…I've worked with him for years and I still don't. He's always in that seat, but nobody seems to know what's behind it."

"…Is that strange?"

"…No. There are a lot of people like that in this city. The longer they've worked, the more so. I think erasing yourself becomes a habit."

"…Doesn't that make you sad, Tyche?"

Tyche thought a moment and said,

"…Not sad, exactly. I'm scared, sometimes, that I might become that way too."

That was unexpected. I'd never thought Tyche carried a fear like that.

"…You're afraid you'll end up like him?"

"…Yes. I like procedure. But if I like procedure for too long, I'm scared that someday I'll be someone speaking without a subject too, just like him."

"…You don't seem like you would, to me."

"…I don't know. He probably wasn't like that from the start, either."

With that, Tyche went back to sorting papers. I watched her back for a moment, then thought of the seat the Secretary must have stood in for twenty-three years.

Walking home, I looked up at the western sky once. I had no idea, that evening, that I would soon hear about a sound coming from the western water channel, different from its usual sound.

(Continued in Chapter 34.)

Chapter 34. The Water Reaches

> *_Previously_ — The Secretary came to find me outside working hours for the first time. He said he had handled the convening for that deliberation eleven years ago too. "…I convened that one too." There was no apology. That evening, I heard that a sound different from usual was coming from the western water channel.*

My aunt stopped in the middle of setting out dinner.

"…Did you hear about the western ditch? They say the water's making a strange, loud sound today."

"…Strange how?"

"…I don't know, I only heard it secondhand. Are you going to go look?"

I set down my bowl and put on my coat. My aunt didn't stop me. She knew too — in this city, if you're curious about something, going to look is the fastest way to find out.

Outside it was already dim. Walking through a few alleys, my heart beat strangely fast. I didn't quite know why. Whenever I felt something was changing, I always hurried toward it. I don't know myself when that habit began.

. . .

The sound of water reached me from the western alley on. It was clearly louder than usual. Too widespread a sound to be coming from a single ditch.

When I reached the end of the alley, I saw why.

The water channel had widened. It used to be a narrow ditch you could barely set one foot across; now it was twice that width. The current had picked up too. The water, once the color of earth, looked a little clearer. It seemed as though more water had come pushing in from somewhere beyond the city's boundary.

Watching this that night, I truly felt that this water had come "inside" this city. When I'd first seen it, it had been flowing somewhere at the western edge of the city, out at the boundary. Not anymore. The channel had already worked its way into the very alleys we walked through every day.

People had come out to stand beside it. Few faces looked startled. Most looked curious. Two children had gone in barefoot and were splashing at the water's edge, and a few adults stood watching them, laughing.

. . .

I ran to the front desk. One person was on the night shift.

"…Excuse me — the western water channel. It's come inside the city. Where do I report this?"

The clerk tapped at the screen. He searched a long while and shook his head.

"…There's no matter number for this."

"…What do you mean, no matter number?"

"…To file a report there has to be a related matter, but this water channel itself has never come before a matter. I don't know what to file this under."

"…So you just can't do it?"

"…I can't open a new matter on my own judgment. That's outside my authority."

I'd expected that answer, and still, hearing it out loud, it left me stifled.

What Tyche had said before came back to me. "If it's never been submitted, it doesn't exist. Not hidden — just not submitted." I'd thought I understood that, at the time. But I'd only understood it in my head. Only now, watching the water actually rise around my own feet, did I feel in my body how frightening that sentence really was.

. . .

The next day, on my way to the district hall, I ran into the Secretary. It was the first time since that night a few days before. I brought up the water channel.

"…Secretary, do you know about the western water channel? It's come inside the city."

"…I know."

"…Then why isn't anything being done?"

"…There's no matter for it."

"…Can't you make a matter, Secretary?"

"…What I can make is a convening, not a matter. A matter only exists once the department with jurisdiction takes it in."

"…Then which department has jurisdiction?"

The Secretary thought a moment.

"…This water channel's jurisdiction has never been settled. Matters involving the city boundary belong to the outskirts management department; matters involving water supply belong to the water supply department. Which of the two this falls under, no one's decided yet."

"…So no one can do anything?"

"…Someone first has to propose which department it belongs to. Only then can a matter be opened."

"…Can't you do that, Secretary?"

"…I could propose it. But I haven't yet judged this to be a problem."

"…Water's come into the city and that isn't a problem?"

"…Something bad has to happen for it to be a problem. So far, nothing bad has happened."

That answer was exactly what Tyche had said. That two different people had said the same thing confirmed for me, again, that this was how the whole city worked.

. . .

That afternoon I went to the reading room and searched for whether anything had ever come into this city this way before, without a matter behind it. I spent half a day changing my search terms, over and over. I found almost nothing. A few very old records turned up, all trivial things. A tree that had grown up on its own by the roadside. A garden plot that had grown up though no one had planted it. Since neither had ever come before a matter, there wasn't even a record of when the tree or the garden had first appeared. It was only written that they'd simply been there, from some point on.

Looking at these records, I thought this city might have been built this way from the start. Things that had gone through deliberation, and things that had simply grown up with no one noticing. This city called only the first kind "the city," and treated the second kind as though it weren't part of the city at all. And yet the second kind was plainly there too. The tree, the garden plot, and now this water channel.

I asked the reading room clerk.

"…Have things like this ever come before a matter, later on?"

"…Sometimes. If someone feels it's a bother. But that tree's still standing there without a matter, even now. So's the garden plot."

"…So if no one's bothered, it just stays that way forever?"

"…Seems like it. I'd never thought that was strange before, but hearing you say it, it does seem a little strange."

"…So this water channel will just keep on being like this, until someone's bothered by it?"

"…Probably. But everyone likes it, don't they? Is anyone likely to be bothered?"

I couldn't answer that question. If truly no one was bothered, this water channel would stay outside any matter forever. I learned, that day, for the first time, that even a good thing could stay outside a matter. The clerk said this and turned her eyes back to the screen. The conversation ended there.

. . .

The next morning, the channel had widened further. The city still hadn't dealt with it. Not so much hadn't dealt with it — there simply was no procedure to deal with it at all.

On my way to the district hall I met Tyche. She knew about the water channel too.

"…This really isn't going to become a matter?"

"…Someone has to bring it up for it to become one. It doesn't rise on its own."

"…Then who's supposed to bring it up?"

"…I don't know that either. Normally, something like this needs a settled jurisdiction before it can be raised, but this channel doesn't have one settled either."

"…So it just stays like this forever?"

Tyche thought a moment.

"…No. Once someone feels it's a problem and raises it as a matter, it'll get handled. But right now, no one seems to feel it's a problem."

"…Water's come right into the middle of the city and that isn't a problem?"

"…People like it. They drink it, children play in it. If it isn't something bad, no one brings it before a matter. This city's only built to respond to bad things."

That was true. And that truth was what chilled me.

. . .

All that week the channel kept widening, little by little. The city still did nothing. People drew the water and used it. Did laundry in it. Children splashed in it. One household brought a jar and filled it there.

Near the market, someone set out a bench beside the channel. In the evenings people gathered there, sitting with their feet in the water, talking. Watching that scene, I felt again how quickly the people of this city adjusted to something new. The astonishment didn't last more than a few days. By the end of a week, everyone was acting as though this water had always been there.

Someone built a small water wheel and set it up in the current. It was a child's toy, but grown-ups would turn it once, passing by, and laugh. Watching that water wheel, I felt something strange. On water that had come before no matter, with no one's permission, someone had built something with their own hands and set it up. That was a rare sight in this city.

A child once showed me the water wheel, proud of it. "Look, I made this myself." I told her she'd made it well. She turned the wheel a few more times, delighted. That child had no curiosity at all about where this water had come from, or whether it was in any matter. All that mattered to her was that the water was there, and the wheel turned.

Watching that child, I remembered what Tyche always said. That nothing gets treated as a problem unless it's something bad. For that child, this was exactly the right attitude. It wasn't something bad. I felt no urge at all to grab her and ask, "Doesn't this feel strange?" That wasn't hers to carry.

I'd thought this might be dangerous, but nothing happened. The water was clear, and no one who drank it fell ill. It wasn't something bad. It truly wasn't something bad.

Writing this passage, I wonder whether I myself had been hoping there was something bad in this water channel. If there had been something bad, it would have been easier, in a way — there would have been a reason to bring it before a matter. But there was nothing bad. It was simply good water, come into the city with no procedure at all. That was what unsettled me most.

My aunt drew that water and used it too. One evening I saw her carrying a water jar on her head and asked,

"…Aunt, did you check whether this is safe to drink?"

"…Check what. Everyone drinks it."

"…But we don't even know where it came from."

My aunt set the jar down and said,

"…Hora, water's always been something you drink without knowing where it came from. Whether it comes from the sky or from a mountain. There's nothing strange about that."

I couldn't answer that. It wasn't wrong.

That night, the woman from next door came over and talked with my aunt about the water channel. Both of them talked about it as though it were old, familiar weather. "The water's come in early this year." "Right, and it's stronger than last year's." Listening to that tone, I felt this water channel had already entered this city's everyday language. It wasn't in any matter, but it was in their speech.

I think this is the quietest passage in this chapter. No great event, no great line. Just two people talking about the water channel the way they'd talk about the weather. But that quiet was what frightened me most. I'd thought frightening things came loudly. This one simply walked, quietly, into an evening's small talk.

. . .

That evening, I walked along the water channel. I wanted to see, with my own eyes, how deep it had come into the city.

The channel ran from the western alley all the way to near the market. Its width wasn't even. Narrow in some places, wide enough in others for people to sit with their feet in it.

Someone I'd never seen before was sitting by the water. He had taken off a pair of worn shoes beside the water and sat with his feet in it, quietly looking at the water.

I walked past him. No one else looked at him. My own eyes went to him only for a moment, and I didn't stop walking either. There was always someone sitting by the water in this city; it wasn't anything unusual.

Looking back on that evening, I can't remember any one thing I saw by the water as anything special. The children, the people doing laundry, the people carrying water jars. And that man. All of it was just the scenery of the waterside. I didn't fix my eyes on any of it, that day. That itself struck me as strange, only much later.

. . .

Walking home, I ran into Tyche again. She was carrying a water jar.

"…You use this water too, Tyche?"

"…Yes. Everyone else does; there's no reason I shouldn't."

"…But doesn't it seem strange? Everyone using water that isn't even in any matter?"

Tyche shifted her grip on the jar and said,

"…It's strange. But strange and bad are different things. I only worry about the bad kind."

"…I worry about the strange kind too."

"…That's the part where you and I differ."

Tyche said that and smiled. It wasn't an unkind smile. It was just a smile confirming that we were different.

Watching this water channel, I felt it again. The Consensus had hidden nothing about this water. There was nothing to hide. It was simply that no one had ever brought it before a matter. And yet that fact — that no one had brought it up — hadn't stopped the water from rising into the middle of the city. If a system only stops something once something bad has happened, then anything that isn't bad can go on coming in, without any check at all, for as long as it likes.

If this city was always asking me one question, it was probably this: is something no one did the same as nothing happening at all? I had only ever thought of this question in terms of people — the person from eleven years ago, the four hundred people, the signature box. But watching the water channel, I understood for the first time that this same question applied just as much to something that wasn't a person. Water that no one had blocked kept coming in, for no other reason than that no one had blocked it. It was good water. But the way it came in, itself, wouldn't let me rest easy.

I left my window open that night. The sound of water drifted faintly down the alley. I fell asleep listening to it. The next day, I decided to take a step I'd been putting off for a long time — going to meet, in person, the one I had only ever known by number.

(Continued in Chapter 35.)

Chapter 35. One of the Seventh Classification

> *_Previously_ — The water channel had come inside the city, but with*
> *no matter behind it, no one dealt with it. People simply began using the water. That night, I decided to take a step I'd been putting off for a long time — going to meet, in person, the one I had only ever known by number.*

The deliberation I'd first been assigned, long ago, concerned people grouped under the Seventh Classification. The summary had been accurate, the procedure had followed the regulations, and it was only after reading the full text to the end that I'd understood what was actually happening. Of the people reassigned by that deliberation, I had never, in all this time, actually met a single one. The roster held only numbers. 7-118, 7-119, 7-120. No name appeared anywhere.

I still don't think being called only by a number is a bad system, in this city. There really was discrimination that it reduced. It's only that, somewhere along the way, it kept nagging at me that I had never once seen the person behind that number.

The day after I saw the water channel, I found the first number on that roster and went to the reassignment district. It was about an hour's walk.

The whole way there, I practiced what I would say. I tried starting with, "Hello, I'm a district-assembly assistant member," but it sounded too official, and I gave that up. "Do you happen to remember

me" was strange too — there was no reason a person I'd never met would remember me. In the end I arrived at the entrance of the district without having settled on a single sentence.

Writing this chapter, I admit again how long I'd put off this walk. Earlier I'd said I wanted to meet that warehouse manager I only knew by number. And still I put it off for months after that. I told myself, at the time, that it was because I was busy. Looking at it now, that was an excuse. I think I was simply afraid.

. . .

The reassignment district was newly built communal housing at the city's eastern edge. The buildings were clean, well kept. I hesitated a moment out front. I'd made up my mind to come, but standing at the door I still didn't know what to say.

I gave my number at the front desk and stated my purpose. I said I was a district-assembly assistant member, and that I had something to confirm relating to a past deliberation. That much explanation was enough. No one in this city pressed for more.

"…You're 7-118?"

The desk clerk sent word inside. A little while later, a person came out.

. . .

They looked much older than me — around my aunt's age, maybe. Their clothes were plain, their hands rough. There was no particular wariness in their face at seeing me.

"…You're from the district assembly?"

"…Yes. I'm Hora."

"…Hora. What brings you here?"

Their voice was calm. Not knowing how to begin, I simply told the truth.

"…The thirteenth deliberation I was ever assigned was the Seventh Classification matter. I read the full text to the end, that time, and since then I've never actually met anyone who really knows what happened to them because of that deliberation."

"…So you came to find me?"

"…Yes. It might sound strange, but I just wanted to meet you."

They looked at me a moment, and smiled slightly.

"…It's not strange. If anything, you're the first person who's ever come to me over something like this."

. . .

We sat on a bench outside the building. They spoke first.

"…I know that deliberation. It was the result that came down to me."

"…How was it, at the time?"

"…Angry, at first. But looking back, it wasn't all bad. I got a place to live here, and work too."

"…But the deliberation document only had the reassignment in it. It didn't say how you were actually living, after."

"…That would be right. A document only writes down as far as the decision. What comes after is just living, so."

That was new to me. Up until then I'd thought reading a deliberation document to the end meant knowing everything. But life went on after the document. That was a part no document could hold.

"…Where did you live before?"

"…South side of the city. I did small farm work there. Here, instead of farm work, I manage this housing complex. It wasn't work my hands knew, but I'm used to it now."

"…Did you like the farm work better?"

"…It's less about liking it or not — it was work I'd done for over twenty years. My body didn't take to a different kind of work right away, when I started."

"…That doesn't show up in the document either."

"…No. The document just says 'reassignment complete.' It doesn't hold things like how long it took my hands to get used to it."

Hearing this, I thought of that warehouse manager Tyche and I had read about, side by side. The one moved to office work — they were probably going through something like a similar span of time right now, I thought. I decided, in that moment, that I needed to go meet that person too, someday.

. . .

"…You're 7-118. But what's your real name?"

Asking this, I worried for a moment whether I was being rude. But they didn't seem to mind at all.

"…I have one, of course."

"…Could I ask what it is?"

They looked at me a long while, then said,

"…I'll tell you. But why do you want to know?"

"…Just — I wanted to call you something besides a number."

They told me their name.

I won't write that name here. There are several people in this record whose names I keep from the page, but this person's is the one I hold back the longest. I'll write the reason in chapter 48. For now, I'll only set down the moment of hearing it.

Hearing that name, I felt strangely at ease. That there really was a name behind a person I'd only known by number felt like a confirmation I shouldn't have needed to make, and yet, needless as it was, it landed heavily in me.

"…That's a pretty name."

"…Thank you. But no one calls me by it here."

"…Why not?"

"…The number's easier. It's on all the paperwork, and everyone calls me by it. It hurt at first, but now I just take it as how things are."

. . .

"…It hurt, but you got used to it?"

"…Not so much got used to it — I just don't have the strength to be hurt by it every time. Living comes first."

That sounded like something Tyche often said. Doing today's work. And yet this person's "today's work" carried a different weight than Tyche's had.

"…Are you all right now, then?"

"…I'm all right. The first few months after the reassignment were hard, but I'm settled here now. There's work, there are neighbors."

"…Do you think everything about that deliberation turned out well?"

They thought a moment at this question.

"…Not everything. A few things I still don't understand. Why I had to come here specifically, why nowhere else would do. But I have to save my strength for that too — questioning it."

"…Temel said something about saving strength too."

"…Who?"

"…Ah, never mind. Someone I know said something similar."

Just then a child ran up and pressed close beside them. Looked around seven or eight.

"…My neighbor's child. We got close since I came here."

The child looked me over and asked,

"…What's your number?"

I didn't understand for a moment.

"…Your number. Everyone here has one."

"…Ah — I don't live here, so I don't have a number."

The child looked at me, astonished.

"…There are people without numbers?"

The person beside her stroked her hair and laughed.

"…There are more people without numbers outside than with them, you know."

The child ran off again, looking unconvinced.

I turned this short exchange over for a long time. To this child, a number wasn't strange — it was simply how things were. I was the strange one, for having none. Watching a child who'd grown up without a number outside this city grow up, inside it, taking a number for granted, I felt something I couldn't quite name. No one here was a bad person, and still that seat didn't sit easily with me.

. . .

"…Why are you this curious, Hora? About someone like me?"

I couldn't answer this right away. I thought a moment and said,

"…I've only ever seen people inside documents. Only by number. But that isn't really that person, is it. I wanted to know that."

"…What changes, knowing it?"

"…I don't know. I just think — once I know, I'll read that document differently, the next time."

They nodded.

"…That sounds like reason enough to me."

I held onto that answer for a long time. Reason enough. I'd been doubting, myself, up until then, whether what I was doing had reason enough behind it. And of all people, the person who had actually been inside that document was the one who told me my reason was enough. That, strangely, left me feeling lighter.

. . .

"…But I still don't really understand what the Seventh Classification actually is," I asked. "It's just a category, isn't it. But what standard is inside it."

"…I don't know exactly either. I was just told, one day, that I'd been placed in that classification."

"…Don't they tell you the reason?"

"…They do. It's all in the document. It's divided by a few standards — residential district, occupation, household makeup. I read that document too. But even reading it, I couldn't quite make out why those particular standards had put me here, of all places."

"…Doesn't that seem strange to you?"

"…It does. But it isn't just me who's strange about it — hundreds of people similar to me came in here together. So it wasn't like I was singled out. That's a small comfort, at least."

That echoed something Tyche had said, talking about the four hundred people. That no one was singled out. I only truly felt, for the first time, how that could be a comfort, hearing it in this person's voice. Reading it in a document, it had just been a number. Now, the person behind that number was taking that same fact as their own comfort.

In that moment I thought of Tyche again. She would have explained this situation in exactly those terms. And this person, in much the same way Tyche did, was steadying themselves. Watching this, I confirmed again that Tyche's logic really was, in this city, a way that let people hold on. That's the reason I can't bring myself to hate that logic.

. . .

The sun was going down. As I stood to leave, I asked one last thing.

"…Could I come see you again?"

"…Of course. Any time."

"…Next time, could I ask you about that warehouse manager too? I wondered if you might know them."

"…Well, all sorts of people from all sorts of districts end up living mixed together here. I can ask around for you."

"…Thank you."

"…But Hora — if you go looking for people one at a time like this, when will you meet them all? There must be quite a few of us."

That made me laugh.

"…I might not meet everyone. But meeting one at a time seemed better than not meeting anyone at all."

"…That's true too."

"…But next time, what should I call you? By number, or by name?"

They smiled a little.

"…Whichever's easier for you. Either's fine with me."

I said goodbye and turned to go. The whole way home, I repeated that name inside myself, over and over. I didn't write it on paper. This time, I decided not to put it in the drawer. I wanted to keep this name somewhere other than that drawer. I didn't know exactly where, even then.

Writing this record now, I still don't set that name down here. I'll wait until chapter 48. Until that day, this name stays with me alone. I think that's the most honest thing I can do, writing this chapter.

I got home and told my aunt what had happened that day. She listened quietly and said,

"…Good that you got the name, then."

"…Yeah. But strangely, just that seems to have changed something."

"…What changed?"

I couldn't answer that right away. I only had the feeling that something had changed. Putting that feeling into words would take more time.

My aunt asked again.

"…Aren't you going to tell me the name either?"

"…No. Not yet."

"…Why?"

"…I don't know. I just want to keep it that way."

My aunt didn't press further. Instead she said this.

"…You know, Hora, I've noticed lately — you keep holding things back. The papers, and now this name too."

"…Is that strange?"

"…Not strange, but I do wonder what it's all for."

I couldn't answer that either. Even I didn't know exactly what it was all for. But the act of holding something back, itself, felt like the only way I knew to treat something as precious.

Writing this chapter, I bring that evening back again. For a while after receiving that name, I grew strangely careful. Even reading a document, whenever I saw a number, I became aware there might be a name behind it. What had changed wasn't the document. The document stayed the same. What had changed was me.

That night before falling asleep, I shaped that name silently with my lips, without any sound. Somehow, saying it out loud felt like it would use it up. Why I felt that way, I still can't explain exactly, even now. I'll only set down here that the night passed quietly, that way.

(Continued in Chapter 36.)

Chapter 36. Three Days

> *_Previously_ — I met, in person, one of the Seventh Classification I had only ever known by number. That person had a name. I heard that name and passed it on to no one. I didn't put it in the drawer. That night I shaped it silently with my lips, without any sound.*

The next morning, getting ready for the district hall as usual, I looked at the documents stacked on my desk. Three new matters had been assigned the day before. I picked one up, and set it back down.

I didn't want to read it.

Writing this sentence, I still find it strange. Through this whole book I've introduced myself as "someone who reads." Reading was the one thing I was good at. And that morning, I didn't want to do the one thing.

Why I felt that way, I still can't explain in a single sentence, even now. It probably had something to do with how much I'd heard in just a few days. Tyche's there isn't one, Temel's I don't know, the Secretary's convening from eleven years ago, and now that name behind a number. I hadn't come to know any of it by reading. Most of it I'd come to know by hearing it, or living through it. And yet I felt myself wanting to sort it all back into something like a document, and I didn't like that in myself.

I don't know exactly why I disliked that urge to sort things, either. Sorting isn't a bad thing. I've gotten through, all this time, by sorting. It's only that, that morning, I wanted to choose leaving

things be, over sorting them. If you asked me for a reason, I couldn't give one. That's the honest start of this chapter.

My aunt saw this and asked,

"…What's wrong, are you not feeling well?"

"…No. I just don't want to read, today."

My aunt wasn't especially surprised.

"…All right. Then rest."

I hadn't meant to rest. I didn't know exactly what I meant to do, then, either. My hand simply wouldn't go to the document.

. . .

The first day, I did nothing at all. I sent word to the district hall that I wasn't feeling well. That wasn't a lie. I couldn't explain exactly what was wrong, but something was wrong, truly.

At home that day, my eyes went to the documents on the desk more than once. I stopped my hand from reaching for them, more than once. I learned, that day, for the first time, how strong a habit could be.

With nothing to do, I looked for something I could do with my hands. I sat beside my aunt and helped with her sewing. Threaded needles, sewed on buttons. While I concentrated on my fingertips, thoughts of letters came less often. My aunt seemed to find it curious that I was sitting beside her, and glanced at me more than once.

Around noon I went out to the back garden and repotted some plants. While I handled the soil, my hands stopped thinking of other things. With soil on my hands, I couldn't touch paper anyway. I liked that. It felt like my body was, on its own, keeping me away from reading.

"…You don't usually do this."

"…I wanted to, today."

"…Bored?"

"…No. I just wanted to keep my hands moving at something."

My aunt didn't ask further and handed me another piece of sewing. I took it and focused a long while on the sound of thread passing through cloth.

Tyche stopped by that evening, worried about me.

"…Are you sick somewhere?"

"…No. I'm just not going to read anything today."

"…Why?"

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…I don't know. I just want to."

Tyche looked at me a moment and said,

"…That's not like you, Hora."

"…I know."

Saying that, I truly felt that I wasn't like myself. And at the same time, I felt this was the most like myself thing I could do right now. That the two feelings could exist at once was the strangest part of that night.

. . .

On the second day, I learned that not reading anything was far harder than I'd expected.

Out on the street, letters caught my eye everywhere. A notice in a shop window, a bulletin on a wall, a paper in a passerby's hand. I turned my eyes away on purpose to avoid reading them. I hadn't known how hard that was until I decided not to read.

It was harder still at home. I kept thinking of the twelve pages my mother had left, of the papers in that drawer. I didn't open the drawer. If I opened it, I would surely end up reading something.

On the way back from the distribution station, I walked with my eyes half lowered. Notices, announcements, posted bulletins. All of it looked as though it were trying to say something to me. I worked to take in none of it, and that cost far more energy than I'd expected. By the time I got home I was far more exhausted than usual, though I hadn't done any physical work at all.

I thought hard that night about where this exhaustion had come from. My conclusion was that not reading was, in the end, an act in itself. It wasn't doing nothing — it was continuing to choose not to read. Choosing takes effort. I hadn't known that, until then. I'd always thought reading was simply something I did without thinking.

What these three days meant to me, I didn't know exactly, at the time. I don't know exactly now, writing this either. But I know one thing. In these three days I decided nothing. I didn't do anything you could call prayer. I never once asked to be shown something. I simply didn't read.

My aunt asked on the evening of the second day.

"…Are you waiting for something?"

"…No."

"…Then why are you like this?"

"…I don't really know myself. It just feels like not reading is the right thing right now."

My aunt didn't press further, hearing that. Instead she spooned an extra scoop of rice into my bowl.

. . .

On the third day, I ran out of things to do inside the house. I cleaned, folded laundry, and once all that was done, the afternoon was left.

I went outside and walked along the water channel. The water was still making its sound. I listened to it. Listening to a sound wasn't reading.

Through these three days, trying not to look at letters, I ended up listening to sound a great deal instead. The water's sound, people's

voices, the noise of the market. Things that were usually drowned out by letters came through unusually loud, during those three days.

Passing through the market, I walked by the notice board. It was the same spot where Temel used to stand. A few sheets were posted there. I walked by without reading them. My steps slowed a little, though.

People were still sitting on the bench by the water, feet in the current. I sat there too, for a moment. I didn't take off my shoes. I just sat and listened to the sound of the water.

Sitting on that bench, I felt, for the first time in a long while, what it was to do nothing at all. Not reading, not worrying — just sitting and listening to water. I realized then how rare a time like that had been for me. I was always reading something, or thinking about what I'd read, or choosing what to read next.

An old man sitting nearby spoke to me.

"…Do you come here often, miss?"

"…I've been coming often, lately."

"…Something good must be happening. You look at ease."

"…Not something good, exactly. I'm just taking a few days off."

"…Resting's the best thing there is."

The old man said that and looked back at the water. I turned that line over in my mind. Resting's the best thing there is. I didn't fully agree with it, but somehow, that day, I didn't want to argue either.

I sat a long while longer, listening to the water brush over the top of my feet. The sun leaned a little lower. No one hurried me.

. . .

I ran into the Secretary by chance, in front of the front desk.

"…You haven't been in for a few days, Hora."

"…No. Personal matters."

"…Are you all right?"

"…Yes. I'm just trying a few days without reading."

The Secretary looked at me a moment, hearing that. He didn't ask what it meant.

"…Then go on that way. When you're back, I'll help you catch up on what's piled up."

"…Thank you."

That was all. The Secretary didn't press for the reason, and I didn't explain it. This short exchange, that day, felt strangely restful to me.

Turning to go, the Secretary added one more thing.

"…Hora."

"…Yes?"

"…Not reading anything at all seems like its own kind of way, too."

Saying that, the Secretary went back inside the front desk. I stood a long while, trying to work out what he meant. I couldn't tell whether it was meant as comfort, or simply an observation. Probably, for this man, the two weren't different things.

. . .

That evening, the third day, Tyche came again.

"…Are you done now? It's been three days."

"…You were counting?"

"…Yes. I was curious."

"…I still don't really know. But I'm going to stop after tonight."

"…What's changed, not reading?"

I thought a long while before answering.

"…Nothing in particular came into view. I just learned how much I've been living leaning on reading."

"…Is that bad?"

"…No, it isn't bad. But leaning on it, and being able to get through without it — those seemed like different questions to me."

Tyche nodded.

"…If you found that out, then three days wasn't wasted."

I still don't quite know whether I can call these three days a fast. I asked for nothing. There was no revelation. The sky didn't open, and no one spoke to me. For three days, I simply didn't do the one thing I was best at.

Before leaving, Tyche asked,

"…But why three days, specifically? Not four, not two."

"…I don't know. Three just felt right."

"…On what basis?"

"…None. It was just a feeling."

Tyche laughed at that.

"…It's been a while since I heard you say there's no basis for something."

"…I know. It's strange to me too."

Writing this conversation, I laugh again. Tyche knew I was someone who always tried to give a basis for everything. That I'd chosen three days with no basis at all must have struck her as funny. It did me too.

My aunt said one thing at my door that night before bed.

"…You'll go back to reading tomorrow?"

"…Yes."

"…Good, then. I figured you couldn't keep it up much longer anyway."

"…I thought so too."

My aunt gave a short laugh and closed the door. I lay in the dark and went back over those three days. Nothing special had happened. I simply hadn't read for three days, and for those three days the world had gone on turning exactly as always. The water channel had kept flowing, the market had kept bustling, and the signature box had stayed blank, I imagined, the whole time. Whether I read or not, none of it waited for me. That fact didn't make me feel small, and it didn't make me feel large either. It only let me know that this was so.

. . .

On the morning of the fourth day, I picked up the document on my desk again. My hand felt a little unfamiliar. Like something I hadn't held in a long time.

I read the first line. The familiar feeling came right back. I read that document to the end, as I always did. There was nothing special about it. It was an ordinary matter.

Reading it, I noticed something strange. Three days of rest hadn't given me some new pair of eyes. I read at the same speed as before, still read to the end, still looked for the signature box first. Not a single thing seemed to have changed.

But there was exactly one small difference. Before, reading had been something like breathing to me. It just happened on its own. Now, reading felt like something I was choosing again, every single time. If you stop breathing, you die. Reading was something I could live without. I'd confirmed that in my body, over those three days. Which

meant that what I was doing now, reading, was something I'd chosen to do even though I could have not done it.

This might sound like a grand realization. But I don't want to write it that way. Just as a person doesn't suddenly become someone else after three days without food, I didn't become someone else after three days without reading. I'd simply done, again, after not doing it, the thing I'd always done. Beyond that, truly, nothing happened at all.

I feel the temptation to write that these three days took me nowhere. But that doesn't seem exactly right either. I was still myself, three days later. Only, over those three days, I confirmed — not without choosing, but by choosing — for the first time, that I was someone who reads. Whether that's a small difference or a large one, I still don't know exactly, even now.

Having read the document to the end, I looked at the signature box at the bottom. Blank. As always.

I looked at that box a long while. A little longer than before.

Tyche, sorting papers at the next seat, looked over at me.

"…How does it feel, reading again?"

"…The same. But the same feels strange, somehow."

"…What does?"

"…Nothing changed in three days, and yet I feel like I confirmed something."

"…What did you confirm?"

I answered without taking my eyes off the signature box.

"…That I keep looking at this. That I didn't have to, and I keep looking at it anyway."

Tyche didn't say much in response to that. She just nodded once and turned her eyes back to her papers. I found that silence restful.

Recording these three days, I've decided to attach no ending to this chapter. The temptation came, more than once, to write it as though something great had begun. But that isn't true. What I did, after three days, was simply pick up a document. Only, that hand, the same hand as three days before, felt slightly different to me. I don't yet have the words to explain that difference.

(Continued in Part Four.)

The Unsigned Book, Part Four

The Name

Chapter 37. What It Is to Write It

> *_Previously_ — Hora read no documents for three days. Reading was the*
> *only thing she knew how to do, so stopping it was her fast.*

On the third night I opened the drawer.

The same drawer that had held my mother's papers. Other things live there now. A notice, a copy of a summary, and the second page of the work guidelines I'd first been given. I took that page out and unfolded it.

There was a box at the bottom. A long, horizontal box. The signature box.

I had seen this box more times than I could count. Every day for over two hundred days. It was on every document, and empty on every document. I thought that was the rule. I still haven't fully learned, in this city, how to tell a rule from a habit.

Below the box, in small print, it read: *(This notice does not require a signature.)*

Does not require. I read that sentence again. The same sentence I'd read two hundred days before read differently to me now.

Does not require doesn't mean do not. I already knew this. I'd learned it back in Part Three. But knowing it, and holding it in your hand and looking at it quietly, are different things.

. . .

For three days I read no documents.

At first I thought I was simply resting. From the second day it started to feel strange. My hand kept reaching for the paper on the table. The third time my hand reached for it, I realized what I'd been doing. I wasn't holding myself back from reading — the habit of reading had worked its way into my body and was moving on its own.

I already called this a fast at the end of Part Three. I didn't know exactly why, then. Writing it again now, I can say it a little more precisely. Reading was how I proved myself to myself. When I stopped reading, I no longer knew what I was proven by.

On the afternoon of the third day, Tyche stopped by the house. She came even though it wasn't work hours.

"…Are you all right?"

"…Yeah. Just not reading."

"…Why?"

I couldn't answer. Tyche didn't press further either. She sat for a while and then left. At the door she turned back once, as if to say something, and didn't. I only understood what that had been much later.

. . .

I thought of the first day I'd asked the Secretary. When I'd asked what happens if you write your name, he'd looked away.

After that I asked several other people the same thing. I looked for a rulebook. I looked for a prohibition. There wasn't one. There really

wasn't one. All there was, was the box.

Nobody stopped me. I've written this sentence many times already, and I will write it many more. It is the most repeated sentence I say in this book. Nobody stopped me.

If someone had stopped me, it would have been easier, in a way. If there's someone stopping you, you can be angry at that person. But there was no one. The box was simply empty. Built, from the start, so that anyone could fill it.

My aunt opened my door without knocking. She's a person who doesn't knock. She's been that way since I was small.

"…Still not asleep?"

"…No."

My aunt came in and sat beside me. She looked at the paper and said nothing. After a long while she asked.

"…What's that?"

"…Work guidelines. The first ones I got."

"…Why are you looking at that again?"

I couldn't answer. My aunt didn't ask again either.

. . .

My aunt didn't know, that night, what I was about to do. Neither did I. Let me be honest as I write this chapter: I hadn't decided anything

yet. The decision comes much later. This chapter isn't the decision — it's the place you have to pass through before it.

The place where you just look at the box.

I rubbed the box with my fingertip. The paper was just paper. No special texture. With no ink on it, it was smooth. The other boxes — the date box, the agenda number box — had letters printed on them, so their surface was slightly rough. Only the signature box, having nothing on it, was smooth.

I felt, for the first time that night, that the smoothness was frightening. I hadn't known before then that nothing being there could be frightening. If I'd believed emptiness was a wrong thing, I'd have been afraid of it long before. As long as I believed the emptiness was a rule, it only looked comfortable to me.

. . .

Beside the box, there was no instruction to write a name. No title, no affiliation. Just a box. It didn't even say whether it was a place for a name, or a place for something else.

I learned later. That box hadn't been designed, from the start, to hold anything in particular. It was simply a box left standing by custom. Long ago it had appeared in some form, and no one had ever erased it, so it had kept being carried forward. There had simply been no one to propose erasing it.

Not erasing something and keeping it on purpose are different things. I confused the two for a long time. The people of this city confuse them too. Not erasing something just means no one touched it. Keeping it means someone did so with intent.

That night I suddenly wanted to look up old forms. Not the one I'd taken from the drawer — the older forms in the archive room. But the archive room was closed at night, and I didn't bother going out to get a key.

This part might look trivial, but I want to set it down. I didn't rush out that night to check. There was no urgency. I hope the reader of this book won't picture me as someone being chased by something. I wasn't being chased. I was simply looking, for a long time.

Instead I remembered what I'd seen in the archive room before. The day I'd opened twenty pages from the front. Back then I was struck that the signature box was empty; I hadn't paid attention to the shape of the box itself. Recalling it again now, those boxes had all been in the same place, the same size. I also remembered that on the older documents the box was slightly wider. Which meant that even as the city changed its forms several times, this box alone had never been removed — only carried forward.

Not removed. I come back to that phrase again. It wasn't that no one said to remove it — it could have been erased at any time, if anyone had wanted to. The Consensus does actually remove things it judges unnecessary. There are quite a few old procedures that have vanished, which I only learned once I reached Part Four. But this box stayed.

Whether that's a meaningful staying, or just a staying because nobody cared — I won't give the answer here. This whole book is my answer to that question, and I'm saving the answer for the last chapter.

. . .

This box is on the side of the not-erased. And yet every time I looked at it, it felt kept. Whether that's my own delusion, or not a delusion

at all, I still can't be sure even after finishing this book.

. . .

I thought again of the person who'd written a name eleven years before. That one line I'd found once. A name, a date, and the record cut off after that.

I never found out, in the end, why it cut off — whether the person had died, or left, or simply stopped writing. I keep writing that the Equity hides nothing, but on this one point I have to be honest. I couldn't even tell whether I hadn't found it because it wasn't there, or because it was there and I still couldn't find it. Full openness doesn't always mean full discovery.

Temel is different. Temel is still alive, and is still being called in. I've already written about that. If there's one thing the person from eleven years ago and Temel have in common, it's this: once each of them filled that box, their own name stopped being only theirs. Wherever that name appeared on a document, it followed.

I also thought again of the moment I first heard the word review. The Secretary had explained it wasn't a punishment. Not a punishment, just being called out again and again. When I heard that explanation, I'd thought, in fact, that it was more frightening for exactly that reason — though at the time I couldn't say why in words.

I can say it now. Punishment has an end. There's a term, there's a fine, and once you've served or paid it, it's over. Review has no end. As long as even one case bearing that name remains, being called remains too. In this city, deliberations keep coming into being. So a person who has once written their name, in theory, never finishes.

Temel knew all this, and wrote it anyway. That was what frightened me most, that night. Not that Temel hadn't known. That he'd known, and written it anyway.

I was afraid of that. I admitted, for the first time that night, that I was afraid.

But being afraid, and therefore not doing it, were different matters. I hadn't yet bound the two together into one, that night. Later Tyche would ask, and later I would walk without an answer. That night I hadn't gotten anywhere near that. Admitting I was afraid was the whole of what that night held.

. . .

My aunt got up and turned the light down a little. Then she sat back down.

"…Hora."

"…Yeah."

"…Are you going to write it?"

I folded the paper. I answered as I folded it.

"…I don't know yet."

My aunt looked at my face and asked one more time.

"…Are you scared?"

"…Yeah."

"…I'm scared too."

I looked at my aunt. She didn't ask back what she was scared of. Neither did I explain further. We just traded one sentence each and stopped.

My aunt never tried to stop me after that night. Nor did she push me on. I think now that was the largest thing she could have given me. Not making the decision for me.

My aunt seemed to believe that answer. And in fact, that night, I truly didn't know. It would make this book tidier to write that I did know, but it isn't true.

I promised at the start to write honestly. So I'll write honestly here too. That night, I hadn't decided anything at all. I only looked at the box, touched it with my fingertip, folded it, and put it back in the drawer.

But after that night, I saw that box differently. Before, I had seen something empty. Now I saw something that could be filled. The same box — and yet the two are entirely different things.

. . .

Before closing the drawer, I looked once more at the first page of the notice. *You have been assigned.* I read that sentence again.

You have been assigned. Still no one who had assigned it. Every sentence in this city takes this shape. What happened is there. Who made it happen is not.

That night, for the first time, I gave this grammar a name. Subjectless grammar. The grammar the Secretary spoke in. This whole city was built

out of that grammar.

And the signature box was, within that grammar, the one place where a subject could be put in. A place no one had stopped anyone from filling. A place no one had ever filled.

. . .

I didn't close the drawer. I sat beside it for a long while.

My aunt went back to her room. I heard the door close. After that the house grew quiet. The nights of this city are quiet by nature. There's seldom any reason to make a sound.

I wrote before that I loved this city for its quietness. That's still true now. Even that night, I didn't hate this city. I want to set this down clearly. I wasn't looking at that box in anger, then. I looked at it while still loving this city.

That loving something and leaving it as it is aren't the same thing — that night, I began, faintly, to understand this. It would be a lie to say I understood it exactly. It was faint.

I opened the second page of the work guidelines again. I looked at the signature box again.

What I would write in that box hadn't been decided yet. More exactly, even whether I would write anything hadn't been decided. I only looked at it for a long time, the way a person memorizes a shape. So many boxes across, so many down, the thickness of the border. I still can't explain why I was trying to memorize such things.

One thing had become clear. That box had been there from the start. It had been there my first day at work, in the very first deliberation document, at the bottom of every document I'd read over more than two hundred days. No one had ever removed that box. No one had ever hidden it either.

If the Consensus had ever hidden anything, it would have hidden this box. But the Consensus didn't hide it. Instead, every single time, at the bottom of every document, it printed it honestly. Even empty, the very fact that this box was there had never once been concealed.

I realized this that night. This city had hidden nothing from me. That the box existed, that it went unfilled, that filling it wasn't forbidden — all of it had been shown to me from the beginning. I was the one who hadn't looked. For two hundred days I saw that box every day, and never once asked what it meant.

Seeing the box and asking about the box are different things. That night, for the first time, I asked.

Near dawn, I glanced out the window for a moment. I could still hear sound from the direction of the water channel. Even at this hour, the water was flowing. Water that had never once come before an agenda, still flowing on, unconcerned with agendas.

Listening to that sound, I thought. There are things in this city that go on without ever coming before an agenda. The water channel is one. And maybe this box was one too. Whether anyone brought it up as an agenda item or not, the box would go on being there. Whether I filled it or not.

That thought put me a little at ease. Whatever I did, that box wasn't going to disappear. There was no need to hurry. That was the one conclusion I reached that night. That I didn't need to hurry.

I folded the paper again and put it back in the drawer.
I hadn't decided. But the question remained. I slept holding that question.

(Continued in Chapter 38.)

Chapter 38. Why I Read

> *_Previously_ — On the third night, Hora takes out the signature box*
> *again. The box had been there from the start. No one had ever stopped*
> *her. The decision hadn't come yet — only the question remained.*

The next morning I took out the full text of the Seventh Classification deliberation again.

It wasn't because the three days of not reading were over. There was still one more day left. But I decided to make that one document an exception. I'd already read it many times, and reading it again wasn't going to produce a new sentence.

It was a long time before I understood why I'd opened it again that morning. I hadn't been trying to read it anew. I had been trying to read the reason why I'd read it so many times.

My aunt asked, while making breakfast.

"…Weren't you not reading until today?"

"…Except this one."

"…Why."

I looked at my aunt without having an answer ready. She didn't wait for one. She just ladled the soup. That's the kind of person she is. She can ask a question and not feel slighted if it goes unanswered.

That morning, at the table, was the first time I genuinely asked myself why I was holding on to this document the way I was. Before that, I hadn't asked — I'd only read. Asking and reading, just like looking at the signature box, turned out to be different things.

We ate later than usual. My aunt didn't hurry me either. The sound of the water channel drifted in faintly from outside. That sound wasn't any different from usual. Only I was a little different from usual.

. . .

I'd read this document to the end, from the front, once already. Over forty pages. The summary was a page and a half, and it was accurate. I'd read that summary, and I'd read the full text, and after that I'd read it again, many more times.

Why did I read it so many times? At first I thought it was to check. In case I'd missed something. But no matter how many times I reread it, there was nothing I'd missed. I'd known from the start that the summary was accurate.

So what was I trying to confirm?

I properly asked myself this question for the first time that morning. Before, I hadn't even known the shape of the question. I'd simply kept reading.

I thought of Tyche. She'd once asked me why I read the way I did. I couldn't answer, then. I only said it was habit. Habit was true, but it was a word that put off the answer rather than giving it. I hadn't said, then, where the habit came from.

I wasn't trying to hide it. I simply didn't know either. For over two hundred days I'd used that habit every day, and never once properly looked into where it had come from.

. . .

I thought of my mother.

Twelve pages. I'd stopped reading at the third page, once. At the sentence, "This should be enough to get you through the winter." I'd thought that was all there was.

I read the rest two years later. On the last line of the last page, these words were there. *I only hope you'll be someone who reads to the end. I missed a great deal because I wasn't.*

I already wrote this story once, near the beginning. Back then I only wrote it as background — as the reason I became someone who reads everything to the end. I let the story be the story, and never brought it back up after that. I need to bring it back up in this chapter. That it wasn't background but a reason — I'm only admitting that now.

I'd calculated those two years many times. About 730 days. A sentence my mother had written thinking of me had waited for me in a drawer for 730 days. I hadn't received that sentence for all that time.

Not received — that's not exact. Exactly: I hadn't read it. Receiving and reading are different. The paper had been in my hand. I simply hadn't read it.

That morning I thought again about why I hadn't read it, back then. I'd been afraid. Afraid of the word last words. Afraid that once I heard the last thing someone had to say, there would truly be nothing after it.

That fear wasn't a wrong fear. If you hear the last words, there really is nothing after them. I had a right to be afraid of that. For an eleven-year-old, that fear was only natural. That morning, admitting this, I decided for the first time not to blame the girl I'd been.

If there was anyone to blame, it might have been the me of now — the one who, for two years, hadn't given that fear a name and had simply put it in a drawer. But even that's hard to blame. For a thirteen-year-old, was there really any way other than putting it in a drawer?

. . .

Back to the Seventh Classification document.

Reading it over and over, I'd thought I was looking for something. A hidden sentence, a missing word, someone's mistake. But there was none. There really was none. The summary was accurate, the evidence was all there, the procedure had no flaw.

And yet I kept reading it again.

That morning I admitted this. The reason I kept rereading it wasn't that I thought something might be hidden in the document. It was that I was afraid I might miss something again.

Like the sentence I'd missed at thirteen. Like the sentence I hadn't received for 730 days. I never wanted to do that again. I'd already written that at the very beginning of this book. But back then I hadn't written it knowing exactly what it meant.

Now I know. I hadn't read that document to the end out of a sense of justice. I read it because I was afraid of missing something again.

I opened the document again from the beginning. This time I wasn't reading to check the content. I read it to see where my own reading slowed down.

The parts covered in the summary I read quickly. I already knew that content. The place it slowed down was always the same spot. The short paragraphs wedged between the supporting materials and the record of processing. The place where each person involved had left a one-line note. "Confirmed." "Passed on." "No objection." Lines like that.

I learned, that day, why I'd always read those lines so slowly. It was because that was the place that looked most like it had nothing in it. Lines carrying no feeling, no meaning at all. I read them slowly because I was afraid there was something in there. More exactly, I read them slowly because I wanted to confirm that there was nothing there.

And there really was nothing there. I must have checked each of those lines a hundred times over, in effect. To confirm there was nothing.

Doing this checking, I thought again of that time, and of those people. The first person who'd said, "I only passed it on." The twelve more I'd met after. All of them people who'd left one of those lines — "passed on," "confirmed," "no objection" — as their own share.

Back then I'd thought I was going to them looking for responsibility. Thinking about it now, maybe I was looking for something else even then. Whether there was something more behind these one-line notes. Whether, the way there had been more behind my mother's third page, there was something more behind their one lines too.

There wasn't, for them. There really wasn't. That one line was the whole of it, for them. I'd been disappointed by that fact, back then. Looking at it again now, that disappointment was my own story too. Not their problem — my expectation's problem.

. . .

This isn't an easy thing to say.

I may have wanted the reader who has read this record from the start to believe I did all of this for a good reason. That would have been easier to write, too. A righteous girl who couldn't bear to watch an injustice and stood up. That kind of story is common, and it's common for a reason. Because it reads well.

But that isn't the truth. I didn't read that document to the end for the sake of the people bound up in the Seventh Classification. I read it for myself. I read it because I never wanted to become, again, a person who misses the last line.

Admitting this, strangely, put my mind at ease instead. I didn't know what that ease was, then. I know now. A person who moves for a good reason wavers when that reason wavers. Not a bad reason, but a person moving for a reason that's entirely their own has, at least, no reason of that kind to waver. I know what I missed. No one can argue me out of that.

I think it's only fair to write this too. This realization didn't make me a kinder person. I still barely knew the people of the Seventh Classification. Not their faces, not their names, not their circumstances. All I'd come to know was my own story. Knowing myself isn't the same thing as having helped them. I'm setting this paragraph apart so I don't mistake the two for each other.

Only — knowing myself honestly made what I did next honest. That much is true.

. . .

That afternoon Tyche came again. It was the last day of the three.

She saw I had the document open, and looked a little surprised.

"…Reading it again?"

"…Yeah. I made this one an exception."

"…What's different about it?"

I thought for a moment before answering.

"…This is me reading why I read."

Tyche looked at that sentence for a long while. Her face wasn't one of not understanding. It was closer to one that understood too well to find anything to say back.

"…So, did you find the answer?"

"…Yeah."

"…What was it?"

I hesitated, then said it.

"…There's something I missed once, a long time ago. So I read so I won't miss anything again. Not because of those people."

Tyche said nothing. She didn't tease me, and she didn't say it was admirable. She just nodded once.

"…So what if it is."

I didn't fully understand, that day, what that meant. Whether it meant it wasn't a bad reason, or that reasons were always this small and

personal to begin with, or just that it was no big deal. Whichever it was, Tyche didn't let me down.

. . .

It would sound too grand to say this realization changed me. Not much changed. I was still the same person, and I still had the same document. Only one thing was different.

Before this, I'd thought of myself as an accuser. Someone who'd seen an injustice and meant to expose it. An accuser has to stand on the right side. I kept having to check whether I was really standing on the right side.

That checking often froze me in place. Am I really right. Am I really doing this for these people. Are my motives pure. These questions have no end, and they keep you from moving until you find the answer. For those couple hundred days, I'd been stopped in front of this question, in effect, the whole time.

Now I was simply someone trying to fill a certain box. Someone who couldn't stand an empty space — the way I once couldn't stand one. That wasn't a matter of right and wrong. It was just my own matter.

Someone who wants to fill a thing doesn't have to keep proving their motive over and over. They just see something empty and their hand moves. I felt, that night, how large that difference was. I hadn't been unable to move, all that time — I'd been inspecting myself before I could move. Once I stopped inspecting, I could move.

An accuser has to prove herself. A person who fills a box just fills it.

. . .

After Tyche left I sat by the window for a long while and looked outside. It was the hour the sun goes down.

In that hour I thought about why I'd been able to say all this, even to Tyche, only that simply. "There's something I missed once, a long time ago." It was too short a sentence to hold the real reason. But I hadn't found a way to say it any longer, then, and even now, writing this record, I still can't fully find one.

Some things don't carry over completely into sentences. I've felt this many times while writing this book. This chapter especially. I'm doing my best right now to explain that day's self, and something still slips out anyway.

Admitting that something slips out may itself be part of reading to the end. Setting down even the part I couldn't fully capture.

That evening I took out the twelve-page paper again. The one my mother had left. It had been at the very bottom of the drawer.

I'd read it all, two years before, but had rarely taken it out since. There'd been no reason to read it. I'd already read all of it.

I hadn't taken it out that evening to find something new. I just wanted to touch it. It sounds strange, but I wanted to feel the thickness of the paper with my hand. The thinness at the point I'd stopped at the third page, and the thickness once I'd read all twelve pages — the same paper, and yet it felt different in my hand.

I opened the third page again. "This should be enough to get you through the winter."

Back then I'd thought that sentence was all there was. Reading it again now, in my mother's own way, that sentence had been enough on its own too. Teaching how to get through a winter isn't not love. At thirteen I'd thought it a small thing; now I think it was love too. It just wasn't all of it.

There'd been more on the last page. Not knowing there was more had made me who I was for two years. And now, I stand before the Seventh Classification document carrying the person those two years made.

I put the paper back in the drawer. This time I set it side by side with the work guidelines that held the signature box. I didn't mean anything particular by it. My hand simply set it down that way.

Looking back later, that arrangement was strangely exact. My mother's last line, and this city's empty last box, lay side by side in the same drawer. Both were places that needed someone to fill them to be complete. One, I'd filled far too late. The other, no one had filled yet.

I slept deeply that night, for the first time in a while. It was the first time in three days.

(Continued in Chapter 39.)

Chapter 39. Tyche's Question

> *_Previously_ — Hora faces the real reason she has always read to the*
> *end. Not a sense of justice, but that she once missed her mother's last sentence. She has become, not an accuser, but someone who wants*
> *to fill a box.*

Once the third day ended, I started reading again.

I didn't read documents at random, the way I used to. From that day on I held to exactly one document. The Seventh Classification. I read it for the twenty-first time, having already read it about twenty.

Reading it for a different reason didn't change how I read it. I still read all forty-some pages from beginning to end, skipping no line. Only this time, as I read, I began to think about what I would do.

My aunt hardly said anything to me those few days. She made meals, she returned my greeting when I left for work, and that was all. I was grateful for that. If someone had kept asking me about it, I probably would have found it even harder to decide.

The decision comes later. At that point I was still standing at that threshold. I was getting closer each day, but the approach wasn't at a speed anyone could see. From the outside, I would have just looked like a girl reading the same document over and over.

. . .

Tyche came often, around then. During work hours, and after work too. No one had told her to. In her own words, it was "just because I was curious."

I only found this strange later. When Tyche is curious about something, she usually finds the materials and works out the answer herself. Coming to visit a person, over and over, wasn't like Tyche. At the time I just thought she was worried about me. Maybe the worry was real too. The two things could be true at once.

The way Tyche came to see me was worth noting too. She always brought something in her hands. Papers laying out evidence, statistical tables, past deliberation cases. But she didn't lay them out in front of me. She just sat holding them, and only took them out once I asked about something.

"…You look at that one for a long time, whenever."

"…Yeah."

Tyche was quiet a moment, then asked.

"…Are you going to write it?"

I didn't answer right away. She didn't press me either. For a while we just sat there looking at the empty box together.

. . .

I've revisited this moment many times since. It was the first time Tyche had ever asked me something directly. Up until then Tyche had been the one observing me. The one explaining things. This time she was the one asking.

"…If you write it, what changes?"

The question seemed simple, but it wasn't. I already felt its weight at the time. Tyche was asking me about the result. And I didn't know the result.

I truly didn't know. I still don't know exactly, even now. That the new deliberation would only be reversed in part — I only came to know that later. What kind of thing review was — I only learned that in my body once I reached that chapter. At that point I stood in front of this question without having gone through any of it.

I thought of Temel just then. I could have asked him the same thing. What changed, once he wrote it. In Temel's case there's a little more of an answer. A few of his cases really were reclassified. But some others weren't. I knew this, and still didn't bring it up to Tyche. I didn't want to borrow a result that hadn't yet been confirmed.

I looked into Tyche's eyes. She was truly waiting for an answer. Her face wasn't the usual one, where she offers her own answer first and only asks for confirmation.

The office was quiet. Outside, the sound of the water channel could be heard, very faintly. I listened to that sound while I tried to find an answer. I wasn't trying to find a perfect answer. I just didn't want to lie.

I answered slowly.

"…Maybe nothing changes. But it won't be empty."

. . .

Tyche was quiet for a long time after hearing that.

"…Is that all?"

"…Yeah."

"…I don't see what meaning that has."

I didn't argue back. I also had no argument to make.

"…I don't know either. But that's everything I have, right now."

I wanted to render this exchange exactly. I wasn't dressing it up to persuade Tyche. I had no logic that day that could have persuaded her. If I'd had one, I would have used it. I didn't, so I said what I had, as it was.

That night, turning this answer over, I understood that it connected to something I'd learned earlier. Reading the same document side by side, Tyche saw the accuracy of the procedure, and I saw the empty box. We were both reading it straight. That same difference was in this conversation now. Tyche was looking at the fact that filling it changes nothing. I was looking at the fact that even so, it stops being empty. Both of us were looking at the same box and seeing different things.

I felt, for the first time that day, that these two sentences didn't contradict each other. Maybe nothing changes, and even so it won't be empty — these two things could stand together. I had thought, until then, that they collided. They didn't.

. . .

Tyche kept turning my words over in her face.

"…I still don't really understand why it matters that it won't be empty. Why is being empty a bad thing? Nobody filling it just means nobody filled it. It's not empty because someone did something wrong."

"…That's right."

Tyche fidgeted with the papers in her hand for a moment. That wasn't like her, usually.

"…I've seen a lot of deliberations, this whole time. Quite a few I sat in on as an assistant. I've never once seen the signature box filled. I thought that was just how it was. I thought it was a rule. But finding out it wasn't — it felt strange."

"…What did?"

"…Why nobody had filled it — that felt strange. It's not that you're not allowed to. I thought at first everyone just didn't know. But everyone knows. Look it up in the rulebook, it's right there. Nobody had just done it."

"…Is that what you think the probability is?"

"…No. This is the part probability can't explain. If it were probability, somebody should have filled it at least once by now. But once in eleven years — that's too rare to explain by chance."

I remember this part for a long time. It was the moment Tyche herself admitted there was a part that probability couldn't explain. But she didn't move from that admission to a different conclusion. She just admitted it and stopped there. That was Tyche.

I felt, at that moment, the temptation to press the point with her. See, it can't be explained, so there must be meaning in it — I wanted

to say that. I didn't. It felt wrong to take something Tyche had admitted herself and use it to serve my own logic. She wanted to leave that fact exactly as it was. I wanted to respect that way of hers.

"…And you still want to fill it?"

"…Yeah."

"…Why?"

I couldn't answer this question right away either. I could have said the answer I'd found before. That I'd missed something once. But that wasn't an answer to Tyche's question. She wasn't asking about my circumstances — she was asking about the meaning of the act itself.

"…I don't know. But does there have to be a reason?"

Tyche gave a small laugh at that. It wasn't a mocking laugh.

"…That's so like you."

"…What do you mean?"

"…Someone who just does something without a reason. I'm not good at that. I always look for the reason first. If the reason doesn't turn up, I can't move. So sometimes I can't do anything at all."

"…Is that a bad thing?"

"…No. But sometimes I envy it."

I thought about that for a long time. It was the first time Tyche had ever said she envied me.

. . .

I was a little surprised, hearing that. I learned, then, for the first time, what kind of person Tyche saw me as. Someone who moved without a reason. To Tyche, that was probably a kind of person that couldn't be explained. Tyche is a person who deals in things that can be explained. Probability, procedure, a vacancy. All of it can be explained.

I was about to do something that couldn't be explained. In front of Tyche.

I asked her something.

"…Why do you work here, Tyche? As a deliberation assistant."

"…Because my number came up right. And also because it suits me. It fits."

"…What does fitting mean?"

"…I like explaining things. Figuring out why something turned out the way it did."

"…Then explain this too. Why I'm doing this."

Tyche looked at me for a moment, steadily.

"…That one, I still can't explain either. You're one of the few things I can't explain, Hora."

I found it strange that this came out of Tyche. She wasn't a person who said comfortably that she couldn't explain something.

"…Doesn't it bother you, not being able to explain it?"

"…It does. But it's better than forcing an explanation onto it anyway. I dislike that even more."

I liked that answer. Tyche didn't force herself to patch over a hole in her own logic. If there was a hole, she just let it stay a hole.

. . .

Tyche asked again. This time her voice was a little more careful.

"…Aren't you scared?"

"…I am."

"…And you're doing it anyway?"

"…Yeah."

"…I don't understand it."

"…I don't fully understand myself either. But it turns out you can do something even without understanding it."

. . .

Tyche didn't answer that. Instead she got up and went to the window. The one that faced the water channel. That day the sound of the water was unusually loud.

"…I still think all of this is probability. That you're sitting here, that those people became the Seventh Classification — all of it is a

vacancy and a number and a procedure lining up. I think putting meaning onto that is something people do because they're lonely."

"…I know. You've said that before."

"…But I don't want to stop you from filling that box, either."

The sound of the water broke off for a moment, then picked up again. Probably the wind.

I was surprised by what she'd said.

"…Why?"

Tyche answered, looking out the window.

"…I don't know. There's just no reason to stop you, that's all."

. . .

This was an answer that sounded like Tyche. She hadn't stayed by my side because she'd been persuaded. She stayed because there was no reason to stop me. I think that difference is the most important part of this chapter.

Tyche never changes her position after this. Not for a long time, not even by the time this record ends. But from that evening on, she kept staying by my side. Without ever being persuaded.

I count this among the most important discoveries in this book. Two people didn't have to reach the same conclusion in order to stay together. Tyche believed, to the end, in chance. I believed, to the end,

that there was something more. And yet, that night, we sat in the same room, with the same document between us.

I think that was Tyche's own way. Staying beside someone while believing it's chance. Being kind while believing there's no meaning. It was nowhere in any proposal document, but I want to call that Tyche's faith. She'd laugh if she heard me say that.

That night I asked her one more thing.

"…If I write it and nothing changes at all, then what does that make me?"

This time it took Tyche a while to think.

"…Just someone who wrote it. That's all."

"…Is that all?"

"…Yeah. There's no such thing as the world taking notice of you or anything. The Consensus doesn't do that. The Consensus just receives it and processes it, that's all."

I didn't find that cold. I found it, instead, precise.

"…So I become someone who amounts to nothing."

"…No. You just become someone who wrote it. That's better than amounting to nothing, I think."

Tyche probably wasn't saying this to persuade me. She was just saying the fact. But it was the first time I felt comforted by her words. The comfort I got from Tyche always took this shape. Not warm words — precise ones. I understood, that day, that this was Tyche's own kind of kindness.

. . .

We sat together in the office late into the night. We didn't talk much more. Tyche looked over her own materials, and I read the document again. The signature box was still empty.

The caretaker came to put out the lights, saw the two of us, and just left. The same as he had, the very first night.

The two scenes overlapped for me. Two hundred and some days before, the night I sat alone reading forty pages. And now, the night with Tyche beside me. The only thing different was that one more person had been added beside me. That one person made quite a large difference to me, that night.

We packed up our things without saying anything. The silence wasn't awkward.

Coming out late, Tyche asked.

"…I'll come again tomorrow. Is that all right?"

"…Yeah."

"…No question about why?"

"…I told you, you're allowed to do things without a reason too."

Tyche laughed. Then she nodded once and walked off. I watched her back for a moment, then walked the other way.

That was how we parted. The night air was cold, and the sound of the water channel followed behind me the whole way.

Tyche hadn't come out that night to persuade me. When I asked her about it later, she said she'd simply been curious what I was thinking. That that was all it had been. I think that was true too.

(Continued in Chapter 40.)

Chapter 40. If I Perish

> *_Previously_ — Tyche asks, "If you write it, what changes?" Hora answers, "Maybe nothing changes. But it won't be empty." Tyche stays close, still unconvinced.*

I slept well that night.

I know it's strange, even as I write this sentence. That I slept well knowing what I would do the next day. But that's really how it was. I lay down in bed and fell asleep not long after, and I didn't wake up in the middle of the night.

I've thought about this many times since. I write it knowing how strange it sounds. I'd thought the night before a great decision was supposed to be spent wide awake. At least, that's how it always goes in stories. I didn't do that. Maybe it's because the sleepless night had already come and gone before this. That night, back then. Maybe it had all been used up then.

Just before falling asleep that night, I thought about one thing only. What Temel had said to me. "Maybe you're sitting here only because of a number. But there are still things you can do in a seat you got only because of a number." I turned that over in my mind again and again. Then I fell asleep.

Whether there was meaning in it or not, I still didn't know, even that night. All I knew was that there were things I could do. That was enough, I think I told myself, just before falling asleep.

. . .

I got up in the morning and washed and dressed as usual.

My aunt was making rice in the kitchen. The same time as always, the same smell as always. I sat at the table, and my aunt ladled out the soup.

"…You're heading out early today."

"…Yeah."

My aunt didn't ask any further. I didn't say anything further either.

That morning I'd thought I should tell my aunt something. That I should let her know my decision. But I didn't. I opened my mouth to speak and then just closed it again. Even now I can't explain exactly why. Only that it felt right, that morning.

A declaration is for someone. It's made for the person listening. That morning I felt there was no one for me to declare this to. Telling my aunt wouldn't have let her do anything for me instead. The Consensus isn't a structure that any one person can block or help. So saying it would only have made my aunt carry a weight.

This wasn't out of not trusting my aunt. If anything it was out of caring for her. Not telling her was the one kindness I could give her, that morning.

After eating, I got up from the table. My aunt looked at me once. Was there something different in her eyes from usual — I didn't notice it, at the time. Looking back now, I think maybe I did know.

"…I'm off."

"…All right."

That was all. Closing the door behind me, I didn't look back. I never did, on any other day, so there was no reason to do it differently that day.

. . .

On my way to the deliberation district, I passed the water channel.

The same channel I'd first seen at the very start. It now reaches deep into the city. I wrote earlier that people had started drinking that water; that morning too, a few people were sitting by the water's edge.

I didn't stop walking as I passed it. I hesitated over this while writing this chapter. It felt like something symbolic should have happened here. The water speaking to me, or giving me some kind of sign. Nothing like that happened. I just walked past, and the water just flowed.

I'd been thinking about this water channel a lot, around that time. Water that administratively doesn't exist, because it never came before an agenda. And yet people drink it. It was fairly real, for something that doesn't exist.

That morning I thought this water channel and what I was about to do were headed in opposite directions. The channel kept flowing even though no one had named it. The signature box stayed empty because no one had put a name to it. One existed without an agenda; the other looked, without one, as if it didn't exist. I didn't fully understand that difference, that day.

One of the people sitting by the water glanced at me. I looked back at that person. Neither of us said anything. We just passed each other.

In my drawer at home was the second page of the work guidelines. I brought it out with me. There'd been no real need to bring it — there would be a fresh form at the office. But I brought that paper anyway.

I don't know why. Maybe it was because it was the same paper I'd rubbed with my fingertip, that night. Or maybe it was just habit.

. . .

The office was the same as always.

A few people had already come in. No one looked at me any differently. I sat at my seat and checked the documents I had to handle that day. The same as usual.

I worked as usual all through that morning. Whoever reads this chapter will probably think I went straight to the signature box. I didn't. In the morning I handled the other deliberations assigned to me. Putting them in order, passing them on, confirming them. I have to admit, in this chapter, that I too was a person who used that grammar.

This fact bothered me strangely. What I was about to do soon after was break that grammar. And yet that morning I still worked exactly by it. I put things in order, I passed them on, I confirmed them. I don't want to call this hypocrisy. It was simply how it was. A person can't just stop doing everything they do every day inside a system, on a single day. You have to eat, and the work assigned to you has to be handled.

I thought, that day, that it must have been the same for the Secretary. He too lives speaking the same grammar every day. I understood, for the first time that day, from his position, that a person can't shed that grammar overnight.

Tyche came at lunchtime. She sat beside me as usual.

"…You're a little different today."

"…How so?"

"…I don't know. Just a little quiet."

I didn't answer. She didn't ask again either.

We ate lunch together that day. We didn't talk about anything special. Tyche talked a little about the materials she'd organized the day before, and I just listened.

I remember that lunch exactly, even now. What Tyche ate, what she talked about. Even though it was such an ordinary lunch. Probably because it was the last lunch I spent as an ordinary person. From that afternoon on, I became a slightly different person.

. . .

In the afternoon I took out the Seventh Classification document.

I opened the last page. For the twenty-some-th time. The signature box was there.

I've thought for a long time about how to write this moment. There was a temptation to write it dramatically. My hands trembling, my heart racing. To tell the truth, none of that happened. My hands didn't tremble. My heart might have beaten a little faster than usual, but that might just be me dressing up the memory now.

I flipped through the whole document once more. Over forty pages. The summary, the evidence, the record, the notes of those involved. Even reading it for the twenty-some-th time, my eyes still followed the same order.

Writing this chapter, I thought about what was different about this twenty-some-th complete reading from the ones before it. Nothing about the content had changed. The summary was the same, the evidence was the same. What had changed was only that I knew, this time, what I was about to do while reading it. Before, I'd read it to understand it. This time it felt like reading it to say goodbye to it.

Goodbye might sound like too strong a word. But that's really how I felt that day. I was about to part with myself as a person who simply read this document. Now I was about to become a person who had put a hand to it.

I looked at that box once more. Still smooth. Still empty.

I still didn't know what would happen if I filled it. I knew about Temel's review, and I knew the story of that person eleven years before. But exactly what would happen to me, I didn't know. That not knowing is the most honest fact of that day.

. . .

I didn't pick up the pen.

Instead I got up from my seat and left the office. I didn't fill it in, that day.

I need to write this part honestly. That afternoon I didn't steel myself and pick up the pen right away. I got up from my seat and went

out. And I walked. I walked with nowhere set in mind.

I walked once around the city. It was a familiar route. A route I'd walked since I was small. My pace was neither fast nor slow.

I passed the First Deliberation District meeting room. The building that held the seat I'd first sat in, once. I didn't stop walking — I just passed it by.

I passed the school too. I remembered my aunt saying, "What matters is near the front." That day the words sounded different to me. I didn't think my aunt had been wrong. Only that this time, it wasn't near the front — it was at the end.

I walked for nearly two hours. I wasn't walking to decide anything in particular. I just walked. As I walked, I took in every corner of this city with my eyes. Why that was necessary to me at the time, I still can't fully explain. Only that it was necessary.

A city where no one queues. A city where the word favor is only used when handing someone an object. I still loved this city. Loving it still, and knowing that one of its most honest boxes stayed empty the whole time — I knew both at once.

The two didn't contradict each other. I realized that as I walked. Loving this city, and filling this box, were things pointing in the same direction.

Walking, I thought of Temel. He wasn't in the city right now. I'd heard he'd gone elsewhere to look for someone. I thought it was fortunate, actually, that he wasn't there.

If he had been, I probably would have gone to find him and asked. Is it all right to do this now, is this the right time. Temel probably

would have said, "I don't know. I don't know either." He'd already answered that way once before. Rather than hear the same answer again, I preferred to walk alone.

This wasn't avoiding Temel. I simply wanted, this once, to go without anyone's confirmation. If you ask before you go, it becomes going with that person's permission. I didn't want permission. That there was no one, to begin with, whose permission I needed — that was something this whole book had taught me.

I thought of the Secretary too. He would probably be there tomorrow morning, in the seat where he'd receive my signature. He wouldn't be surprised. I was strangely certain of that.

. . .

By the time the sun was setting, I came back to the office.

Most people had already left for the day. Tyche wasn't there either. I sat alone at my seat.

Outside the window the sun was fully going down. The evenings of this city are quiet. As I've said, it's a city with little reason to make a sound.

I didn't go through some grand moment of resolve, that evening. The decision hadn't arrived in a single instant. From back then to here, it had built up little by little, over four days. Writing this chapter, I kept telling myself I had to resist the temptation to turn it into one dramatic scene.

I opened the document again. I looked at the signature box. This time I didn't look at it for long.

I picked up the pen.

The pen in my hand was an ordinary pen. One of those common pens found anywhere in an office, nothing special about it. I found that a little funny. A moment like this felt like it should call for some special instrument, and what was in my hand was just an ordinary pen.

I brought the nib close to the paper. It didn't touch. In those few millimeters, I stayed still for a long time. I don't remember now whether it was seconds, or minutes. Time felt strangely stretched out, in that moment.

In that moment I thought of my mother. The last line of the twelve-page paper. And I thought that this signature box, too, was in the same way a last line. A box at the very bottom of the document, in the place where everything ends. I had missed a last line once. This time I was about to leave something on a last line, myself.

. . .

I didn't sign it that night. That night I only picked up the pen and set it back down. I think it's right to end this chapter here. The signature itself belongs to a much later part.

What I was trying to do that day wasn't the signature. It was the decision. And a decision, from what I learned that day, wasn't a declaration. It was simply going, the next morning.

That night, at home, I said nothing to my aunt. I ate, washed, and slept. The same as usual. My aunt didn't say anything unusual either.

It wasn't that I pretended it was the same as usual. It really was the same as usual. I wasn't afraid, that night. I know that's the strangest

part of this chapter. The fear came the next day.

I told Tyche this once, later. She said that was only natural. That the time before a decision is the most frightening, and once it's made, it's actually less frightening. That the real thing only starts after that. Tyche was right. The reason I was at ease that night was that nothing had started yet.

Between picking up the pen and putting it down, and actually writing the name, there was still one more door left. I spent that last night on this side of that door.

I gave this chapter its title later. I hadn't thought of these words that night. This is a title I attached after the fact, while writing this book. That night's self had no room to think anything so grand. I was only thinking about going, the next morning.

The next morning, I woke as usual. And I left the house as usual. The weather was clear, and the sound of the water channel was exactly the same as the day before. This city stayed the same whatever decision I'd made. I found that steadying, if anything. Nothing was standing still, waiting for me.

I slept well that night. I set this down honestly too. I didn't toss and turn, and I had no frightening dreams. I woke as usual in the morning. I learned, then, that the night before a great day could be this ordinary.

(Continued in Chapter 41.)

Chapter 41. The Signature

> *_Previously_ — Hora doesn't declare her decision. Carrying a resolve*
> *that built up slowly over more than three days, she meets an ordinary*
> *morning and leaves the house with an ordinary step.*

I got to the office early that morning. A little earlier than usual.

No one was there yet. The hallway was quiet, and so was the meeting room. I sat at my seat and took out the Seventh Classification document. I opened the last page. The signature box was there.

I hesitated for a long while before writing this chapter. I didn't know how to properly carry the weight of this moment onto the page. In the end I decided to just write it exactly as it happened. Not to invent anything to add weight to it. That's my rule for writing this chapter.

The office was quiet. It wasn't yet fully light out. A pale light was coming in through the window.

I looked through the document once more. It was habit. I didn't flip through all forty-some pages again. I just checked the first page and the last. The summary was there, and the signature box was there.

Even up to this moment I felt there was still something left to check, one last time. Whether the evidence was right, whether the procedure was right. In fact it wasn't that. All of it I'd already checked, weeks

before. What I really wanted to check that morning was whether my mind was still the same.

It was.

. . .

I picked up the pen. The same pen I'd picked up the evening before.

This time I didn't stop.

I wrote my name in the name box. Hora. Two syllables. The sound of the pen tip touching the paper was exactly the same as any ordinary time I wrote.

That was really all there was. Even as I write this sentence I feel the temptation to add something more. That my hand trembled, that I cried. There was nothing. I simply wrote my name. The same motion of the hand as any ordinary time I wrote my name on an application.

I once tried to time how long it took me to write these two syllables. Probably two, three seconds. Two hundred-some days of time, three days of resolve, four days of preparation, all ended in a three-second motion of the hand. I thought for a long time that this imbalance was strange. I don't think it's strange now. A great decision didn't need to be expressed by a great motion.

. . .

Once I'd written it, I looked at the box.

It wasn't empty anymore.

Had I expected something to happen, at this moment? Looking back now, I think maybe I had. A bell ringing somewhere, or someone rushing in, or at the very least the air in the room changing. None of that happened. The room stayed the same. The light outside the window stayed the same. The document was just a document.

I sat for a moment and kept looking at the box. I watched the ink dry. It took a few minutes.

Above my name, the other boxes came into view too. The date box, the agenda number box. All boxes that had already been printed. The signature box was the only one that had been filled by hand.

That contrast bothered me. The printed letters had been made by the Consensus, and the two written syllables had been made by me. On that paper, for the first time, something that wasn't the Consensus's had come to exist. Very small, but clearly different.

. . .

I heard the sound of a door opening. It was the caretaker. He'd come to do the morning cleaning.

"…You're in early."

"…Yes."

The caretaker walked past without much thought. He probably didn't know what I'd done. Even if he had, he probably would have walked past just the same.

That moment was strangely comforting to me. That no one was looking at me as anything special. I felt as though the world had ended, and yet

in the caretaker's unconcerned footsteps I confirmed that the world hadn't ended at all.

The caretaker finished cleaning and left. I stayed sitting at my seat the whole time. The document lay on the desk.

I don't remember exactly what I did during those tens of minutes. I think I was in a daze. I wasn't deep in thought, and I wasn't anxious either. Time just passed. All I remember is that the light outside the window grew a little brighter.

I could have left this blank space out of the writing. But I think this blank space matters in this chapter. Right after signing, nothing happens. Truly nothing happens, so much that I don't even remember what filled that time. I mean to leave this blank space as it is, without inventing anything to fill it.

. . .

When it was time for the reception desk to open, I gathered up the document and went.

The person at the reception desk greeted me with their usual face. I held the document out.

"…Please receive this."

The person at the desk took the document and looked it over. They flipped through a few pages, and their hand stopped at the last one.

I'd waited a long time for this moment. I thought this person would say something. Be surprised, or ask a question. Nothing was said.

The person at the desk stamped it. Then they put the document in a file box.

"…Received."

"…Yes. Thank you."

The person at the desk tore off a receipt slip and handed it to me. It had a date and a number written on it.

"…Keep this with you."

"…Yes."

That was all.

I've thought many times, later, about how many more cases that person at the desk must have processed that day. Probably several. Mine was just one of them. There was no reason, from that person's side, for it to be anything special. Even if it was the first time they'd seen a document with the signature box filled, the reception procedure was the same. Take it, check it, stamp it, file it.

I tried to recall again whether that person's expression had changed at all, seeing the signature box. I don't remember. Probably there was no expression at all. That person, too, was only doing their job.

I don't even know that person's name. I didn't ask. In this city, you don't often ask such things. That person remains, to me, simply someone who was sitting at the reception desk. And I probably remain, in that person's memory too, simply one of the people who came in that morning.

. . .

I gave this chapter the title "The Signature." It's the shortest chapter in this book, coming after the longest preparation. I did that on purpose. I know the reader will expect something dramatic at this moment. I expected it too. There was none.

The weight of this chapter comes from the fact that nothing happened. I rewrote it several times. Each time there was a temptation to add something. To lay in description like background music, or to write as if someone had been watching me. I decided against it. Because none of that actually happened.

I've written many times that this city doesn't lie to me. That principle held in this chapter too. The Consensus showed no special reaction to my signature. That not reacting was itself an honest reaction. Not ignoring it to hide something — simply that no such reaction existed in the reception procedure to begin with.

Walking out of the reception desk that day, I half expected some kind of murmur to rise up behind my back. There was none. The reception desk was as quiet as it had been when I'd walked in.

. . .

I left the reception desk and went back to the office. An ordinary day went on as usual. I handled the deliberations assigned to me. I put things in order, passed them on, confirmed them.

Tyche came at lunchtime.

"…Quiet again today."

Instead of answering, I showed her the receipt slip. She looked at it for a long while.

"…Did you write it?"

"…Yeah."

Tyche didn't say anything. She just handed the receipt back to me.

"…Let's go eat."

We went to eat as usual.

At the restaurant, Tyche asked again.

"…Weren't you scared? While you were writing it."

"…No, strangely, I felt nothing at all."

"…Why not?"

"…It was just two syllables of a name. I write that all the time anyway."

Tyche thought about that for a moment and nodded.

"…That's stranger. That such a big decision ends with such a small motion."

"…I think so too."

We ate the rest of our meal without much more talk. The restaurant was crowded with people as usual, and no one paid us any attention.

. . .

I know this scene is strange. A person in this city had just written her own name in the signature box, and right after, the scene was an ordinary lunch. Tyche and I walked as usual, ate as usual. Tyche talked a little about her own things, as usual.

Even by that evening, I felt no sign that anything had changed. Nor did the next day. Nor the day after that. I woke every morning a little tense, wondering if something had changed. But every morning was the same as before.

The change comes much later. It comes quietly, without warning. It wasn't there that day. On that day there was only the fact that one sheet of paper had been received.

In the afternoon I ran into someone from another deliberation district. That person treated me as they always had.

"…Hora, could you look this over for me."

"…Yes."

I took the document they handed me and checked it. It was my usual work, and my hand moved as it always did. That person seemed to have no idea at all what I'd just done.

This was, strangely, a comfort. What I'd done wasn't yet special news to anyone in this city. For it to become news would take time. Or maybe, in fact, it would never become news at all. That the document had been received was itself an open fact, but there was no way to know it unless someone deliberately went looking.

This city hides nothing. And yet it also announces nothing. Hiding something and not announcing it are different things. I felt that difference again that afternoon.

. . .

That night, at home, I told my aunt.

"…I wrote it."

My aunt stopped ladling the rice. She looked at me for a moment.

"…All right."

"…Aren't you angry?"

"…This isn't something to be angry about."

She went back to serving the rice. We ate dinner as usual.

I only understood, later, what that calm of my aunt's had been. She hadn't been unsurprised. She must have already been expecting this moment, for many nights before. Her calm was a prepared calm.

Once she'd finished serving, my aunt added just one more line.

"…Do you know what happens next?"

"…No, I don't."

"…Neither do I."

We didn't talk about it any further after that. We talked about other things over dinner. My aunt talked about a tree the neighbors had planted in their yard lately, and I listened.

I've replayed that evening many times, wanting to remember it exactly. My aunt didn't show any sign of worrying about me. I didn't say anything to reassure her either. We just ate dinner as usual. I still

think, even now, that this was the best thing the two of us could give each other.

. . .

That night, before bed, I looked at the receipt slip again.

It had only a date, a number, and the stamp confirming receipt on it. An unremarkable piece of paper.

I held that paper in my hand for a long while. It didn't feel like I was holding anything grand. It was just paper. But that ordinariness was exactly what I learned that day. A thing that changes the world comes in a shape the world doesn't notice. At least, in this city, it did.

I turned off the light and lay down. Nothing happened. The sound of the water channel drifted in very faintly through the window, and faded before I fell asleep.

I mean to close this chapter with that night. Writing this part, I kept wanting to give the reader something more. A twist, a tension, at least some sense of foreboding. But there was none of that, that night. I simply fell asleep, ordinarily.

Looking back on it now, this ordinariness was the most honest face this city has. The Consensus wasn't waiting to punish me. Nor was it waiting to celebrate me. The Consensus had simply received it. What happened to what was received would, in this city's own way, begin quietly, following a set procedure.

I had no idea, that night, what shape that procedure would take. If I had known, I probably wouldn't have fallen asleep so peacefully.

. . .

The next morning, too, I woke as usual. I went to the office and worked as usual. No one treated me any differently.

This went on for several days. I came to work every day, put documents in order every day, ate lunch with Tyche every day. I kept the receipt slip in the drawer. Beside the second page of the work guidelines, beside my mother's paper.

The three papers lay side by side like that. I would sometimes open that drawer and look at all three together. All three were papers with something written on a last line. One a line I'd missed. One a box no one had ever filled. And now one a box I had filled.

I received no word at all, during those days. Nothing happened at all. I didn't think it would last long. I just didn't know exactly when it would end. I didn't know exactly how fast the Consensus moved. It could be quick, or it could be slow. There was no way to know.

I enjoyed that quiet exactly as it was. Because I knew it was the last quiet.

Tyche still came as usual, during those days. She kept asking me if anything had changed, and every time I answered no. It really was nothing.

"…That's strange. It feels like something should have happened by now."

"…I thought so too. But there's nothing."

"…Could there just keep being nothing?"

"…I don't know."

We spent several days like that. I didn't know, at the time, that those few days were the last peaceful time I'd spend in this city. If I had known, I probably would have tried harder to feel that peace a little longer.

(Continued in Chapter 42.)

Chapter 42. Review

> *_Previously_ — Hora writes her name in the signature box. The reception desk stamps it and files the paper. Nothing happens. That quiet goes on for several days.*

On the sixth day, I received my first summons.

A notice came. The same kind of paper as when I'd first received the work guidelines. *You are requested to appear for the reexamination of the deliberation concerning the Seventh Classification. Date: three days from now.*

Receiving this notice, at first, actually put me at ease. That something had started felt better than nothing happening at all. How naive that ease was, I already learned that very evening.

My aunt saw the notice and asked.

"…What's this?"

"…A deliberation reexamination. It says to appear."

My aunt read the notice once more.

"…So it's starting now."

"…Yeah. I guess."

She said nothing more. That night I read the notice again, many times over. The words *three days from now* stuck in my eye especially.

I didn't know what to prepare during those three days, so I just spent them as usual. There wasn't really anything to prepare. Why I'd read that document to the end, why I'd signed it — those were already established facts. There was nothing new to make up.

. . .

Three days later I went to the assigned room.

It was a small room. One table, three chairs. Two people sat across from me. Faces I'd never seen before.

"…We'll confirm a few things regarding the proposal for a new deliberation on the Seventh Classification matter."

"…Yes."

"…Would you state your reason for proposing it."

I spoke as I'd prepared. I pointed to a few pieces of evidence, and I spoke about the gap between the summary and the full text. The two of them wrote it down.

"…Confirmed. Thank you."

That was all. It took about twenty minutes.

Coming out, I saw someone else in the hallway. That person, too, was coming out of a room, the same as me. Somewhat older. Our eyes met, and that person nodded to me first.

"…First time?"

"…Yes."

"…You'll get used to it."

That person said only that and walked on. I couldn't tell, at the time, whether that was comfort or a warning.

Looking back now, I think it was both. In this city, comfort and warning often come in the same sentence.

I never met that person again. I've written before that meeting the same person twice in review is rare — the same was true among the people undergoing review with me. A different face every time. Whether this was chance, or itself some kind of design, I never confirmed, in the end. Confirming it would have meant going and asking someone else again, and by then I didn't have much energy left for that.

. . .

I thought this was the end of it. I'd stated it, it had been accepted, and I thought I'd move on to the next stage.

I was wrong.

Ten days later, another notice came. A different room this time, different people. I was asked the same questions again. I answered the same way.

"…We're confirming whether this matches your earlier statement."

"…Yes."

This one, too, took about twenty minutes.

At this second review, I noticed something strange for the first time. Both the room and the people were different, but the questions were identical, down to the last word. "Would you state your reason for proposing it." I learned, then, that this was a line fixed like a script. The people in charge changed, but the question didn't.

In that moment I felt this was a cold system, but by the time I left the room, I'd revised the thought. It wasn't cold. It was just fair. That the same question is asked no matter who conducts it. I realized this was the same way as everything else in the Equity. A way in which no one takes sides — that same way was being applied to review too.

. . .

Next, another notice came, not in ten days but in six.

I went again. I was asked the same questions again. I gave the same answers again.

The third time I went, I asked something for the first time.

"…How many more times will this happen?"

The person across from me glanced at a screen for a moment and answered.

"…There is no set number. You'll be convened whenever it's needed."

"…Who decides when it's needed?"

"…That's the procedure."

I didn't ask any further. I already knew that asking further wouldn't bring a different answer.

On my way home I counted my review notices for the first time. I'd been collecting them in the drawer each time one arrived, and by that day there were three. Laying the three side by side, the gaps between the dates stood out to me. Ten days, then six. No pattern.

I learned that day that the lack of a pattern was, if anything, more of a weight to carry. If the interval had been fixed, I could have predicted the next date and prepared my mind for it. Because there was no pattern, I started each morning thinking a notice might arrive that day.

. . .

The Secretary had once explained review to me, long ago. It was not long after I'd first met Temel. What Temel went through. Not punishment, but review. I thought, at the time, that I'd understood that explanation. I hadn't.

Understanding something and living through it are different. I only know the difference in my body now. When I was told about it, review was a single fact. Living through it, review becomes a rhythm. Six days, ten days, six days again. Being called out again and again at unpredictable intervals.

. . .

I met different people at every review. A different face every time. I almost never met the same person twice.

I learned later that this wasn't coincidence. The people conducting review were meant to change every time as well. If one person kept handling me, there was a risk that person would become the one responsible. A structure meant to keep anyone from becoming responsible was being applied even to the people who called me in.

I couldn't bring myself to hate this structure. Because the person to hate kept changing. This was how this city treated me. A way of offering no place for anger to land.

At first I thought this was a cunning move by the Consensus. A structure that blocked resistance by never giving you anyone to be angry at. But thinking about it again, this wasn't cunning — it was simply this city's founding principle, applied to review in exactly the same way. The principle that no one takes sides, and no one remains the responsibility of any one particular individual. I wrote, near the very beginning of this record, that I thought this principle was good. Even now, I can't fully overturn that judgment.

Once, during a review, one of the people in charge said something personal to me.

"…Why did you do this? You could have just lived quietly."

I wasn't prepared to answer that question. That person didn't seem to be waiting for an answer either. They just seemed to be curious.

"…No reason, really."

"…All right. Let's move to the next question."

I remember this short exchange for a long time. That person didn't blame me. They didn't sound like they couldn't understand, either.

They were simply curious, took my short answer as it was, and moved on. The people of this city were mostly like that. They didn't press.

. . .

One day Tyche was waiting for me as I came out of a review.

"…Went again?"

"…Yeah."

"…What did they ask?"

"…The same thing. Reason. Evidence."

"…Same every time?"

"…Almost."

Tyche walked in silence for a moment, then asked.

"…Is it hard?"

I thought for a moment before answering.

"…It's not hard, exactly. It's strange. No one's angry at me, and yet I keep being called in."

"…That's review. I understand now, why people are afraid of it."

Tyche told me, that day, about what she'd looked into herself.

"…I looked at the statistics on review counts. On average people are called in two or three times a month. But the variance is big. Some

people go months with nothing, then suddenly get called in over and over."

"…Why does that happen?"

"…There's no explanation given. It's just marked as procedure."

"…I know. Everything's procedure."

Tyche laughed a little.

"…That's this city's way, isn't it."

Tyche wasn't trying to persuade me that day either. She just brought me a fact as it was. I was grateful for that. More than words trying to comfort me, accurate information helped me more, at that moment.

. . .

Around this time I started thinking about Temel again. He'd been going through this for years. I was already starting to wear down at six-day, ten-day intervals, and Temel had been called in far longer, and far more often, than that.

I thought I understood, now, why he'd seemed so unruffled. He wasn't unruffled — he'd simply grown used to it. He must have had no choice but to get used to it. You can't keep being freshly startled, every time, by something that never ends.

Around then I thought about writing Temel a letter. I didn't know where he was now, and I had no real way to send a letter anyway. In the end I didn't write one.

If I'm honest about why I didn't write it: I didn't want to be comforted by him. Whatever he might have answered, I knew, in the end, that I had to go through this alone. It must have been the same for him. Review wasn't something anyone could go through in your place. That no one can take it on for you might be the most exact definition of review there is.

. . .

My aunt said nothing every time I came back from a review. She made meals, and I ate them.

One evening she said just one thing.

"…Tell me if it's too hard."

"…I told you, it's not hard."

"…Then what is it."

I couldn't answer. She didn't ask any further either.

At the time, I couldn't find the right word for my own state. Hard wasn't the right word. Frightening wasn't quite right either. The closest word was probably "ongoing." It just went on. That was the nature of review.

Even on days with nothing scheduled, I found myself habitually checking the notice box. The first thing I did on waking each morning was look at that box. If it was empty I felt relief; if there was something in it, I just accepted it.

I only noticed this habit had formed after the fact. At first it was something I did without being conscious of it. One day it struck me that checking the notice box had become the very first thing I did every morning. If reading had once been my old habit, waiting had become my new one.

My aunt seemed to have noticed this habit too. One morning, seeing me walk toward the notice box, she said quietly, "…Nothing today. I already checked." I was so grateful for those words that I couldn't say anything back.

I thought about these two habits side by side. The habit of reading had been something I chose. The habit of waiting had formed without my choosing it. Both had made me who I was.

I might well have been angry that a habit I hadn't chosen had formed in me, but strangely, I wasn't. This too was a result of having signed it. When I signed it, I hadn't foreseen this habit specifically, but just because an unforeseen result had come, I didn't want to take the signature back.

. . .

Review did not hurt the body. It did not lock anyone in a cell. It did not take anyone's money.

The one thing review did was call people in. And not stop doing so.

I understood, around then, why this was harder to bear than punishment. Punishment is built on the premise that there's an end. Serve your term, and it's over. Review isn't built on the premise of an end. As long as even one case with my name on it remained, a reason to call me in remained too.

And in this city, deliberations keep coming into being. So, in theory, I could be called in forever.

It took me time to accept this fact. At first I felt it was unjust. Having no visible end was a shape unlike any procedure I'd known before. Nearly every procedure in this city has a start and an end. Deliberations begin and end in confirmation. But review had no confirmation. It was a structure that couldn't be confirmed.

I came to see this differently, later. At that point I hadn't reached that place yet. Back then I was simply enduring this endlessness.

About a month in, I felt my body starting to adapt to the rhythm of review. When a notice arrived, I no longer felt startled. I just checked the next date.

I couldn't judge, at the time, whether this adapting was good or bad. I'm still not sure, even now. Adapting means it has become bearable, but it also means it has become normal. I didn't want to accept being called in over and over as normal. But my body was already accepting it.

About a month and a half in, coming out of my eighth review, I stopped and counted, on impulse. Eight times. Every one a different person, every one the same question.

The number eight, by itself, isn't very large. But if I added up the mornings I spent, between those eight, checking the notice box every day, that became a far larger number. Review's real weight lay less in the time actually spent being called in, and more in the time spent waiting, wondering if I might be. I understood this exactly, around then.

Around then, Tyche said something to me.

"…We still don't know if this will lead to a new deliberation. It could just be the procedure continuing on its own."

"…I know."

"…And you'll keep going anyway?"

"…Yeah."

Tyche didn't ask anything further.

I remember this short exchange for a long time. Tyche didn't try to stop me. She didn't cheer me on either. She just told me one fact, heard my answer, and let it go. That was Tyche's way of dealing with people. I didn't feel, at the time, that it was cold.

I never stopped counting after that, either. The moment I stopped counting, it felt like this would stop being something I'd chosen and become just something that was happening to me. I kept adding those numbers to the end of the paper in the drawer.

(Continued in Chapter 43.)

Chapter 43. The New Deliberation

> *_Previously_ — Review went on with no fixed rule. Six days, ten days,*
> *six days again. Tyche asked, "And you'll keep going anyway?" Hora*
> *answered, "Yeah," and Tyche asked no further.*

About two weeks after the eighth review, a notice came.

This one was a different kind. Not a request to appear, but a notice of outcome. *Seventh Classification reexamination matter, deliberation result confirmed.* I looked at that sentence and for a long while couldn't open the envelope.

I had imagined this moment many times. In my imagination, the hand opening the envelope trembled. In reality it didn't tremble. I simply opened it. That my hand didn't tremble felt a little strange to me, in the moment — but thinking about it now, it was only natural. I'd already been holding on to this one document alone for two hundred-some days. I'd grown as used to it as a person could.

. . .

The result document ran forty-two pages, with eighteen more pages of supporting materials attached. I didn't start with the summary. I read it from beginning to end.

The front section explained the reexamination procedure. It set out how the new deliberation I'd proposed had been convened, what materials had

been reexamined, and how many people had taken part. This time it wasn't four hundred, but six hundred and twelve. More people had been involved in the reexamination than in the original deliberation.

I paused for a moment at this number. I couldn't tell, at the time, whether more people having looked at it was a good sign or a bad one. I'm still not certain, even now.

The result appeared on the twelfth page.

Regarding the above reexamination matter, the following is hereby confirmed. Among the list of relocation-target sites, the unregistered residences falling under items 3, 7, and 12 are converted to formally registered sites, the grounds for their provisional designation having lapsed. Residents of these residences are removed from the Seventh Classification, and released from relocation-target status.

I read that sentence three times.

. . .

Even read three times, the sentence stayed the same. Items 3, 7, and 12.

I looked further back to find the number of people covered under those three items. There was a table on the sixth page of the supporting materials. Ninety-one residents under item 3, sixty-eight under item 7, fifty-four under item 12. Added together, two hundred and thirteen.

I sat with this number for a long time. It wasn't a small number. I knew these people would now go on living without hearing the words

unregistered residence attached to their names. That much was real. It wasn't false.

I turned the page.

Excepting the above items 3, 7, and 12, the remainder of the list retains the original decision. No grounds for reexamination were confirmed.

. . .

Two hundred and thirteen out of one thousand one hundred and forty.

The remaining nine hundred and twenty-seven stayed as they were. The document didn't write anything new about those nine hundred and twenty-seven. It only said "the original decision is retained." There was nothing after that one line. It didn't re-explain the grounds, and it didn't apologize. It meant there was no reason to make a new decision about something already decided.

I sat for a long time that day with those two numbers side by side. Two hundred and thirteen, and nine hundred and twenty-seven. I knew I was supposed to feel glad, looking at the side of two hundred and thirteen. And I really was, a little glad. But I couldn't help looking at the side of nine hundred and twenty-seven too. That number just sat there. It hadn't been erased.

Reading this result for the first time, I think I'd expected something dramatic. Someone who'd done wrong being exposed, that person being punished, and not just two hundred and thirteen but all one thousand one hundred and forty coming back. There was no such scene.

I should be honest here. I thought of the old stories I'd heard as a child. Stories where someone who drove an innocent person to ruin ends up hanged on the very gallows they built. I did, a little, expect something like that. I hoped some such name would appear, somewhere in this result document. Who had first designated item 3 as provisional, who had decided to leave the rest as they were. No such name ever appeared, to the very end. There had never been a place for one to appear. This document had no one who had driven anyone to ruin, so there could be no scene of that person being punished, either.

I thought again that this was this city's most honest face. Without a villain, there is no scene of a villain falling. That fact held me for a long time.

. . .

After closing the result document, I walked straight to the area under item 3. It was a place I'd never been. Low ground, not far from the water channel. There were a few houses, and laundry hung out, no different from any other day. I think I'd expected something to have changed there. A flag hung up, or people gathered and celebrating.

There was nothing. One person was splitting firewood in a yard, and gave me only a light nod when they saw me. I had no way of knowing whether that person knew that their name had just been removed from the unregistered list. I wanted to ask, but couldn't. It felt like a question I had no right to ask.

Walking past that yard, I thought about when and how this news would reach each of the two hundred and thirteen people. It would come as a notice. On the same kind of paper as any other notice, in the same kind of print. Maybe those people, too, would receive it and be unable

to open the envelope for a long while, the way I had been. Or maybe they'd just open it, read it, and be done. Either way, I wouldn't see that moment. I would stop here, and each of them would receive that paper in their own place, on their own.

. . .

The Secretary called me in that afternoon.

"…You'll have seen the result."

"…Yes."

"…This reexamination proceeded according to procedure, and has been confirmed. If you have an objection, you may raise it again the same way."

"…What about the remaining nine hundred and twenty-seven?"

"…No grounds for reexamination were confirmed for them. No new evidence came forward."

"…Why didn't any evidence come forward? They're the same kind of people."

The Secretary looked at his papers for a moment.

"…There was evidence that items 3, 7, and 12 had been provisional designations. The other items were formal designations from the start. That's a different matter."

Hearing this answer, I couldn't find anything to argue back with. The Secretary hadn't lied to me. He'd told me exactly and fully why those

three items alone had been resolved. That was this city's way. It doesn't hide anything. And yet I still felt some kind of wronged feeling. I couldn't put my finger on the shape of that feeling, that day.

. . .

"…So what more can I do now?"

"…You can open another new deliberation for the remaining matter. If you find new grounds."

"…What more grounds would be needed?"

"…I don't know that either. That's for the reexamination committee to judge."

Hearing that, I remembered an earlier moment, long before. The Secretary had answered the same way, then. When I'd asked what happens if you write your name, he had looked away for the first time. This time he didn't look away. He was simply saying as much as he knew.

"…What do you think of this result, Secretary?"

The Secretary paused a little at this question.

"…That's not mine to think about. I only convene and pass things on."

"…Even so. Just as a person."

The Secretary looked at me for a moment. There was something in that look, but I couldn't read what it was, that day.

"…Two hundred and thirteen is a good thing. That much I do think."

"…And the rest?"

"…The rest — it was put in order that way."

I felt a brief catch in that sentence. Very short. I didn't miss that catch, but I didn't press further, that day. The Secretary moved on to the next document, and I asked nothing more.

. . .

Tyche came that evening. Her face said she'd already seen the result.

"…Two hundred and thirteen."

"…Yeah."

"…That's not a small number. I honestly thought it might not happen at all."

I was surprised by that.

"…You thought it wouldn't happen?"

"…Yeah. Looking at the statistics — cases where a reexamination overturns even part of the original decision — even across ten years of records, there are hardly any. And usually only when a procedural flaw is obvious. This case wasn't that obvious."

"…But it happened."

"…It did. I still can't fully explain why. I can say it happened because there happened to be grounds about the provisional designation, but I don't know if that's all there was to it."

Hearing this, I looked at Tyche again. She, too, was admitting there was a part she couldn't fully explain. But that admission didn't lead her straight to a different conclusion. It was the same as before. Tyche left the hole a hole.

. . .

"…And the rest? What do you think about that, Tyche?"

"…That just stays as it is. Because no grounds came forward. I don't think that's a bad thing. Overturning something without grounds wouldn't be fair either."

"…But they're people. Nine hundred and twenty-seven of them."

"…That's right. That stays as it is. I don't feel nothing about that either."

Tyche's expression didn't change as she said this. She was someone who could say something was sad without wearing a sad face. I knew this wasn't hypocrisy. Tyche really did carry sadness in exactly that way.

"…I don't know whether I should call this winning or losing."

"…I don't think it's either."

"…Then what is it?"

Tyche thought for a moment.

"…Just that two hundred and thirteen people changed. I don't think there's anything more than that."

. . .

Tyche started to get up, then sat back down.

"…But Hora, I did learn one thing from this."

"…What?"

"…I've told you almost everything can be explained by a vacancy, a number, and probability. I still think that. But looking purely at probability, this reexamination was really unlikely to happen. The procedural flaw wasn't obvious, and there was no guarantee that more people being involved would flip the result."

"…But it did flip."

"…Yeah. So I file this away as a low probability that happened to be realized. Low isn't zero, after all. But… "

Tyche paused for a moment.

"…But what?"

"…Every time a low probability gets realized, calling it just probability feels strange sometimes. I know it's strange of me to say that. But if I don't file it that way, I fall apart. So I file it that way."

I sat with this for a long time. Tyche wasn't saying her own logic was wavering. She was saying that the reason she held onto that logic wasn't the certainty of the logic itself, but the fact that she'd fall apart if she didn't. I think that was the most honest thing Tyche ever gave me.

. . .

That night I told my aunt the result. She listened quietly, then asked.

"…So is it good, or not good?"

"…I think it's both."

"…What does that mean."

"…Two hundred and thirteen came through. Nine hundred and twenty-seven didn't."

My aunt said nothing for a long while, then spoke.

"…So that's the result, then."

"…Yeah."

"…It doesn't feel satisfying."

"…No, it doesn't."

I want to set this exchange down exactly. My aunt didn't try to comfort me. I didn't try to reassure her either. We simply set those two numbers side by side and left it there.

. . .

That night I took the result document out again and looked all the way to the last page. There, at the bottom, was a signature box. It was empty. Empty again, this time too. In the end, no one at all had confirmed the reexamination, either.

I didn't copy out the list of the nine hundred and twenty-seven names separately. I wasn't sure I had the right to copy them out. Instead I wrote that number at the top of the paper in the drawer. *927.* I meant not to erase it.

Writing this chapter, I keep asking myself again. Was this a victory. I don't think so. If it were a victory, something should have ended. This hasn't ended. Two hundred and thirteen came back, and nine hundred and twenty-seven stayed as they were. I won't erase that remaining number from this record. The moment I erased it, I felt this book would end up doing the same thing this city has always done.

. . .

The next morning, on my way to work, I passed the water channel again. The water was flowing as usual. I stopped in front of it for a moment and tried to put yesterday's events in order in my mind. It didn't come together well.

Two hundred and thirteen people no longer hear the words unregistered. Nine hundred and twenty-seven still do. I hadn't drawn that line. I had only opened a new deliberation, and how far that deliberation would reach hadn't been mine to decide. The three items — 3, 7, and 12 — had existed first, and the people caught under those items had existed first. I had only opened a door; who would walk out through that door wasn't something I got to choose.

Thinking this, I remembered again what Temel had once said. That there are still things you can do, even in a seat you got only because of a number. I did what could be done from that seat. That the work only reached two hundred and thirteen people was part of that work too.

I carried this thought with me through the whole day's work. I handled the other deliberations assigned to me. I put things in order, passed them on, confirmed them. Like every other document in this city, those documents too had signature boxes, and they too were empty. Looking at those boxes, I wondered whether a day would come when someone filled them too. That day had not yet come.

At lunchtime, Tyche asked again.

"…So what will you do now? About the remaining nine hundred and twenty-seven."

"…I don't know. I'll have to keep looking for grounds."

"…And if there aren't any?"

"…I'll still look. And if there aren't any, then there aren't any."

Tyche looked at me for a moment, then nodded. She didn't try to stop me, and she didn't push me on either. Her face simply accepted that answer as it was.

*That evening I opened the drawer and looked again at the paper marked

1. The number I'd written that I wouldn't erase. I left that paper where it was, at the top of the drawer. I didn't want to put an unfinished number away as if it were finished.*

(Continued in Chapter 44.)

Chapter 44. What the Names Mean

> *_Previously_ — The new deliberation's result came in. Of the one thousand one hundred and forty, two hundred and thirteen were released from the Seventh Classification. The remaining nine hundred*
> *and twenty-seven stayed as they were. It wasn't satisfying. Hora wrote the remaining number in the drawer and decided not to erase it.*

It was about two weeks later that I heard Temel had come back to this city.

The person at the reception desk told me. "…That person who does the searching for people, you know. He's back again." The moment I heard that, I dropped what I was doing and went to the north market.

Even now I can't fully explain why I hurried so much, right then. There wasn't really anything left for me to ask Temel. I just heard the news, and my body moved before I thought about it.

. . .

Temel was in front of the notice board. The same posture as before. The same bag, only his shoes looked a little more worn.

"…Back again."

Temel saw me and smiled a little.

"…Oh, Hora."

"…Who are you looking for this time?"

"…No, this time it's something else. Just passing through."

"…Just passing through?"

"…Yeah. On my way to another city. Stopped by here on the way."

I didn't believe that. This wasn't a city you'd stop by on the way to somewhere else. Still, I didn't press him on it.

"…What about your open cases? You said you had three here."

"…All finished. Found one, couldn't find the other two."

"…What about the one you found?"

"…Got word to the family. That's the best moment there is. It doesn't come often, though."

"…And the two you couldn't find?"

"…Just left the record. Someone might pick it up and keep looking, someday."

I felt that his way of speaking was exactly the same as before. Calm, unhurried, never calling a loss a loss. Months had passed, and this person hadn't changed.

"…So this time you're really just passing through?"

"…Yeah. Nothing to do in this city, this time. But I felt like I should come here anyway."

"…What does that mean, felt like you should come?"

"…Can't really explain it. Sometimes a thought like that just comes to me, walking along. Not often."

"…Why?"

Temel gave a small laugh.

"…I don't really know that either."

We sat beside the notice board, as before. I told him everything that had happened. Two hundred and thirteen, nine hundred and twenty-seven, everything I'd felt caught between those two numbers. Temel listened to all of it. Without saying anything, the whole time.

"…That's it? That's your reaction?"

"…What more did you want?"

"…I don't know. Something like — that's amazing."

Temel shook his head.

"…Nothing amazing about it. Two hundred and thirteen is two hundred and thirteen. No more, no less."

This indifference stung me at first. Looking back now, that was the most exact reaction Temel could have given me. He didn't turn me into a hero.

. . .

We sat in silence for a while. The market made its usual sounds. Somewhere far off, someone was haggling.

"…Hora."

"…Yes."

"…You've never asked me, have you. Why your name is Hora."

I was a little surprised by the question.

"…I never thought about it. It's just my name."

"…Never wondered what it means?"

"…I asked my aunt once. She said she doesn't know. My mother chose it, and she's gone now."

Temel looked out toward the market for a moment before speaking.

"…I met an old record-keeper once. Someone who knew the old languages. Digging up where names came from was a hobby of his. I asked him about a few, once."

"…Mine too?"

"…Yeah. He said it comes from a word written ὥρα. It means the hour — the appointed time."

. . .

I couldn't say anything, hearing that.

The appointed time. Hearing those words, I thought back over what I'd spent sixteen years doing. Reading to the end. Reading to the last line. Waiting for the last line to come. I know it's a name that was given by chance. My mother may or may not have known its meaning when she chose it. And yet, in that moment, I couldn't shake the feeling that something fit into place.

I thought again of the twelve pages my mother left. I'd read that last line two years too late. That a person who missed her own appointed time should be called by the name of the appointed time felt, that day, a little strange to me. I don't want to say the name led me somewhere. I don't want to write this record that way. But once I knew how closely the name and the way I've lived overlapped, I could never again think of the two as entirely separate.

"…You knew that, and never told me until now?"

"…You never asked."

"…Would you have told me if I had?"

"…Yes. No reason to hide it. Nobody ever asked."

I thought that line summed up this whole city. Nothing hidden. Simply, no one had asked.

Writing this sentence, I counted how many times I've written something like it, from the start of this book to now. Not written down, or not asked. In this city, the reason for not knowing something was always one of those two. It was the same with the meaning of a name. It hadn't been hidden. Simply, for sixteen years, no one — not even I — had asked.

. . .

Just then Tyche arrived. She seemed to have heard at the reception desk that I'd gone to the market, and followed me.

"…What are you two up to?"

"…Talking about what names mean."

"…What names mean?"

I told her, exactly, what I'd just heard. At first Tyche's face was unmoved.

"…That's what your name meant, Hora? That's interesting."

Temel looked at Tyche for a moment and said.

"…Want me to look up yours too?"

Tyche shrugged.

"…Go ahead. I am curious, I guess."

"…It comes from a word, τύχη. It means chance — luck."

. . .

Tyche laughed, hearing that.

At first it was a short laugh. Then, strangely, it went on. I watched it from beside her. She covered her mouth lightly with one hand and kept laughing. A little water gathered at the corner of her eyes; I couldn't tell whether it came from laughing, or from something else.

"…Chance. My name."

She said that and laughed again. This time the sound was smaller.

In that moment I thought of Tyche's grandmother. A story she'd told me before. Her grandmother had been the kind of person who said there was a reason this city was one where no one is wronged, and that such a reason couldn't possibly be chance. Tyche had said she'd grown up hearing that and spent her whole life checking it, and that nearly all of it turned out explainable by a vacancy and a number and probability. I imagined, briefly, what that grandmother would have said, seeing this moment.

I thought Tyche would say something. She always did. Tyche was someone who put things into words, whatever they were. This time, even after the laughter faded, no words came.

She opened her mouth once, then closed it again.

I waited. Temel waited too. Neither of us pressed her.

Tyche, in the end, said nothing at all.

I want to render this silence exactly. Tyche gave me no answer that day. I don't want to fill that silence with anything. What Tyche was thinking, I don't know. I didn't ask. That wasn't a question that was mine to ask.

Writing this part, I felt several temptations. The temptation to write that something in her shook, in that moment; or, on the other hand, that her own conviction only hardened further. I decided to write neither. I couldn't clearly read either one on Tyche's face. Laughter, and silence — those two things were all I saw. I won't invent anything beyond that.

. . .

A stillness settled over that spot for a moment. A sheet of paper on the notice board fluttered slightly in the wind.

Beside us, someone in worn clothes walked past at a slow pace, unnoticed by anyone.

The sound of the market pressed back in around us. Tyche got up first.

"…I'll go ahead. I've still got some work left."

"…Okay."

She said only that, and walked off. Her stride wasn't much different from usual. Only I watched her back for a little longer than usual.

. . .

Watching her go, Temel spoke to me.

"…Guess I brought up something I shouldn't have."

"…No. Tyche's the one who asked you to."

"…That's true, but."

Temel let the end of that sentence trail off. I wondered for a moment whether he knew something more, then realized he didn't. Temel had only passed along a name, the same as with me. What that name would touch inside the person hearing it — even he couldn't have known that.

"…Does telling someone something like this change a person? From what you've seen."

Temel thought for a moment.

"…Some people change, some don't. I'm just the one who passes it on, so I don't get to see what comes after. I pass it on and move to the next city."

"…This time you're not moving to the next city. You're staying to watch."

"…So I am. Might stick around a little this time, I'm thinking."

"…Why?"

"…I don't know. Just a feeling I have."

I felt, then, that Temel was holding back his words more than usual. I should have asked why, and didn't. Thinking about it now, I think he too was gauging, in that moment, what he'd just opened up. He'd only said one name, and he'd watched, right in front of him, that name touch something inside Tyche.

"…Do you know what your own name means?"

Temel thought for a moment.

"…Never asked."

"…Why not?"

"…Wasn't curious. I'm more used to looking for other people's names than my own."

That answer felt exactly like him. I didn't press any further.

. . .

That evening, at home, I told my aunt about this. She listened quietly, then said.

"…That's what your name meant?"

"…Yeah. Did Mom know?"

"…I don't know. I don't remember your mother liking that kind of talk."

"…Aunt, do you think I'm really living out that meaning?"

My aunt, ladling the rice, looked at me.

"…I don't know that either. Some people live out their name's meaning, and some don't."

I nodded at that. My aunt gave no certainty either. I found that, somehow, a relief.

"…Why do you think Mom chose that name for me?"

"…Your mother chose it, so you'd have to ask your mother. I don't know."

"…But if you had to guess."

My aunt set down her spoon for a moment and thought.

"…Your mother was someone who decided things ahead of time about everything. The day to put away the winter clothes, decided ahead of time. The day to buy rice, decided ahead of time. So maybe she picked a name like that for that kind of reason."

"…Is that the same thing as this meaning?"

"…Well, I don't know that either. Just that she was that kind of person."

Hearing that, I thought of the twelve pages my mother had written. My aunt might have been right. My mother was someone who decided things ahead of time. And yet the very last sentence she left for me hadn't been placed somewhere fixed in advance — it had been placed somewhere it could easily be missed.

"…Did you hear about Tyche?"

"…You just told me. Laughed, and said nothing, you said."

"…What do you think about that?"

My aunt thought for a moment, then spoke.

"…I know people like that. People who laugh and then can't speak. That's not a bad thing. It just means there's nothing to say, in that moment."

"…Isn't having nothing to say a bad thing?"

"…No. Having nothing to say is an answer too, Hora. Don't keep trying to squeeze an answer out of her."

I thought about that for a long time. I think I'd been treating Tyche's silence as if it were something lacking. Only after hearing my aunt's words did I come to think, again, that the silence itself might be whole on its own.

. . .

The next morning I went to work as usual. The meeting room was the same as always. Tyche, too, was out as usual, sorting through materials. She said nothing about the day before. Neither did I bring it up first.

"…What's the schedule today?"

"…Two requests to view records in the morning, one meeting in the afternoon."

"…Got it."

We started the day as usual, that way. On the surface, nothing about the day had changed. I was, if anything, grateful for that ordinariness. It meant Tyche wasn't avoiding me over what had happened the day before.

From that day on, I came to hear my own name differently than before. Every time someone called out, "Hora," its meaning would flicker past, just for an instant. The hour. The appointed time. I still don't know whether that's true or not. Only that, after that, I could never hear it again the way I once had, meaning nothing at all.

Tyche never brought up her own name's meaning to me again, after that day. I never asked either. That silence continues on for a long time still to come.

Writing this chapter, I set the two names down side by side. The hour, the appointed time. Chance, luck. The two words look like opposites. What is appointed, and what is not. And yet I'm still not certain, even now, whether the two are really opposites. An appointed hour can still, for someone, arrive as a moment of pure chance; and chance, looked back on later, can look as if it had been appointed all along. I won't decide, in this book, which of the two is right. I'll

only set down, exactly, that the two were spoken that day, in the same place, from the same person's mouth, side by side.

(Continued in Chapter 45.)

Chapter 45. Tyche's Reprieve

> *_Previously_ — Temel told the two of them what their names meant.*
> *Hora — the hour, the appointed time. Tyche — chance, luck. Tyche laughed on hearing it, and after laughing, could say nothing at all. The next morning, the two of them worked as usual.*

For several days after that, Tyche was largely no different than usual.

She sorted materials, sat in on meetings, ate lunch with me. The subject of names never came up again, not once. I thought that was Tyche's own way of doing things. Letting some things simply pass.

During those few days I wanted to ask her, several times, why she hadn't been able to say anything, that day. I didn't ask. Writing this book, I've thought many times that holding that question back was the right thing to do. I still think so now.

Temel left this city the next morning. I couldn't go to see him off. I had a backlog of notices to process. I heard later from the person at the reception desk that he'd shouldered his bag and gone quietly, as usual. Hearing that news, I felt a pang, but soon acknowledged that this was just like him. He was a person who moved on without leaving anything behind. This time, though, he'd left behind two names.

One thing, though, had changed. Before this, whenever Tyche organized deliberation materials, she liked to cite probability and statistics. That this agenda had turned out this way because of how many people were involved, and so the probability was high, that kind of thing.

During those few days, Tyche never once used that word. I only noticed on the third day.

"…Tyche, you haven't been talking about probability lately."

"…Have I not? I hadn't noticed."

"…You really haven't. I counted."

Tyche laughed a little.

"…You really do count things like that, Hora."

Then she changed the subject. I didn't press her further.

I've thought about this small change many times since. Whether not using the word probability meant something, or whether there had simply happened to be no material that week calling for it — I never did find out, in the end. I could have asked Tyche again, and I didn't. I felt it was right to leave some things unconfirmed.

. . .

On the sixth day, Tyche came to find me first.

It was near the end of the workday. Only the two of us were left in the meeting room. Tyche stood for a moment with the papers she'd been organizing still in her hand, then spoke.

"…Hora."

"…Yeah."

"…I've been thinking, ever since then."

I stopped what I was doing. Tyche's face looked like she'd come prepared with something. She hadn't brought materials the way she usually did. She'd come empty-handed.

. . .

"…I've always said that wanting there to be a meaning, and believing there is one, are different things."

"…Yeah."

"…That still hasn't changed. It's the same now."

Hearing that, I tensed a little. I wondered if Tyche had come to lay out some conclusion.

"…But the truth is, that day, hearing what my name meant, I did laugh. I still don't really know why it was funny to me."

"…Why do you think it was funny?"

Tyche thought for a moment.

"…Probably because it fit too well. I'm someone who's said, my whole life, that everything is chance — and my own name literally meant chance. That struck me as absurd."

. . .

"…But what that means, I still don't know, even now."

I nearly asked what she meant by that, then held back. Tyche went on.

"…The reason I couldn't say anything after I laughed was that I didn't know what to say. I felt like I should say something, but I didn't know what. That had never happened to me before."

"…Do you know now?"

"…No. I still don't know. That's why I came. To tell you I don't know."

I expected, in that moment, that Tyche would say something different. Maybe I even hoped for it, a little. That she thought there might be meaning after all. That the probability of a name fitting this well was too low. That she might fill, differently this time, the hole she'd admitted to before, further back.

. . .

Tyche walked to the window. The one that faced the water channel. The sun was setting, and the light outside the window was red.

"…I've worked it out like this. The person who chose my name was my parents. It's unlikely my parents knew the Greek word τύχη when they chose it. My family weren't people who'd studied that kind of thing. Probably they liked the sound of it, or it was a name they'd heard somewhere."

"…So the meaning attached itself by chance."

"…Yeah. The meaning attached itself by chance. Actually, I even ran the numbers on it."

"…You ran the numbers?"

"…Yeah. Roughly how many names are used in this city, how many of those carry a Greek meaning, and of those, what the odds are that the meaning would happen to match the person's character. I calculated it, roughly."

"…And?"

"…Low. Low, but not zero. About that."

I thought, in that moment, how like Tyche this was. Even in a moment like this, she was someone who didn't let go of calculation. But what came after that calculation surprised me.

"…But…"

Tyche stopped. I waited.

. . .

"…That I grew up to be someone who believes in probability and chance the way I do now — I think all of that can be explained too. My grandmother's words, the environment I grew up in, the work I love. All of it has a reason. It's not because of my name."

"…But?"

Tyche turned to look at me.

"…But that my name happened to mean that, and that I happen to be living out that meaning — calling even that a coincidence has started to feel a little hard for me now."

. . .

Tyche kept looking out at the water channel for a while. I didn't press her. The clock in the meeting room sounded unusually loud. I thought, over those few days, that Tyche hadn't been sleeping well at night. The skin under her eyes was darker than usual.

"…Actually, I meant to come say this yesterday too, and didn't."

"…Why not?"

"…I couldn't get it sorted out, what to say. It's still not fully sorted out today either, but I came anyway."

I held my breath and waited for what would come next. I felt something large was coming.

Tyche looked straight at me and said.

"…I suppose my name meaning that is a coincidence too. Isn't it?"

I opened my mouth to answer that question.

Tyche didn't wait for my answer.

She turned around just as she was, gathered her papers, shouldered her bag, and walked toward the door.

"…See you tomorrow."

Her voice was no different than usual.

The door closed.

. . .

I stayed alone in that room for a long while. Outside the window it had gone fully dark by now. The sound of the water channel came in over the windowsill.

I looked at the chair Tyche had been sitting in. The papers she'd been holding still lay on the table. I gathered them up and put them in the file box. Something Tyche would ordinarily have done herself.

Putting those papers away, I felt strangely urgent. I wanted to chase after Tyche and finish giving her my answer. I felt that if I opened the door and went out, I could probably still catch up to her. I didn't. I already knew, in that moment, that if Tyche had wanted an answer, she would have waited.

I stood there for a long while. What I'd meant to say stayed right there in my mouth. I never told anyone that, in the end. I don't intend to write it down in this record either.

Turning off the light and leaving the meeting room, I ran into the caretaker in the hallway. He looked at me and asked.

"…Why are you leaving so late today?"

"…Oh, a conversation ran a little long."

"…What about?"

"…Just, about names."

The caretaker nodded, not looking particularly curious, and walked on. I was strangely grateful for that indifference, that day. That the world was turning as unremarkably as ever — that short exchange confirmed it to me again.

I've rewritten this scene many times. Each time I wanted to revise it so that I answered her with something before Tyche walked out the door. But that wasn't the truth. Tyche really did leave without waiting for an answer. I decided to leave that fact exactly as it was.

Tyche hadn't asked that question wanting to be persuaded. Nor had she asked to be refuted. Even now I don't know exactly who that question was aimed at. It could have been me. It could have been Tyche herself. It could have been no one at all.

At the very front of this record, I meant to write that this book was the story of two people arriving at different conclusions over the same document. Writing this chapter, I feel again how exact that was. Tyche and I heard the same two names on the same evening, from the same person's mouth. I saw something in them. Tyche saw a question. Neither of us was wrong.

. . .

The next day Tyche really did come in as usual.

"…Good morning."

"…Yeah, good morning."

Neither of us said anything about the day before. I didn't bring it up either. We sorted materials as usual that day, and ate lunch as usual.

At the restaurant, Tyche said, out of nowhere.

"…Hora, remember what you told me before. That maybe nothing changes, but even so, it won't be empty."

"…Yeah, I remember."

"…That kept coming back to me, strangely, this whole time. I think yesterday's question was something like that too. My answer doesn't change. I still believe in probability. But I think it's better that I asked that question than that I never did."

"…Why?"

"…Because once I asked it, it stopped being nothing at all. It's not empty anymore."

I couldn't say anything back, hearing that. Tyche was handing my own words back to me, in her own way.

"…So you've filled something too, then."

"…Filled what?"

"…That question. Like a signature box."

Tyche gave a short laugh at that.

"…It's not that big a deal. But, well, maybe it's something like that."

We finished eating after that, with nothing more said. The restaurant was crowded as usual, and no one paid us any attention.

I don't convert Tyche in this book. I have no intention of doing so. Tyche lives on, even after asking that question, as someone who still believes in probability and procedure. Only, I think that question probably never entirely vanished inside her. If it had vanished, she wouldn't have asked it to begin with.

. . .

When I told my aunt this story, she was quiet for a long while.

"…So what did you answer?"

"…I couldn't. Tyche didn't wait."

"…Good."

"…Why?"

My aunt set down her rice bowl.

"…Some questions aren't meant to get an answer. You just say them to someone."

"…Then why say it at all?"

"…So you can move on to what comes next. Not saying it and moving on, and saying it without hearing an answer and moving on — those are completely different things."

"…How are they different?"

My aunt thought for a moment.

"…If you don't say it, it's as if the question never existed. If you say it, even without hearing an answer, the question stays. Somewhere."

I turned that over. I thought about where Tyche's question was, right now. In the air of that meeting room. Inside Tyche herself. Or inside me. I couldn't settle on any single one of those. Probably it was all three.

I thought about it for a long time. I still can't be certain whether Tyche's question was really that kind of question. But I do know she would have waited if she'd wanted an answer. Tyche was a person who waited. Always. Only that day, she didn't.

"…Aunt, you've never even met Tyche. How do you know her so well?"

"…I don't know Tyche. I know that there's a kind of person like that. A person who asks a question and then runs. I was like that too, when I was young."

"…You were?"

"…Yeah. I once asked your mother a question, just one time, and left without hearing the answer."

I'd never heard this before.

"…What was the question?"

My aunt laughed a little.

"…I'm not going to tell you that. That one's mine."

I didn't press any further. I realized, for the first time that day, that my aunt had a drawer of her own too. And that maybe everyone in this city was carrying, somewhere, one question they'd never been able to speak.

That evening I opened the drawer and looked again at my mother's twelve pages, and the short notes I'd kept there all this time. I didn't write Tyche's question down on paper. It wasn't the kind of thing that could be written down. Instead of writing it, I decided just to remember it, for a long time.

I gave this chapter the title "Reprieve." A postponing of judgment. That night, Tyche postponed judgment on herself. She didn't say it wasn't chance. Nor did she reconfirm that it was. She just left one question behind and went. I don't know when that reprieve will end. Maybe it never will. I think that, too, is Tyche's own to keep.

. . .

Several more weeks passed after that. Tyche was still someone who spoke of probability. Still precise, still kind. Only, from that night on, Tyche gained a habit of pausing mid-conversation, sometimes. Very briefly. A habit she'd never had before.

I never asked what that pause was. It might have been nothing at all. It might just have been that Tyche had grown a little more careful, since that day.

I wrote, somewhere in this book, that I wasn't going to try to win against Tyche. I keep that promise here too. Tyche hasn't changed. If anything has changed, it's only that Tyche now carries, with her, one question she asked herself. I think that's enough. Maybe that's the whole of what one person can do, in this city.

(Continued in Chapter 46.)

Chapter 46. A Document with a Name on It

> *_Previously_ — Tyche asked, "…I suppose my name meaning that is a*
> *coincidence too. Isn't it?" And left without waiting for an answer. Hora, in the end, said nothing at all. A few days later, the two of them were back at work as usual.*

About a month after Tyche left without waiting for any answer, the reading room clerk called me over one day.

"…Hora, could you take a look at this?"

What the clerk held out was an official document from another city. It was an exchange record between deliberation districts, the kind of thing that circulated occasionally. This one was marked as a case study in administrative procedure improvement.

"…What about it?"

"…Your name's in the signature box here, Hora."

. . .

I took the document from her right there.

It bore another city's name. Somewhere I'd never been. At the very bottom of the document, in the signature box, was written "Hora." The

handwriting wasn't mine. The stroke order was different, and so was the angle of the strokes.

"…I didn't write this."

"…What? Then who—"

"…I don't know. I've never even been to that city."

The clerk checked the screen.

"…The receipt date was three months ago. You were here then, weren't you?"

"…Yes. I was here, undergoing review, at that time."

"…Then it's definitely not you."

"…Yes, definitely not me."

I felt something cold pass through me, in that moment. It wasn't quite the same as fear. More than that, it was simply strange to me that my own name had been written somewhere I knew nothing about.

I studied that handwriting for a long while. The strokes were long and straight. My own writing tends to be short and a little crooked. My aunt always said my writing looked rushed. This handwriting wasn't rushed. It was neat, careful, as if it had been practiced.

That neatness bothered me strangely. When I'd written my own name before, I'd just written it the way I write anything, ordinarily. That was the moment I wrote took about three seconds. This person seemed to have written those two syllables far more carefully, far more slowly than I had. I tried, for a moment, to imagine what that person must

have felt, sitting in front of that box. The imagining didn't last long. I knew too little.

. . .

The clerk didn't take it very seriously.

"…Probably just someone with the same name. There are a few other Horas in this city too."

"…There are?"

"…Yes, it's not a common name, but it's not so rare either."

I nodded at that explanation. It sounded plausible. The same name, different person. There are plenty of people in the world who share a name. I let it go, that day.

Writing this chapter, I don't regret not pressing further, that day. Even if I had, no answer probably would have come of it. I simply want to set down exactly what happened that day.

That night I read the contents of the document again. Before, I'd only skimmed the result and moved on; this time I read it to the end. It was habit.

The content concerned a registration reexamination. In that city too, there had been people bound up in some classification, a new deliberation had been opened, and only part of them had been reclassified. Not all — only part. I found that shape familiar.

I realized, that day, for the first time, how closely this shape resembled what I had gone through. Not all, only part. The same

pattern. I couldn't tell whether this was chance, or whether such deliberations simply tended, as a rule, to end this way. I had no way of confirming it.

. . .

Then, two weeks later, another document arrived.

This time it was from a different city. A different region again from the first. The signature box again bore the name "Hora." This time the handwriting was different again, different even from the first.

I laid the two documents side by side. The same name, two different hands. There was something strange about it, even setting aside a mere shared name. I grew curious what these names were doing. I read through the contents of both documents again.

Both cases were similar. A case study in administrative procedure improvement. Reexamining an existing decision, and reconfirming part of it anew. Documents received with the signature box filled.

. . .

I went to the reception desk and asked.

"…How far are these cities from here?"

"…Far. One's about ten days away, and the other is even farther than that."

"…Can you find out whether anyone from those places has ever come here?"

"…We have no way to check that. We can't see the roster of another city."

"…Then can you at least confirm that this really wasn't me?"

"…The handwriting is different, so that much is confirmed. But beyond that, there's no way for us to look into it further."

I stood there a moment, hearing that answer. This city hides nothing. But this time, it wasn't a matter of something being hidden — there simply was no way to know, to begin with.

. . .

That evening, the first person I thought of was Temel. As far as I knew, he was the only person who traveled between cities.

I held onto this thought for a long while. But I soon realized it didn't add up. The first document's receipt date was three months before. Temel hadn't even come to this city yet, at that time. It was much later — the day he told us what our names meant — that he'd arrived. There was no reason, and no time, for him to have written my name into another city's document in advance.

I set down here that I suspected him. And I set down, alongside it, that the suspicion was wrong. To this day I still don't know who wrote those two documents. All I know is that it wasn't Temel.

. . .

When I told Tyche about this, she was unimpressed at first.

"…Isn't it just someone with the same name? It's not that unusual a name."

"…But it's two of them. In two different cities. Both filled in the signature box. The box that nobody here fills."

Tyche's face grew a little thoughtful at that.

"…That is a little strange. Filling in the signature box is rare enough on its own — that two people with the same name would both have done it."

"…Right."

"…But that's not something probability can't explain either. There's exchange between these cities, so word that one of them had filled it in first could have spread to the other. Someone might have followed suit."

"…Followed my name?"

"…Not your name specifically — it could just be that two people who happened to both be named Hora each did it on their own."

"…But why now, of all times? It's been since I signed."

Tyche took a moment before answering that one.

"…That's explainable too. That you signed it, Hora, might have become known among the people of this deliberation district, and spread to other cities from there, and a few people followed suit. Since filling in the signature box is so rare, word that someone had done it might well have traveled far."

"…So it started because of me."

"…Not started, exactly — more like, triggered. You didn't tell anyone to do it."

I thought that distinction was fair. I hadn't told anyone to do anything. And yet the very possibility that something I'd done might have moved someone else's hand, somewhere I'd never see, felt heavy to me all the same.

. . .

I couldn't fully believe that explanation, but I had no grounds to argue against it either. Tyche's account, once again, was the simplest explanation there was.

I won't try to win against Tyche on this point either. She might well be right. Shared names, rumor, an overlap of coincidences. All of it could happen. I only want to set down this one fact exactly. I never wrote the names on those two documents. That's the one thing I know for certain.

. . .

I told the Secretary about this too. He studied the two documents for a long while.

"…Has anything like this happened before?"

"…Not as far as I know."

"…So this is the first time?"

"…As far as I know. I have no way of checking the records of other deliberation districts."

"…Is there any way to check?"

"…No. Each deliberation district manages its own records separately. There's no place where everything is gathered together."

Hearing that answer, I thought back to something I'd heard earlier. That no one holds the whole picture. Back then, it had been said about the people who called Temel in. Now I was hearing the same thing said about my own name.

"…Secretary, so there's no way at all to look into this?"

"…Not at the deliberation-district level. If you wish, you could raise it as a matter for full review."

"…So, another new deliberation?"

"…Yes. The same procedure."

Hearing that, I hesitated. I'd already been through one new deliberation. I knew, in my body, what rhythm review moved to. That day, I didn't have the confidence to start that rhythm all over again for this.

"…Are you not going to open one?"

"…I don't know. Not right now."

The Secretary added nothing to that answer. He simply nodded once and put his papers in order.

"…Doesn't this strike you as strange, Secretary?"

"…It strikes me as strange."

That short answer surprised me. It was rare for the Secretary to say anything carrying feeling.

"…But finding it strange doesn't give me anything more I can do about it."

I nodded at that. In this city, the distance between finding something strange and being able to do something about it always went uncrossed, that way.

. . .

A few days later I went to the reading room and looked again into how many records existed, in this city, of the signature box ever being filled. The one person eleven years before. Temel. And me. That was the entire record for this city. Records from other cities I had no way to see, here.

I laid those three names side by side and looked at them for a long while. All three, without knowing one another, had each filled the same box for their own separate reasons. I tried, several times, to connect those three names to the unfamiliar handwriting bearing my own name from other cities. It wouldn't connect. I decided to stop trying.

The reading room clerk, tidying up, asked me.

"…What are you looking for?"

"…Just counting how many people in this city have ever filled the signature box."

"…How many is it?"

"…Three."

The clerk looked a little surprised.

"…That's few. I only just learned that too, though. I've worked here for years, and I've never once counted that."

"…Nobody ever counts it?"

"…No reason to. Everyone just passes over that box without looking, generally."

Hearing that, I thought again of how, in this city, there are always one of two reasons for not knowing something. It isn't written down, or nobody asked. This time there was a third. Nobody had ever counted.

. . .

That night I put both documents in the drawer. Beside my mother's paper, beside Temel's name, beside the notes of these two hundred-some days.

When I told my aunt about it, she studied the documents for a long while, then spoke.

"…Is this supposed to be a frightening story?"

"…I don't know. I don't even know if it's frightening or not."

"…Are you sure you didn't write it?"

"…Yes, I'm sure."

My aunt handed the documents back to me.

"…Then just write that down. That you didn't write it. The rest isn't something you can know."

"…But Aunt, I have this strange feeling."

"…What kind of feeling."

"…Like something keeps going even without me. Like something I did is still walking around out there, without me."

My aunt looked at me for a moment, then spoke.

"…Is that a bad feeling?"

"…I don't know. It doesn't feel bad, but it's not comfortable either."

"…Your mother probably felt that too. She probably never imagined that last line she wrote would sit in a drawer for two whole years without her, and then finally reach you. But it got there in the end, didn't it."

I couldn't say anything back to that. My aunt sometimes pointed out, just like that, connections I hadn't seen.

I thought she was right. I don't know why these two documents exist. I don't know who wrote them. There's only one thing I know. I didn't write them.

. . .

Writing this record now, I have to set down one more thing. In these last few days, while writing this chapter, a third document arrived.

From a city farther still than the first two, different from both. The content was similar too. A registration reexamination, a partial reclassification, my name written in the signature box.

Only after receiving this third document did I accept that this wasn't a coincidence happening once or twice, but something continuing to happen. Tyche would probably say even three times can be explained by probability. She probably would. I can't argue against that explanation. I only set down, alongside it, that I no longer know when this will stop, or whether it will continue at all.

When I began writing this record, I already knew where this story would end. But that a new document would arrive while I was writing this very chapter — even I hadn't known that in advance. I decided not to invent anything, and to put it in exactly as it happened.

Before closing this chapter, I want to leave this fact exactly as it stands, in this record. The only time I ever wrote my name in a signature box was that once, in this city, on that one document. And yet my name now appears in at least three other documents, in three other cities. I didn't write those names. Someone is filling the same box. Who that is, I never managed to find out, in the end. This record ends without giving that answer.

I know this is the most uncomfortable part of this book. The reader will probably want to guess the answer before I do. I wanted that too. But I close this chapter not knowing the answer. If there's one thing this city has taught me, it's not to fill in what I don't know as if I did. That's exactly like this city's signature box. When it's empty, you leave it empty.

(Continued in Chapter 47.)

Chapter 47. The Secretary

> *_Previously_ — Hora's name appeared on documents from three other*
> *cities. She wrote none of them. Who did, she never managed to find out. This city hides nothing, but this time there simply was no way to know, to begin with.*

The Secretary came to find me around the end of the workday.

It was within working hours. Unlike that night, long before. That time we'd first met outside of working hours; this time it was an ordinary weekday afternoon. He came carrying a single folder. Nothing about him seemed different from usual.

"…Hora, do you have a moment."

"…Yes."

This meeting was unlike any review I'd had before. No one had called me in. He had come to find me on his own. That had never happened before. It was an unusually quiet afternoon. The other seats were already empty, and the late sunlight was coming in long through the window. I watched that light and thought, briefly, that the light must have looked something like this the very first time I'd walked into this building.

. . .

We sat in an empty meeting room. The Secretary set the folder down on the table. But he didn't open it.

"…I'm not here about paperwork today."

I was a little surprised. He had never come to find me without a matter of business before.

"…Then what is it?"

"…It will soon be fifteen years in this post."

"…That long?"

"…Yes. Since before Hora was born."

His expression barely changed as he said this. It was the same face as always.

"…How many people have passed through this seat, in that time? Assistant members, like Hora."

"…No count was ever kept, but it's probably over a hundred."

"…Are all of them remembered?"

"…Faces are hazy. But the matters each one handled are remembered. The matter comes to mind before the person."

I found that answer strangely sad. That the matter comes to mind before the person.

"…And me? Am I remembered as a matter too?"

The Secretary took a moment before this question.

"…No. Hora is remembered by name."

I couldn't say anything back to that answer. That single line — remembered by name — stayed with me longer than the whole rest of the conversation.

. . .

"…Fifteen years, and only convening was done. Setting meeting dates, distributing materials, writing minutes, passing on results. That was all."

"…I know."

"…Everything that's happened in this seat since Hora arrived has been watched, all of it. The Seventh Classification matter, review, the new deliberation, and now this reexamination."

"…Yes."

"…What was done, across all of that, can be said exactly. It was convened. It was passed on. That's all."

I couldn't tell why he was bringing this up again, so I just listened quietly.

. . .

"…Hora once asked what happens if you write your name. The gaze was averted, then."

"…I remember."

"…The answer wasn't unknown, then, and that isn't why the gaze was averted. The answer was already known. It had been seen, eleven years before."

I stopped breathing for a moment, hearing this. The words eleven years before overlapped with something he'd said earlier. I convened that one too.

"…And at the very start, when the wrong paperwork was filed. Hora asked how something that isn't there could be confirmed."

"…You remember that?"

"…Yes. That was thought about for a long time."

The Secretary nodded briefly.

"…That was a fair thing to say, then too. There was no way for Hora to confirm a notice that didn't exist. But every time that was said, no distinction was drawn between something not existing because it truly wasn't there, and something not existing because no one had made it exist. Even though the two are different."

. . .

"…The person who wrote a name, back then — what became of that person was watched to the very end. A new deliberation was opened, part of it was overturned, the rest wasn't, that person kept being called in, and then one day, vanished from the roster."

"…Vanished, meaning—"

"…Where that person went isn't known. The record simply stops there."

"…Do you remember that person's name?"

The Secretary nodded.

"…It's remembered. But it won't be spoken here."

"…Why not?"

"…That's that person's name. Not mine. It isn't a place to bring it up carelessly."

I was a little startled by that answer. The Secretary wasn't someone who hid names. Nowhere in this city was there a hidden name. And yet, in that moment, for the first time, he chose to know something and not say it. That was different from hiding it. I felt that difference immediately, right there.

Saying this, the Secretary lowered his gaze for the first time.

"…That matter was only convened. But in the eleven years since, no one wrote a name again. That wasn't thought to be anyone's fault. There was only convening done."

. . .

"…But?"

The Secretary looked at me again.

"…But then Hora came. And wrote it."

"…Are you saying that's your fault?"

"…No. That's not what's meant."

He took a moment to choose his words.

"…It's true that, for those eleven years, only convening was said to have been done, over and over. But across those eleven years, that record was reopened, every single time. No one asked it to be."

"…Why?"

"…That isn't known. It was simply kept being looked at."

"…What was being looked for?"

"…At first, where that person had gone. Later, not even that. It just became a habit."

"…What was found?"

"…Nothing was found. Not in eleven years."

I found that answer strangely sad. Eleven years of finding nothing. I tried to imagine those years. Sitting in the same seat every day, doing something no one had asked for, with no result, over and over.

"…And it was still kept up?"

"…Yes. It's strange. Even I can't fully explain why."

. . .

I didn't understand right away what this meant. The Secretary went on.

"…Reopening that record, over and over, wasn't part of the work here. No one ever instructed that it be checked."

"…Then why was it done?"

The Secretary was silent for a long while. Only the sound of the meeting room clock could be heard.

"…I was curious."

. . .

Something different passed through me, hearing that. I thought of every sentence he'd spoken, all this time. It was put in order. It was confirmed. It was convened. Sentences that had gone fifteen years without a subject.

"…You just said, 'I was curious.'"

The Secretary paused for a moment.

"…Yes."

"…Are you going to correct it?"

This time he didn't correct it.

"…No. This time it's the right way to say it. It won't be corrected."

. . .

I'll remember this moment for a long time. Once before, he had said "I" exactly once, and corrected it right away. At the time I thought it had simply been a slip of habit. I know now that it wasn't a slip. He

must have known it, even then. He simply hadn't allowed himself to say it, that time.

I didn't know how to answer him. It wasn't something to congratulate, and it wasn't something to comfort. I just listened to those words, as they were.

I thought, in that moment, of the people I'd met earlier in this record. "I only passed it on." Twelve people had all said exactly that. None of them had lied. I'd known, even then, that all those words were true, and still felt some kind of emptiness. Only now do I think I understand, a little, what that emptiness had been. Being true didn't mean it was the whole of it. The Secretary, too, was only saying today, for the first time, that there was a self standing behind that truth.

. . .

"…So what is it you wanted to say?"

The Secretary looked at the folder again. Still unopened.

"…Nothing. This was simply what needed saying to Hora."

"…Is that all?"

"…Yes. That one line, just now. That's the whole of it."

I waited for him to say more. An apology, perhaps, or regret. No such words came.

Writing this chapter, I felt the temptation to correct him. To write him as if he'd suddenly become a different person, as someone who, from this chapter on, had reclaimed a subject. I decided against it.

He was still the Secretary, even after saying this. The very next sentence came out without a subject again. I wasn't disappointed by that. If anything, it left that one sentence standing out all the more clearly.

. . .

"…But Secretary, what about that folder? It was never opened."

The Secretary looked down at it.

"…Ah, that was just a pretext. Coming empty-handed felt awkward."

"…What's in it?"

"…Nothing in particular. Next week's meeting schedule. It could have been handed over any time."

I laughed a little at that. That even the Secretary needed a pretext, sometimes, felt strangely human to me that day. I thought it had been a long time since I'd laughed like that.

"…This will go handle the next agenda item now."

The Secretary said that and stood. Gathering the folder, his usual way of speaking returned.

"…What's been confirmed today will be passed along the approval line."

I laughed a little, hearing that. It wasn't a sad laugh.

"…Secretary."

"…Yes."

"…Thank you."

"…Nothing to thank. It was only said because it wanted saying."

He said that and left the room.

. . .

I sat alone for a long while. Outside the window the sun was setting.

This whole record was written trying not to write this person as an accusation. He wasn't a bad person. He was simply someone who believed he was nothing at all. But today, in exactly one sentence, he said, of his own accord, that he wasn't nothing.

I won't write that this changed him completely. Tomorrow, too, he will convene, and pass things on, and confirm them. Without a subject. I only set down, exactly, this one thing that happened today. He said, "I was curious." He didn't correct that sentence. That's the whole of what happened to this person.

Turning off the light and leaving the meeting room, I thought, on impulse, of a stamp I'd once seen. The one with only a window number engraved on it. A mark that belongs to a seat, not a person. I'd long thought of the Secretary as a person like that stamp. I didn't fully give up that thought today. Only, I learned, for the first time, that even a stamp sometimes has a hand.

I'm not certain this comparison is exact. But it's the only way I could put it into words. The Secretary was a seat, today too, and at the same time, today alone, he wasn't only a seat.

. . .

The next day I told Tyche about this. She said little the whole time she listened, and once I'd finished, asked.

"…Is it really that big a deal? He just didn't correct one word."

"…I thought the same at first. But I keep thinking about it."

"…Why?"

"…Because he said, today, something he hadn't said once in fifteen years."

Tyche thought for a moment, then spoke.

"…Even looked at through probability, that's not so strange. A person speaks in the same pattern for fifteen years straight, and then one day, by chance, the pattern breaks. That kind of thing happens."

"…But why today, of all days? Why to me, of all people?"

"…That, I can't explain either."

I noticed that Tyche was, once again, admitting a part she couldn't explain. She didn't bother hiding it. I confirmed again that this was Tyche's own kind of honesty.

"…But Tyche, what do you think of the Secretary?"

"…I think he's a good person. Fifteen years doing that work is impressive too."

"…Have you ever once thought he was a bad person?"

Tyche shook her head.

"…Not once. There's no reason to. You said my parents did something similar too. I can't find a reason to think badly of people like that."

I agreed with her. I'd never thought badly of the Secretary either. Only, after today, I could no longer see him in exactly the same way as before. Not worse, and not better, either. Just a little more exactly.

. . .

At home, I told my aunt this story. She listened quietly, then asked.

"…So do you think he'll change now?"

"…I don't know. I don't think he will."

"…Then why does it matter so much to you?"

I couldn't answer that right away. After thinking for a long while, I said.

"…Because it was one sentence. But that one sentence was the first in fifteen years."

My aunt nodded at that. She didn't press further.

"…But Hora, was that person a bad person, or was he just a seat?"

I had to think about that question for a long while.

"…He wasn't a bad person. But it's hard now to call him just a seat, either."

"…Then what is he?"

"…I don't know, Aunt. Sometimes it feels like both. Sometimes it feels like neither."

My aunt didn't press further at that. She just nodded.

Writing this chapter, I felt the temptation, many times, to reach one conclusion about the Secretary. That he was, in truth, a good person — or, that he was merely a part of the system. I decided to write neither. I close this chapter without concluding anything about him. I think that's the most honest thing I can do for him.

That night I opened the drawer and put nothing into it. I felt this wasn't something to write down on paper. I decided to leave it only in this record.

That person went on being the Secretary, after that. As far as I know, he still is.

(Continued in Chapter 48.)

Chapter 48. The Unsigned Book

> *_Previously_ — For the first time, the Secretary came to find Hora on*
> *his own, not outside working hours but within them. He still spoke without a subject. But in one sentence, he said, "I was curious," and*
> *he didn't correct it.*

Before closing this record, there's one name I've put off writing that I need to set down now.

That person belonged to the Seventh Classification. One of the nine hundred and twenty-seven. One of those the reexamination back then had not released. I'd met that person a long time before, and heard the name then. I hadn't written it in this record until now. I didn't think it was mine to write.

That person's name was Jeong Su-a.

I think back again to the day I met her. A low house near the water channel. Laundry hung out in the yard, and she was neither wary of me nor welcoming. She just told me to sit. I didn't ask much that day. I asked her name, I asked her age, I asked how long she'd lived there. It wasn't a remarkable conversation. I hadn't remembered her name that day because she was special. I'd simply realized, for the first time that day, that she was someone who could be called by a name, not only a number.

. . .

I wrote this name on the twelfth page of this document, in the entry for the affected roster. The place that had only ever read 7-614. There was no box, originally, meant to hold a name beside the number. I didn't erase the number. I wrote the name into the margin beside it.

I hesitated over this for a long time. Whether it was better to erase the number, or write beside it. In the end I decided not to erase it. The number, too, was part of what had happened to this person. I didn't want to make it as if it had never happened.

This wasn't a formal procedure. I didn't bring this before a new deliberation. I simply wrote three syllables of a name, by hand, in the margin of a document I had held onto for a long time.

Picking up the pen, I thought again of the moment I'd written my own name in the signature box, much earlier. I'd written, then, that it took about three seconds. This time it took longer. This time it wasn't my own name — it was someone else's name I was writing down in her place. I tried to copy each stroke exactly the way Jeong Su-a herself had told it to me. The handwriting, of course, came out as mine. That bothered me. This name belonged to her, but the writing came from my hand.

I still don't quite know how to settle this mismatch. I wasn't writing on her behalf. I hadn't asked her before writing it, either. I simply took a name I'd heard long before, and wrote it, with my own hand, into a document I held. Whether this was the right thing to do, I never became fully certain, to the end. I only decided to believe that it was better than leaving her as only a number.

. . .

I went to the reception desk and resubmitted the document.

"…Please receive this again."

The person at the desk took the document and looked it over. Their hand stopped at the roster entry.

"…This is an entry not provided for by regulation."

"…I know. But it's not forbidden either, is it."

The person at the desk thought for a moment, then spoke.

"…That's right. It's not forbidden."

"…Have you never seen anything like this before?"

"…No, this is the first time. A name written beside a number."

"…Does it strike you as strange?"

The person at the desk looked at the document once more before answering.

"…Not strange, exactly — a little unfamiliar. But unfamiliar and not allowed are different things."

I thought that answer summed up this whole city once again. What's unfamiliar and what's not allowed are different things.

He stamped it and put the document in the file box.

"…Received."

That was all. The name Jeong Su-a now existed, inside a document of this city, beside a number, written by hand.

. . .

I want to set this moment beside that earlier signature. Nothing had happened then, either. Nothing happened this time either. The person at the reception desk wasn't surprised. They stamped it, and filed it. I think these two ordinary moments are the whole of what I learned in this book. A thing that changes the world comes in a shape the world doesn't notice.

I didn't expect this name to change anything by itself. Jeong Su-a was still one of the nine hundred and twenty-seven. She hadn't been released from relocation-target status. This one entry didn't change that fact.

I thought again of something I once said to Tyche. Maybe nothing changes. But it won't be empty. I applied those words, this time, to the margin beside the number. Her name being written there doesn't cancel the relocation. But that space is no longer empty now.

. . .

From there I went straight to tell the Secretary. He took the document and looked it over.

"…Confirmed. No violation of regulation."

"…Is that all?"

"…Procedurally, that's all. Only—"

He paused for a moment.

"…Only, entries like this could go on happening, from here on. There's no regulation to stop it."

I understood that wasn't a threat, but a statement of fact. That was always how things were, in this city.

"…Would you like there to be more of these, Secretary?"

The Secretary took a while choosing his answer to that.

"…That isn't mine to decide. Only, it's not thought to be a bad thing."

I knew even that much was rare from him. I thanked him and left.

. . .

Tyche heard about this that afternoon and asked.

"…What changes, writing that?"

This was the same question Tyche had asked me before, about the signature box. I answered similarly to before.

"…I don't know. But now this document doesn't just have a number. It has a name too."

"…Is that all?"

"…Yeah. That's all."

This time Tyche didn't press further. She just nodded.

"…I guess that's enough."

I was a little surprised by that. I hadn't expected Tyche to accept it so easily.

"…Enough?"

"…Yeah. Even if nothing big changes, that much is enough."

Tyche looked out the window for a moment, then spoke again.

"…I still think all of this is probability, Hora. That Su-a wasn't released before, and that her name got written today. All of it is a vacancy and a number and a procedure lining up."

"…I know. You've said that from the start."

"…But now, even as I say it, I can't feel like that's the whole of it, the way I used to."

I looked at her, surprised by that.

"…What does that mean?"

"…I can't explain it. It's just that before, saying probability was the end of it. Lately, even after I say probability, something is left over."

I want to render this exactly. Tyche didn't convert. I don't want to use this sentence as evidence of a conversion either. I only set down the fact that she said this, that day. Tyche is still a person who believes in probability. Only, something more has come to stand beside that belief. What that is, even Tyche herself hasn't found a name for yet.

. . .

I told my aunt this story too. She listened for a long while, then asked.

"…Did you ever meet her?"

"…Yeah. A long time ago."

"…What kind of person was she?"

It took me some time to choose an answer to that.

"…Ordinary. Just, exactly a person like me. Except that she had a number attached to her."

My aunt nodded.

"…Then you did well."

"…Did well how? Her relocation status never got lifted."

"…But you still wrote her name."

I thought about that for a long while. My aunt wasn't promising anything large. She was simply acknowledging something small.

"…Aunt, is this all over now, do you think?"

My aunt set down her rice bowl.

"…What's supposed to be over?"

"…I don't know. I just feel like something should be over."

"…Isn't it less that it's over, and more that you've come this far?"

"…What's the difference?"

"…If it's over, there's no what comes next. If you've come this far, there's still a what comes next."

I thought about that distinction for a long while. I was about to close this record. But by my aunt's account, closing a record and a story ending were different things.

"…Then how far have I come?"

"…I don't know that either, Hora. That's probably not something even you know."

. . .

That evening I walked along the water channel.

There was no particular reason. I just wanted to walk. The sun was setting, and the sound of the water was the same as always. Listening to it, I thought of the beginning of this record. The very first time I'd seen this water channel, I hadn't even known why it was strange. Now I know where this water comes from. I also know that this city has still never once brought it before an agenda.

Walking, I counted back through this whole record. Forty-eight chapters. Of what truly happened within them, there wasn't much. I read a document. I wrote a name in the signature box. Today I wrote another name beside a number. That was all of it. Everything else was someone's words, someone's explanation, someone's silence. Writing this record, I came to know again that those silences, in truth, held more than the words did.

Walking along the channel, I came close to the edge of the city. From here on, the water's origin could only be guessed at. No one had ever

brought this stretch before an agenda. I no longer bother pressing the question, myself, either. Some things simply flow on, unrevealed. That, too, is something I learned in this city.

Someone in worn clothes was sitting by the water.

He said nothing at all.

. . .

I walked past him and kept going. I didn't look back.

I've written these two sentences more carefully than anything else in this record. I don't know who that person is. I don't know his name either. His face wasn't angry, and it wasn't sad. He was simply sitting by the water. Across this whole book I've passed someone like him a few times. Once on a road, once by the water, and once more, not long ago. Each time I tried not to put any special meaning to it. I mean to do the same, this time too.

Only, closing this record, I want to set down this one fact: that he was there. Nothing more than that. I write nothing further.

. . .

On the way back along the channel, I ran into Tyche. She said she was on her way home from work. We walked a little way in silence.

"…Did you write it?" Tyche asked.

"…Yeah."

"…Beside the number?"

"…Yeah. I didn't erase the number."

Tyche nodded. Then, after a long while, she spoke.

"…Nothing will change for her. She's still relocation-target. Still tagged the same."

"…I know."

"…And you still wrote it?"

"…Yeah."

Tyche didn't ask any further. We walked together as far as the fork in the road, and there we each went our own way. Tyche raised a hand once as she went.

Writing this part, I want to leave it exactly on record that Tyche never, in the end, agreed with me. She wasn't on my side. But she walked with me as far as the fork. I learned, in this city, that those two things can exist together.

. . .

Back home, I opened the drawer.

My mother's twelve pages. One name from eleven years before. Temel's name. Two hundred-some days of notes. The paper marked 927. Three official documents from other cities. On top of it all, I added one more sheet, on which I'd written a short line about today. *Jeong Su-a. Written into the document today.*

I looked into that drawer for a long while. The papers had grown fairly thick by now. When my mother first left twelve pages in this drawer, she couldn't have known it would come to this. Neither had I.

I wanted to leave this drawer as the last image of this record. On top of my mother's twelve pages, the names and sentences of the people I've met piled up, one by one. I don't want to call this an inheritance. An inheritance is something handed down by someone; this drawer is something I filled, one sheet at a time, myself. Only, it's true that my mother laid down that first page.

. . .

I mean to close this record here.

When I began this book, I didn't think I would end up proving anything large. Even now, I've proven nothing. Of the one thousand one hundred and forty in the Seventh Classification, only two hundred and thirteen were released. Nine hundred and twenty-seven remain exactly as they were. Jeong Su-a is one of them. I only wrote that one name into a document, and it didn't change her circumstances.

There was a time I wished this book would end triumphantly. Everything overturned, the hidden person exposed, all the wronged released at once. No such ending came. I don't regret that anymore, now. If such an ending had come, I probably would have finished writing this whole book without properly learning anything at all.

Tyche believes in chance, to the end. I believe there's something more, to the end. Both of us read the same documents, and saw the same facts. Our conclusions diverged. This book doesn't erase that divergence. I won't write that Tyche was wrong. She won't write that I was wrong

either. I think that much is the whole of what this book can give the two of us.

The Secretary is still the Secretary. Tomorrow, too, he will convene and pass things on. Only, once, exactly once, he said "I." I won't write that this one time saved him. But I will write that this one time can't be made as if it never happened.

I don't know what city Temel is in now. He's probably, even now, still writing his own name onto someone else's application. And probably, in payment for it, being called in somewhere, over and over.

Jeong Su-a still lives, even now, in that house near the water channel. Still carrying the relocation-target tag. I never went back to see her again. I couldn't be sure I had the right to. Only, I know that her name now sits, at least in one document, beside a number, written down.

My name is now, at least, in the documents of three other cities. I didn't write it there. Who did, I don't know. Even now, closing this record, I still don't know.

. . .

I wrote this record in four parts. It began with someone who was no one in particular, moved through learning that nobody did it, passed through the question of who knows, and arrived at a name. I didn't live according to this order, decided beforehand. Looking back, having lived it, it simply turned out to be this order. Maybe every story sorts itself out that way. While you're living it, the order isn't visible; only once it's all written does it come to have parts and chapters.

I don't think what I did in this city was special. I only read to the end, and looked at an empty space, and wrote a name. That's all. It's no great resolve, and no heroic story. I was only a child who'd read her mother's last line two years too late, and after that, never wanted to do it again.

The Consensus hid nothing. Everything written in this record was something anyone could have read. I only read, to the end, what others passed over after only the summary. If something had been hidden, I couldn't have written this book. Nothing was hidden. And yet it still took me forty-eight chapters to finish writing it.

This book has no author. The way no document in this city has one. I write my own name onto this record. That doesn't make it my book, though — I know that now. I'm only the one who wrote it. What happened within it, I didn't make happen.

Writing this last chapter, I felt, for a long time, the temptation to declare something. That I believe now, or that I know now. I decided against it. In the first sentence of this book, I wrote that there was no reason at all for me to end up in that seat. Even reaching this last chapter, I never fully found that reason. Only, I learned, writing this book, that believing there's no reason at all, and believing you simply haven't found the reason yet, are different things.

I once heard an old story. A story in which no name ever appears. Someone raised, by chance, to a high seat. A decree that couldn't be undone. A step taken forward with no summons at all. I heard that story, too, didn't end triumphantly. I won't retell that story here. I only set down that it and this record are asking the same question. Over the same document, one person says there was nothing there at all, and another says all of this cannot possibly have been chance. I have written this record, up to here, so that neither side wins completely.

. . .

I never once met him.

And I cannot bring myself to believe all of this was chance.

(The End.)

The Unsigned Book

Jaehyuk Choi